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Directly-Transmitted Yang-Style Taijiquan — Fu Zhongwen

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BOOK PAGE COVER

Page cover

(Cover)

Chinese Martial Arts — Taiji Series The Authentic Lineage Yang-Style Taijiquan Coaching Method By Fu Zhongwen Fu Shengyuan Fu Qingquan Tongji University Press (Back cover)

A classic masterwork handed down through the generations — Yang-style Taijiquan Yang-style Taijiquan is one of the traditional schools of Taijiquan, developed and created by Yang Lukchan (1799–1872) — a native of Yongnian, Hebei — together with his son Yang Jianhou (1839–1917) and his grandson Yang Chengfu (1883–1936), building upon the Old Frame of Chen-style Taijiquan. The Yang-style form is relaxed and uncluttered, the body method centred and upright, the movements harmonious, combining lightness with steadiness. In its practice method it proceeds from looseness into suppleness, with hardness and softness mutually assisting one another, simple and plain — and so it is deeply loved by the broad public and has spread extremely widely. The Yang-style frame has high, medium and low variations, which can be adjusted in amount of exercise according to the needs of different ages and different constitutions; thus it suits both those in good physical condition seeking to build fitness, and the physically weak seeking therapy and health preservation. This book was carefully written by Fu Zhongwen — former vice-chairman of the Shanghai Wushu Association, one of China's Hundred Outstanding Wushu Figures, and a transmitter of Yang-style Taijiquan — together with his son Fu Shengyuan (National Wushu 8th Duan) and his grandson Fu Qingquan (National Wushu 6th Duan), on the foundation of many years of teaching practice. In its writing there are many new supplements to the essentials of the movements, such as the addition of the "deflecting" application in the usage notes. In the teaching method and practice method there are fairly detailed and innovative expositions — the progressive-increase method, the mnemonic formula method, the error-correction method, and so on — all of which have been tried out in teaching practice for many years with very notable results.

This book suits Taijiquan enthusiasts for study, and can also serve teachers in universities, secondary and primary schools, teachers' colleges, physical-education units and popular training classes for carrying out Taijiquan instruction.

(Three columns at right, reading vertically) Three generations carefully transmit Master Yang Chengfu's Taijiquan methods — rules and standards not the slightest bit off A detailed account of boxing theory and boxing method, breaking down the secrets of technique — the very essence of Taijiquan Dual use for coaching — scientific fitness, cultivating the internal and training the external, armed for both attack and defence, cultivating body and nature ISBN 7-5608-2201-0 Price: 32.80 yuan (Title page)

The Authentic Lineage Yang-Style Taijiquan Coaching Method By Fu Zhongwen, Fu Shengyuan, Fu Qingquan Tongji University Press (Colophon)

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Grand Master Yang Lukchan (1799–1872) (Plate page: portrait of patriarch yang jianhou)

Patriarch Yang Jianhou (1839–1917) (Plate page: portrait of patriarch yang chengfu)

Patriarch Yang Chengfu (1883–1936) (Plate page: portrait of mr. fu zhongwen)

Fu Zhongwen (1903–1994) (Plate page: portrait of mr. fu shengyuan)

Fu Shengyuan (1931–) (Plate page: portrait of mr. fu qingquan)

Fu Qingquan (1971–) (Plate page: historical photographs)

Fu Zhongwen in his youth Fu Zhongwen in the form posture Step Back and Ride the Tiger Group photo of Mr. Gong Xueping, Deputy Secretary of the Shanghai Municipal Party Committee, and municipal sports commission leaders with Fu and his son (Plate page: historical photographs)

Patriarch Yang Chengfu and Fu Zhongwen photographed together Fu Shengyuan photographed with his teacher-uncles the late Master Cui Yishi and the late Master Niu Chunming In 1934 Fu Zhongwen accompanied Patriarch Yang Chengfu to teach at the Guangzhou Municipal Government (Plate page: historical photographs)

Fu Zhongwen in middle age Fu Zhongwen with the martial-arts film star Jet Li Fu Zhongwen pushing hands with Fu Shengyuan (Plate page: historical photographs)

Fu Zhongwen teaching Fu Qingquan at age six Fu Zhongwen teaching his granddaughter Fu Zhengrong sword practice Fu Zhongwen and Fu Qingquan photographed together at the White House, USA Three generations of the Fu family photographed together in Shanghai in the mid-1980s (Plate page: historical photographs)

Three generations of the Fu family photographed together after Fu Qingquan won a competition prize Fu Zhongwen and Fu Shengyuan teaching foreign experts at Tongji University in the early 1980s Certificate (Chinese Wushu Association, November 1998, awarding Fu Shengyuan the Wushu Promotion Award) / Letter of Appointment (Chinese Wushu Association, October 1998,

appointing Mr. Fu Shengyuan liaison officer of the Overseas Development Committee of the Chinese Wushu Duanwei System)

Fu Zhongwen leading Fu Qingquan on a visit to Japan in 1988 (Plate page: historical photographs)

Australian former Prime Minister Bob Hawke warmly meeting Fu and his son Mr. Xu Cai, adviser to the All-China Sports Federation, photographed with Fu Shengyuan (Plate page: historical photographs)

Fu Shengyuan awarded the Chinese Wushu 8th Duan Fu Shengyuan with American students Fu Shengyuan with German students Fu Shengyuan with Thai students (Certificate: Wushu Duanwei Certificate, Chinese Wushu Association / Wushu Sports Management Centre of the State General Administration of Sport) (Plate page: historical photographs)

Taiji Sabre Taiji Sword Fu Shengyuan instructing Ms. Li Hui, world wushu taijiquan champion Pushing hands, issuing power (Plate page: historical photographs)

Mr. Zhou Muyao, Vice Mayor of Shanghai, warmly meeting Fu Qingquan Mr. Li Jie, President of the Chinese Wushu Academy, photographed with Fu Shengyuan and his son Fu Qingquan (Plate page: historical photographs)

Fu Shengyuan and his son Fu Qingquan with Australian students (Certificate: Wushu Duanwei Certificate, Chinese Wushu Association / Wushu Sports Management Centre of the State General Administration of Sport)

Fu Qingquan teaching Australian students form practice Fu Qingquan photographed teaching in Taishan City, Guangdong — the famous overseas-Chinese home town Fu Qingquan photographed teaching in Osaka, Japan Fu Qingquan photographed with Mr. Mishiro Masahiro, chairman of the Japanese Taijiquan Friendship Association, and university students Taiji Sabre Fu Qingquan in a television-drama still Fu Qingquan photographed with Hong Kong students (Demonstration plate: Grand Master Fu Zhongwen demonstrating the Taijiquan form, frames 1–25)

Grand Master Fu Zhongwen of Yongnian demonstrating the Tai Chi Chuan form (Demonstration plate: Grand Master Fu Zhongwen demonstrating the Taijiquan form, frames 26–52)

Grand Master Fu Zhongwen of Yongnian demonstrating the Tai Chi Chuan form (Demonstration plate: Grand Master Fu Shengyuan demonstrating the Taijiquan form, frames 1–26)

Grand Master Fu Shengyuan of Yongnian demonstrating the Tai Chi Chuan form 8th Duan, Chinese Wushu (Demonstration plate: Grand Master Fu Shengyuan demonstrating the Taijiquan form, frames 27–56)

Grand Master Fu Shengyuan of Yongnian demonstrating the Tai Chi Chuan form (Inscription page) (Inscription page) (Preface, written by Chen Weiming)

Mr. Fu Zhongwen is a junior kinsman of Master Yang Chengfu of Yongnian, and received the master's transmission — in rules and standards he is not the slightest bit off. People call him an orthodox lineage of Taijiquan. He and Jianhua, and Yongnian, taught students at the Taiji Study Society without taking remuneration, and their achievements are very numerous. Now, on reaching the tenth year, they asked me to write a few words as a memento. As for carrying it forward and giving it greater brilliance — who else but Zhongwen?

Chen Weiming (Preface I, written by Xu Cai)

Giving Chinese Martial Art a Worldwide Character

BOOK PAGE PREFACE I

— In Praise of Three Generations of the Fu Family

— In Praise of Three Generations of the Fu Family

Grand Master Fu Shengyuan is the son of Fu Zhongwen, a master of his generation in Yang-style Taijiquan. Fu Zhongwen studied the Taiji art under Yang Chengfu, grandson of Yang Lukchan, founder of Yang-style Taijiquan, and won Master Yang's high regard; Yang had him attend at his side without ever leaving it, giving him instruction at all times. In later days Master Fu Zhongwen became a famous leading disciple of the master of his generation, Yang Chengfu.

In his youth Grand Master Fu Shengyuan absorbed the essence of Yang-style Taijiquan, and under his father's personal instruction practised assiduously; his Taiji skill reached the realm of purity and perfection, and he became the fifth-generation master and transmitter of Yang-style Taijiquan. Mr. Fu Qingquan received strict training from his grandfather and father from childhood; as a youth he took part many times as a professional athlete in domestic and overseas competitions and won championships, becoming the rising talent of this Taiji family. The two of them, father and son, have spread this art overseas, taking in a great number of students and disciples, and carried this great wealth of Chinese culture out to the countries of the world. Thanks to Master Fu's efforts, more and more people have gradually come to understand and take a liking to Taijiquan, and many people in every part of the world count it a joy to have the chance to become Master Fu's disciples and learn Taijiquan skill from him. Master Fu's spirit of dedication in spreading Chinese martial art to the world deserves to be honoured and praised.

(continued on the next page)

The world today has entered the information age. In this society filled with inexhaustible information and highly developed communications, people's outlooks are undergoing enormous change; in a sense the world has already become smaller and smaller, and time and distance no longer form an obstacle to exchange — which in turn has driven cultural exchange among people everywhere on earth, and thereby further advanced the spread of Taijiquan.

Chinese wushu has now become a common favourite of the peoples of the world. Taiji, as the martial art with the deepest cultural substance in Chinese wushu, has become one of the most valuable "gifts" offered to humanity, because of its function of strengthening the body and building health. It is especially suited to the middle-aged and elderly and to those extremely busy in their work, including a great many mental workers. It can be said with certainty that all those who practise Taijiquan may derive benefit from it.

The publication of *The Authentic Lineage Yang-Style Taijiquan Coaching Method* can, at a deeper level, provide Taijiquan enthusiasts with the experience and methods of teaching and practising. This book gives a detailed introduction to every movement, which is rare even among books of the Taijiquan kind. It is bound to become a good teacher and helpful friend to Taijiquan enthusiasts.

Grand Master Fu Shengyuan (Chinese Wushu 8th Duan) and his son Fu Qingquan (Chinese Wushu 6th Duan) have already effectively (Preface I, continued)

spread the art of Taijiquan, and we hope their enterprise achieves tremendous success! And may they continue to promote Taiji — this gem of Chinese culture — to the peoples of every country in the world, so that it may flourish and shine throughout the world!

Xu Cai September 2000 Author of Preface I Adviser, All-China Sports Federation Honorary Chairman, Asian Wushu Federation (Preface II, written by You Xuande)

The Essential Meaning of Taiji Chinese kung fu has a long history, and has long enjoyed the reputation of "Wudang revered in the south, Shaolin esteemed in the north". Yet among Chinese martial arts the one that today flourishes in every part of the world and is most beloved by people is none other than the method of Taijiquan. At a time when the central government advocates fitness for all in service of society, I was delighted to hear that my martial nephew Qingquan has a work of three-generation true transmission — *The Authentic Lineage Yang-Style Taijiquan Coaching Method* — about to appear; at the request of my worthy elder brother Shengyuan, I write a preface for my martial nephew Qingquan's new work, to express my joy and congratulations.

The art of Taijiquan was created in the Song dynasty by the Perfected One Zhang Sanfeng of Mount Wudang in Hubei Province, and several hundred years have passed to the present day. Mount Wudang is a famous Daoist holy site and scenic resort of China. Its long cultural accumulation gave birth to the world-renowned Wudang school of martial arts, and its Taijiquan skill in particular is celebrated at home and abroad. The Wudang martial arts took disciples with extreme strictness through the ages; in the Qing dynasty Wudang martial arts passed from within the religion out to the common people, and so took shape the internal-family Taijiquan system — the Southern School represented by Zhang Songxi, the Northern School represented by Wang Zongyue. In the course of transmission the Taiji art further developed several schools, forming an exceedingly rich cultural and artistic treasure-house of Taiji art. And of those who spread the Taiji art throughout the world, none has rendered more distinguished service than the master of his generation, the elder Mr. Fu Zhongwen.

The elder Fu and I were friends despite the difference in our ages, so I have felt deeply his quality of lofty integrity, his bearing of a mind as open as a valley, his skill brought to the point of purity and perfection, and the majestic spirit that shook the martial world. In the Republican period, bouts between different schools occurred from time to time; and because the elder Fu's skill spread widely from north to south, there were many challengers too. Many boxers and famous hands, the instant they crossed hands, were thrown more than ten feet — and were left utterly mystified by the Taiji skill of looseness, sinking, roundness and liveliness; at the same time they were moved by the elder Fu's noble martial virtue, and there was no lack of those who took him as their master. After the founding of New China, the elder Fu received the State's care and commendation and won very high honours.

Qingquan is the grandson of the elder Fu by direct transmission; taught by the family's elders, he practised martial arts from childhood alongside his father (the famous martial artist and chairman of the World Yongnian Taijiquan Alliance, Mr. Fu Shengyuan), and for a long time accompanied his grandfather Fu Zhongwen to martial-arts gatherings in many places. As a youth he won the national Taijiquan championship — truly a tiger cub of a warrior house. Because Qingquan is naturally quick and bright, diligent and hard-working, he has now reached the age of thirty, and appears all the more spirited and vigorous — truly, the waves behind the Yangtze push on those before! Keeping in mind his grandfather's unfulfilled wish, Qingquan has spared no hardship in travelling at home and abroad to transmit the Taiji art, and today his students are everywhere. Many of the students he has taught have won major prizes in competitions in various regions, and China Central Television has even filmed a special instructional series with him. (Preface II, continued)

The appearance of *The Authentic Lineage Yang-Style Taijiquan Coaching Method* — whether one looks at the boxing theory or the boxing frame — leaves one feeling that eye and ear are made new; it does not lose the bearing of a great master, and for professional martial artists and amateur martial-arts enthusiasts alike it has high value for reference and for collecting. It is bound to become a celebrated work spanning the centuries. If the elder Mr. Fu Zhongwen has awareness in heaven, he too will surely feel deeply comforted and rest at peace in the Nine Springs. We cherish the memory of the master of his generation, Fu Zhongwen, and we hope all the more that Qingquan will compile a series of works, so that more people may learn the true skill of traditional Yang-style Taijiquan. As a transmitter of the boxing lineage within the Wudang school, and because I have long dwelt among the mountains and wilds, these few hurried words cannot exhaust the essential meaning of the book; I trust my colleagues in the martial world will discern this. This is my preface.

Author of Preface II The Perfected One of the Grotto-Heaven, You Xuande First month of the year 2000 (Preface, written by Fu Qingquan)

Preface At the moment when the new century is about to arrive, our country stands in a great historical period in which politics, economy and culture are daily advancing and the people of every ethnic group live and work in peace; having largely satisfied their material needs, the

broad masses urgently hope to master a scientific and simple method of fitness to preserve health of body and mind. At the same time, a nation's prosperity cannot be separated from the raising of its people's quality — including both physical quality and psychological quality. The aim of the fitness-for-all movement is to enable the greatest possible number of citizens to possess a strong physique and sound mind: and the most ideal method of popular fitness is none other than practising Taijiquan. Comrade Deng Xiaoping gave Taijiquan a high appraisal and wrote the inscription "Taijiquan is good!" — which fully embodies the long-standing attention paid by Party and State leaders to fitness for all and to traditional martial arts.

Taijiquan, as a science of movement and an art of bodily form, is a representative of our country's excellent traditional martial-arts culture, and a great contribution of the Chinese nation to the whole world. It can strengthen the body and build health, calm the spirit and nourish the brain; it can also cultivate the self and nurture the nature, and refine sentiment — and it contains, moreover, a rich cultural foundation and philosophical substance. Taijiquan has truly achieved the state of being enjoyed by both refined and popular tastes and suited to young and old alike; it has long been deeply loved by the people, and has already been spread throughout the world. In the course of its transmission Taijiquan developed and gave rise to many schools; among them the Yang style has all along been the most widely transmitted, and after Liberation it was taken by the National Sports Commission as the basis and adapted into competition routines more times than any other Taijiquan school.

My grandfather began at the age of nine to learn boxing by following the third-generation transmitter of Yang-style Taijiquan, Patriarch Yang Chengfu, and continued until his death in 1994 at the advanced age of ninety-one, devoting the energy of his whole life to the development and transmission of Yang-style Taijiquan, and winning the broad respect and affection of Taijiquan enthusiasts at home and abroad. My father likewise began at nine to learn boxing by following my grandfather, and before Liberation assisted him in promoting Yang-style Taijiquan. After the founding of New China he taught for more than thirty years as a professional martial-arts coach. After retiring he was invited to Australia, Europe and America and many other countries to spread Yang-style Taijiquan, and though he is now in his seventies he still spares no hardship in travelling the world, introducing orthodox Yang-style Taijiquan abroad, letting more foreign friends understand and take a liking to China's Taiji art, and contributing to friendly exchange between our country and others and to building our country's good international image. From the age of six I practised boxing with my grandfather and father, receiving formal martial-arts training from childhood. In the 1980s I became a professional martial-arts athlete, and represented the Shanghai team and the national team many times in domestic and international martial-arts competitions, achieving good results. Afterwards I too taught boxing at home and abroad for many years, and formed a set of teaching methods with distinctive characteristics. We, grandfather, son and grandson of three generations, are most willing to offer up without reservation the authentic Yang-style Taijiquan of our family transmission — better, more clearly and more accurately — to society, and to live up to the earnest expectations of the broad community of Taiji lovers (Preface, continued)

lovers. This wish, to a very large extent, brought about the publication of this *The Authentic Lineage Yang-Style Taijiquan Coaching Method*.

This book takes as its principal blueprint the earlier work by my grandfather and father, *Yang-Style Taijiquan: Teaching Method and Practice Method* (compiled by Fu Zhongwen and Fu Shengyuan, written up by Yao Minghua; Shanghai: Tongji University Press, 1st edition 1989), and was written by blending my grandfather's and father's decades of insight in practising boxing and experience in teaching boxing with my own personal experience of more than twenty years in practising and teaching boxing. It is a comprehensive summary of our three generations' — grandfather, son and grandson — understanding, practice and teaching of Taijiquan, and the latest crystallisation condensing three generations' wisdom and heart's blood. In the course of many years of teaching boxing, we have clearly realised that the efforts of a mere few people are far from able to satisfy the wish of the broad community of Taijiquan enthusiasts to learn authentic Taiji skill; this requires more people to take part in the process of practising and teaching Taijiquan, and to take part in the enterprise of its development and transmission. Therefore we have carefully collated and summarised three generations' methods, techniques and experience of teaching boxing, to provide genuine and effective help to all those who have set their hearts on the development and transmission of Taijiquan. In addition, in the course of teaching we have discovered that people generally overlook the martial-application function of Taijiquan, and many errors and deviations arise from this. In truth, Taijiquan was originally a martial art of technique and combat; only by understanding the correct application of each and every posture of Taijiquan can one grasp the essentials of Taijiquan at the root, accurately master the key points of every movement, and achieve the purpose of better fitness. Therefore another notable feature of this book is its emphasis on explaining the martial-application usage of Taijiquan, which can also more readily arouse the learning interest of young people.

The 21st century is a new century of swift development in science and technology. How traditional excellent culture may adapt to and keep pace with this change, and gain further development, is a serious question. The enterprise of Taijiquan's development and transmission faces this challenge likewise; on the other hand, while modern industry and civilisation bring people more convenience and richer material goods, they impose higher demands on people's physical and psychological quality. How to maintain health of body and mind amid an ever-faster social life and fierce competition for survival has already become a real problem that modern people must face seriously — and in this respect Taijiquan undoubtedly has many unique functions.

As one who practises martial arts, I feel deeply how broad and profound Taijiquan is; only by personally putting it into practice can one appreciate it. Science knows no boundaries; Taijiquan is still in constant development. Although this book has undergone the supplementing and perfecting of three generations, it still inevitably has omissions and deficiencies. At the start of the new century, I hope to study and compare notes together with the broad community of boxing friends and friends from all walks of life who engage in and care about the development

and transmission of Taijiquan, and to strive together, so that Taijiquan may ascend another storey and bring more well-being to humanity.

Finally, I hope that the publication of this book may help more people benefit from Taijiquan and appreciate its inexhaustible charm. May humanity live more healthily and happily in the 21st century!

Fu Qingquan 1 August 2000 (Contents I)

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Chapter One A Brief History of Yang-style Taijiquan Yang-style Taijiquan originated in the middle of the 19th century (the Daoguang reign of the Qing dynasty). It is barely 150 years old, yet it has spread widely throughout the world and become an excellent method by which hundreds of millions of people strengthen their bodies and improve their health.

The founder of Yang-style Taijiquan was Yang Fukui (1799–1872), courtesy name Lushen, born into a peasant family at the southern gate of Yongnian county town, Guangping prefecture, Hebei. The custom of practising martial arts had a long history in Yongnian county, and Yang Lushen had studied Shaolin boxing since childhood. In the slack farming season he often took short-term work at a grain shop on the West Main Street of the county town. One day a ruffian burst into the Taihe Tang pharmacy next door to the grain shop and, bullying the pharmacist Chen Dehu because he was not a local, insisted on buying precious medicinal herbs cheaply; cursing as he did so, he was about to throw a punch. Chen Dehu merely raised his hand, and the ruffian at once went tumbling out into the street. Yang Lushen was astonished, and a few days

later he asked Chen Dehu to teach him boxing. At first Chen Dehu always declined vaguely, but when he saw that Yang Lushen was honest and warm-hearted, he told him that he himself was from Chenjiagou, Wen county, Huaiqing prefecture, Henan; that many people there practised Taijiquan, also called "sticking-and-adhering boxing"; and that his own teacher was Chen Changxing of the same clan, whose boxing skill was second to none under heaven. Delighted at this news, Yang Lushen asked Chen Dehu to introduce him, went to Chenjiagou in Henan, and became Chen Changxing's disciple.

Under Chen Changxing's guidance Yang Lushen trained hard, regardless of cold or heat. Six years later he returned home with outstanding boxing skill. At that time many people in Yongnian county studied boxing, and one man of considerable reputation announced: "Lushen has come back from his studies — I shall have to ask him for a lesson." When the two did test each other, Yang Lushen was defeated. Unwilling to accept defeat, he set his mind on returning to Chenjiagou to study, and trained hard for another six years. When he came home again it happened to be the New Year, and the neighbours, taking the occasion of the New Year greetings, contended with him — and none could beat him. Everyone said that old Lu had really learned something this time. But in a certain Wu family of officials there, one man who had relatives at Chenjiagou and had also studied various boxing arts heard that Yang Lushen had come home and proposed a test; the result was a draw. Yang Lushen felt that he was still not good enough, and so he went to Chenjiagou a third time and studied under Chen Changxing for another three years. Chen Changxing was deeply moved by Yang Lushen's pursuit of the true transmission of Taijiquan and by his spirit in entering Chenjiagou three times. After secretly testing and examining Yang Lushen's determination to learn and the quality of his character, he finally passed on to him his whole body of true skill. Two years later Chen Changxing said to Yang Lushen: "You may go home now; this time no one will dare provoke you." The moment Yang Lushen got back to his home village everyone came to watch him cross hands with others — and somehow, with a single flick of his hand, he sent his opponent flying behind him. And so everyone said that Yang Lushen had truly "brought the goods back" — that is, he had learned real skill. (Chapter 1: A Brief History of Yang-Style Taijiquan, page 2)

Yang Lukchan entered the Chen family village three times to study boxing for eighteen years; having mastered Chen Changxing's true skill he was still not satisfied, and continued ceaselessly to delve into it and train hard, until at last he reached a level of the marvellous and the divine, and became a famous figure of his locality.

Before long, Yang Lukchan accepted the invitation of a distant relative, Wu Ruqing, to go to Beijing to teach boxing. Wu Ruqing was a *jinshi* of the Daoguang reign of the Qing and at that time served as a vice-director of the Ministry of Punishments. In the capital, Yang Lukchan first accompanied Wu Ruqing on a visit to the mansion of a certain wealthy man, Zhang. Zhang had begun with a small shop and was nicknamed "Little Shop Zhang", and afterwards made his fortune suddenly. The Zhang mansion was a place where officials, gentry and the rich sought their pleasure, and there too several martial-arts instructors were employed to teach a class of sons of wealthy families the practice of arms and boxing. At the banquet of their first meeting,

Little Shop Zhang saw that Yang Lukchan was slight of build and somewhat looked down on him, seating him after a row of burly, broad-shouldered martial instructors. During the meal Little Shop Zhang asked: "Mr. Yang, can your soft boxing actually strike a man?" Yang Lukchan said: "My soft boxing cannot strike bronze men, iron men, or stone men; but anything born of father and mother with blood and flesh, it can strike." Little Shop Zhang said again: "Then could you have a contest with the gentlemen present?" Yang Lukchan said: "Very well; I shall get friendly with each of the masters" — meaning, exchange a few moves. So everyone present went out into the garden. When the contest began, one boxing master came straight at Yang Lukchan with a fierce air; and they saw Yang Lukchan merely put out a hand a little, and that boxing master at once fell several zhang away. Another boxing master, seeing this, said "He's no good — let me!" and came in at him too; and in no more than a single move he was seen to fly out. The remaining boxing masters dared not compete further. Little Shop Zhang was greatly astonished at the sight, and at once gave orders to lay the table again with silver vessels and to invite Yang Lukchan to the seat of honour. But Yang Lukchan saw that the host's attitude before and after were as different as two men, and thought little of it; so he rose angrily from the feast and strode off.

After the affair of the contest at the Zhang house got about, men came one after another attracted by his fame wanting to try conclusions with him, but all were defeated at his hands. And so, when Yang Lukchan was mentioned in the capital, everyone called him "Yang the Invincible". Afterwards Wu Ruqing introduced no small number of princes and young noblemen to study Taijiquan under Yang Lukchan, making this boxing art widely current in the capital, and at that time officials' households counted it an honour to be able to engage Yang Lukchan. In this way Yang Lukchan, with his two sons Yang Banhou (1837–1892) and Yang Jianhou (1839–1917), long resided in the Prince Duan mansion to teach boxing, and only in his later years returned to his home village.

Yang Banhou was Yang Lukchan's second son; from childhood he studied arms with his father, and trained a whole body of good skill. Though hot-tempered, his character was upright and unyielding. Once there came to Beijing a boxing master who had fought on the raised platforms of seven provinces and was known as "Ten-Thousand-Catty Strength", who declared he would test who was higher and who lower with Yang Lukchan. When the Yang father and son learned of this, Yang Lukchan thought it need not be attended to; but Yang Banhou said to his father: "Our shop has goods; if someone comes to buy, how can you not sell?" — meaning, we have true skill, so why can we not measure ourselves against another? So Yang Banhou went alone to agree with "Ten-Thousand-Catty Strength" on a contest at the Xisi Archway, and they set down a life-and-death pledge in writing. On the day, "Ten-Thousand-Catty Strength" won the crowd's cheers with his developed musculature, and at the same time people worried for the slight Yang Banhou, who was like a scholar. When the contest began, they saw "Ten-Thousand-Catty Strength" lunge in with one fist, and Yang Banhou dodged aside with a flicker; but when "Ten-Thousand-Catty Strength" attacked again, coming at Yang Banhou's face, they only heard Yang Banhou give a shout, and before anyone had seen clearly, "Ten-Thousand-Catty Strength" had been kicked several zhang away — and Yang Banhou had planted a separating kick in his crotch,

killing him on the spot. And while people were still marvelling, Yang Banhou had already unhurriedly returned to the Prince Duan mansion. (Chapter 1: A Brief History of Yang-Style Taijiquan, page 3)

Yang Lukchan's third son, Yang Jianhou, had a boxing skill in which hardness and softness assisted one another, and was especially good at using clever force; he was also extremely devoted to the study of sabre, sword and spear. His temperament was gentle, and in competition and in martial practice he slighted no one, and so he could win every contest.

The third generation of the Yang family to study the art included Yang Banhou's son Yang Lingxiao, courtesy name Zhaopeng, who studied the art under Yang Banhou's disciple Chen Xiufeng, and afterwards studied boxing with his elder cousin Yang Chengfu, and later taught boxing in Shaoxing in Zhejiang and in Guangxi and elsewhere. Yang Jianhou's eldest son Yang Zhaoxiong, style-name Shaohou, learned boxing from childhood, was at his best at free hands, moved swiftly, and had a steady frame; he kept up training all his life. And Yang Jianhou's third son Yang Zhaoqing, style-name Chengfu, was surpassingly clever, obtained his father Yang Jianhou's personal transmission in full, had refined art and high skill, and at last became a master of his generation in Yang-style Taijiquan.

Yang Chengfu (1883–1936), under his father's instruction, buried himself in study of the art in Beijing. Only after Yang Jianhou's death did he accept an invitation to go south, teaching boxing first in Wuhan, Nanjing and elsewhere. In 1928, at the invitation of Zhang Zhijiang, he taught at the Central Martial Arts Institute in Nanjing, and later, at the invitation of Zhang Jingjiang, went to Hangzhou as dean of studies at the Zhejiang Provincial Martial Arts Institute. In 1930 Yang Chengfu settled in Shanghai and published *The Complete Book of Taijiquan: Substance and Application*; in 1932, at the invitation of Chen Jitang and Li Zongren, he went to Guangzhou to teach boxing, and only two years later returned to Shanghai.

While Yang Chengfu was dean of studies at the Zhejiang Provincial Martial Arts Institute in Hangzhou, there was in the institute a boxing master named Gao Shouwu who practised Taiyi boxing and consistently belittled the Yang family's Taijiquan, often speaking insolently to Yang Chengfu. One day Yang Chengfu's patience ran out and he exchanged sharp words with Gao Shouwu; Gao Shouwu took up a long spear to have it out with Yang Chengfu, and Yang Chengfu, holding a long spear, gave it but a light flick — and Gao Shouwu's spear flew out of his hand and fell to the ground. At the sight Gao Shouwu was dumbstruck, and was in an instant ashamed beyond bearing.

Yang Chengfu's temperament was gentle, his boxing skill was "a needle hidden in cotton", hardness and softness assisting one another; he had the quality of being able to open out and able to gather in, expansive and generous — and so he was admired and imitated by many. Although Yang Lukchan was Chen Changxing's transmitter, he did not cling rigidly to the old rules; he further developed the art on the foundation of the Old Frame of Chen-style Taijiquan, making it more rational and more popular, and making it suitable for old and young alike so that all could practise it — and people of the time called it "Yang-style Taijiquan". Through the

unceasing study and improvement of Yang Lukchan and the two generations after him, the Yang family's Taijiquan was only formally fixed in its manual in the hands of his grandson Yang Chengfu, forming a Yang-style Taijiquan whose frame is expansive and uncluttered, whose structure is strict, whose body method is centred and upright, whose movements are harmonious, and which combines lightness and agility with steadiness.

It was precisely through the efforts of three generations of the Yang family that this traditional boxing art was promoted, developed and widely transmitted — and that Taijiquan came to have its rich and varied schools: for example, Wu Yuxiang, younger brother of Wu Ruqing, who was taught by Yang Lukchan, created Wu-style Taijiquan; Wu Yuxiang taught his nephew Li Yishe, who in turn taught Hao Weizhen, who created Hao-style Taijiquan; Hao Weizhen in turn taught Sun Lutang, who created Sun-style Taijiquan; and Quan You, taught by Yang Banhou, in turn taught his son Wu Jianquan, who created Wu-style Taijiquan. Thus it may be said that Yang-style Taijiquan is the root of Wu-style, Hao-style, Sun-style and Wu-style Taijiquan. In 1956 the National Sports Commission again took the most widely transmitted Yang-style Taijiquan and created a set of Simplified Taijiquan; the boxing manual, boxing photographs and other materials adopted at that time were provided by Fu Zhongwen. The subsequent 88-Posture Taijiquan and 48-Posture Taijiquan and so on were all compiled and created by the National Sports Commission on the basis of Yang-style Taijiquan — just as the martial-arts historian Mr. Tang Hao said: "Yang-style Taijiquan and pushing hands have made the greatest contribution and have been developed most widely." (Chapter One — A Brief History of Yang-style Taijiquan, book page 4)

In the 150 years of the development of Yang-style Taijiquan, Yang Lushen taught Yang Banhou, Yang Jianhou, Wang Lanting, Wu Yuxiang and others. Yang Banhou taught Wan Chun, Ling Shan, Quan You, Hou Deshan, Chen Xiufeng, Zhang Xinyi, Li Lianfang, Zhang Yintang, Jiao Liantang, Ji Laofu and others; Yang Jianhou taught Yang Shaohou, Yang Chengfu, Xu Yusheng, Liu Shengkui, Zhang Yi and others; and Yang Shaohou taught Liu Xizhe, Xu Daishan, Tian Zhaolin, You Zhixue and others. Three generations of the Yang family devoted themselves to spreading and transmitting Taijiquan, and their students were everywhere; Yang Chengfu in particular had the greatest number of disciples. Besides his sons Yang Zhenming, Yang Zhenji, Yang Zhenduo and Yang Zhenguo, he also taught his formal disciples Chen Yuepo, Yan Zhongkui, You Zhixue, Cui Yishi, Wang Xudong, Niu Chunming, Li Chunnian, Wang Jingxing, Zhang Qinglin, Guo Zirong, Chen Weiming, Jiang Tingxuan, Liu Donghan, Zhang Qinlin, Fu Zhongwen, Wu Huichuan, Tian Zhaolin, Dong Yingjie, Chu Guiting, Zheng Manqing and others.

Three generations of the one family of Fu Zhongwen, Fu Shengyuan and Fu Qingquan have all devoted themselves to the development and spread of Taijiquan. The grandfather, Mr Fu Zhongwen (1903–1994), was a native of Yongnian county, Hebei — the famous home of Taijiquan. He began to study Yang-style Taijiquan at the age of nine, and after going to Shanghai at fourteen he studied boxing under the great Taiji master Yang Chengfu for many years. He respected his teacher and trained diligently and hard; moreover, since he married the niece of Master Yang's sister, he won Master Yang's trust and true transmission. The Taijiquan authority

Mr Chen Weiming called him "the orthodox line of Taijiquan". When Yang Chengfu taught boxing in Guangzhou, Nanjing, Wuhu and elsewhere, Fu Zhongwen always demonstrated on the spot and also stepped in for Yang Chengfu in contests, winning victory after victory. In order to carry forward Taijiquan and to promote the traditional martial arts among the people so as to lift the spirit of the nation and strengthen the people and save the country, Fu Zhongwen, with the great help of gentlemen such as Huang Yanfang, Ma Gongyu and Huang Jingwan, founded the Shanghai Yongnian Taijiquan Society on 1 October 1944. After the founding of New China, Fu Zhongwen took an active part in all kinds of social activities connected with Taijiquan. In 1956 he served in Beijing as a referee at the national martial-arts competition of twelve provinces and municipalities, during which he received the kindly reception and encouragement of Comrade He Long, Vice-Premier of the State Council; in 1958 he became one of the first batch of coaches of the Shanghai municipal wushu team, contributing greatly to the training of Shanghai's wushu athletes, and he led the team to outstanding results in every national wushu competition. In 1972 Tongji University invited Fu Zhongwen and Fu Shengyuan to teach Yang-style Taijiquan, and joined with the Shanghai Institute of Sports Science, the Shanghai Institute of Hypertension, Huashan Hospital and other research units in carrying out scientific tests of the health-preserving and therapeutic functions of Yang-style Taijiquan. The research proved that Yang-style Taijiquan practice, supplemented by drug therapy, is an effective method of building health, preventing illness and treating chronic diseases such as hypertension, coronary heart disease, arthritis, stomach and intestinal complaints and neurasthenia; it also improves the functioning of the heart and lungs and increases physical strength, so that the practitioner is full of energy and his study and work efficiency rise. This research result attracted the attention of the National Sports Commission and international interest — people came from Japan, Germany, Thailand and elsewhere to learn about it. During the "Cultural Revolution" Mr Fu Zhongwen suffered persecution; in 1979 his reputation was restored and he was elected vice-chairman of the Shanghai Wushu Association. In his later years he still frequently took part in the social activities of Taijiquan. In 1984 he was named one of the "Thirteen Famous Masters of Taijiquan in China"; between 1991 and 1993 he helped to organise and led teams to the First and Second China Yongnian International Taijiquan Friendship Gatherings. In 1994, at the advanced age of 91, he was invited to visit the United States, where he was warmly received; he had also visited and taught in Singapore, Japan, Australia, Germany, Italy, Switzerland and other countries in turn, powerfully promoting the spread of Taijiquan throughout the world. On 25 September 1994, (Chapter One — A Brief History of Yang-style Taijiquan, book page 5)

Mr Fu Zhongwen unfortunately died of illness in Shanghai at the age of 91.

Mr Fu Shengyuan (1931–) received his father's true transmission, and is a Taiji master of high prestige both in China and abroad. Mr Fu Shengyuan began studying boxing with his father at the age of nine, and before the Liberation he was already helping his father spread Yang-style Taijiquan. After the founding of New China he attended the Shanghai sports cadres' refresher course and became the first wushu coach of the Shanghai municipal sports school, and was invited to teach boxing at Tongji, Fudan and other institutions of higher learning. During the

"Cultural Revolution" he was sent down to labour in a factory, after which he returned to higher education and continued to teach wushu and physical education until his retirement. In the mid-1980s, at the invitation of Australian Taijiquan enthusiasts and others concerned, he crossed the oceans and taught Yang-style Taijiquan in a number of countries in Europe, America and Australia, and afterwards settled in Australia. Though now in his seventies, he still spares no effort for the development of the Taijiquan cause. At present Mr Fu Shengyuan is based mainly in Australia, promoting Yang-style Taijiquan to the countries of Europe and America. In 1995, in view of the rapid worldwide growth of Taijiquan, the Shanghai Yongnian Taijiquan Society, then celebrating its fiftieth anniversary, had completed its historical mission, and Mr Fu Shengyuan founded the World Yongnian Taijiquan Federation on the basis of the Shanghai Yongnian Taijiquan Society and became its chairman; in 1998 he was awarded the eighth duan of Chinese wushu, and in the same year, in recognition of his contribution to the popularisation and development of Chinese wushu internationally, the Chinese Wushu Association conferred on him the "Wushu Promotion Award".

Mr Fu Qingquan (1971–) began practising boxing with his grandfather and father at the age of six, and received formal wushu training from childhood. In the 1980s he became a professional wushu athlete; from 1985 to 1987 he won the Shanghai Yang-style Taijiquan championship for three consecutive years; in 1988 he won the taiji-sword championship and was runner-up in Yang-style Taijiquan at the national taijiquan and taiji-sword competition; in 1989 he represented the national team in the China–Japan Taijiquan competition and won the Yang-style Taijiquan championship. In the same year he moved with his father to Australia and founded the Fu Shengyuan International Taijiquan Academy, and from 1995 he served as vice-chairman of the World Yongnian Taijiquan Federation. Because of his grandfather's death, Mr Fu Qingquan from 1997 gave up his superior living conditions and high remuneration abroad and returned to China to continue the Taijiquan cause his grandfather had left unfinished. In 1998 he was awarded the sixth duan of Chinese wushu. He is now based in China, promoting Yang-style Taijiquan to Singapore, Malaysia, Japan and other Southeast Asian countries.

Mr Fu Qingquan's Taiji movements are standardised, light and nimble, natural, combining form and spirit and full of beauty; he grasps the essence of Taijiquan deeply, and enjoys the reputation of "the young marshal of Taiji". He is not only outstanding in boxing skill but also has a set of teaching methods with striking characteristics. In teaching he is especially good at combining Taijiquan theory with practice — clear in structure, vivid in imagery and full of wit — so that people can enter the gateway of Taijiquan easily and happily. He upholds the family teaching, is optimistic and open-minded, resolves doubts and dispels confusion, and is quick-witted and experienced, embodying the style of a new generation of Taiji masters. He has taught boxing for many years in China and in Australia, Japan and other countries, always with the greatest success. In 1999 China Central Television broadcast his series of teaching films on Yang-style Taijiquan, sword, sabre and pushing hands, which met with an enthusiastic response. In Mr Fu Qingquan we see the fair prospects for the vigorous development of the Taijiquan cause in the 21st century.

Looking over the history of the development of Yang-style Taijiquan, the speed and breadth of its spread are unprecedented. This shows that Yang-style Taijiquan is indeed a good method of preventing illness and improving health, a form of physical training loved by the people and full of vitality. It may be believed that, through the common efforts and constant exchanges of the great body of Taijiquan enthusiasts, (Chapter One — A Brief History of Yang-style Taijiquan, book page 6)

Yang-style Taijiquan is certain to become an international sport and to make a still greater contribution to the physical culture of the peoples of the world.

(Chapter Two — A Detailed Analysis of the Teaching and Practice Methods of Yang-style Taijiquan Movements, book page 7)

Chapter Two A Detailed Analysis of the Teaching and Practice Methods of Yang-style Taijiquan Movements

BOOK PAGE 7

Explanation of the Illustrations in This Book

Explanation of the Illustrations in This Book

1. The movement photographs printed in the "key points of the movement" sections of Chapter Two are all of Fu Qingquan performing the form.

2. So that readers may conveniently check the direction of each posture against the illustrations, the directions of the movements shown in the figures of this book are defined as follows: facing the reader equals south; back to the reader equals north; the reader's right side of a figure facing the reader equals west; the reader's left side equals east. Once one is proficient, or when the space does not permit, one may begin in any chosen direction — one need not start by standing facing south.

3. In order to help readers understand the whole process of the movement of the hands and feet, and their coordination with the trunk, this book has added further illustrations, so that the paths of the hands and feet at every stage of a movement and their coordination are made clearer.

4. Some movement illustrations, in the interest of continuity, inevitably end up with the figure's back to or side-on to the reader; for these, this book has added front views and side views as references for practice.

5. For some rather complicated movements whose process is not easy to grasp, this book has added illustrations to help comprehension.

Repetition of movements enables the learner to understand the process of the same movement when it is joined before and after in different ways. For example, in Grasp the Bird's Tail there is

the difference between the join with the left ward-off and the join without it; left Brush Knee and Twist Step connects to Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch, or to Turn Body and Throw the Fist, and the connection to Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch may have the transitional movement of shifting the weight back with the left hand sinking and the right fist extending forward, or may not have that transitional movement (Chapter Two, First Posture — Preparation, book page 8)

— and so on, so that the learner in practice can appreciate that when the same movement (posture) is joined to different movements (postures), the manner of the join is different in each case.

BOOK PAGE 8

First Posture　Preparation (Yubei Shi)

First Posture　Preparation (Yubei Shi)

1. Course of the Movement

Stand naturally, the feet a shoulder-width apart, the toes pointing forward (parallel); the arms hang naturally, the shoulders sunk and the elbows dropped. The head must be upright, with the intention of a suspended crown. The eyes look straight ahead (this is based on starting from a stance facing south); be relaxed, quiet and natural (see Figure 1).

2. Key Points

1. One must "suspend the crown with insubstantial energy", "contain the chest and raise the back", "keep the coccyx centred and upright", "sink the qi to the cinnabar field", and relax the whole body.

2. Both arms must relax and hang naturally, the shoulder joints relaxed, the fingers naturally slightly curved.

3. The body's centre of gravity falls evenly on both feet, so that one "stands with the body centred and at ease".

4. The mind must be quiet and the thoughts concentrated.

3. Requirements

1. The body is upright and natural; one must not arch the chest, protrude the belly, lower the head, lean forward, round the back or stick out the buttocks. From the crown of the head to the tailbone the body must be vertical; the whole body is relaxed and natural, with no place tense.

2. The Baihui point on the crown of the head is lightly lifted upward (as if a rope were suspended from above the head drawing it up), so that the head is naturally vertical, guarding against tipping forward or backward or leaning to left or right. The suspended-crown energy should be as if present and as if absent — one must not force the head stiffly upward.

3. The lips are naturally closed and the tip of the tongue lightly curled up, resting lightly against the upper palate. Breathe naturally, with the gradual aim of achieving abdominal breathing. The gaze looks straight ahead into the distance, and the mind is single-minded.

4. The lower body is steady and the upper body is light and nimble.

4. Errors Easily Made, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Error: raising the head, lowering the head, tilting the head, or tension in the neck muscles. (First Posture — Preparation, book page 9)

— and so on. This is mainly because the neck is over-strained or strained improperly, and the eyes look up, down or sideways. Correction: ① relax the neck naturally. ② the eyes should look straight ahead. ③ draw the chin slightly inward.

2. Error: arching the chest. This is mainly because one is not relaxed enough, the shoulders are tensed backward, and one uses thoracic (chest) breathing; without containing the chest it is hard to neutralise an attack. From the health point of view, arching the chest stiffens the upper body and restricts the movement of the respiratory muscles. Correction: ① relax both shoulders and bring them slightly forward to close, letting both arms hang naturally. ② breathe naturally.

3. Error: hollowing (concaving) the chest. This is mainly because one pursues "containing the chest" to excess. Correction: the shoulders should not come too far forward, nor should the belly protrude.

4. Error: rounding the back. This is mainly because "raising the back" is done improperly, which hinders "rolling energy" and "releasing energy". Correction: with the first to fourth thoracic vertebrae — the highest part of the middle of the back — the intention is to bulge and lift them, drawing slightly back and upward, rather than deliberately rounding the back.

5. Error: standing with the feet splayed outward (a "V" stance). This is mainly because one uses one's ordinary relaxed way of standing. Correction: the feet parallel; the legs straight but the muscles not tightened — that is, not standing "dead": there must be substance within emptiness and emptiness within substance.

6. Error: clamping the arms tight. This is mainly because the muscles of the shoulders and arms are too tense and the shoulders are not loosened. Correction: the armpits must be loosened, leaving a space the size of a fist; this benefits the free passage of the axillary artery and vein and of the median, ulnar and radial nerves beneath the armpit, and benefits the blood supply and nervous control of the whole upper limb.

7. Error: scattered thoughts, or fixing on one point. This is mainly because a beginner's attention is not easily concentrated, or is distracted onto some one local movement. Correction: first value the form, then value the intention, and thereafter "first the intention moves, and then the form moves", until inner and outer are united; as the practice deepens with time, one can gradually reach the advanced stages of Taijiquan described as "not in the form but in the momentum, not on the outside but on the inside" and "value the intention, not the form".

5. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Repeatedly open the feet to left and right. Experience the position and direction of the feet and the relaxation and quietness of the body.

2. Check from top to bottom the correct requirements for the head, shoulders, hands, chest, abdomen, buttocks and feet. The practitioner checks each item himself, while the teacher checks from the front, (First/Second Posture, book page 10)

the side and the rear, correcting any problems found.

3. After standing relaxed, take several natural breaths, experiencing depth, length, fineness, evenness and slowness; one should gradually experience "moving the body with the qi, and making sure all is smooth and unobstructed".

4. The teacher must first establish the movement concept in the practitioner. Explain the key points and requirements of standing, so that the practitioner understands that the Preparation posture is meant to bring thought, spirit and body into the state for practising Taijiquan and to clear away distracting thoughts — that is, to put aside for the time being the things one usually thinks about too much, to devote oneself single-mindedly to the practice, and to give the cerebral cortex alternating rest. Stand well in a comfortable and reasonable position, relax the whole body, and let the qi and blood flow freely.

5. Use a heuristic method of teaching, to arouse the practitioner's enthusiasm for learning.

6. Breathing

The student should adopt the method of natural breathing.

7. Technical Analysis

The Preparation posture, as its name implies, is the stance that makes one ready before practising the form. It requires that at the beginning of practice one first stand well in a natural posture, attaining "a quiet mind", "intention", "a relaxed body" and "an upright body"; intention, body and qi are to be trained together. In practice one must be quiet and relaxed, with the qi and blood flowing freely, and must pay attention to the breathing. The breathing of Taijiquan derives from the ancient arts of daoyin (guiding and pulling) and tuna (expelling and absorbing), making the movement and the breathing naturally coordinated so as to achieve "the union of spirit and form"; it further requires that the postures of every part of the body be correct. Therefore the

Preparation posture must not be regarded as a simple ordinary standing; one must deeply experience the method of training in which inner and outer are united, and it must on no account be slighted.

BOOK PAGE 10

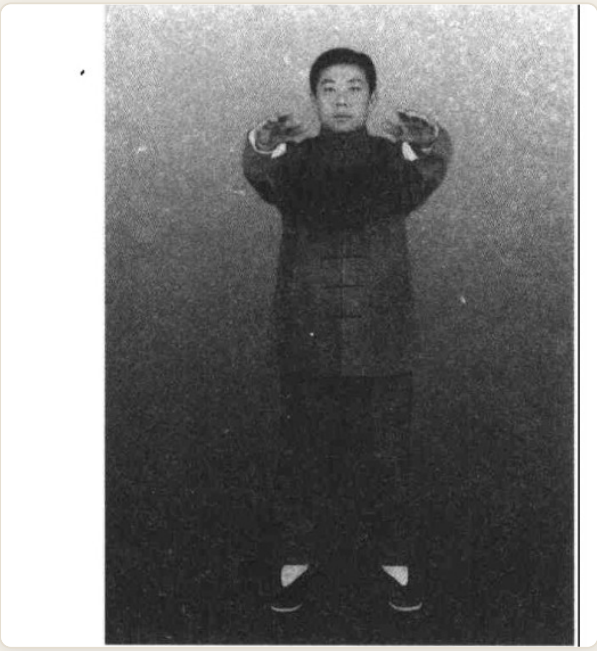
Second Posture　Beginning the Form (Qishi)

Second Posture　Beginning the Form (Qishi)

1. Application

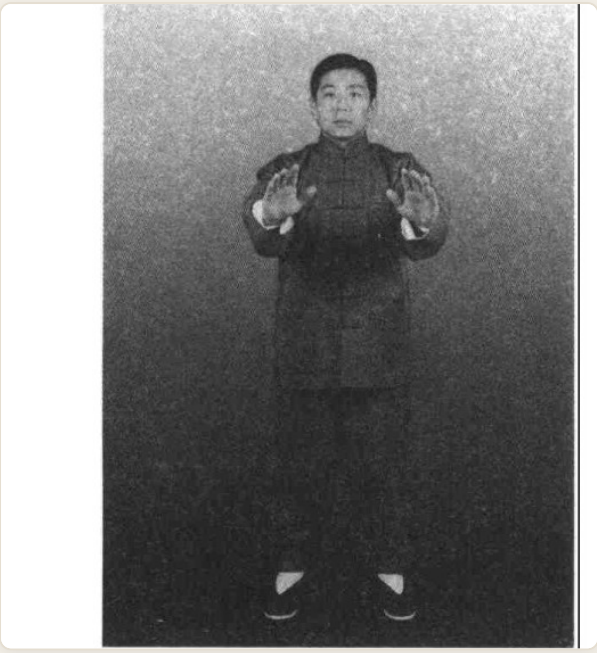
Beginning the Form is the stance of the preparatory movement of Taijiquan. On standing, the head must be upright, the intention must contain the suspended-crown energy, the eyes look straight ahead, the chest is contained and the back raised, and one must not lean forward or backward. The shoulders must be sunk and the elbows dropped, the fingertips pointing forward, the palms facing downward; loosen the waist and hips, and, with the toes squarely to the front and the feet planted straight, the feet are parallel and apart (Second Posture — Beginning the Form, book page 11)

图 2



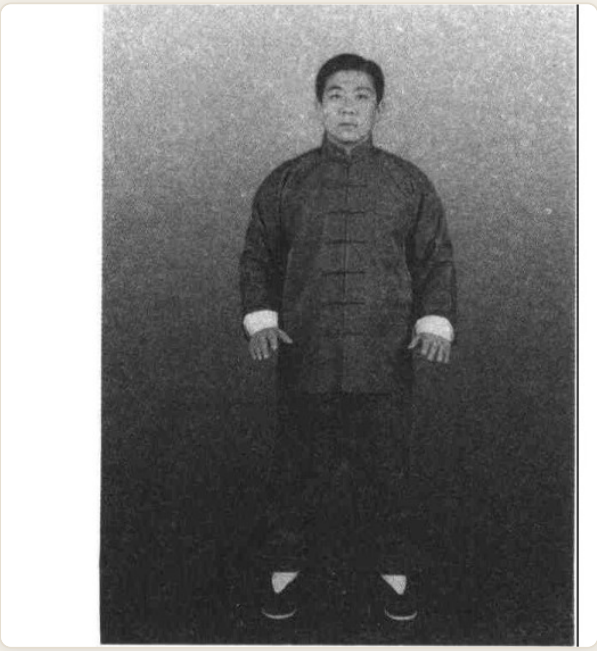
The arms are slowly raised in front of the body, the fingers naturally slightly spread, the palms facing downward, at shoulder distance.

图 3



When the hands have risen to about shoulder height, the shoulders sink and the elbows drop; the elbows lead the arms as the wrists are seated and pressed downward, drawing inward as they press down.

图 4



When the arms are about to straighten but are not yet straight, the wrists are seated, the elbows hang down, and the palms come to rest in front of and to the side of the hips, the heels of the palms slightly forward of the body's centre line.

apart, a shoulder-width. In particular, one must pay attention to consolidating the spirit within, sinking the qi to the cinnabar field, and letting everything be natural without forcing. Guard my own stillness in order to await the other's movement — only thus can inner and outer be united and both the exercise and its application be complete. Many people are only too apt to neglect Beginning the Form, not knowing that this is the very root of both the training method and its application. The learner is urged to put his first attention on practising this movement well.

2. Course of the Movement

1. Both hands are slowly raised from in front of the body, the fingertips pointing forward, the fingers naturally slightly spread, the palms facing downward, at shoulder distance (see Figure 2).

2. When the two hands have risen to about the height of the shoulders, first sink the shoulders; then, with the elbows leading the arms and the wrists seated, press downward, drawing inward as you press down (see Figure 3).

3. Press down until the arms are about to straighten but are not yet straight (forming an arc); seat the wrists, let the elbows hang down, the fingers still pointing forward, the palms angled slightly inward toward the sides of the hips but basically facing downward and parallel to the ground, coming to rest in front of and to the sides of the hips, with the heels of the palms slightly forward of the body's centre line (see Figure 4).

4. The eyes look straight ahead.

3. Key Points

1. Perform Beginning the Form only after the Preparation posture meets the requirements.

2. "First in the mind, then in the body": when raising the arms, first be aware of how they are to be raised, and only then raise them slowly. First put the attention on lifting the wrists; move the arms with the intention and lead the qi through to the fingers; seek stillness within movement, with the attention concentrated on the movement.

3. Consolidate the spirit within, sink the qi to the cinnabar field, let the movement be natural and do not force it.

4. All the joints of both arms must be loosened; the shoulders must be relaxed and sunk, the elbows should hang down, the wrists seated, the palms slightly extended, the fingers slightly curved, the palms naturally hollowed slightly inward and slightly curved. In this way, as days and months accumulate, the inner energy passes from the feet to the legs, to the waist, and takes form in the fingers; by this correct method of practice the inner energy arises of itself.

5. Loosen the waist and hips.

6. When pressing down, the shoulders must lead the elbows and the elbows must lead the hands.

4. Requirements

1. When pressing down, the tip of the elbow (the olecranon) must point downward throughout. (Second Posture — Beginning the Form, book page 12)

2. The path of the hands is to sink as they draw in.

3. The palms do not move purely horizontally up and down; rather, the two palms should be angled slightly inward and the backs of the hands angled slightly outward.

4. There must be room left at the armpits — they must not be clamped shut.

5. Head, chest, abdomen and feet remain natural.

6. The arms must be light, nimble and rounded, yet at the same time extremely soft and heavy; they must not float and drift.

7. Ordinary practitioners tend to neglect the simple movement "Beginning the Form", but if the form as a whole is to have a good beginning, one must practise this movement well.

5. Errors Easily Made, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Error: lifting the shoulders when raising the arms. The main cause is tension in the shoulders. Correction: the shoulders must be relaxed and sunk; the shoulders must lead the elbows and the elbows must lead the hands.

2. Error: when pressing down, the tips of the elbows (the olecranon) lift sideways. The main cause lies in bending the elbows outward and pressing both palms down in a completely horizontal plane. Correction: the two palms are angled slightly inward, the forearms rotate slightly outward, and the tips of the two elbows point straight down.

3. Error: the path of the hands is wrong. The main cause is that when pressing down one does not lead the hands with the elbows. It shows as: ① pressing straight down with the arms extended. ② drawing the palms in flat first, then pressing straight down. ③ going down first, then drawing in. Correction: draw in and press down at the same time.

4. Error: not seating the wrists. The main cause is that the energy is in the palms and not in the wrists. Correction: the moment the elbows go down, seat the wrists at once, and keep them so all the way down until the arms are about to straighten.

5. Error: the arms and hands are too relaxed, floating and without strength — this is called "drifting". The main cause is failure to grasp that the inner energy passes from the feet to the legs, to the waist, and takes form in the fingers, and that the intention is not consolidated within. Correction: when raising forward, do not let the wrists droop slackly; when pressing down, seat the wrists.

6. Error: when pressing down, before the hands have reached their place one goes on to the next movement — Grasp the Bird's Tail. This lies mainly in not having a complete concept of the

movement. Correction: the two hands must slowly sink until the arms are about to straighten but are not yet straight, and only then take up Grasp the Bird's Tail.

6. Teaching Method and Practice Method

(Second Posture — Beginning the Form, book page 13)

1. Explain "let everything be natural" and "guard my own stillness": there must be no rigidity in any muscle or joint, the attention must be concentrated, and inner and outer must be united, with the intention leading the movement.

2. Demonstrate the width and height of the arms from the front; demonstrate the path of the hands and the action of the elbows from the side.

3. The teacher observes every detail of the movement from front and side, paying particular attention to "relaxation".

4. After practising the movement whole, do it in parts. First raise both arms forward to the horizontal, then press down (concentrating on improving the elbow and wrist action), and finally perform the movement whole.

5. If there are too many practitioners for the teacher to correct one by one, let the first row practise while the second row watches, then let the second row practise while the first row watches, alternating, so that the practitioners both help others by reporting what they have observed (the shortcomings present) and, through the help of others, come to understand their own errors and shortcomings and improve by comparison.

6. The teacher selects a fairly typical faulty movement, gives a pointed demonstration and explanation of it, and then demonstrates and explains the correct movement.

7. The practitioner must learn patiently and attend to improving details. First attend to improving the forward raise: do not lift the shoulders, the tips of the elbows (the olecranon) point downward, the palms angled inward. Then attend to the downward press: the elbows lead the wrists, the elbows sink, the wrists stand up, drawing inward and going downward at the same time. Press both hands down until the heels of the palms are at a position slightly forward of the body's centre line (to the outside of the groin).

8. Finally perform the continuous whole movement of raising up and pressing down.

7. Breathing

Natural breathing is the best; beginners in particular should attend to this, for if the breathing is not smooth and one ends up holding the breath, it is on the contrary bad for health.

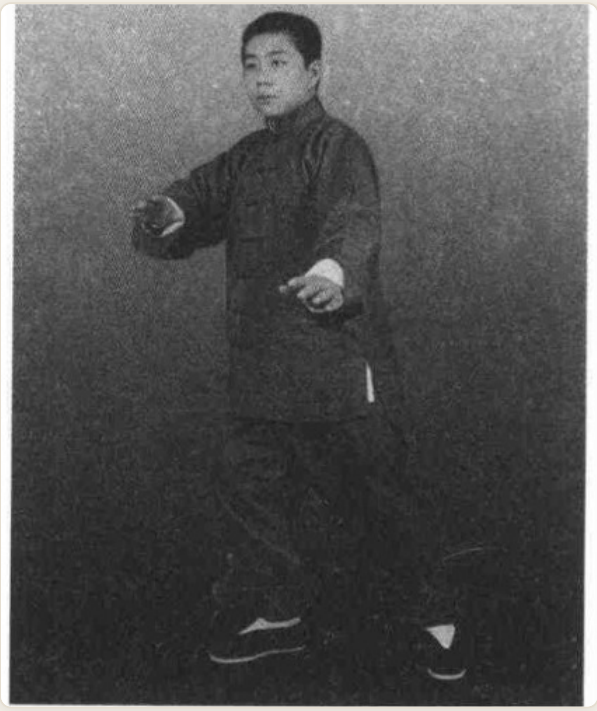
8. Technical Analysis

1. Although Beginning the Form is a preparatory movement, from the very start it is required to be different from other boxing systems: one must let everything be natural and not force it, and

concentrate the mind on practising the form.

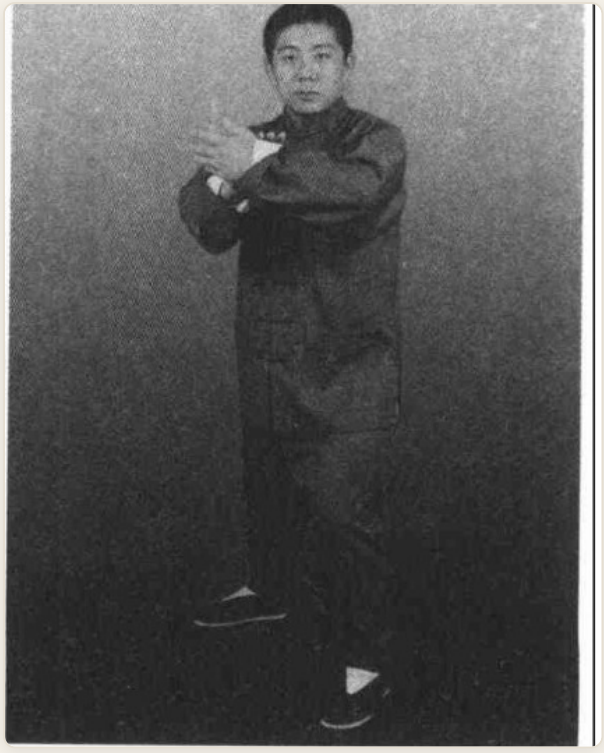
2. One must attend to the union of inner and outer and to completeness of both exercise and application, so that the nervous system is regulated and coordinated, the channels and blood vessels flow freely, the muscles and joints are exercised, health is improved and disease prevented and cured. Its application is to guard (Second/Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 14)

图 5A



The right toe turns out, the weight shifts onto the right foot, the body turns right, the right leg bends at the knee and squats slightly, the left leg bends at the knee and is lifted, and both hands, palms down, swing to the right with the turn of the waist.

图 5B



The right hand rises in an arc, passes in front of the abdomen and to the right and outside, then turns back with a small circular grind toward the chest, the palm still facing down; the left hand moves in an arc to the right past the front of the abdomen, gradually turning to an upright palm slightly tilted up.

my own stillness in order to await the other's movement; after long practice one gradually attains "the other does not know me, while I alone know the other". "When the movement is urgent, respond urgently; when the movement is slow, follow slowly." Hence the relaxation of every part of the body and the consolidation of the spirit within become extremely important.

BOOK PAGE 14

Third Posture　Grasp the Bird's Tail (Lan Que Wei)

Third Posture　Grasp the Bird's Tail (Lan Que Wei)

Grasp the Bird's Tail is the master movement of Taijiquan in which exercise and application are both complete. In pushing hands one is required to adhere, connect, stick and follow, going back and forth without leaving or breaking; the bird's tail is used as a metaphor for the arm, and it is taken as the general name for the movement. Its methods are four in number, called ward-off, roll-back, press and push, and they are also called the four cardinal hands.

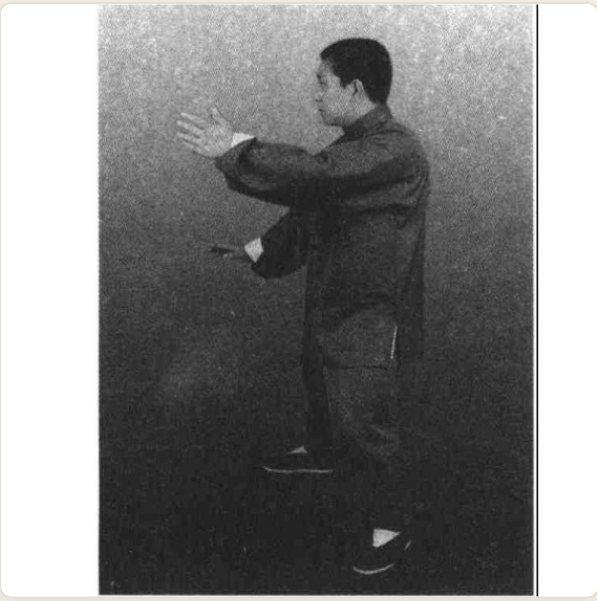
(A) Left Ward-off

1. Application From Beginning the Form: if the opponent strikes my chest from the front with his left hand, I open my right foot to the right side and settle it solid, then lift the left foot and step forward, bending the knee and settling solid, the right leg straight, forming a left bow stance with the left solid and the right empty. At the same time, bring the left hand up to the chest, palm facing inward, the elbow tip hanging slightly, and press my left wrist against the middle of the opponent's elbow-and-wrist, warding off forward and upward with a sideways energy (one must not be stiff and flat). Then the opponent's force is drawn along by me, and his position is naturally no longer stable.

2. Course of the Movement 1. The right toe turns out about 45°, and at the same time the weight shifts onto the right foot; the right leg bends at the knee and squats slightly, and the body turns right about 45°; the left leg bends at the knee and is lifted, and both hands, palms down, swing to the right with the turn of the waist, the right hand rising in an arc (right hand high, left hand low), passing above the front of the abdomen and then to the right and outside, and then turning back with a small circular grind toward the chest, the palm still facing down. The left hand moves in an arc to the right past the front of the abdomen, gradually turning to an upright palm slightly tilted up with the palm facing inward, until it meets in front of the right hand; the two arms form an arc, the elbows hanging slightly lower than the wrists, and the eyes follow the body, looking level toward the diagonal front (see Figures 5A and 5B).

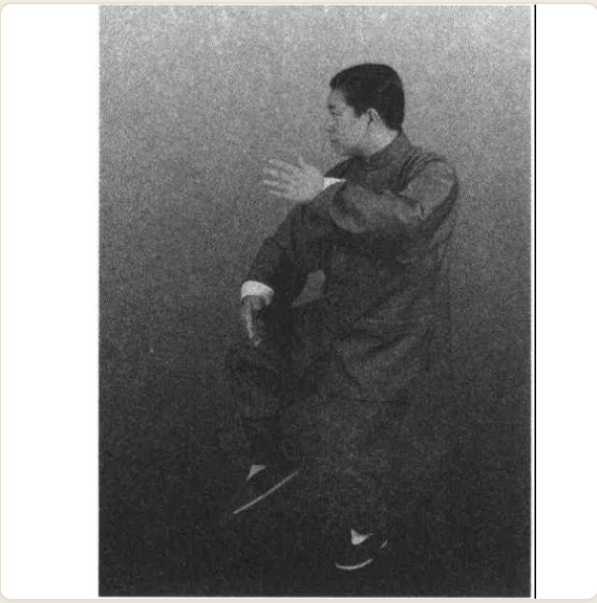
2. The right leg continues to squat slightly and settle solid; the left foot steps out to the left side (toward the south), the heel landing first, the toe angled inward about 45° (the toe pointing southwest, the left toe and the right heel on one line); the weight shifts left, forming a left bow stance settled solid. As the left foot steps out the upper body turns slightly (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 15)

图 6



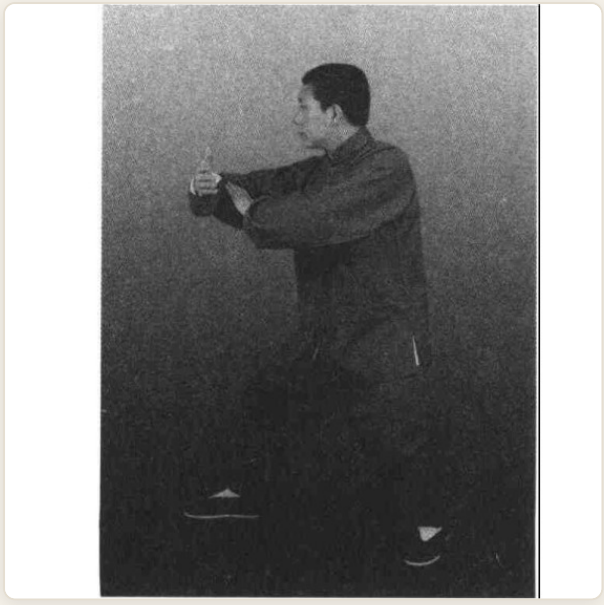
The left forearm wards out in an arc to the upper left with the body; the right palm gathers in an arc down to the lower right to slightly above the hip; the face is toward the west and the eyes look level ahead (west).

图 7



The whole weight shifts onto the left leg; the right foot bends at the knee and is lifted; the left elbow withdraws slightly downward and backward, and the left palm moves down to the left side of the chest; the right arm scoops in an arc to the left to the front of the abdomen, and the right arm rotates outward so that the palm turns facing inward and slightly upward.

图 8



The body turns slightly right; the right foot steps forward, the heel landing first; the right leg is bent and the left leg pushed straight to form a right bow stance; the right arm pushes forward and upward, with the point of force at the back of the wrist.

left, and after the left foot lands the upper body gradually turns right. At the same time, the left forearm, following the movement of the body, wards out first in an arc to the upper left, the left palm level with the shoulder, the wrist bent slightly inward, the point of force at the back of the wrist, the palm angled slightly upward. The right palm gathers in an arc down to the lower right to slightly above the hip, palm facing down, fingers pointing forward, wrist seated, the point of force at the outer side of the heel of the palm. At this moment the face is toward the west, the eyes look level ahead (west), but one must also be aware of both hands (see Figure 6).

(B) Right Ward-off

1. Course of the Movement 1. The weight gradually shifts entirely onto the left leg; the waist leads the body in a slight turn to the left, and the right foot bends at the knee and is lifted; as the body turns, the left elbow withdraws slightly downward and backward, naturally carrying the left palm down to the left side of the chest; as it moves down the left arm rotates inward, the palm becoming upright with the palm facing forward, and the gaze attends slightly to the withdrawal of the left arm. At the same time, the right arm scoops in an arc to the left to the front of the abdomen, and with the scooping motion the right arm rotates outward so that the palm turns facing inward and slightly upward; both arms form arcs, and the gaze gradually turns toward the right arm and then looks level ahead (southwest) (see Figure 7).

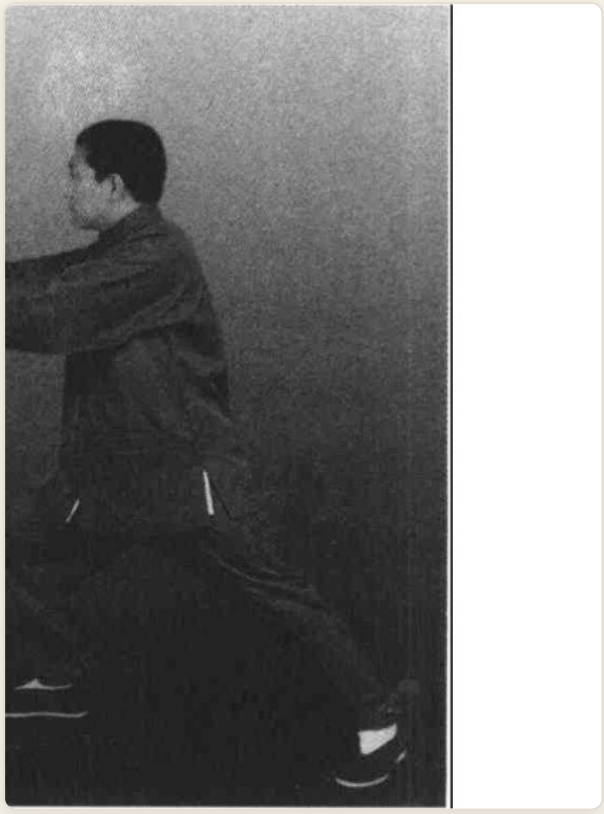
2. The body turns slightly right (facing west); the right foot steps forward (west), the heel landing first, and then the weight gradually shifts onto the right foot until it is entirely settled; the right leg

is bent and the left leg pushed straight to form a right bow stance. As the body turns, the right arm goes forward (west) and upward, the back of the right palm facing outward (the palm angled slightly upward), level with the shoulder, the elbow slightly lower than the palm; the left palm is placed slightly below the wrist joint, the right arm pushes forward, and the point of force is at the back of the wrist. The eyes look level ahead, and the gaze must attend to the forward ward-off of the right forearm (see Figures 8 and 9).

2. Key Points 1. The two legs distinguish the substantial and the insubstantial, and rise and fall like a cat walking. When the weight shifts to the left leg, the left is substantial and the right insubstantial; when it shifts to the right leg, the right is substantial and the left insubstantial. But "insubstantial" is not "empty": the momentum of movement must not break off, and room must be left for stretching and contracting at any moment; and so-called "substantial" does not mean using excessive force. In a bow stance the bend of the leg is limited to not passing the toes; beyond that is excess force. Beginners must first seek expansiveness and afterwards seek compactness.

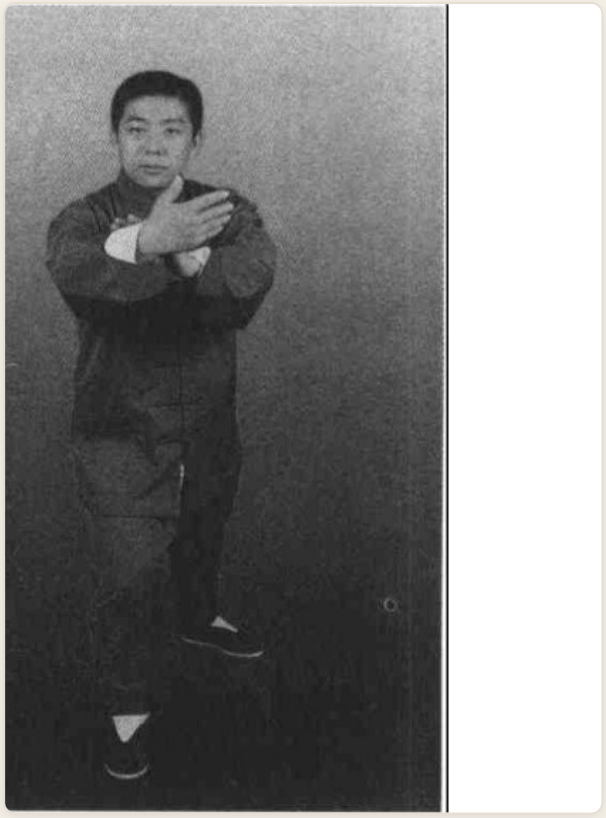
2. In the left ward-off the left hand must use the strength of the waist; one must not move only the hand without moving the waist and legs. "Palm, wrist, elbow and shoulder, back, waist, hip, knee and foot, above and below (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 16)

图 9A



The right arm pushes forward (west) and upward, the back of the right palm facing outward, level with the shoulder, the elbow slightly lower than the palm; the left palm is placed slightly below the wrist joint.

图 9B



A front view of the settled right bow stance: both arms form arcs, the right palm wards forward and the left palm is placed slightly below the right wrist joint.

nine joints of energy, and the energy issues from the waist joint by joint." The circulation of the inner energy is brought about by the waist and spine leading the four limbs; hence the boxing treatise says, "the master is in the waist."

3. When the right ward-off goes forward, the left palm acts as supporting energy.

4. The movement must form an arc — it must not go straight back and forth — but one must not be affected, nor deliberately make large circles. One must "store energy in the curve so that there is surplus".

5. One must "when one thing moves, nothing is unmoved": waist, feet and hands must move together; one must not have the feet move while the hands do not, or the hands move while the waist does not — this is what is meant by "above and below following one another".

6. The ward-off energy of Taijiquan is extremely important: the shoulder joints must be relaxed and sunk, the elbows dropped and the shoulders sunk; the arms must be extremely light, nimble and rounded, yet at the same time extremely soft and heavy; the two arms must be "as if relaxed yet not relaxed", "hardness and softness contained within", rich in elastic and tenacious ward-off energy. After long practice one comes gradually to understand the conversion of substantial and

insubstantial, to grasp adhering, sticking, connecting and following, and the quality of one's ward-off energy rises step by step.

7. One must value "seating the wrist". The wrist must not be slack and weak; once the wrist slackens, the back of the hand inevitably has no ward-off energy and one is easily seized by the opponent at the wrist and controlled — but one must not use clumsy force either.

3. Requirements

1. Wherever the eyes turn, the neck turns also.

2. To go right, first go left; to go left, first go right. When starting the left ward-off the body turns right, and the two hands should not be lifted straight to the right but should circle round to the left front — though one must not deliberately trace circles.

3. The substantial and insubstantial must be clear. At the start of the left ward-off the right heel turns, and the right leg immediately squats down and becomes substantial while the left foot is lifted and becomes insubstantial. In the change one must take care that the waist, leg and hip change gradually and not abruptly; the leg must be sent out slowly and drawn back slowly. The left ward-off is a left bow stance, with the left leg substantial; when taking up the right ward-off one lifts the right leg and then slowly steps it forward, and before the right heel has landed the weight must not shift forward — at this time the left leg is still the substantial leg, and only thus is the substantial and insubstantial clearly shown.

4. One must value the waist as the master. The waist must lead the four limbs; one must not have the arms move while the waist does not — for example, when the left ward-off takes up the right ward-off, the waist must lead the withdrawal of the left hand.

5. One must "when one thing moves, nothing is unmoved". At the start of the left ward-off the right arm goes (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 17)

forward, to the right, and in an inner arc round to the front of the abdomen, at which moment the left hand has moved from the left to the front of the abdomen, so that the two hands meet exactly — one hand must not stop there while the other is still moving.

6. In both the left ward-off and the right ward-off, when the posture is settled the hands and the feet should both have arrived: one must not have the leg already bent into the bow while the hands have not yet reached their place — above and below should follow one another.

7. One must "keep the coccyx centred and upright". In the left ward-off the upper body must not lean to the left; in the right ward-off the upper body must not lean forward too much.

8. In the right ward-off, when the right heel lands the left palm should immediately push forward along with the right arm; it must not be too late or too quick, and the knee, leg and waist of the left foot must gradually exert force, penetrating joint by joint.

9. The crotch must be opened; the two legs must not be clamped inward to form a "pointed crotch" shaped like the inverted-V of the character for "person".

10. There must be "union of shoulder and hip": above and below in accord, the two hips corresponding to the two shoulders and moving in the same direction. For example, in the settled posture of the left ward-off the shoulder faces west and the hip joint must also face west. At the start of the right ward-off the waist leads the left hand in a slight withdrawal downward and backward, and at that time the waist and hips turn toward the southwest and the shoulders must also turn toward the southwest, the right (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 18)

When the ward-off is completed, the waist and hips turn toward the west and the shoulders must also turn toward the west.

11. The two arms must be full and rounded. At the start of the left ward-off, when the two hands come together, they must be full and rounded, not collapsed, and it is best if the two wrists are basically opposite each other; the right arm must drop its elbow (the elbow lower than the wrist).

12. In the bow stance, the knee of the front bent leg should project slightly forward of the vertical line, but must not go beyond the toes. The knee and the toes should face the same direction; the sole and heel of the rear pushing leg must be entirely on the ground, and that leg should not be straightened too much.

4. Errors Easily Made, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Error: when moving the arm, the upper arm is clamped tight and moves pressed against the body. The main cause is insufficient loosening of the shoulders. Correction: from the very start of swinging the arms, loosen both shoulders and leave a gap under the armpits. This benefits the free flow of the channels, qi and blood.

2. Error: at the start of the left ward-off, when the hands come together, the left arm travels fast and arrives first, waiting for the right arm's circling. The main cause is that the attention was too much concentrated on the movement of the right arm, and the too-rapid movement of the left arm was overlooked. Correction: the two arms must move evenly.

3. Error: at the start of the left ward-off, when the hands come together, the hands are either too close to the body or too far from the chest and abdomen; too close forms the two arms clamped tight and pressing on the chest, and too far makes the movement "scattered". The main cause is that the two arms do not follow one another above and below, and the shoulders do not follow the hands. Correction: the posture must be full and rounded, not slack and not shrunken; the left wrist should be below the right wrist.

4. Error: when the hands come together the hands move but the waist does not. The main cause is that the hands are not led by the waist. Correction: the hands follow the turn of the waist.

5. Error: in the left ward-off, when the left leg steps out the heel lands very heavily and the weight shifts out too early. The main cause is that the substantial and insubstantial are not clear

and the right leg has not settled solid. Correction: the right leg settles solid; when the left leg extends it hangs suspended, and one must "send" the left leg to land by sitting down on the right leg, so as to step as a cat walks.

6. Error: in the left ward-off, the left bow stance is already bent forward but the two hands are still moving. The main cause is a shallow understanding of the key point "when one thing moves, nothing is unmoved". Correction: the hands and the feet must both arrive; at the same moment that the left leg bends into the bow the left arm should have warded out to its place — thus one meets the requirement. (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 19)

7. Error: in the bow stance the two feet are awkwardly placed. The main cause is that the two feet stand on one horizontal line. Correction: for the left ward-off, when the left foot steps it should come down slightly toward the rear, so that the left toe and the arch of the right foot are roughly on one line; for the right ward-off, when the right foot steps it should come down moved slightly to the right, so that the two feet have a certain lateral distance from one another and are not on one straight line.

8. Error: in the settled posture of the left ward-off the position of the two arms is wrong — the left hand too high or too low, the right hand too close to the body. The main cause is unclear intention. Correction: the opponent is striking my chest. My wrist presses between his wrist and elbow and wards forward and upward with a sideways energy. Therefore it is enough for its height to be about level with the shoulder; any higher and one's own "doorway" is opened and it is inconvenient to defend against the opponent's renewed attack. The right hand is a separating and gathering hand; if it is too close to the body there is no supporting energy, so the right hand is best placed about 30 cm in front of the hip.

9. Error: at the start of the right ward-off the left arm does not withdraw backward and the upper body does not turn slightly left. The main cause is that the waist does not lead the hands and the wrist and waist are out of joint. Correction: before moving the hands, turn the waist first, and the turn of the waist leads the withdrawal of the left hand; the left elbow hangs down, and the left palm turns to an upright palm as it sweeps aside.

10. Error: when beginning the right ward-off the left leg is not settled solid, so that the weight shifts forward too early (the right foot landing heavily and fast). The main cause is an unclear concept of substantial and insubstantial. Correction: keeping a slight bend and squat, "send" the foot out so that the right heel lands lightly — then the movement appears light and nimble.

11. Error: the direction is skewed — the left ward-off goes either southeast or southwest, and the right ward-off does not face squarely west. The main cause is that the direction of the step is not correct. Correction: I originally stood facing south; the opponent, facing north, strikes at my chest with his left hand, so my left ward-off should of course be toward the south, and not southeast or southwest. Then the opponent, on the west side, strikes at my side ribs with his left hand; I step to the west, ward out, roll back and press, and therefore the direction of the right ward-off should be due west.

12. Error: lifting the elbow in the right ward-off. The main cause is a failure to understand the downward-dropping energy of the elbow. Correction: if the elbow is lifted away from the body and juts outward, the two ribs are too much exposed, which in combat is harmful and not beneficial. But one must also attend to "the elbow not pressing against the ribs". (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 20)

13. Error: in the right ward-off the upper body leans too far forward, so that the head goes beyond the knee. The main cause is inattention to the requirement of keeping the coccyx centred and upright. Correction: above and below must be basically on one line, shoulders united with hips and withdrawing together; from the crown of the head through the trunk to the tailbone one must always keep basically to one line. Leaning forward or tipping back are both faults of body method.

5. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explain the key points to establish the concept, and demonstrate the movement whole. Lay emphasis on performing the movement on a foundation of relaxation and on clearly distinguishing substantial and insubstantial.

2. To practise skill, first practise energy; to practise energy, first practise smoothness. Therefore one should first teach the course of the movement and its requirements, first seek correctness of movement, and only afterwards practise issuing energy.

3. While the practitioners try the movement, the teacher observes the correctness of their movements from every side.

4. At the crucial points the teacher should give a spoken cue: for example, when one foot has stepped out but has not yet come down, the teacher should say, "slow — light — the heel comes down." When drawing the leg back, one should also cue "slow".

5. In teaching the footwork, one requires that the leg turn first and then lead the hip and foot, after which one advances along an arc. The arced stepping must not be affected; every movement must be observed and improved; one must not go straight back and forth or straight up and down.

6. The comparative method may be used. With several tens of people practising together, all settle one leg solid and step the other leg forward; from drawing the leg in to extending it and landing, see who is slowest, with the proviso that it be without pausing; two or three people may also form a circle and compare together.

7. Use the method of division in teaching: ① both hands swing right while the body turns and grinds the right heel — attend to fixing the direction. ② the right leg squats and the left foot is lifted, preparing to step forward-left — attend to the landing position of the left foot. ③ the right hand circles in a large circle while the left hand closes in a small circle — attend to the position of the hands and their path of movement. ④ the left foot crosses and lands — attend to the direction of the left toe. ⑤ the left hand wards up and the right hand gathers down, while the left

leg bends into the bow. Practise in this order one at a time, so that the practitioner can easily understand the details of the movement; but practising only in parts easily produces discontinuity, so one must use the progressive method, joining them one by one until the whole is complete. (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 21)

8. The progressive method: its steps are as follows: (1) first do movement ①, then movements ①②, then movements ①②③; (2) at the position of movement ③ do movement ④, then movements ④⑤; (3) finally perform the complete single movement "left ward-off".

9. Combined practice with the application: two people stand facing each other (the practitioner is A, the opponent is B). A — stands facing south; B — strikes at A's chest with his left fist (the movement should be slow and without force, to prevent injury). A — at once turns right about 45°, squats on the right leg, steps the left foot out to the left, presses the wrist of his left hand between B's elbow and wrist, wards out forward and upward with a sideways energy, and gathers down with the right hand (A's hand must stay adhering to the upper ward-off, and must not strike hard), experiencing the combative meaning of the left ward-off. In this way one can correctly understand the intention of the movement and increase the practitioner's interest.

10. Auxiliary practice: ① The right leg bends at the knee and sits solid; the left knee is lifted slowly and evenly from the left rear, then slowly stepped to the left, and the left leg bends into the bow. Then return to the original position and repeat the practice. This is to experience the substantial and insubstantial and to strengthen the legs. ② The left leg sits solid, with the same requirements, and the right leg steps forward; repeat the practice likewise.

The above practices may, as needed, serve as practice to increase the amount of exercise; the number of repetitions is to be decided by the practitioner's constitution.

11. The method of emphasis: for beginners, each practice session should have a clear emphasis according to plan — for example, if substantial-and-insubstantial is the main theme, then speak more on matters relating to substantial and insubstantial and practise more of the exercises relating to it. Other requirements may be passed over for the time being and deepened step by step. Once the movements are basically mastered, then take the commoner and more prominent problems as the emphasis for further explanation and practice; one must on no account explain everything and do everything at once — after one session the practitioners mostly do not understand and cannot do it well, which dampens their enthusiasm for learning.

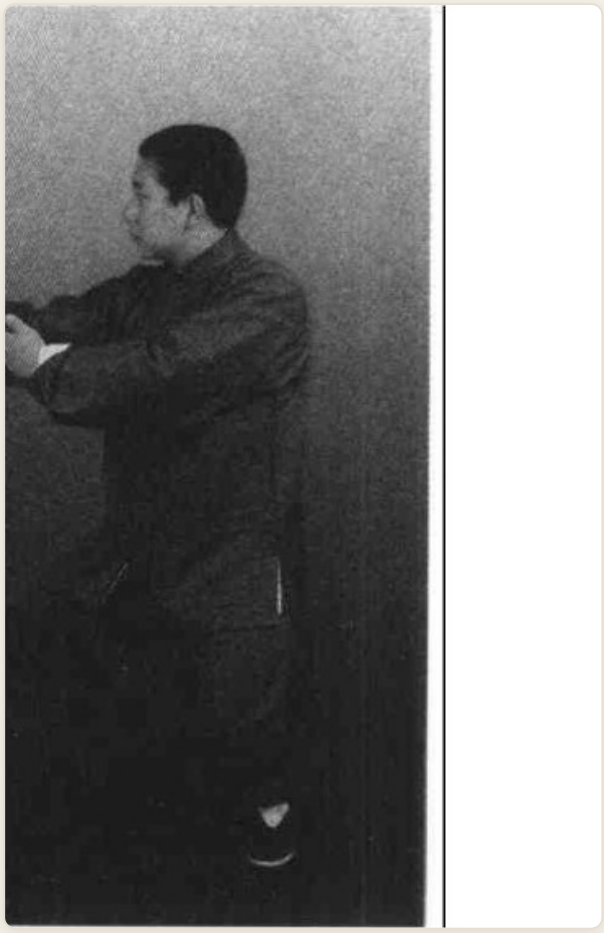
12. The practitioner should repeatedly do the right turn of the body at the start of the left ward-off, the squatting of the right leg, and the outward turn of the right solid foot of about 45° (not up to 90°); hence the angle of the outward turn should also be checked.

13. Repeatedly do the right turn of the body and the squat with the two hands coming together, checking that the two hands arrive at the same time, the position of the two hands, the dropping of the elbows, and so on.

14. In the movements of the left ward-off and the right ward-off, emphasise practising the clear distinction of substantial and insubstantial. For example, in practising the left ward-off, sit solid

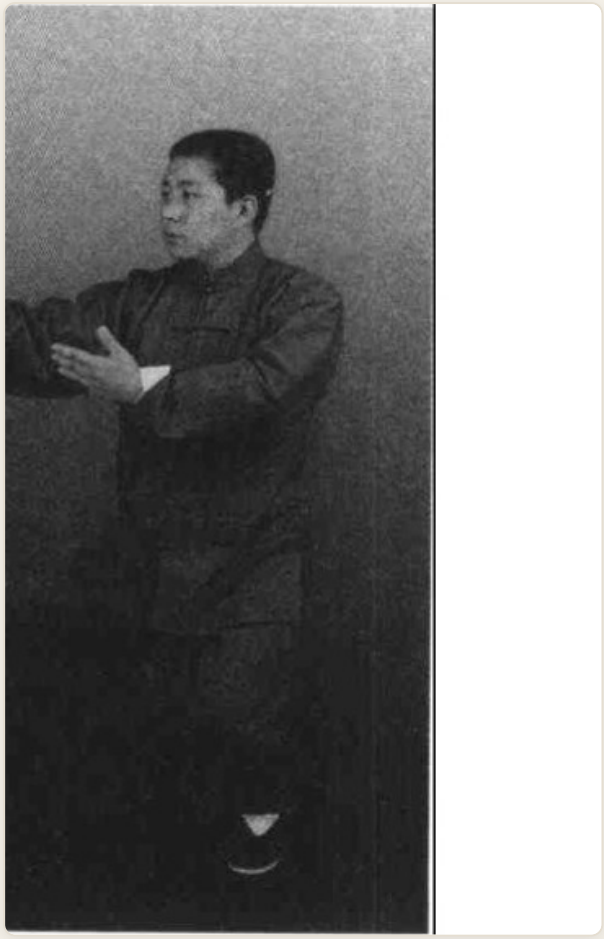
on the right leg and extend the left leg to the left, not (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 22)

图 10



The weight gradually shifts onto the left leg; the body turns vertically and gradually to the left; the left arm rotates inward so that the palm turns facing obliquely inward and upward; the wrist of the right arm extends slightly forward.

图 11



The right palm rolls over and rolls level to the left; the two elbows slowly drop downward, and the two palms roll level to the left.

land and then draw back, then extend again; practise repeatedly, experiencing the substantial and insubstantial (the same applies in the right ward-off). The result of such practice is inevitably to strengthen the legs and thereby promote health.

15. Repeatedly perform the left foot's heel landing and its inward turn of about 45°, checking the direction of the left foot.

16. Repeatedly practise stepping out, taking care first to draw in slightly the hip root of the side that is sitting solid, so that the abdomen of that side is full and the centre of gravity stable. Then the other leg is slowly stepped out along an arc. But the knee joint must be slightly bent, preserving stored force and flexibility.

(C) Roll-back (Lu)

1. Application I am in the left ward-off position (facing west). The opponent strikes at my side ribs with his left hand. I immediately draw in my right leg and step it forward to the right (west), bend the knee and set it solid, the left foot becoming insubstantial, and the body turns to

the right at the same time; the eyes follow, looking level ahead; both hands circle and move out to the right front, the right hand in front with the palm facing sideways inward, the left hand behind with the palm facing sideways inward; when the right palm has turned sideways downward and the left palm upward, quickly press the side (the ulnar side) of the space between the elbow and wrist of my right arm against the opponent's right upper arm, and with the left wrist bent sideways press and adhere the wrist and palm to the back of the opponent's wrist and up the arm, toward the outer left. The whole body sits on the left leg, with the left foot substantial and the right foot insubstantial. If the opponent attacks, I roll toward my chest and to the left side; then his root force is uprooted and his body is thrown off balance accordingly.

Variations: ① If the opponent tries to withdraw his arm, I take the opportunity to press forward. ② If the opponent attacks with a shoulder stroke, I add a left step, right foot in an insubstantial stance (toe touching the ground), contain the chest, and strike the opponent's left shoulder with my right hand, so that he falls out to the left.

2. Course of the Movement 1. The body's weight gradually shifts onto the left leg, and at the same time the body turns vertically and gradually to the left; the left arm rotates inward so that the palm turns facing obliquely inward and upward; the wrist of the right arm extends slightly forward, then immediately rotates outward so that the right palm turns facing obliquely outward and downward; the two elbows slowly drop downward, and the two palms roll level to the left (see Figure 10).

2. The waist continues to turn slightly to the left, and the weight continues to shift onto the left leg, (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 23)

the left leg sits solid, forming a right insubstantial stance; but the two arms drop their elbows slightly and continue to roll left with the turn of the body; the left palm comes to rest in front of the upper left abdomen and the right palm in front of the right chest, the right hand slightly higher and the left slightly lower. At the start of the left roll the gaze first attends to the left roll of the right arm, and as it is about to end the gaze attends slightly to the left hand, and then gradually turns to look ahead (west, slightly south) (see Figure 11).

3. Key Points

1. In the roll, the distance between the two hands must be the same as in the roll of pushing hands — that is, the right hand rests on the opponent's upper arm near the elbow, and the left hand rests on the opponent's wrist, in order to draw him in. In the rolling transformation the distance between the hands does not change, and it coordinates with the movement of the feet; this is called "the two arms being linked above".

2. In the left roll the body must always turn squarely, without leaning forward or tipping back or swaying; the key is that above and below follow one another, "neither first nor last". If one sits back too fast or too slowly, the waist and legs will come out of joint.

3. In advancing and retreating, turning left and right, one must achieve "union of shoulder and hip"; the shoulders and hips must always maintain a natural vertical relation above and below, satisfying the requirement of "basically one line above and below".

4. The two arms must roll left with the turn of the waist; the two palms must not be too far apart, but the two upper arms must not be clamped tight against the ribs either. Dropping the elbows serves to protect the ribs, and a gap about one fist wide must be left at the two armpits. The elbows not pressing the ribs leaves the arms room to circle, so that one does not trap one's own body. All subsequent movements in the form should be the same.

5. As to the direction of the roll, from its outward appearance, because the left leg is settled solid, it looks as though the two palms tend slightly downward; in fact this is due to sitting on the left leg — the correct movement should be to roll level to the left. Therefore rolling to the lower left or rolling downward are both wrong movements.

6. One must bring into play the functions of adhering, connecting, sticking and following, of not losing contact and of drawing the opponent in and making him land on nothing, and must use the wrist and palm to lead the opponent's centre of gravity.

7. One must value seating the wrist, and should generally attend to relaxed softness and flexibility. If during practice the wrist is weak and powerless, the inner energy cannot easily be poured through to the fingers, which affects the accumulation and growth of the ward-off energy of the arms, and inevitably affects the effective use of "roll", "ward-off", "press", "push" and "seize", and the effectiveness of breaking free from the opponent's "gather" and "seize" hand methods. (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 24)

4. Requirements

1. The substantial and insubstantial must be clearly distinguished, and moreover there must be substance within insubstantiality and insubstantiality within substance. "Insubstantial" is not total emptiness, not utter absence of strength; "substantial" is not standing completely dead. One must have "yin and yang each as the root of the other" — that is, substantial and insubstantial must interpenetrate. One must know that "double-weightedness brings stagnation; a single weighting brings liveliness".

2. In the roll one must not arch the chest; contain the chest and raise the back — but one must not "cat-hunch" either (hollowing the chest).

3. Loosen the waist and hips; the waist must lead the arms; one must not move only the hands without moving the waist.

4. Above and below must follow one another: the sitting back onto the left leg and the left roll of the two arms must move together and must not come apart, one before the other.

5. In the change of hand shape when taking up the roll from the right ward-off, the palms must not turn over straight up and down; rather, the two hands must trace a small arc slightly to the

right and outside and then turn back. One must be aware that after the two hands have circled, it is exactly the space between the elbow and wrist of my right arm that adheres to the opponent's left upper arm, my left wrist and palm adhering to the back of the opponent's wrist.

6. While sitting onto the left leg, the two arms begin to roll back in an arc toward the front of the body, and then gradually the waist turns and rolls level to the left and outside — one must not roll all the way back to the front of one's own body, for otherwise it is "drawing him in and letting him land solid". But neither should one send the two arms rolling to the left outside right from the start, for then one cannot get any advantage.

7. During the roll the shape of the two hands and the distance between them must not change — one must not change them up and down (left hand higher than right), front and back (shortening or widening the distance between the hands), or left and right (the left or right hand drawing close or pulling apart) — but must keep the distance between the rolling hands and the hand shape until the movement is finished.

5. Errors Easily Made, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Error: when beginning the change from the right ward-off to the roll, the two hands turn over straight up and down. The main cause is that one is unclear about the part of the opponent's arm to which the two hands adhere. Correction: the waist must lead the circling of the hands. The right hand goes from the back of the hand forward, turns to palm facing left, then turns to a diagonal pressing palm, and at the same time the hand extends forward-right and then turns back; the left hand turns from palm facing down to palm facing up, and at the same time the palm goes from the front to the right and then gathers back. (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 25)

2. Error: the two hands change shape during the roll. The main cause is a failure to understand the application of the roll. Correction: through "paired practice", experience why the position of the two hands should not change. Because what I roll is the opponent's left arm, one hand on the outer side of the elbow joint and slightly above it, the other on the outer side of the wrist joint — this determines the position of my two hands.

3. Error: the hands and feet come out of joint. Sometimes the left leg has already sat solid while the two hands are still moving; sometimes the two hands have already moved while the leg has not. The main cause is that above and below do not follow one another, each attending to itself. Correction: hands move and feet move; hands and feet arrive together.

4. Error: the body does not turn, and the face remains toward the west. The main cause is a failure to understand the application. Correction: I roll the opponent's left hand to the left with both hands. If I use only the strength of the two hands with the body unmoving, losing the cooperation of the waist, the result is that I draw him in and let him land solid, and the opponent's left fist strikes straight at my chest; but if the waist leads the hands, I can seize the opponent.

5. Error: the movements are not performed completely — rolling before the ward-off has reached its place, pressing before the roll is finished. The main cause is a failure to understand the application. Correction: when the opponent attacks, I must roll until the opponent's root is uprooted and his body is tilted, so of course I must roll to the full position; both excess and deficiency are bad.

6. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explain and demonstrate the application of the roll, so that the practitioner understands the concept of the movement.

2. Clarify the connections: do the circling well from the right ward-off, so that the preparatory movement of the roll is correct.

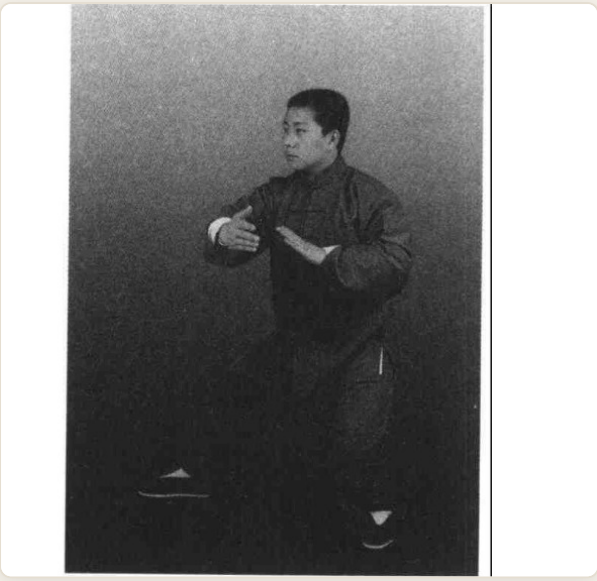
3. The teacher checks from the side that the left knee is squarely in the direction of the toes and the right knee slightly bent, then checks from the front the changes of the hands during the roll.

4. Repeatedly practise the circling of the two hands, becoming proficient in extending, circling and turning over the palms.

(D) Press (Ji)

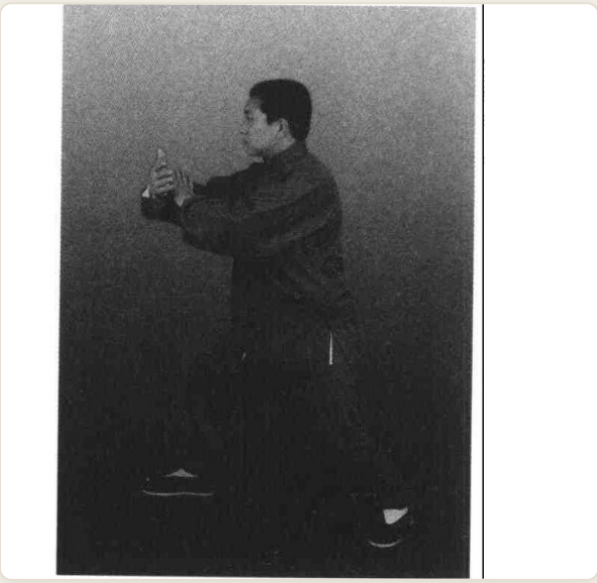
1. Application Following the previous posture: if the opponent draws his arm back, I immediately bend the leg and the right knee and set the right foot solid, straighten the left leg, extend the shoulder forward, and stretch and lengthen the waist, following as he retreats, the gaze also looking forward. At the same time, quickly turn over the right wrist (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 26)

图 12



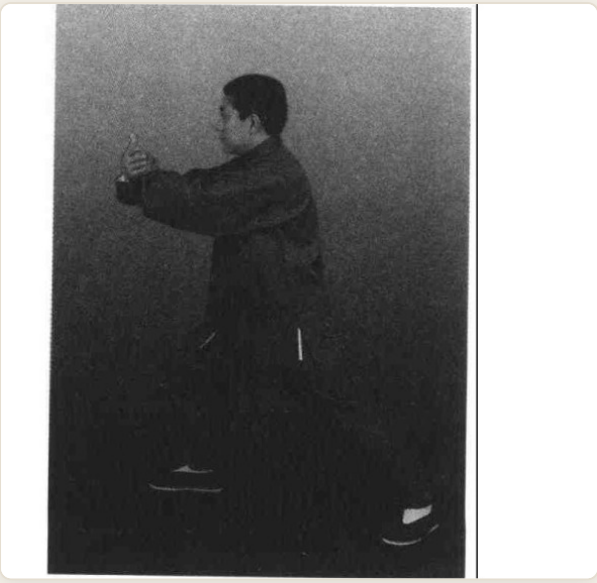
The settled right bow stance: the right arm forms an arc across the chest, and the left palm is attached to the inner side of the right forearm, pressing forward.

图 13



Side view of the press: the right arm rotates outward so that the right palm turns facing inward, and the left arm rotates inward so that the left palm turns facing outward, the fingers angled slightly upward.

图 14



Another side view of the press: the elbows sink, the right elbow slightly lower than the right wrist, and the heel of the left palm gradually comes close to the inner side of the pulse point of the right wrist as the press proceeds.

hands outward, and the heel of the left palm pressed to the inner side of the wrist joint of the right forearm; when he withdraws his arm, follow closely and press forward, the gaze directed forward.

2. Course of the Movement The body turns slightly to the right, and at the same time the weight gradually shifts onto the right leg; the right knee and leg bend into the bow and the left leg pushes, forming a right bow stance (facing west). As the body turns, the right arm rotates outward so that the right palm turns facing inward, and the left arm rotates inward so that the left palm turns facing outward, the fingers angled slightly upward; the right arm forms an arc across the chest, the elbow dropped (the right elbow slightly lower than the right wrist), and the left palm, attached to the inner side of the right forearm, presses forward (west), the heel of the left palm gradually coming close to the inner side of the pulse point of the right wrist as the press proceeds. The eyes look level ahead, and the gaze must attend to the right arm (see Figures 12, 13 and 14).

3. Key Points 1. In pressing forward the upper body should turn to the right, and the waist is the key to the turning of the upper body. "The master is in the waist, and it takes form in the fingers"; therefore, to move the hands one must first move the waist.

2. In pressing forward the upper body must not lean forward or tip back; the shoulders and hips must be opposite one another above and below.

3. The shoulders must not be hunched up but loosened and sunk. Whether the arms can be relaxed, soft and nimble depends on whether the shoulder joints can be loosened.

4. The elbows must not be raised, and the tips of the elbows must be slightly lower than the wrists; raising the elbows exposes the ribs and does not meet the requirements of combat.

5. The buttocks must not protrude; one must attend to drawing in the coccyx. If they protrude too much the head will inevitably lower and the back hunch, and one cannot achieve "the coccyx centred and the spirit reaching the crown". (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 27)

6. After the press, between the left palm and the right wrist there should be an "as if touching, as if not touching; as if relaxed, as if not relaxed" — hardness and softness contained within.

4. Requirements

1. In going from the roll to the press, the right hand must not circle widely.

2. In the press the two hands must not be too close to the chest, or they collapse; and once collapsed, it is easy to "land solid", which causes passivity.

3. Hands and feet must arrive together: one must not have the leg already bent to its position while the hands are still pressing.

4. When the front leg bends into the bow, the knee must not go beyond the toes; beyond that it is easy to lose balance, and it is also called "excess force".

5. In pressing out one must leave surplus: the two arms must not be stretched fully straight, but are required to be curved and not straight, "storing energy in the curve so that there is surplus".

6. In the press the two hands must adhere and then press forward (as if adhering, as if not): they must not be far apart, nor pressed tightly together.

7. The direction of the press must be correct.

5. Errors Easily Made, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

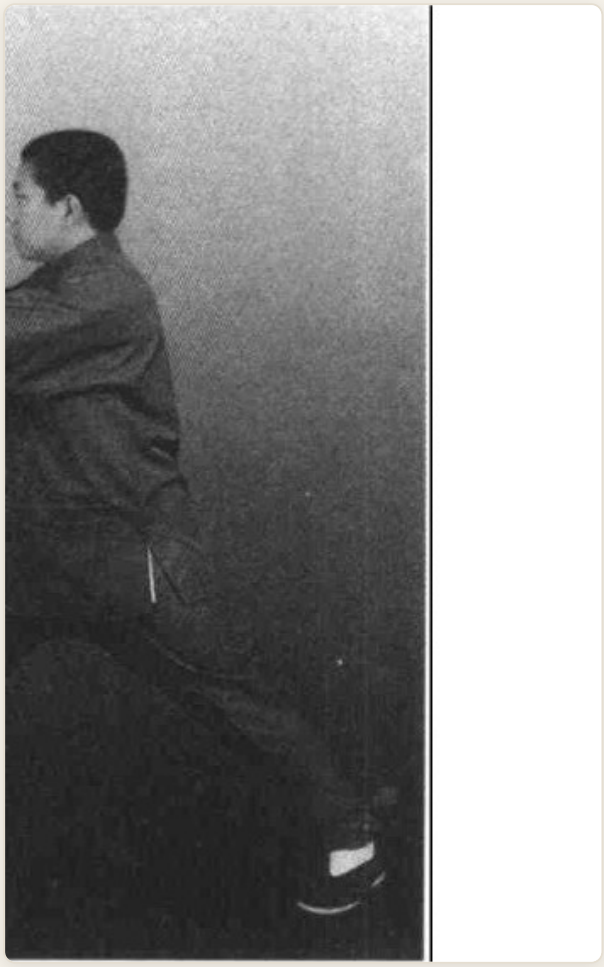
1. Error: the waist and hips are not relaxed and the movements are not nimble. The main cause is a shallow understanding of "the source of destiny and intention is in the waist crevice". Hence the movements appear sluggish and the arms float without strength. Correction: one must "at every moment keep the mind in the waist"; the waist and hips must be relaxed, sunk and held upright, and must turn slightly. If the waist and hips are not nimble, the waist and legs will find it hard to accord and follow one another.

2. Error: the hands move and the feet do not — the foot has already bent into the bow and the hands are still pressing. The main cause is a shallow understanding of "when one thing moves, nothing is unmoved": only if the energy passes from the feet to the legs, to the waist, and takes form in the fingers can there be pressing energy. In going forward there must be a support behind, otherwise the reactive force cannot be strengthened. Correction: hands move and feet move; hands and feet arrive together.

3. Error: raising the elbows. The main cause is failure to attend to sinking the shoulders and dropping the elbows and to keeping the two forearms level and exerting force. Correction: the two shoulders must sink, the elbows must be lower than the wrists, and the fingers of the left hand angled upward — only thus will the two elbows hang down naturally. Otherwise the two shoulders stiffen and the light and nimble energy is lost; and light nimbleness is not floating either — light nimbleness must be combined with steadiness, containing steadiness within.

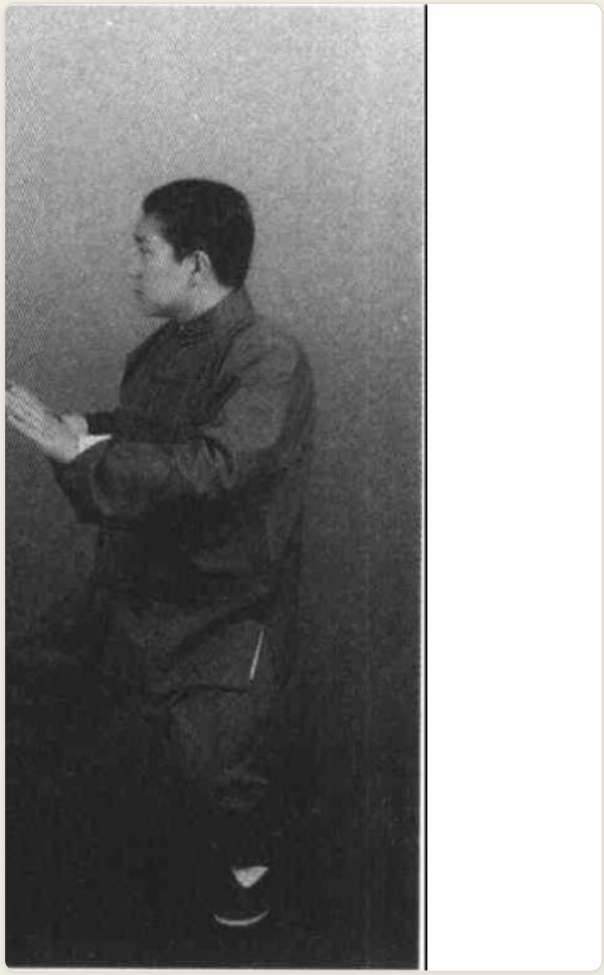
4. Error: in the press the two hands are too high or too low. The main cause is a failure to understand the application of the "press". If too high, the pressing force goes upward, (Third Posture — Grasp the Bird's Tail, book page 28)

图 15



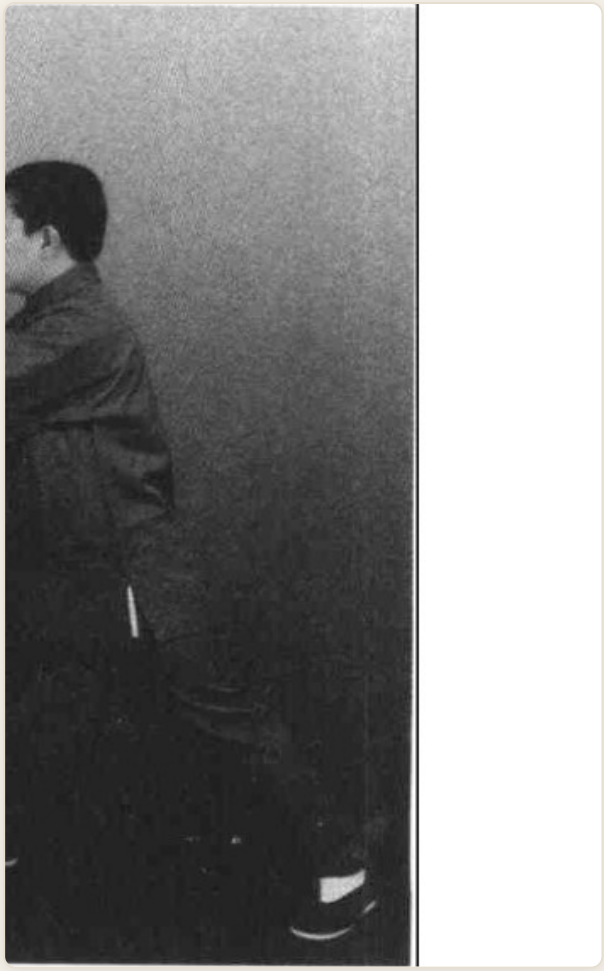
The two palms wipe back, wiping level back as the two elbows sink, the wrists slightly seated, both palms facing down; at the same time the weight gradually shifts back and the left leg sits solid.

图 16



As the wiping back is nearly complete, the two palms gradually become upright palms with the wrists seated, facing forward.

图 17



The two palms press forward, pressing level and straight, the width gradually narrowing; at the same time the right leg bends into the bow and the left leg pushes, forming a right bow stance.

is easily neutralised by the opponent, so that the aim of the press is not achieved, and moreover the front of the chest is empty and open to the opponent's attack; if too low it is also easily neutralised. Correction: press out from the front of the chest, level and straight forward.

5. Error: in the movement from the roll to the press the arc traced is too large. The main cause is a failure to understand the application. Two hands already adhering should not release and separate. Correction: the right wrist goes slightly down and then up, and the left hand follows upward, pressing forward. One must respond urgently to urgency and follow slowly to slowness.

6. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. The teacher demonstrates.

2. Explain the function of the press and the course of the movement.

3. As the connections are not easily grasped, repeatedly practise the turning over of the two palms, doing the preparatory movement of the press well.

4. Practise the movement whole.

5. Repeatedly practise the change of hand shape from the roll to the press. Rotate the right arm outward with the palm turning inward, and turn the left palm facing outward, close to the pulse point of the right hand, so that the connection is clear.

6. The turn of the waist, the gradual bending of the leg and the turning over of the palms must be done together, experiencing "when one thing moves, nothing is unmoved" and also bringing above and below into accord.

7. Combined practice with the application. A — performs the roll, B — with his left arm between A's two hands; B — withdraws his arm, and A bends the right knee and straightens the left leg while turning the right wrist outward, the heel of the left palm adhering between the pulse points of my right wrist, taking the opportunity to press straight forward.

(E) Push (An)

1. Application Following the previous posture: if the opponent takes the opportunity to press at me, I immediately adhere to his arm with both wrists from the left side, first using sinking energy, then lifting slightly upward, so that the opponent's pressing force lands on nothing. Immediately I then make the wrists upright, sink the shoulders and drop the elbows, contain the chest, with the weight on the left leg, and quickly receive his elbow and wrist with the centres of both palms, pressing forward and squeezing; bending the right leg and sitting it solid, extending the left leg, and the waist at the same time coordinating the forward attack, the gaze following forward too.

2. Course of the Movement 1. The right arm rotates slightly inward with the palm turning down; the left arm rotates slightly outward and the left palm becomes a downward-facing palm; it passes across the back of the right hand in a crossing brush, and immediately the two palms separate, （Form 3　Grasp the Bird's Tail, p. 29）The distance is slightly narrower than shoulder-width. Sink the wrists slightly, both palms facing down, and let the two elbows gradually sink, drawing both palms back with them; at the same time the center of gravity gradually shifts back, settling fully onto the left leg. The eyes look level ahead, and the gaze should take in the two palms as they draw back (see Figs. 15 and 16).

2. Both palms gradually rise to an upright palm with settled wrists, facing forward, and press forward to the front of the chest, pressing out level and straight, the width gradually narrowing; at the same time bend the right leg and straighten the left leg, forming a right bow stance. The eyes look level ahead, and the gaze should take in both palms pressing forward (see Fig. 17).

3. Key Points

1. As the center of gravity gradually shifts back, the root of the right hip draws slightly back, so that the body faces squarely to the front (it must not lean to the left side).

2. Both palms draw back together with the settling-back onto the left leg.

3. At the same time both palms must draw back level with the sinking of the two elbows; the shoulders must be relaxed and the elbows sunk — the arms must not bend at the elbow or lift the elbow.

4. As they draw back the two palms move inward toward the front of the chest (the left palm slanting slightly to the right, the right palm slanting slightly to the left); just before the press goes out, both hands form upright palms, the left palm center slanting slightly toward the right front and the right palm center slanting slightly toward the left front. As the two palms press out, their centers turn slightly forward with the press, but must not turn so far that the palms face straight ahead.

5. The two palms must press forward as the center of gravity shifts forward; when pressing out the shoulders must not lift and the force must not be overdone, otherwise balance is easily lost; the arms must be bent throughout and never straight, maintaining stored potential. The two elbows must not protrude outward.

6. In drawing back and pressing out, the two hands appear from the outside to trace an upward and downward arc; this is because of the settling back and the forward bow of the leg — in fact the two hands travel essentially level, and the arc is not large.

7. One must "gather the buttocks" — that is, relax the waist and settle the hips; this is favorable to "sinking the qi into the dantian" and to "lifting the perineum."

4. Requirements

1. The waist must be relaxed, and attention paid to keeping it straight and sunk; one must hold to the middle earth, and the middle earth must not leave its place — so first of all, relax. The upper body must not lean forward; the tailbone must be centered, the perineum lifted and the crown suspended.

2. Whether advancing or retreating, one must, as the boxing treatise says, have "baihui, zhongji and the one breath running through" — any forward lean or backward tilt fails to （Form 3 Grasp the Bird's Tail, p. 30） Requirements (continued).

3. In advancing and retreating the two hips must be upright and true, advancing and retiring together as one with the whole body. The hip joints must move in accord with the shoulders, satisfying the requirement that "hip and shoulder unite." At the same time the legs must bow in front and push back behind, with empty and full clearly distinguished.

4. One must sink the shoulders and drop the elbows. First comes relaxing the shoulders; only when the shoulders are relaxed can the elbows drop, and only when the shoulders are relaxed and sunk can the arms be relaxed, soft and nimble. Therefore, in drawing the hands back and pressing out, the shoulders must not lift and the elbows must not rise; room must be left under the armpits, and the two upper arms must not press tight against the ribs.

5. In drawing back and pressing out, the two hands must not rise and fall greatly, making the arc of their path too large — this does not meet the requirement of pressing out straight ahead. Rising and falling greatly creates disorder, and one cannot hold the opponent; the issuing force cannot be concentrated in one direction. When pressing out, the two hands should not be spread too wide laterally — about one fist apart.

5. Common Errors, Their Causes, and Corrections

1. Error: the two hands separate without first forming an overturned palm and without crossing. The main cause is insufficient understanding of how the movement travels in an arc so that the joints turn roundly and freely. Correction: in the moving posture the hand leads the elbow and the elbow leads the shoulder; therefore when the right arm rotates inward the right hand should form an overturned palm, the two hands crossing and then separating. In this way, on the contacting surface, one neither yields nor resists, and with a slight turn that avoids the solid and takes the empty one can issue force, using a lifting force to void the opponent's power.

2. Error: leaning forward when pressing out and tilting back when drawing in. The main cause is a shallow understanding of "the tailbone centered." Leaning forward loses the center of gravity; tilting back loses nimbleness and makes one easy to topple. Correction: the upper and lower must be essentially one line, and shoulder and hip must advance and retire together.

3. Error: the palm presses out flat and straight, squared to the front. The main cause is that the fingers are not relaxed and extended enough. Correction: for the beginner the fingers should be naturally extended, not pressed tight together with force nor spread apart; the palm center should slant slightly. Force should be stored in the bend and kept in reserve, otherwise one becomes stiff and cannot convey force.

4. Error: in drawing the hands back and pressing out, the arc traced by the hands is too large (in drawing back the hands sink too low). The main cause is insufficient understanding of the application. Correction: demonstrate it in paired practice. The opponent presses in from the left front; I use a lifting force to void his true strength, then both my palms adhere to his elbow and wrist, (Form 3 Grasp the Bird's Tail, p. 31) In this stage of pressing forward, large vertical arcs are not permitted; if the arms sink excessively the whole chest is exposed to the opponent. Therefore, when drawing back the heel of the palm should stay higher than the elbow, and one moves back level and straight following the opponent's pressing momentum; when pressing forward the height should correspond to the opponent's chest and ribs, so the two hands essentially keep a level to-and-fro.

5. Error: when drawing back or pressing forward the distance between the two hands is too large or too small. The main cause is a failure to understand the application. Correction: take as the standard the distance at which my two palms press the opponent's elbow and wrist (when pressing out the two thumbs are one fist apart); therefore, if too large one's own movement comes to nothing and the focus of force is not concentrated.

6. Teaching Methods and Practice Methods

1. Explain the application and the movement sequence, and demonstrate.

2. Follow-along practice. (The teacher practices the form in front, and the learners follow along behind.)

3. Incremental method: ① First practice the two hands crossing and separating. ② After the hands separate, add the settling back and drawing in. ③ After the hands separate, add the settling back and drawing in, then add the forward bow and press out.

Learn one part, add a part, and link up a part, until the whole movement is learned.

4. The teacher cues with spoken commands: ① The two hands cross, palms turning down to separate. ② When one part moves, all parts move; the hands move and the waist and legs move. ③ The center of gravity shifts back, the two hands draw back, the shoulders relax and the elbows drop. ④ The left leg settles fully; the two palms face each other, at the front of the chest and not at the abdomen. ⑤ Upper and lower are essentially one line; do not lean forward or tilt back. ⑥ The intent is on the heel of the palm pressing forward. ⑦ Repeatedly practice taking the position of the squeeze and linking it to the crossing and separating of the two hands. ⑧ Repeatedly practice drawing the two hands back. Then practice sinking the shoulders and dropping the elbows, improve the relaxed shoulder and dropped elbow, press and press out, and correct the path of the hands and the changes in the shape of the hands. ⑨ Do the complete movement, improving hand-arrives and foot-arrives, with force issuing from the legs. ⑩ Practice in pairs and correct each other. The teacher sets one requirement, everyone practices to the specified requirement, and once the basic requirement is met another is substituted.... ⑪ The teacher checks the learner's strengths and weaknesses from different angles. From the front, look at the width of the two hands; from the side, look at the path of the hands in drawing back and pressing out, watch the hands move with the waist and legs, and the hands arriving (Form 3 Grasp the Bird's Tail — Technical Analysis, p. 32) ...the foot arriving.

7. Technical Analysis

Grasp the Bird's Tail is the master hand of taijiquan, complete in both body and application. The "Song of Striking Hands" revised by my late teacher Wang Zongyue states it clearly: "Ward-off, roll-back, press and push must be done in earnest; when upper and lower follow one another the opponent finds it hard to enter. Let him come at me with tremendous force — a touch of four ounces deflects a thousand catties. Draw him in, let it come to nothing, and issue as he closes; adhere, connect, stick and follow, neither losing nor resisting." These six lines should run through

the entire taijiquan set, and they are especially applicable as the basis of the technical analysis of Grasp the Bird's Tail.

In the entire Yang-style taijiquan set, Grasp the Bird's Tail appears six times. Its movement is fundamental and typical. Push-hands likewise takes ward-off, roll-back, press and push as its basic movements; therefore this movement of Grasp the Bird's Tail must be practiced well.

1. In Grasp the Bird's Tail there are many variations of bow stance, empty stance, upright palm, upward-facing palm, downward-facing palm, and of hand and foot.

2. The footwork changes a great deal — not only the empty-full changes of moving forward and back, but also empty-full changes while supported on one leg, as when the beginning posture links to left ward-off, left ward-off links to right ward-off, one leg settles fully, one leg slowly withdraws, one leg slowly extends.

3. There are requirements within the body method; in the empty-full changes the tailbone must be centered.

4. There is the application of waist strength: "at every moment keep the mind at the waist." In Grasp the Bird's Tail the beginner is very prone to leaning forward and tilting back, and to failing to do relaxed, sunk and straight properly; when the waist strength is right, one can strengthen the issuing of force.

5. There must be not only ward-off, roll-back, press and push but also adhere, connect, stick and follow; not only striking but also neutralizing; one may neither resist nor lose contact. Therefore the demands on intent are very high.

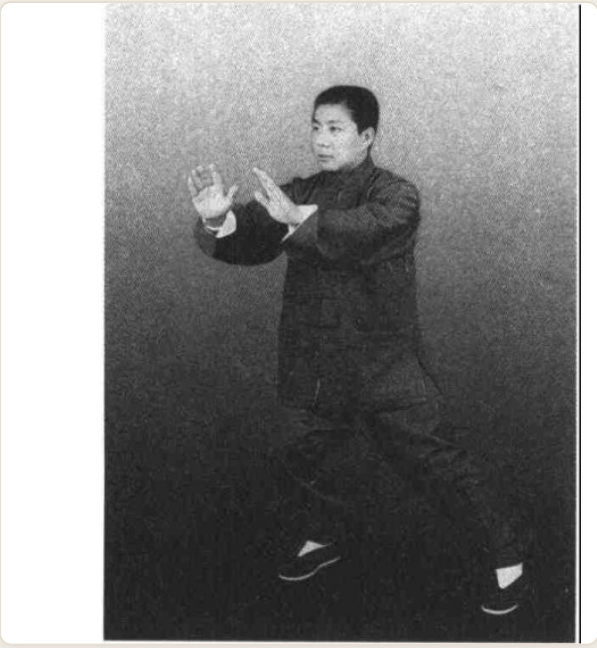
6. Points of force: ① In left ward-off, at the radial side of the left forearm near the wrist and at the outer side of the right wrist (the right hand is an opening force). ② Right ward-off is at the wrist on the radial side of the right arm. ③ Roll-back is at the right forearm near the wrist; the left hand carries ward-off force, and the force point is on the outer side of the forearm (the ulnar side). ④ Press is mainly at the heel of the left palm, with the right hand as backing. ⑤ Push is at the heel of the palm.

7. The question of empty and full in the waist and legs: whether front empty and back full, front full and back empty, left empty and right full, or left full and right empty, in emptiness there must be fullness, and in （Form 3　Grasp the Bird's Tail — Technical Analysis / Form 4　Single Whip, p. 33）...there is emptiness within fullness. Emptiness is not total void or limp weakness, nor may fullness stand too dead. Empty and full must interpenetrate and shift imperceptibly. Only when empty and full are nimble and natural can one advance and retreat freely; therefore one demands that they appear and hide by turns. The legs must have "intent and qi that change nimbly, so that there is the delight of roundness and liveliness"; "wherever one fails to find the moment or the position, the fault must be sought in the waist and legs."

The leg bearing most of the body's weight is called full, the other empty. The shifting of empty and full in waist and legs is close to isometric exercise. One leg supports with great effort, and so

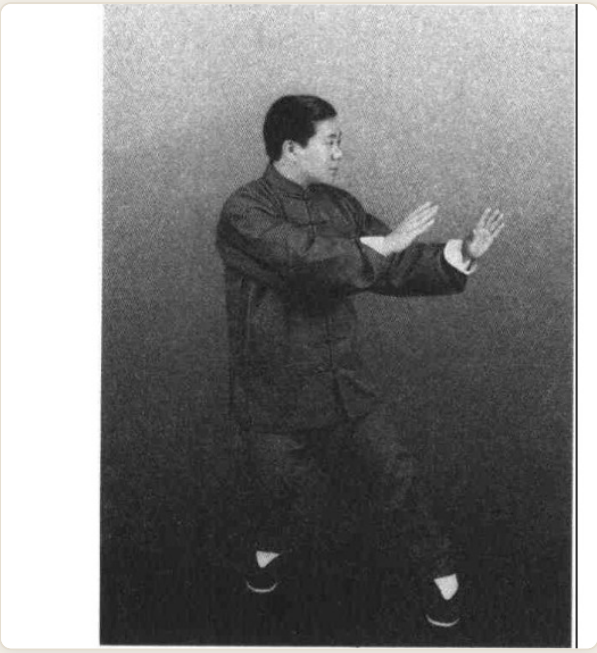
those who practice taijiquan long have very strong leg muscles, walk and climb stairs lightly, and greatly improve their health. For beginners and the elderly or weak, the stance may be taken higher at first to reduce the amount of exertion, and later, as the constitution strengthens, it may gradually be lowered to increase the exertion.

图 18



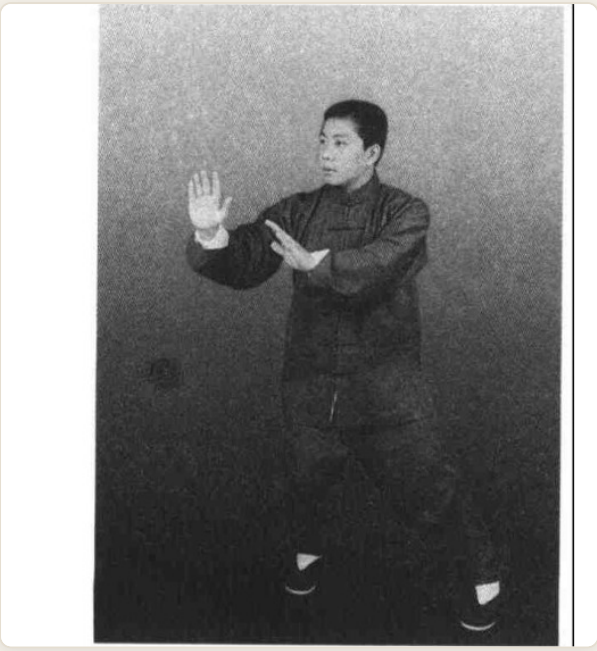
Preparing to turn: the weight is on the right leg, the body turns left, and the two palms sweep left with the body through half of a flat ellipse.

图 19



After the body has turned to about 135° (facing southeast), the two palms continue sweeping with the body through the chest and on to the right oblique front through another half of a flat ellipse, both palms at shoulder height.

图 20



Turning right about 70° (toward the southwest), the two palms continue sweeping; the eyes follow the body, looking level, and take in the right palm.

BOOK PAGE 33

Form 4　Single Whip

Form 4　Single Whip

1. Application

If the opponent strikes at me from behind, I immediately raise the tip of my right foot slightly, turn left and settle fully, raising both hands level with the shoulders with palms facing down, and let them swing to and fro left and right with the waist; when the two hands swing to the right oblique, the five fingers of the right hand gather to form the hook hand. The body turns to the left rear, wheeling about to the back; the left foot lifts and steps out to the left; bow the left leg and bend the knee to settle fully, straighten the right leg; at the same time the left hand passes inward before the face, turning as it goes, and extends a palm out to the left, the palm center slanting outward, relaxing the waist and hips, pressing toward the opponent's chest, sinking the shoulders, dropping the elbows and settling the wrist. The gaze follows forward — the hand arrives, the eyes arrive, the foot arrives.

2. Movement Sequence

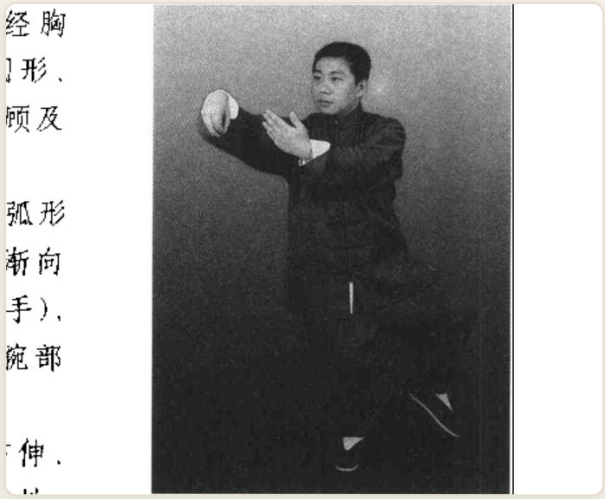
1. The weight is still on the right leg; the body turns left (about 135°) to face southeast, while the tip of the right foot lifts slightly and the body pivots on the right heel, the toes turning inward as far as possible, then settling. At the same time the two elbows sink slightly and bend a little, and the two hands, as downward-facing palms, sweep left with the body through half of a flat ellipse, both palms at shoulder height. The gaze follows the turning of the body, looking level; the hand arrives and the eyes arrive, and the gaze takes in the right hand (see Figs. 18 and 19).

2. After the body has turned to about 135° (facing southeast), the body （Form 4　Single Whip, p. 34）…then turns right about 70° (toward the southwest), and the two palms sweep with the body, the two arms passing before the chest to the right oblique front (southwest) through another half of a flat ellipse, both palms at shoulder height. The eyes follow the turning and shift level; the gaze must take in the right palm (see Fig. 20).

3. The weight is on the right leg; the left leg lifts, and the left foot steps out along a natural arc nearer to the inside. At the same time the body continues turning slowly right, and the right arm gradually extends obliquely to the right, the tips of the five fingers drooping and gathering as it extends to form the hook hand; the left arm extends slightly forward, the left palm center facing inward, the fingers near the right wrist (see Fig. 21).

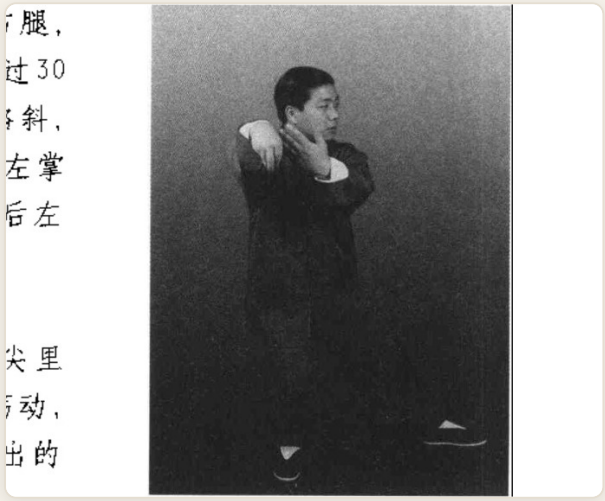
4. The body turns slowly left, the right hook hand continues to relax the shoulder and extend right, and at the same time the left foot steps out to the left (east), touching down heel-first, then settling the whole sole as the weight shifts left. Bow the left leg and push back the right leg, forming a left bow stance. At the same time the left palm passes before the face (no more than 30 cm from the face) and moves left; as the left arm rotates inward, turn the palm center to face forward and slant slightly, pushing out slowly, obliquely and levelly toward the left (east). The eyes look level at the leftward shift, following the left palm to the left; the gaze must see the left palm pushing left, and when the movement is completed the two arms should be spread about 135° apart (see Figs. 22 and 23).

图 21



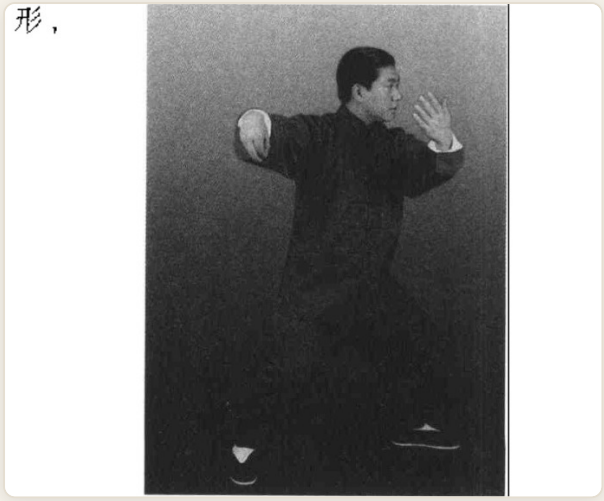
The right arm gradually extends obliquely right, the tips of the five fingers drooping and gathering to form the hook hand; the left arm extends slightly forward, the left palm center facing inward, the fingers near the right wrist.

图 22A



The left palm passes before the face and moves left; the left arm rotates inward, turning the palm center forward and slanting it slightly.

图 22B



The left palm pushes out obliquely and levelly to the left, forming a left bow stance, the two arms spread about 135° apart.

3. Key Points

1. Turn the waist and hips to the left; the right foot pivots on the heel, and the toes must turn inward fully; the weight is still on the right foot, and the two hands swing left or right with the waist. The upper body must be upright, and must not lean forward or tilt back. As the left hand pushes out to the left front, the right hook hand slowly extends obliquely to the right.

2. The two palms sweep a circle to the left or right — it is a flat ellipse, （Form 4　Single Whip, p. 35） The two elbows hang down (elbows lower than the wrists); the two arms must be linked to each other, not loose and scattered; the front hand goes out and the rear hand follows, at equal distances. The hands turn with the waist, and the two arms must bend and extend roundly and livelily as the palms sweep; when the two palms sweep outward the arms must not be straight, and when they sweep inward one must slightly settle the wrists while dropping the elbows, hollow the chest and turn the waist.

3. In the settled posture the two hands and two feet must have the sense of drawing to and linking with each other above and below. The left arm and the left leg must point in the same direction and be aligned above and below; the knee must not pass beyond the toes; the wrist joint of the right hook hand must be bent, the five fingers gathered and drooping, and vertically opposed to the tip of the right foot.

4. Requirements

1. The two arms sweep the circle, and the movement must be led by the waist — the waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower limbs.

2. In the extending and retracting of the arms through the circle one must be relaxed, soft, round and lively. To achieve this, one must first of all have the shoulder joints relaxed and sunk, and the beginner in particular should start from "relaxing." Leave room under the armpits; do not press the upper arms tight against the ribs; one should gradually reach "loosened, my force not bent," with elasticity.

3. One must "sink the shoulders and drop the elbows," not hunch the shoulders and lift the elbows; both the left arm that sweeps the circle and the right arm that forms the hook hand must have the elbow lower than the wrist.

4. When the two hands begin to sweep the circle and the waist leads the right foot to turn inward, the weight must be on the right foot, the full leg; the weight must not shift (to the left foot and then back to the right).

5. In sweeping the circle the body turns from west to southeast, then back to south slightly toward the west; the turn must not be too large, or one will "scatter."

6. After sweeping the circle, the left hand comes near the right wrist with the palm center facing inward, and as the body turns the two hands shift left; after passing due south, the left hand, as it shifts, turns the palm outward, forming a side palm, and pushes out obliquely and levelly forward (east), while the right hand moves back in translation 45°.

7. After sweeping the circle, the left foot lifts and takes a step forward-left (east); the left leg, once lifted, must step forward immediately — it must not be drawn back near the inner ankle of the right foot before stepping out.

8. In the settled posture the right hook hand should be slightly higher than the shoulder; the left knee bows forward and the right leg pushes back, but the right leg must not be straightened completely; the left hand and the left （Form 4　Single Whip, p. 36） ...the tip of the foot vertically opposed. The direction of the left toe is squarely east.

9. The right foot must turn inward fully, more than 90°.

10. During the movement the body's center of gravity must not rise and fall abruptly; in particular, when the right foot turns inward the center of gravity must not rise.

5. Common Errors, Their Causes, and Corrections

1. Error: the right foot turns inward insufficiently, making it difficult for the left foot to step toward east. The main cause is a failure to relax the waist and turn the hip. Correction: the big toe of the right foot must lead the force; the toe points and the hip loosens — so the foot leads the knee and the knee leads the thigh, and when the inward turn is complete the left leg can step smoothly.

2. Error: the body rises and the weight shifts left. The main cause is an unclear concept of empty and full. Correction: with the tip of the right foot slightly raised, pivoting on the right heel, begin from drawing in the root of the right hip and let the right knee turn left in line with the right toe.

Do not push off the right leg; the right leg must bend, and the turning of the waist and hips drives the right foot to turn inward.

3. Error: the two hands do not sweep a circle but go straight back and forth, or the two hands rise and fall too greatly. The main cause is an insufficient understanding of the application. Correction: they must be raised level with the shoulders and swing to and fro to form a turning momentum; therefore the arms must be bent and not straight. If the rise and fall is too great, it is hard to gain the turning momentum; so there is some rise and fall, but it should be fairly small.

4. Error: the hand shape is poor when sweeping the circle — some hold it taut and stiff, some let it sag limply. The main cause is insufficient attention to the requirements for the palm. Correction: the empty and full of the palm must accord with the empty-full changes of the movement as a whole. The boxing treatise says, "Its root is in the foot, it issues from the leg, it is governed by the waist, and it takes form in the fingers... always it must be one complete breath of qi" — therefore, as they swing left and right, the fingers too must convey force, and so they may not be left limp; but neither may a stiff force be used.

5. Error: lifting the elbows when sweeping the circle. The main cause is a shallow understanding of the downward-sinking force of the elbow. Lifting the elbow obstructs the sinking of the shoulder and affects the breathing. Correction: relax the shoulders and drop the elbows, so that the elbow is lower than the wrist.

6. Error: in sweeping the circle, the turning of the waist and the turning of the hands and feet are not in accord; the turning of the hands and feet is divorced from the turning of the waist, and in some cases only the hands move and the waist does not. The main （Form 4　Single Whip, p. 37） ...cause is a shallow understanding of "the waist as sovereign." Correction: the waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower body. Only when the waist strength is applied correctly can the strength of the whole body be concentrated at one point. If the hands move and the waist does not, the hands and waist are severed, and the internal force of taijiquan cannot be conveyed to the hands; there can be no turning momentum in the left-right swinging. Therefore, one must "at every moment keep the mind at the waist."

7. Error: the right hook hand is placed too far open; in the settled posture the two arms are almost 180° apart. The main cause is that the right hand moves back too far and the waist turns right too much, with the result that the chest is thrust out. Correction: the right hook hand should move slightly to the right, but still come to rest on the southwest diagonal.

8. Error: the left hand turns its palm too abruptly when pushing out. The main cause is a shallow understanding of hand technique: in taijiquan the palm, in extending forward, extends with rotation and gradually unfolds — it does not rise straight up and drop straight down, nor go straight forward and straight back; and because the force travels from the spine and back, through the shoulder and elbow, to the palm and pushes forward, if the palm is turned abruptly the force cannot be conveyed. Correction: turn the palm as it moves, keeping the fingers essentially slanting upward.

9. Error: when the left hand moves and pushes out, the palm is too far from or too close to the body. The main cause is an insufficient understanding of the application. Too far and it scatters; too close and it collapses. When the opponent strikes from behind me, my left palm presses toward his chest. If the hand is too far, one scatters before anything else; if the hand is too close, my arm is already bent and close to the body — how can I then exert my force? Correction: the left hand must be no more than 30 cm from the face.

10. Error: when the left foot steps out to the left front, the two feet stand on a single straight line. The main cause is insufficient turning of the waist, insufficient inward turn of the right foot, and insufficient opening of the hips, which makes one stand unsteadily. Correction: the right foot must turn inward fully; on the basis of the body's left turn, open the hips and extend the left leg to the left and slightly back — thus there is a proper lateral distance between the two feet. In the entire taijiquan set, whatever the direction or angle, there is never a case of the two feet standing on one straight or transverse line.

11. Error: when the left foot steps out the weight shifts left too quickly, and the left heel lands fast and heavily. The main cause is unclear empty and full and insufficient leg strength. Correction: the step must be like a cat walking. The right leg settles fully, the left leg lifts slowly and lands slowly; when the left heel touches down the weight should still be on the right foot, and only then shift slowly out. (Form 4 Single Whip — Technical Analysis, p. 38)

6. Teaching Methods and Practice Methods

1. The teacher explains and demonstrates (with emphasis on distinguishing empty and full).

2. Breakdown method: ① Led by the waist, the tip of the right foot lifts slightly, and the right foot turns inward pivoting on the heel — foot, knee and waist must turn together. ② Sweep the circle. Where the hands move and the direction in which they settle. ③ The left hand moves and pushes out; get clear on the timing of the palm's turn. ④ Lift the left leg and step out to the left front with the turn of the body; strive to settle the right leg fully. ⑤ Check the settled posture.

3. Incremental method: ① Turn the foot in. ② Turn the foot in and add the circle sweep. ③ Turn the foot in, sweep the circle, and add the two hands settling into place. ④ As above, add lifting the left leg, turning the body, shifting the left hand, and stepping the left leg. ⑤ As above, add turning the palm and bowing the leg. ⑥ Complete practice.

4. Cue summary: ① Turn the foot in (the right foot must turn in somewhat more). ② Oblique-front hook hand (reminding of the position of the two hands). ③ Bow step, turn the waist, turn the palm (reminding of the position of the left hand).

5. As a group, practice the right-foot inward turn repeatedly, requiring the waist and knee to turn.

6. As a group, have the left hand push forward with the turning of the waist while the right hook hand gradually extends and shifts right, experiencing "when one part moves, no part is still."

7. As a group, settle the right leg fully, lift the left leg and step left with the turn of the body, landing lightly, experiencing the clear distinction of empty and full; the teacher may praise whoever distinguishes them more clearly.

8. As a group, have the left foot step out at various angles as the body turns; beginners may be asked to extend as far to the left rear as possible to compare whose turn is greater, and then the correct landing position is required.

7. Technical Analysis

1. The movement requires a change of forward direction, altering it by 180° (from west to east).

2. In the push of Grasp the Bird's Tail, the right bow stance has the right leg full and bears most of the body's weight; in linking to Single Whip, the form requires turning on the full leg. Empty and full are clearly distinguished, so the load on the leg is heavy. Because the load is heavy, repeated practice strengthens the leg muscles and thereby strengthens the constitution.

（Form 4　Single Whip — Technical Analysis / Form 5　Raise Hands and Step Up, p. 39）　3. After the right leg turns inward, the left leg lifts, forming a one-legged support on the bent right leg, with the whole body weight borne by the right leg. When, after the left leg steps and the heel lands, the weight shifts, poor control of the right leg easily causes the left heel to land quickly, so that the requirement of stepping like a cat walking cannot be met, and there is inevitably interruption and tension.

4. The "Single Whip" movement involves a change of direction and at the same time the movement of hands and feet; the beginner easily gets confused, so one must be clear about the direction of the movement and the coordination of upper and lower, so that the movement is continuous without break, upper and lower follow one another, and empty and full are clearly distinguished.

5. When the two hands begin sweeping the circle they must be laid level; attend to the shifting of empty and full — relax where it should be relaxed and tighten where it should be tightened; hard and soft must complement; it must accord with the momentum of the turn.

6. Changes in the lower limbs easily disrupt the movement of the upper body. Note that when the head turns it must be upright; when sweeping the circle do not lower the head; when lifting the left leg do not tilt the face up; when turning in any direction the head must not lean or slant left or right, but be naturally level. The facial muscles must be relaxed and natural, the lips lightly closed, the breathing natural, the ears quietly listening behind and taking in both sides. Therefore, in training the Single Whip movement one must see that every part of the body conforms to the requirements of taijiquan, and that hand, eye, body and step are coordinated.

7. Many students beginning taijiquan report knee pain after practice, lasting months or half a year at a stretch. This is because Yang-style taijiquan turns by grinding on the full foot: if, when turning, the knee and the foot are not on one line, but the knee forces an inward turn to drive the grinding of the foot, then the knee precedes and the foot follows, and over long, excessive

stretching this causes chronic injury to the tendons and ligaments on the inner side of the knee, producing pain. Therefore the beginner must take care that in the full-foot grind the knee turns together with the foot.

BOOK PAGE 39

Form 5　Raise Hands and Step Up

Form 5　Raise Hands and Step Up

1. Application

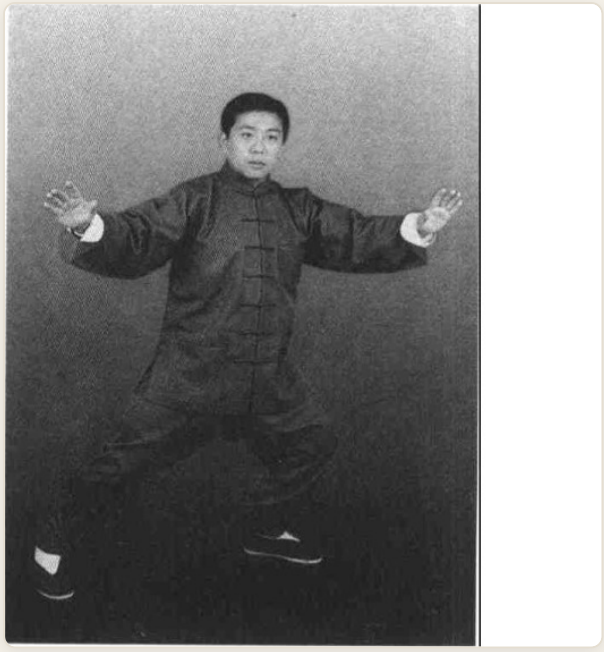
If the opponent strikes from the right side, I turn my body from left to right, the left foot turning inward and the body turning right; the right foot lifts and steps forward, heel landing with the toe suspended in the air, and the whole body sits on the left leg. Hollow the chest and raise the back, （Form 5　Raise Hands and Step Up, p. 40） ...relax the waist, the eyes look forward, and at the same time the two hands are raised and brought together inward — this is a closing force, the right hand in front and the left behind, the two palm centers facing each other left and right. When the two hands are raised and link up with the opponent's elbow and chest, one must store the momentum and await the opponent's change. If the opponent advances, I roll back; or one may turn the right palm center upward and close the left palm onto my right wrist to press out — there is likewise a resemblance in body method and step method to the press.

Variation: if the opponent steps up, one may also neutralize his incoming fist to the right and urgently use the right hook hand to strike upward at his chin.

2. Movement Sequence

1. The weight is still on the left foot; the tip of the left foot, pivoting on the heel, turns inward about 15°–30° and settles, the left leg settling fully; the body gradually turns right, the right hook hand becomes a palm, and the two arms drop their elbows (see Fig. 24).

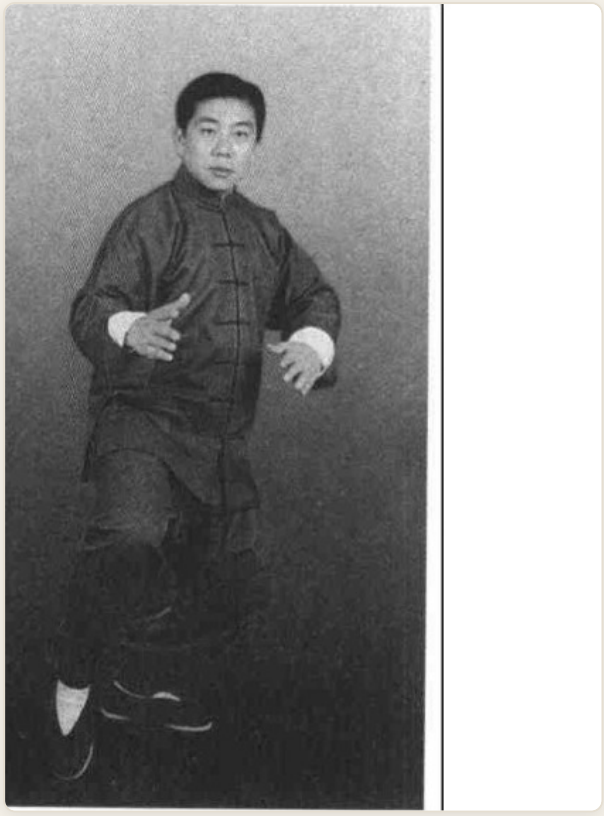
图 24



The weight is still on the left foot; the tip of the left foot turns inward about 15°–30° pivoting on the heel and settles; the left leg settles fully; the body gradually turns right; the right hook hand becomes a palm; the two arms drop their elbows.

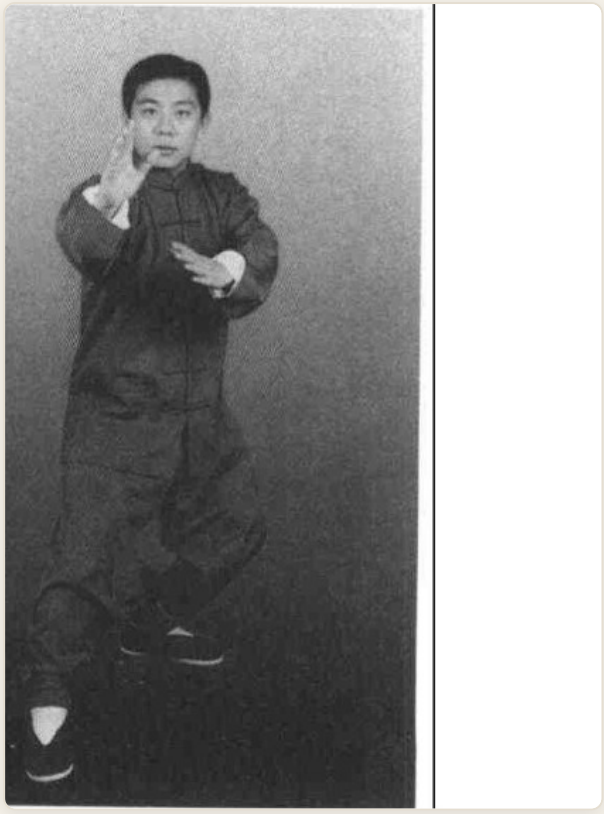
2. The right leg lifts and comes down one step in front of the left foot, landing heel-first with the toe naturally raised a little, the right knee bowing slightly to form a right empty stance. At the same time the two palms close forward, the right palm in front, fingertips at brow height, palm center facing left, an upright palm with settled wrist; the left palm behind, fingertips at chest height, palm center facing right and slanting slightly downward, squarely opposite the right elbow joint, the upper body turning slightly left. The gaze looks forward level past the right palm, forming the raise-hands posture (see Figs. 25 and 26).

图 25



The right palm is in front, fingertips at brow height, palm center facing left, an upright palm with settled wrist.

图 26



The left palm is behind, fingertips at chest height, palm center facing right and slanting slightly downward, squarely opposite the right elbow joint, with the upper body turning slightly left.

3. Key Points

1. Raise Hands and Step Up is a closing force; the movements of foot and hand must be coordinated and in accord.

2. As the right hook hand becomes a palm and the two hands close inward, when the two arms open, the two shoulders must be relaxed and the elbows dropped.

3. When the left foot turns inward the waist and hips must be relaxed, the body must stay upright, and the buttocks must not protrude.

4. The right heel touches the ground as an empty point, with the toe raised very slightly — it must not be tilted too high; the right knee must bow slightly and not be straightened — one must achieve emptiness but not total void.

5. When the two arms close, the chest must not squarely face the front; the upper body turns slightly left — only so does it meet the requirement of the application: storing the momentum and awaiting the opponent's change.

6. When the two palms begin closing inward, the right hand sinks slightly and, moving forward, （Form 5　Raise Hands and Step Up, p. 41）...and then rises slightly. In the settled posture the left tiger's mouth faces the bend of the right elbow, the left fingers are level with the right arm, and the left hand is about one fist's width or a little more from the right arm. If the two hands are too close, roll-back is hindered.

7. The two feet must not be on a single straight line.

4. Requirements

1. Lifting the right foot and stepping forward must be light and nimble; this requires relaxing the waist and hips. In moving the foot and bringing the leg out, first draw the root of the left hip inward and settle the weight firmly on the left leg.

2. Raise Hands requires that upper and lower follow one another: the tip of the right foot squarely faces the front, the fingers of both hands must also point to the front, and the line of sight looks to the front; even the chest and abdomen must turn with the hands and feet, so that the movements of above and below, left and right, are in accord, strengthening the gathering and closing force of the whole body, so that upper and lower follow one another and one breath of qi runs through.

3. In linking from Single Whip to Raise Hands the elbows must drop and the two palms settle their wrists; they close as they move forward — the two arms must not first draw inward and close and then go forward, nor must the two arms go forward too early.

4. As the right leg lifts the knee and steps forward, the two arms close as they move forward.

5. One must hollow the chest, but must not form a hunchback.

6. The right foot must not first come near the inner ankle of the left foot and then go forward; rather, after the right leg lifts forward it steps forward in a natural arc.

5. Common Errors, Their Causes, and Corrections

1. Error: unclear empty and full. The main causes are, first, that in linking from Single Whip and turning the left foot inward, the weight easily shifts right and forms double-weighting; second, that the left leg is not settled fully when the right leg steps forward, so the weight shifts forward. Correction: "double-weighting causes stagnation." The shifting of empty and full between the two legs must be clear; the upper body must be nimble, and the lower body must be made stable. Therefore, when the right leg steps forward, only the heel may land lightly, and the weight must sit on the left leg. Therefore one should practice the full-foot turn often, sinking as one turns.

2. Error: the movements of hand and foot are separated. Commonly the right foot has already landed while the two hands are still extending forward. The main cause is that upper and lower

do not follow one another. Correction: foot arrives as hand arrives — thus hand and foot are one force.

3. Error: the two elbows prop outward and lift up, protruding outward away from the body. （Form 5　Raise Hands and Step Up, p. 42） ...The main cause is failure to attend to the requirement that the elbow not leave the knee. Correction: the elbow should unite with the knee. When linking from Single Whip the upper body begins to turn right, and one should immediately relax the shoulders and drop the elbows; if the two elbows are too exposed, this is harmful and in no way beneficial in combat.

4. Error: the position of the two hands — high or low, inner or outer — does not meet the requirement. The main cause is insufficient understanding of the application. Correction: the requirement of Raise Hands is that one's own two wrists connect with the opponent's elbow and wrist; this makes clear the reason for the requirements that the right hand is in front and the left behind, the right hand slightly higher and the left slightly lower, and the front-to-back distance between the two hands about one forearm. For this, one may use the opponent's elbow and wrist to correct the position of one's two hands.

5. Error: in the settled posture the upper body leans too far forward — this is called "cat's waist." The main cause is the loss of a centered, upright stance. Correction: Raise Hands is a storing of momentum to await the opponent's change; in order not to let the body become slack and lose its center one must hollow the chest and raise the back, and keep the tailbone centered. Thus one can roll back when retreating and press when advancing. If the two hands extend too far forward and the weight moves forward, one brings passivity upon oneself.

6. Error: in the settled posture the upper body squarely faces the front. The main cause is a shallow understanding of the application. The movement of Raise Hands is to await the opponent's change; if I squarely face him and the opponent attacks straight ahead, I have no way to draw him in, and if he is drawn straight in he easily lands on me. Correction: the body must be slightly oblique.

6. Teaching Methods and Practice Methods

1. Explanation (with emphasis on empty and full) and demonstration (with emphasis on the full-foot turn).

2. Mnemonic: turn the waist and turn in the left foot; the weight stays on the left; Raise Hands is a closing force; hand and leg go out together. Breathe naturally, store the momentum and await his movement.

3. In pairs, one attacking and one defending, experience the position of the hands; in groups of several, watch each other and correct errors.

4. Key-point cues: ① When turning the body and turning in the left foot — the weight must not change. ② When the body has turned to face south — the right hook hand becomes a palm, the

elbows sink, and the two hands travel in an arc. ③ When the right leg steps forward — land lightly, hand and foot arriving together.

5. Incremental method: ① Turn the left foot inward and turn the body to the south. ②　(Form 5 Raise Hands and Step Up — Technical Analysis, p. 43)　Turn the left foot inward and turn the body to the south. The right hand becomes a palm and the two elbows drop. ③ Turn the left foot inward and turn the body to the south, the right hand becoming a palm and the two elbows dropping; lift the right leg forward and bring the two hands inward and forward, raised and closed.

6. To deepen the understanding of empty and full and to train the leg strength, repeatedly turn the left foot inward and settle the left leg fully, and repeatedly lift the right leg and step forward into a right empty stance.

7. In the position of the right empty stance, repeatedly practice lifting and setting down the right leg, experiencing the slightly bent knee and the light, nimble foot.

8. To deepen the understanding of the path of the hands and of their position in the settled posture, repeatedly practice the raising and closing of the two arms inward and forward, beginning from the left upright palm and right hook hand.

7. Technical Analysis

1. The whole movement is supported on the left leg, so the load on the left leg is fairly heavy.

2. The movement requires the waist to move, the hands to move and the feet to move, and the gaze to move with them; if one place does not move, there is disorder. Therefore, when turning the waist and turning the body to the right (to the south), at the same time the right hook hand must become a palm, the elbow sink slightly, the right knee lift, and the eyes look forward — upper and lower following one another.

3. In this movement, when the waist turns to the south it is easy to thrust out the chest, and when the hands close inward and extend forward it is easy to cave in the chest. If the chest is thrust out, the qi presses against the chest, the upper is heavy and the lower light, and the heels tend to float. A caved-in chest is unfavorable to breathing; a hollowed chest favors neutralizing force. The boxing treatise says, "the two arms are linked to each other," and "the whole crux lies in the transformation within the chest and waist." Therefore a hollowed chest is the "storing of momentum" of the chest; with a hollowed chest one can raise the back, and with a raised back the force can issue from the spine.

4. The right leg must step forward light and nimble; "light and nimble" means not using stiff force — once stiff force intrudes, the turning is no longer nimble. Therefore in practicing the form one must practice the union of light and sunk, and the mutual complement of hard and soft. In this movement, in the right leg's forward step one must first draw the root of the left hip inward and settle the left leg firmly; in changing from full to empty attend to nimbleness, in changing from empty to full attend to steadiness, so that the right leg's forward step involves the whole body

within and without. One must attend to "both light and sunk, hard and soft contained within," storing and not issuing, with skill and force-power given equal weight.

(Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings, p. 44)

BOOK PAGE 44

Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings

Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings

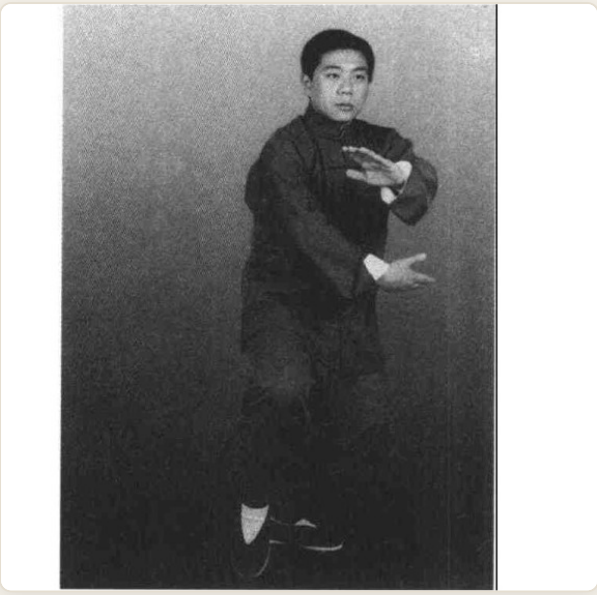
1. Application

Linked to the preceding posture. If the opponent strikes with both hands from the left side of my body, I quickly withdraw the right foot, lift it and step forward across, the toe slanting slightly (toward the southeast), bending a little and settling fully as the body turns left (to the south) together with the right foot, while the left foot moves to the front (east) and touches down on the toe. At the same time the left palm center closes onto the inner side of the right arm at the elbow, sinking slightly; the right hand then rises to open up above the right forehead, the right palm center facing up and outward, and I use my right hand to lift the opponent's left hand upward. The left hand hurries downward, opening out from the left side down to beside the left hip, palm center facing down — and so the force of the opponent's two hands is dispersed and broken by me.

2. Movement Sequence

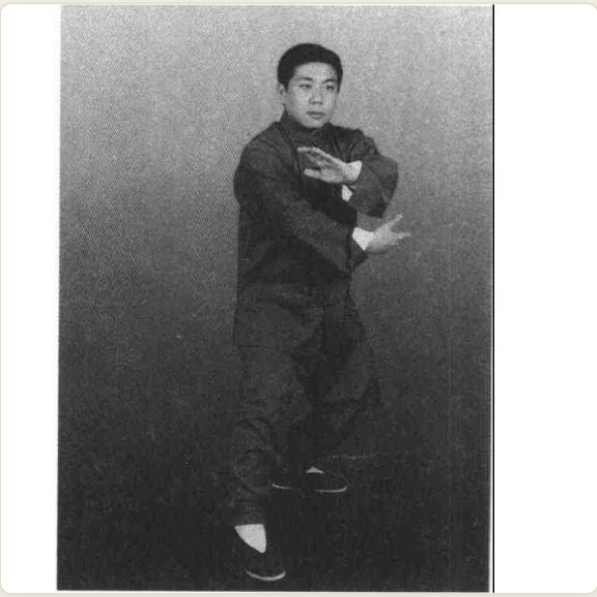
1. The weight is still on the left foot; the waist and body turn slightly left, the root of the left hip draws slightly inward, and the right foot lifts. At the same time the left elbow withdraws to the left rear, and as it withdraws the arm rotates inward so that the palm center turns downward; the right palm likewise, with the turning of the body, comes down from the front and moves in an arc to the left front beneath the left hand, and as it moves the arm rotates outward so that the palm center turns upward. The gaze attends slightly to the withdrawal of the left elbow, then turns to look level ahead (see Figs. 27 and 28).

图 27



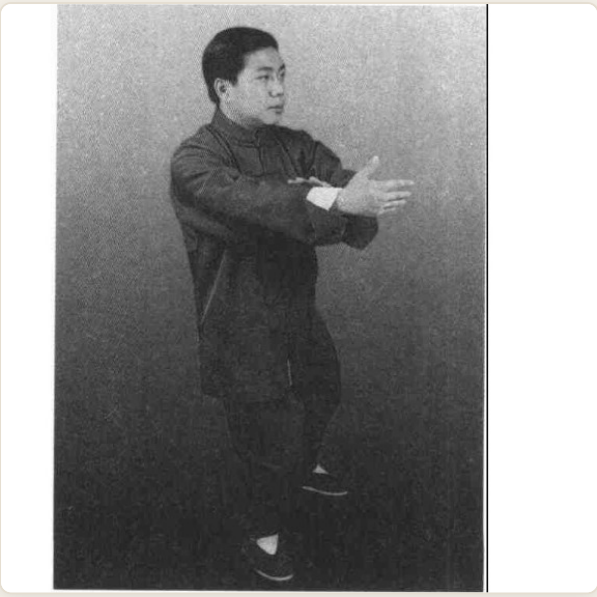
The left elbow withdraws to the left rear, and as it withdraws the arm rotates inward so that the palm center turns downward; the right palm, with the turning of the body, comes down from the front and moves in an arc to the left front beneath the left hand.

图 28



As the right palm moves, the arm rotates outward so that the palm center turns upward; the gaze attends slightly to the withdrawal of the left elbow, then turns to look level ahead.

图 29

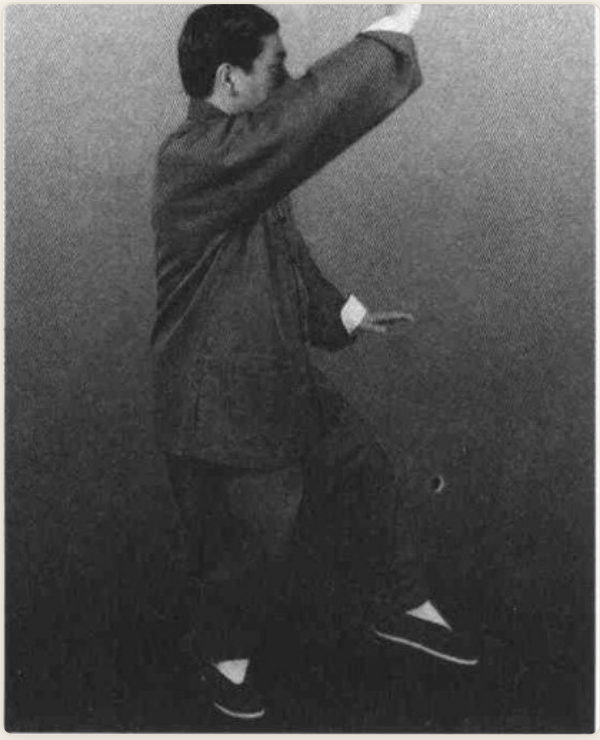


The right arm rises to the front of the upper abdomen, the left palm clinging to the inner side of the right forearm (facing southeast), and the gaze attends the right arm. (This figure is re-printed on the following page as a push-hands demonstration, figure 29.)

2. The right foot comes down in place, still forward of where it was, landing heel-first, and then the toe settles at about 45°. The waist gradually turns left, the weight gradually shifts entirely onto the right leg, and the right leg bends at the knee and settles fully; at the same time as the waist turns and the step is taken, the right arm rises to the front of the upper abdomen, the left palm clinging to the inner side of the right forearm (facing （Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings, p. 45） ...southeast), with the eyes attending to the right arm (see Fig. 29).

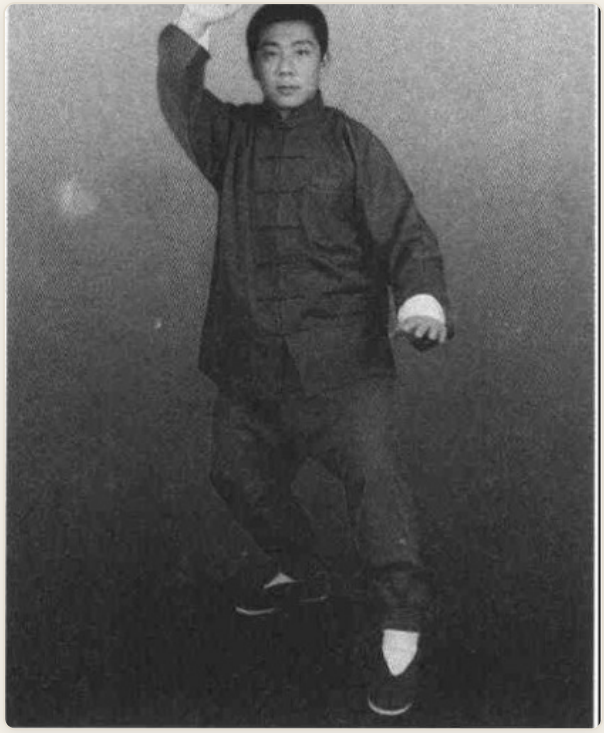
3. The body turns slightly left, the left foot lifts a little and moves to the front of the body (east), touching down lightly on the toe, and the left knee bows slightly; at the same time the right palm rises, and as it rises the arm rotates inward so that the palm center turns outward (the fingers slanting upward), while the left palm likewise falls in an arc to beside the left hip, palm center facing down with settled wrist, fingertips pointing forward. The eyes attend slightly to the right palm rising, then look level forward, but the gaze must also take in the two palms. (See Figs. 30A and 30B.)

图 29



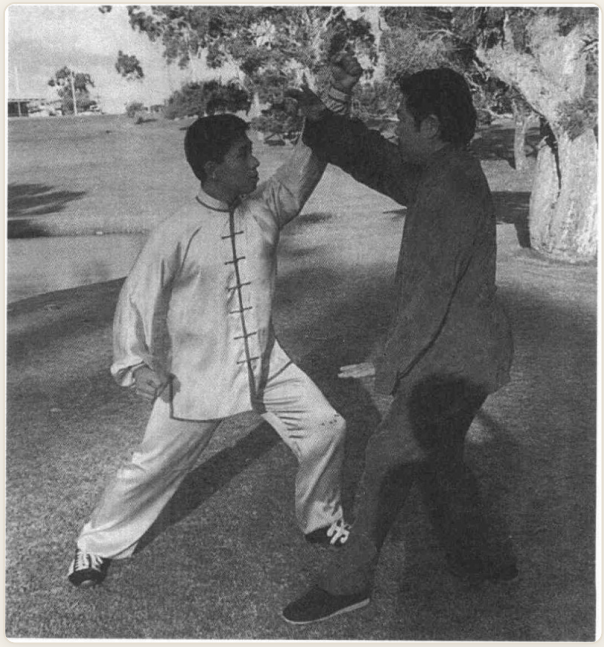
The right arm rises to the front of the upper abdomen, the left palm clinging to the inner side of the right forearm (facing southeast); the eyes attend to the right arm.

图 30A



The right palm rises, and as it rises the arm rotates inward so that the palm center turns outward (the fingers slanting upward); the left foot lifts a little and moves to the front of the body, touching down lightly on the toe, with the left knee bowing slightly.

图 30B



The left palm falls in an arc to beside the left hip, palm center facing down with settled wrist, fingertips pointing forward; the eyes then look level forward, but the gaze must also take in the two palms.

3. Key Points

1. The lifting of the right leg, the withdrawal of the left elbow, and the sinking of the right arm must all take place at the same time. The head must not be lowered, the body must not lean forward or tilt back, and the root of the left hip must draw inward — only then is upper and lower shown to be in accord.

2. There must be an upward spirit, but the right leg must still sit down and draw up the waist, so that there is the sense of upper and lower drawing apart and the limbs and body being stretched long. But note: the abdomen must not be thrust out. With the top of the head leading upward the spirit is raised, and with the qi sunk and the hips settled the lower body is steady.

3. When the posture is settled the two arms must form an arc, but the elbows must not be bent up straight; although the right palm is above and before the right forehead, the elbow must not be raised nor the shoulder hunched, （Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings, p. 46） ...but relax the shoulders, drop the elbows and settle the wrists. The body must still be centered and upright; it must not lean forward or tilt back, nor thrust out the chest or protrude the buttocks.

4. Requirements

1. Empty and full must be clear. When the right foot withdraws and steps forward again, the weight is entirely on the left leg, and the left leg must settle fully. When turning left and the left

leg lifts and steps forward, the weight is entirely on the right leg, and the right leg must settle fully; the shifting of the weight must not be too fast.

2. The waist is the axle, driving the rotation of the four limbs. When, with the waist's left turn, the left elbow withdraws to the left rear, the waist must lead the hands; one must not move only the hands without the waist.

3. The left leg's forward touch on the toe must be empty and must not bear the body's weight.

4. The right hand rises and the left hand presses down; there must be a sense of division, but the two hands are not unconnected — it is not shown in outer form, but intent suffices: use intent, not force.

5. When the two hands separate one must draw up the waist and stretch apart by opposition, lift the perineum and suspend the crown; it is not that the body goes upward, but there is a feeling of extension.

6. The right palm naturally slants upward; it must not be a horizontal palm — a horizontal palm requires lifting the elbow.

7. One must do the hollowing of the chest and raising of the back well; it is not a caving in of the chest with tension drawn inward, but the chest must feel broad and comfortable, the chest muscles relaxed, which favors the movement of the diaphragm. The beginner must take care not to thrust out the chest, but also must not hunch the back.

5. Common Errors, Their Causes, and Corrections

1. Error: when the right hand falls from the front, the left hand halts and does not move. The main cause is failure to withdraw the left hand. Correction: both hands must move.

2. Error: when lifting the right leg the upper body bends forward. The main cause is the wish to relieve the left leg that maintains the body's center of gravity, resulting in protruding buttocks, or a bent waist with caved chest and lowered head. Correction: the upper body must still be upright; attend to the tailbone being centered. The step must change with the body; if the body slants it loses balance. If, in the transitions of advance and retreat, empty and full are unclear and the lower body is unsteady, balance is lost and the body slants. Therefore the stance must be centered and comfortable, with upper and lower essentially on one line. （Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings, p. 47）　3. Error: the right leg steps forward abruptly and lands hard. The main cause is that the weight shifts forward too early, losing lightness and nimbleness. Correction: the left leg must sink slightly, the position of the weight on the left leg must not move, and the right leg extends slowly forward — thus it can land lightly.

4. Error: in the settled posture the two legs press tight together. The main cause is that the lateral distance of the left foot is insufficient; it should move a little to the left. Correction: the root of the hip should be relaxed and held round.

5. Error: in the settled posture the head is lowered and the waist is bent like a cat's. The main cause is insufficient attention to empty-leading top-of-head energy. Correction: the baihui point on top of the head lifts gently upward, the head is naturally upright, and the body is then not apt to lean forward or tilt back; but one must not push rigidly upward, forming a stiff straightness.

6. Error: the left arm presses tight, the fingers not pointing forward. The main cause is that the shoulder is not relaxed. Correction: the shoulder must be relaxed; leave a fist's width of space under the armpit, and the left hand must settle its wrist.

6. Teaching Methods and Practice Methods

1. Explanation and demonstration (with emphasis on the movement and position of the hands), building an overall concept.

2. Group follow-along practice. Practice the two directions as two separate segments, so as not to add to the learner's difficulty of having to learn the movement and change direction at the same time.

3. The teacher observes the errors present from different positions: from south to north, watching the movement of the two hands; from east to west, watching the position of the two hands, the upward spirit, and so on.

4. Use various methods to correct, and through repeated drilling gain improvement while also strengthening the constitution.

5. Paired practice with the application: ① A — strikes with both palms from B's left side. ② B — beginning from the Raise Hands posture, withdraws the right leg and steps forward across, turns the body left, separates the two hands, the right hand rising and the left going down, separating A's two palms.

Practice repeatedly, exchanging roles, to experience the combative meaning of the movement.

6. Movement commands (for beginners): ① Withdraw the right foot and close. ② Step the right foot out in place. ③ The body turns from south to east. ④ Step the left foot out to the east. ⑤ The right hand rises and the left hand goes down; the two hands separate. ⑥ Pull up above and sit down below.　(Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings — Technical Analysis, p. 48)　7. Repeatedly practice withdrawing and stepping out the right leg; note that the upper body must not lean forward or tilt back, the step must be like a cat walking, and the landing must be light. The right leg must be "sent" by the sinking of the left leg. On landing the sole slants inward about 45°. Experience this repeatedly and practice repeatedly.

8. Linking from Raise Hands into this movement: the upper body turns slightly left, the left elbow withdraws to the left rear, the right hand goes from front to down, and at the same time the right leg lifts. Practice repeatedly so that one posture links to the next without pause.

9. The beginner must repeatedly practice the right leg stepping forward with the rear heel landing first and the sole slanting inward about 45°, so as to understand this and prepare the foot

well for the turn of body afterward, so that the later movements are not awkward.

10. With the right leg settled fully, practice putting the left leg out from the side to the front of the body and back from the front to the side. At that time the root of the right hip draws slightly inward and sinks, while the muscles of the left hip and leg relax, allowing the left leg to move nimbly.

11. Repeatedly compare the position of your own two hands in the settled posture, and correct each other. Do not let them be too open, too high or too low.

7. Technical Analysis

1. This movement is a separating movement, so when the practitioner separates the two hands up and down the intent must be clear; of course it should be intent, not force.

2. The settled posture is a left empty stance, but it must not be so empty as to be utterly without strength, nor so full as to stand utterly dead.

3. In taijiquan practice the elbow must at all times have a downward-sinking force. In White Crane Spreads Its Wings the right arm is raised above the shoulder, yet the internal force of the elbow is still downward-sinking. Therefore the right hand must not be a horizontal palm — a horizontal palm requires lifting the elbow.

4. In practicing this movement the stance easily rises. When practicing the whole set, the high, medium or low stance fixed at the beginning must thereafter be kept at a single height, and must not rise and fall erratically.

5. Practicing the White Crane movement easily produces disorder, and one fails to make upper and lower follow one another. Taijiquan says that one must achieve: "the body moves, the waist moves, the feet move, and the gaze also moves with them — only thus may it be called upper and lower following one another." But the beginner, in linking from Raise Hands to White Crane Spreads Its Wings, often has the right leg withdraw, the right hand withdraw, the two hands closing before the body, while the right foot is still （Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings — Technical Analysis, p. 49）...not yet stepped forward — thus a break is formed. From the point of view of application: the opponent strikes with both hands from my left side; my right hand sinks and rises with him, lifting and drawing up to open out above the right temple, while the left hand hurries downward, performing the functions of adhere, connect, stick and follow. In dividing his force it neither opposes nor breaks off, leaving him utterly without leverage, so that his force is dispersed and broken and he is controlled by me. Therefore my movements of hand and foot must make upper and lower follow one another, continuous without break; and the right hand must close and rise with him, and the body too turns east as the right foot steps out, with the gaze arriving before the hand. Thus it meets the requirement of the boxing treatise: "its root is in the foot, it issues from the leg, it is governed by the waist, and it takes form in the fingers; from foot to leg to waist, always it must be one complete breath of qi" — and so upper and lower follow one another without disorder.

6. When this posture is settled, most people cannot produce the "spirit." It is either a nodding head and caved chest, or a thrust-out chest and protruding buttocks. The difficult point is training the "intent." The movement should have an upward spirit: the spirit must be raised, one must feel a force at the top of the head pulling upward and a force in the lower abdomen sinking downward, as though the body were stretched long by two forces; in outer form the stance is extended, and in spirit it is empty, numinous and natural — then the movement meets the requirement.

7. In practicing taijiquan one must value "relaxation" — that is, loosening and being natural. The mouth and abdomen must not hold the breath; the breathing is deep, slow, soft and even. The four limbs, waist and legs must not use strong force; the whole body relaxes, and the spirit relaxes with it. Relaxation is loose and natural comfort, but it is not slackness. The beginner easily uses force; with long, repeated practice the stiff force is gradually eliminated, the movement becomes loose, relaxed and natural, and one gains "the delight of roundness and liveliness." At the same time, when training loose and relaxed and natural, the number of open capillaries in the muscles increases, making the blood vessels throughout the body free-flowing — especially as regards venous blood, for through the alternate tightening and loosening of the muscles the blood is urged back to the heart; the alternation of tension and relaxation also relaxes the blood vessels, favoring a lowering of blood pressure. Therefore, when the two hands close and the left leg settles fully, the other limbs must relax; when the right leg goes out and settles fully, then the left leg and other limbs must also relax. Thus tension and relaxation in alternation achieves loose, relaxed naturalness, coordinated breathing and free-flowing blood.

8. "The spirit is the commander, the body the servant." In practicing the form one must value the inner and outer being in accord, and value opening and closing. In opening, not only do the hands and feet open, but the mind opens with them （Form 6　White Crane Spreads Its Wings — Technical Analysis / Form 7　Brush Knee and Twist Step (Left), p. 50）...in closing. The inner and outer must be unified into one breath of qi. There must first be inner movement, and the outer form then moves with it. Therefore one practices "training intent," "training qi" and "training the body" at the same time. The boxing treatise says, "All of this is intent, not outside" — showing that it lays particular stress on "intent." Therefore, in practicing White Crane Spreads Its Wings, the closing and separating in consciousness must be combined with the movement, the breathing, and the gathering and extending in the movement; inner and outer must be in accord, and one must value the role of "intent" — only thus can the movement be practiced well and health improved.

Form 7　Brush Knee and Twist Step (Left)

Form 7　Brush Knee and Twist Step (Left)

1. Application

Linked to the preceding posture. If the opponent strikes from my left side at the middle and lower levels with hand or foot, I sink my body downward, placing the force temporarily on the right leg; the left foot then lifts and steps forward, the left knee bends and settles fully, and the right leg straightens accordingly. At the same time the left hand turns up to the front of the right chest and goes outward-left and downward, brushing aside the opponent's hand or foot; the right hand at the same time, as an upward-facing palm, hangs down and turns straight back to the right rear side, rotating up to beside the ear and settling its wrist, the fingers seemingly open yet not open and seemingly closed yet not closed, palm center facing forward, sinking the shoulders and dropping the elbows, relaxing the waist and hips, pressing toward the opponent's chest. Every part of the body and hands must form a single force, and the intent too extends forward — thus one gains power.

2. Movement Sequence

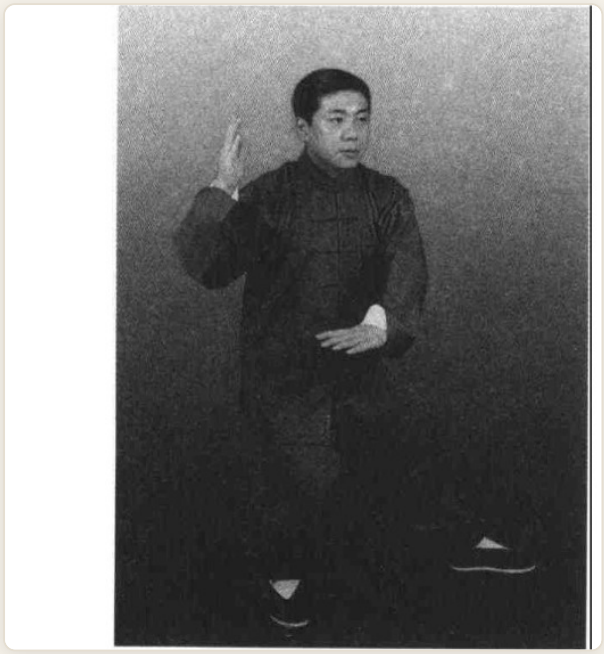
1. The waist turns slightly right, the root of the right hip draws inward, and at the same time relaxing the right shoulder and sinking the right elbow naturally drives the right palm to rotate outward so that its center faces inward, falling in an arc; passing beside the hip the right arm rotates outward so that the palm center gradually turns to slant upward; at the same time the left palm, with the turning of the waist, comes from the lower left forward and upward, the base of the palm at the height of the upper abdomen, and moves in an arc to the right with the palm facing down (the two hands moving in crossing arcs, one upward and one downward). The eyes follow the turning of the waist, looking level forward, and the gaze must take in the right palm (see Figs. 31 and 32).

2. The left leg lifts, and the upper body continues to turn slightly right; with the turning, the right palm moves in an arc up to the right oblique angle, the palm slanting upward. The left palm continues in an arc to the right, falling to the front of the abdomen (nearer the right), the palm still facing down. The eyes attend slightly to the right palm, then shift to attend to the direction of the left palm (see Fig. 33).

3. The left foot comes down forward (east), touching the ground lightly with the heel,　(Form 7 Brush Knee and Twist Step (Left), p. 51)　...as the weight gradually shifts onto the left leg the whole sole settles gradually, bow the left leg and push back the right leg, forming a left bow stance. At the same time the body gradually turns left, and the left palm, with the turning of the body, moves downward and forward in an arc, brushing past the left knee in an arc to beside the left hip (the left oblique front). The right palm likewise turns left with the body, moving in an arc upward, passing beside the right ear and pushing out forward (east). The eyes attend to the

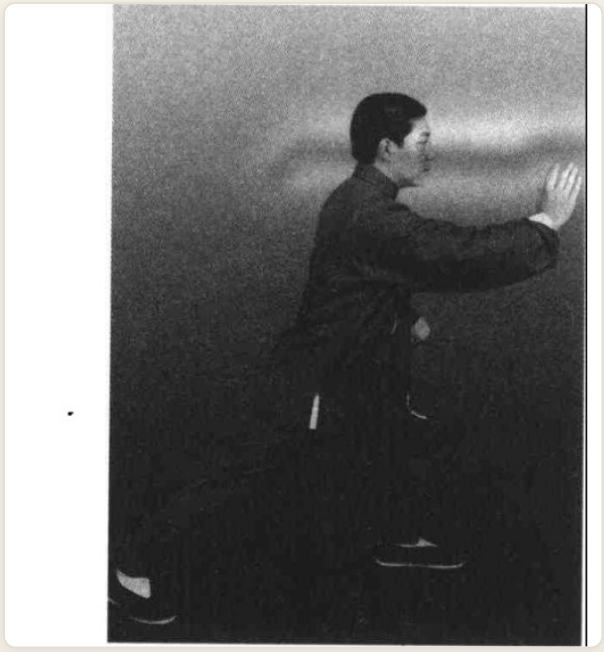
direction of the left palm brushing past the knee, then look level forward, and also attend to the right palm pushing forward (see Figs. 34 and 35).

图 34



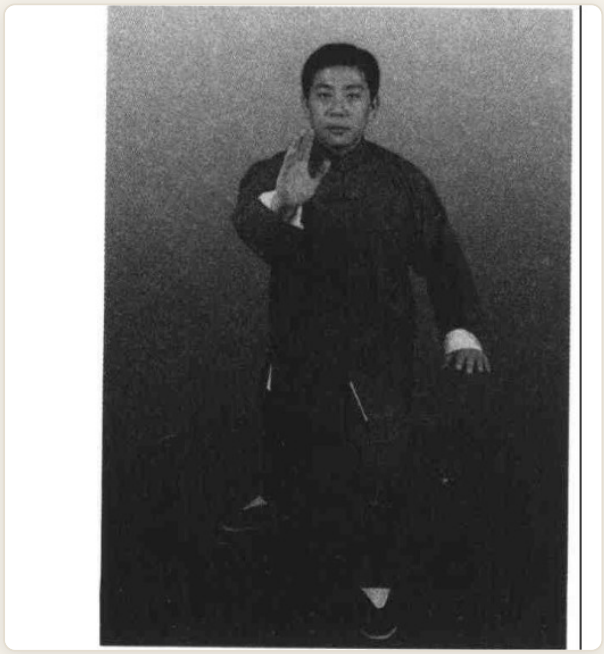
The body gradually turns left, and the left palm, with the turning of the body, moves downward and forward in an arc, brushing past the left knee in an arc to beside the left hip (the left oblique front).

图 35A



The left palm brushes past the left knee; bow the left leg and push back the right leg, forming a left bow stance.

图 35B



The right palm passes beside the right ear and pushes out forward (east); the eyes attend to the direction of the left palm brushing past the knee, then look level forward.

3. Key Points

1. When the waist changes from turning right to turning left the body must not sway; otherwise the upper body will lean forward or tilt back or lean to the side, which does not meet the requirement of "the tailbone centered."

2. When stepping forward the upper body must also be upright, for the ordinary practitioner, in the course of the step, having only the crouched leg as support, will tend to push the buttocks out in order to balance the body — which does not meet the requirements of "gathering the buttocks" and "the tailbone centered."

3. Moving the right palm from below to the right upper position must be in accord with the lifting of the left foot; the body turning left and changing into the bow step must be in accord with the right palm's push out; the whole movement of Brush Knee and Twist Step must be done coordinated, round, full and soft, and must not be halting or angular.

4. When the right shoulder relaxes and sinks downward, the right shoulder must not end up lower than the left (the two shoulders must be level — and this applies throughout the whole set).

5. The arm that brushes the knee must form an arc and avoid being straight. In pushing out the right palm it must rotate slightly as it goes out, but at the settled posture the palm center must not squarely face the front but slant slightly left, nor may the left palm center squarely face the ground but must slant slightly inward; both palms must settle their wrists.

6. In the settled posture everything must arrive at the same time: one hand must not already be in place (halted) while the other is still moving, nor may the foot arrive while the hand has not. When the movement begins both hands must move; the upper hand must not move forward while the lower hand is still halted.

7. Thought and outer form must be in accord, inner and outer as one; advancing and retreating must have a certain atmosphere, with extension and compactness combined; it must not be wooden or disorderly.

4. Requirements

（Form 7　Brush Knee and Twist Step (Left) — Requirements / Common Errors, p. 52）1. Sink the right elbow while the right arm rotates outward, the right palm turning inward; otherwise one falls into stiffness. And in thought one must sink with the elbow.

2. The right elbow sinks and the left palm arcs upward, and this must move together with the slight right turn of the waist, meeting the requirement that "when one part moves no part is still." The right palm moves up at the right oblique angle, and the left palm falls in an arc to the front of the abdomen (palm facing down); at the same time, when the left leg lifts, one hand must not move while the other does not.

3. The right arm must not shift back at too great an angle — toward the southwest, slightly west, suffices. The turn of the body must not be too much; the front of the body turning toward the

southeast, slightly south, suffices.

4. The left leg comes down forward, touching lightly with the heel first; then the body slowly turns left: the left hand brushes, the right hand slowly pushes out, and the left leg bows out — all must begin together and end together in place, only thus can upper and lower follow one another.

5. When the left leg lifts and draws inward it must not come too near the inner ankle of the right foot; rather, draw it in naturally, then extend it naturally forward and step down, achieving a step like a cat walking.

6. When turning the waist the upper body must not sway; the legs must be steady and the waist relaxed.

7. In brushing one must settle the wrist, turn the waist, and let the waist lead the hands, with elbow and wrist moving together.

8. In stepping the left leg forward the upper body must not lean forward or tilt back; the right leg that bears the body's weight must settle fully. The advancing left leg must first lift the thigh, storing force in the knee, carrying up the heel with the toe hanging naturally; then, from bent to extended, it steps out slowly, the toe changing from hanging down to slightly tilted up, the heel landing lightly first, and then the sole and the toe landing, all settling firmly.

9. The two feet in the bow stance must have a somewhat wider lateral distance (slightly narrower than shoulder-width); they must not stand on one line — only thus can one stand steadily in the settled posture.

5. Common Errors, Their Causes, and Corrections

1. Error: the right elbow sinks, but the right arm does not rotate outward and the right palm does not turn inward. The main cause is a failure to understand the extending, retracting, winding and coiling function of the sinking elbow. Therefore the movement goes straight back and forth, and the elbow easily moves away from the body and protrudes outward, exposing the ribs. Correction: taiji is ward-off force; the movement

BOOK PAGE 53

VII. Technical Analysis (Seventh Posture, Left Brush Knee Twist Step — continued)

VII. Technical Analysis (Seventh Posture, Left Brush Knee Twist Step — continued)

Walk the spiral: therefore the palm must rotate outward, the wrist turning and the upper arm rotating, with the elbow sinking downward.

2. Error: the right hand moves while the left hand does not. The main cause is that attention is concentrated on the right hand and the principle "when one part moves, every part moves" is neglected. Correction: the mind must be single-minded before there can be "a quiet mind directing the intention": as the right hand moves downward, the left hand must move upward at the same time, and the waist moves slightly as well.

3. Error: turning the body too far to the right — as much as 90° (the body facing south). The main cause is that the physiological and martial significance of the waist's degree of rotation is not clear. If the waist axis rotates too far, the movements of the body and limbs overshoot, so that shoulders and hips no longer match above and below. Excessive twisting of the waist takes the body off its central uprightness and easily causes breath retention. If the opponent strikes from the front while I face sideways, how can I observe his attack? So from the standpoint of martial application it is also wrong. Correction: turn about 75°, the body facing southeast-by-south, the eyes never leaving the hands, right first and then left. The method is: stop after rotating and check the degree of the turn.

4. Error: during the rotation the left hand is held against the chest, which makes the body shrink and the posture incomplete. The main cause is inattention to the requirement "relax and open so that my strength is not bent". Correction: leave room under the armpit, about the space of one fist, so the arm has room to turn and one does not trap oneself.

5. Error: the right hand, striking forward, is not drawn back to pass by the ear before going out, but is pushed sideways, far away from the shoulder. This exposes the ribs, scatters the movement, fails the martial requirement, and prevents the parts of the hand and body from combining into a single strength. The main cause is a lack of understanding of the application. Correction: the right palm moves back along an arc so that the palm passes the ear and pushes straight forward.

6. Error: when the left hand brushes the knee, the wrist is slack and the fingers hang. The main cause is insufficient attention to seating the wrist; this prevents the internal strength from reaching the fingertips and leaves the wrist powerless. Correction: lead the wrist with the elbow, seat the wrist, and brush the knee with a level palm.

7. Error: the two feet stand on a single line. The main cause is that the hip joints are not opened, so waist and legs do not look after each other. Correction: when the left leg steps forward it should shift slightly to the left, so that the lateral distance between the two feet is a little less than shoulder width; the width can be checked when the posture is settled.

than shoulder width, and the width can be checked when the posture is settled.

8. Error: in brushing the knee only the hand moves and the elbow does not. The main cause is a lack of understanding of the application. Correction: the waist should lead the elbow and the elbow lead the hand; only thus can the requirement of pouring in strength be met.

9. Error: in the left-hand brush over the knee, the arc drawn is too large or too small. The main cause is that the requirements of the application have not been deeply felt. Correction: the path

of the hand should be horseshoe-shaped; it must not be too far from the knee, nor pressed against the abdomen.

BOOK PAGE 54

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explain the course of the movement, its application and its essentials. Demonstrate from every angle in order to build up a concept of the movement.

2. Use comparison to improve the lateral distance between the feet in the bow stance: (i) with the two feet on a single line, apply a push laterally and make them move. (ii) with the two feet about shoulder-width apart, apply a push of the same magnitude laterally and compare the stability of the body. The conclusion follows: standing on a single line, the muscles of waist and legs cannot easily exert force, the support is small and the body topples easily.

3. To master "when one part moves, every part moves" well, divide the practitioners into groups of 2–3 and have them watch one another to see whether the two hands move at the same time and whether the two hands arrive at the same time.

4. Practice for distinguishing substantial and insubstantial. As a group, support on the right leg, lift the left leg, extend it slowly forward, lift it slowly again, then set it down lightly ... repeat; rest and relax, then repeat again, so that the practitioners fully experience substantial and insubstantial. They may also work in groups of 2–3, watching one another's degree of substantial/insubstantial and its merits and faults.

5. When practising the joining of shoulder and hip, the turning of the waist and hip and the bowing of the leg, the hips and shoulders must advance together, matched above and below, maintaining "the tailbone centred and upright".

6. Repeatedly perform the left bow stance, the left-hand brush over the knee, and the right-hand push, experiencing the correct brushing action and the simultaneous arrival of the two hands.

VII. Technical Analysis

1. In this movement one must first do the brush-knee-and-push-palm well, especially the brush over the knee. Ordinarily the brush is done with the hand alone; but in fact, when the opponent strikes with hand or foot, if my brush lacks strength it cannot sweep aside the opponent's hand or foot.

Therefore the brush is not done with the hand alone: the strength of the elbow must be added, and further still the strength of the waist. For this reason the brushing action is one in which the

waist leads the elbow and the elbow leads the hand.

2. The forward strike of the right hand is made together with the brush, so that the parts of the body do not move singly but combine into a single strength; hence hand and foot should arrive at the same time.

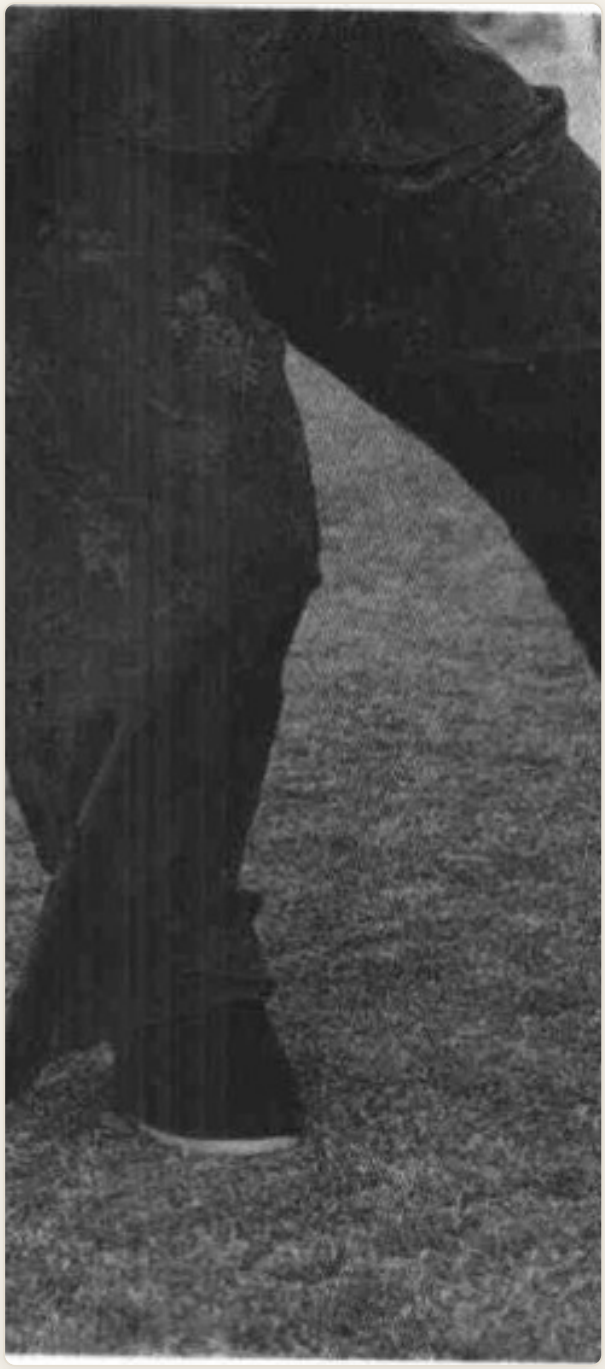
3. Tai chi chuan sets store by quietness, relaxation, uprightness and roundness, by evenness, ease, lightness and steadiness. Therefore, in practising the form one must first put aside distracting thoughts, concentrate the spirit, relax inside and out, so that blood and breath flow freely, the body is centred and upright and the movements are even. Hence, when one begins to practise, the teacher brings these basic requirements forward step by step, so that the practitioner masters and grasps them one stage at a time.

Eighth Posture: Hand Strums the Lute (Shou Hui Pi Pa)

I. Application

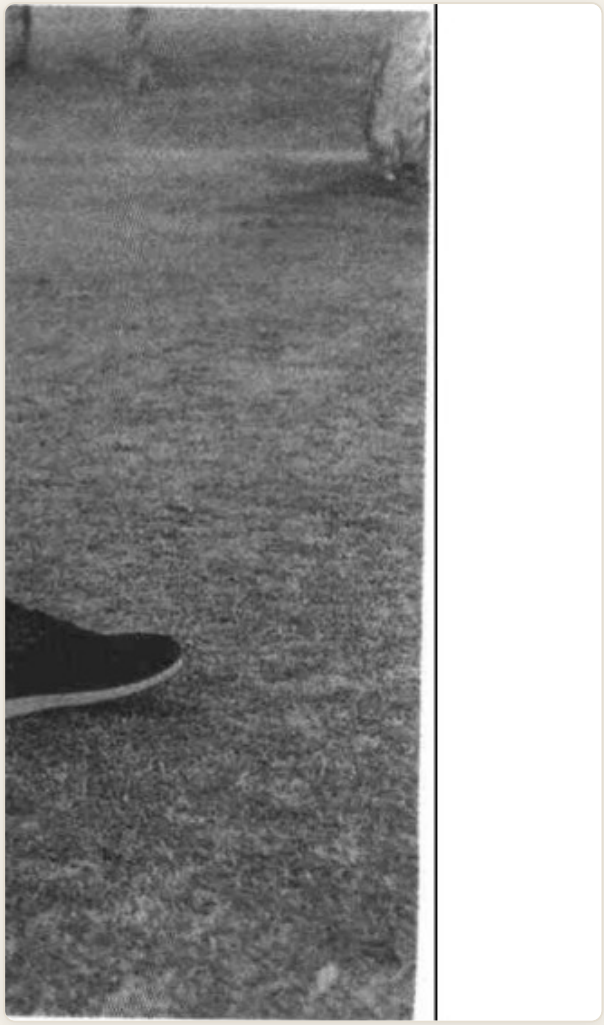
I. Application

图 36



Right hand withdrawing, left hand extending forward, both hands before the chest in the lute-cradling shape (Eighth Posture, Hand Strums the Lute: the application)

图 37



Hand Strums the Lute in its settled posture: left palm extended forward, right palm drawn back to the inside of the left elbow, the body turned to face southeast-by-south

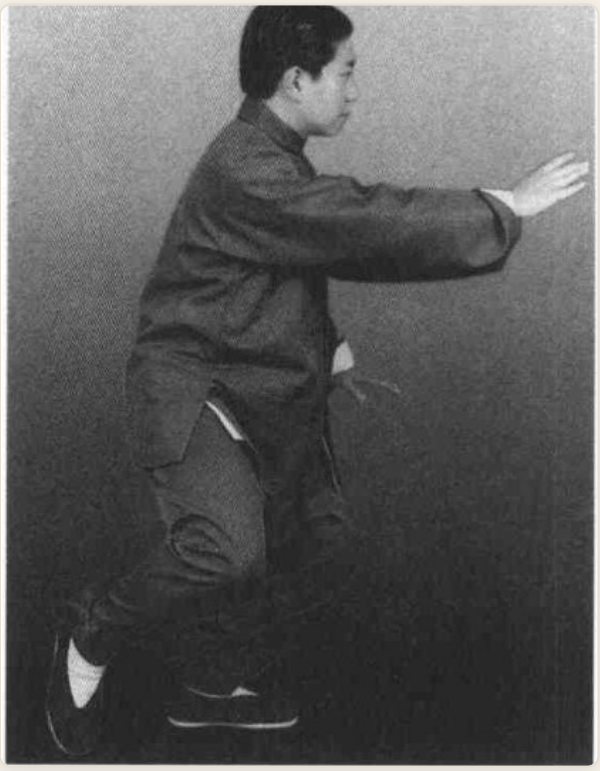
Continuing from the previous posture. Suppose the opponent uses his right hand to strike my chest; I immediately hollow the chest and bend the right knee, sitting solidly upon it. The left foot is then lifted and drawn back, then the heel touches down, gathering and storing the momentum. At the same time the right hand withdraws, closes and sinks, passing round beneath the opponent's wrist — that is, I stick my wrist to his wrist and, with the right hand, gather and close the inside of his wrist, plucking and pulling it down to the lower right. The left hand at the same time closes and draws up from the front left, sticking and adhering the palm and wrist to his elbow in the shape of one cradling a lute, carrying out a left rending and a right plucking. This method stores my own momentum in order to watch for his change; therefore is called Hand Strums the Lute.

II. Course of the Movement

II. Course of the Movement

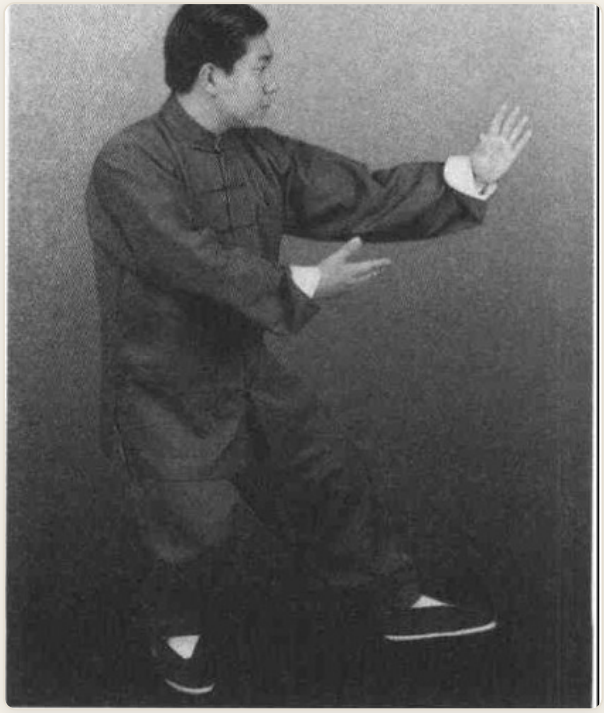
The whole weight gradually shifts onto the left leg; the right foot lifts slightly and comes down essentially in its original place (slightly forward), the ball of the foot touching first; the whole weight gradually shifts onto the right leg and the body gradually turns right about 45°; the left foot lifts slightly and goes back and then forward, again coming down essentially in its original place, heel touching down with the toes slightly raised and the knee slightly bowed, forming a left empty stance. At the same time, the left palm, following the turn of the body, lifts forward along an arc, the arm rotating slightly outward as it lifts so that the palm faces right, the index finger level with the eyebrows. The right palm likewise follows the turning body slightly upward, then withdraws downward and back, the arm rotating slightly outward so that the palm faces left, coming to rest inside the left elbow, the right thumb level with the left elbow; the two palms face each other from front to back, the chest angled toward the front as though cradling a lute, the eyes looking level ahead past the left palm (see the figures on this page).

图 36



The settled lute-cradling posture, the two palms facing each other from front to back, the chest angled toward the front (Eighth Posture, Hand Strums the Lute)

图 37



Hand Strums the Lute: the left palm lifted level with the eyebrows, the right palm withdrawn to the inside of the left elbow

III. Essentials

1. In changing from Brush Knee Twist Step into Hand Strums the Lute, the right foot repositions slightly forward as it comes down; whether the weight moves forward or settles back, the upper body must be upright, never leaning forward or backward; the requirement "tailbone centred and upright" must be met — this increases the power of the downward pluck.

2. The right leg sits solid; the left hand lifting diagonally, the right hand withdrawing, and the left foot drawing back must all be carried out together with the turning of the waist.

3. When the right palm withdraws, the waist is the axis and one must relax the shoulder, drop the elbow and sink the wrist, drawing back joint by joint, letting the body lead the hand; one must not withdraw the right palm first while the waist, shoulder and elbow remain unmoving.

4. Before drawing the right hand back it should sink slightly; after drawing back it closes forward and inward, the palm held upright with a slight outward slant.

5. After the left hand has lifted diagonally upward it should draw in slightly toward the front of the body, then close forward.

6. The left foot extending forward and stepping down must be carried out together with the closing of the two hands.

IV. Requirements

1. Substantial and insubstantial must be clear. The whole weight shifts onto the left leg; the right leg lifts slowly and comes down slightly forward; the weight slowly shifts back, sitting solidly on the right leg; the left leg lifts and is set down lightly forward. All the above movements require one leg to support, sitting solid and steady, before the other leg can be nimble — only thus is there no double-weighting.

2. The crotch must be both rounded and hollow; it must not be pinched into the sharp inverted-V of the character for "person"; the hip roots must be opened and spread.

3. The elbow does not leave the ribs, and the elbow does not stick to the ribs. Therefore the elbow must not be raised, nor sunk so far that it presses against the ribs; room must be kept under the armpit.

BOOK PAGE 57

V. Errors That Are Easy to Make, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Errors That Are Easy to Make, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Error: the upper body leans forward or backward. The main cause is that when the weight moves onto the left leg and the right leg lifts, the left leg is not yet sitting solid; in order to keep the body balanced, the body is tipped forward. Again, when the weight sits on the right leg and the left leg steps forward, the right leg is not solid and the right hip root has not drawn in and rotated slightly downward; to keep balance the body falls backward. Correction: whether lifting the rear leg or stepping the front leg, the body must be straight and correct — from the crown of the head through the trunk to the perineum it must always form a single line, achieving "above and below essentially one line".

2. Error: the centre of gravity rises and falls too much. The main cause is that when the right leg lifts the left leg straightens, and when the left leg is set down the right leg sits too deep. Correction: when lifting the right leg, sit steady on the left leg, lift the thigh slowly, store strength in the knee, carrying the heel up; let the ball of the foot touch first, then the heel. When stepping the left leg, sit solid on the right leg, first lift the thigh, store strength in the knee, and let the knee go from bent to extended, extending slowly, the heel landing. The key is that the leg that is sitting solid must not perform an extending action, otherwise the body's centre of gravity will rise.

3. Error: the front and rear feet land on a single line, so that the body does not stand steadily. The main cause is an insufficient grasp of the idea of a stable lower body. Correction: after the feet are placed, check whether the lateral distance between them meets the requirement. This also

widens and rounds the crotch, which helps blood and breath to flow freely and makes the change from substantial to insubstantial nimble.

4. Error: in the settled posture the upper body faces directly front. The main cause is an insufficient understanding of the application. This posture requires a left rending and a right plucking; facing directly front makes it inconvenient to issue force, does not accord with the folding strength of tai chi chuan, and easily leaves one unable to advance or retreat and inflexible in body when attacked. Correction: turn the body right about 45°, so that it faces the front obliquely; hence, when the left hand lifts diagonally and the right hand withdraws, this should be coordinated with the turning of the body.

5. Error: the path along which the hand moves does not meet the requirement. For example, some closing too near and extending too far forward, some closing with the position overshot, some with a closing but no extending action, some with the two hands too low or too high, some with the right hand between the wrist and elbow of the left arm, some with the right hand between the shoulder and elbow … The main cause is an insufficient understanding of the application. Correction: the opponent strikes my chest with his right hand; my right wrist sticks to his right wrist and my left hand sticks to his upper arm. Therefore the left hand should be a little higher than the right, and the front-to-back distance between the two hands should be about the length of one forearm.

BOOK PAGE 58

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explain the path and position of the hands, and demonstrate (front view and side view).

2. Practise together as a group following the leader.

3. Broken-down practice: (i) from Left Brush Knee Twist Step into Hand Strums the Lute, sit solid on the left leg while the right leg lifts and steps back; the weight shifts back, and one experiences substantial and insubstantial (lifting slowly, stepping down slowly). (ii) Sit solid on the right leg, lift the left leg and step out; the left heel lands lightly, and one experiences substantial and insubstantial. (iii) One may repeat the practice both landing and not landing the foot, training the left leg and the right leg alike.

4. Mnemonic: the weight moves forward, lift the right leg, the right foot steps back a half step; the weight moves back, lift the left leg, left rend and right pluck, Hand Strums the Lute.

5. Comparison method: working in groups of 2–3, or standing in two facing rows, sit solid and support on one leg while the other leg lifts and extends forward without landing; compare how long the position is held, and compare how many times the leg can be drawn back and re-

extended. In the other leg, compare lifting the leg as the weight moves forward, and stepping the right foot down as the weight moves back. This both gives a feel for substantial and insubstantial and strengthens the legs; but the number of repetitions and the time must be set according to age and constitution, with the principle of never holding the breath.

6. Progressive method: (i) the right leg lifts and steps down, the weight moving from forward to back, the two hands sinking and lifting slightly. (ii) To the above, add the left hand lifting diagonally and the right hand withdrawing. (iii) To the above, add lifting the left leg. (iv) To the above, add the two hands extending forward and closing, and the left leg stepping forward and landing. In practice the movement may be simplified — consolidate each bit as it is learned, which makes practice easier.

7. Paired application drills: A — strikes B's chest with his right fist; B — from Left Brush Knee Twist Step takes up Hand Strums the Lute, but without the rending or the plucking (when proficient, a slow, light rending and plucking may be added).

8. Practise repeatedly: the left hand lifts diagonally, the right hand withdraws, then the two hands close forward again, experiencing the path along which the hands travel.

BOOK PAGE 59

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. In this movement support on a single leg is very important; therefore the practices concerned with clearly distinguishing substantial and insubstantial should be done often.

2. In this movement my two wrists stick to the opponent's elbow and wrist, storing my momentum in order to watch for his change — "if he does not move, I do not move; if he moves but slightly, I move first." Left rending and right plucking are issued following me. Therefore, in practising the form one must have "a quiet mind directing the intention", striving to achieve "the intention moves, the form follows". Hence one must "in posture after posture keep the mind weighing the intention" and never treat the movement as simple and so do it carelessly.

3. In moving forward and back one must maintain the body's centre of gravity well; the hands and feet must be well coordinated, matching above and below, neither first nor last. As the right leg lifts slightly, the right hand relaxes the wrist and turns the palm downward; the left hand must be in front, and in this way balance is easily maintained and the centre of gravity steady.

4. The left leg or the right leg half-squats, bearing the whole body's weight — this makes considerable demands on the quadriceps at the front of the thigh. At first there will be a slight trembling and a slight swaying of the upper body; but after repeated practice the strength of

waist and legs increases and this no longer occurs, and meanwhile the constitution is strengthened.

5. That no part, inside or outside, is unrelaxed is a principle. First the muscles and joints: in this movement the elbows easily press against the ribs, whereas there should be an empty space under the two armpits and the elbows should not stick to the ribs. This lets the channels flow freely and blood and breath be harmonious, and then further allows the central nervous system and the internal organs to relax at the same time. This method of training, relaxing the whole body inside and out and joining inner and outer, benefits health and disease prevention and also meets the requirements of martial application.

6. Whether advancing or retreating, leave room to spare. The right leg steps essentially down in its original place; one must not step too far, otherwise the left foot cannot be drawn back slightly and the storing and gathering of momentum is impaired.

7. Note that double-weighting makes one sluggish, while weighting to one side makes one nimble. In the settled posture the right leg is substantial and the left leg insubstantial; if the left leg lands bearing too much weight, double-weighting results and turning can no longer be nimble.

Ninth Posture: Left and Right Brush Knee Twist Step

BOOK PAGE 60

I. Application

I. Application

See the Seventh Posture, Left Brush Knee Twist Step (the Right Brush Knee Twist Step is the same with the directions reversed).

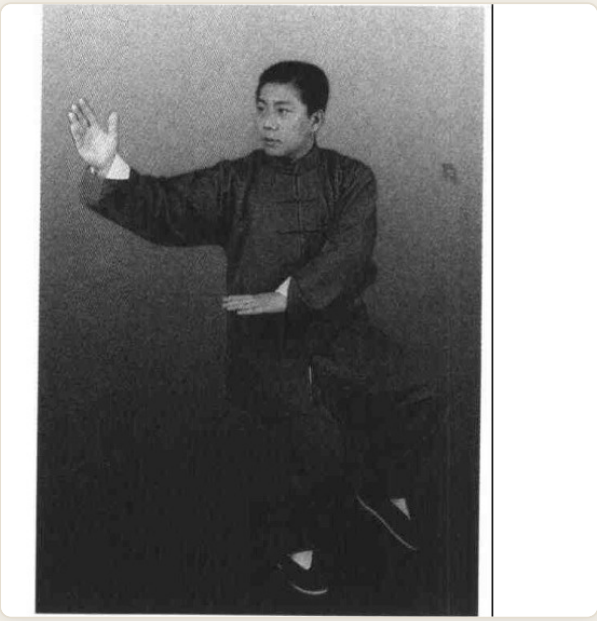
II. Course of the Movement

1. Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the waist turns slightly right, the right hip root draws in slightly, the left leg lifts and the whole weight gradually shifts completely onto the right leg. As the waist turns, the right shoulder relaxes downward and the right elbow sinks, naturally carrying the right palm down along an arc past the side of the right hip; as it descends the arm rotates outward so that the right palm gradually turns face up. At the same time the left palm, following the turning of the waist, moves forward and inward past the right chest and the front of the abdomen, descending along an arc; as it moves the left arm rotates inward so that the palm turns face down. The eyes follow the turning waist, shifting level ahead, with the gaze attending to the right palm (see the three figures at the foot of this page). The above movement is the same as the

earlier Left Brush Knee Twist Step (see the corresponding figures in the Seventh Posture, pp. 51–52).

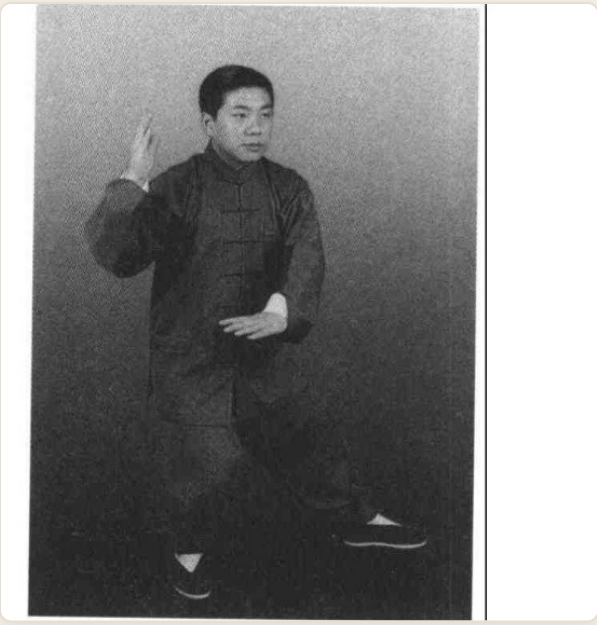
2. Right Brush Knee Twist Step: (i) The waist gradually turns left; with the left foot pivoting on the heel, the toes turn out about 45°. As the body turns, the left palm moves gradually along an arc to the left and back, the arm rotating outward so that the palm turns face up; at the same time the right palm, following the turn of the body, moves from the front inward and along an arc down to the left, the arm rotating inward so that the palm turns face down. The eyes follow the turn of the body, shifting level ahead, with the gaze attending to the left palm (see the fourth figure on this page). (ii) The whole weight gradually shifts onto the left leg, the right foot lifts and moves forward, and the body continues to turn slightly left; as the waist turns, the left palm moves along an arc up to the left diagonal, and the right palm continues to descend along an arc to the left.

图 38



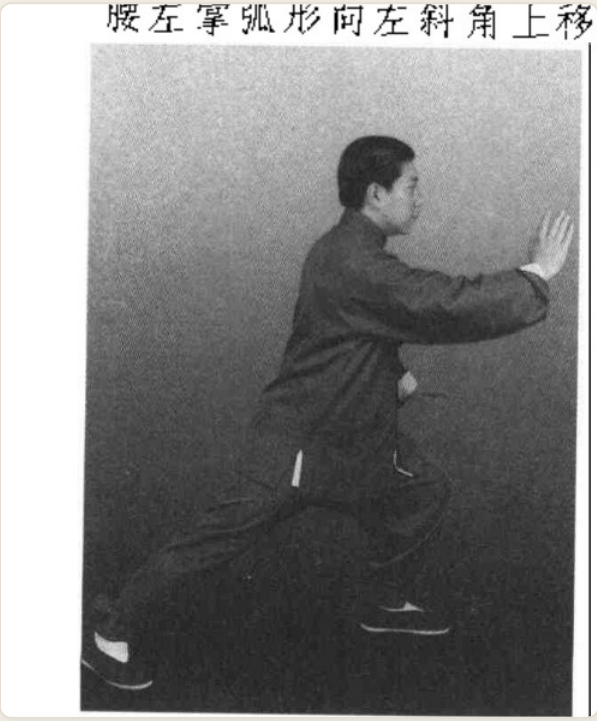
Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the right palm descends along an arc past the side of the right hip, the palm turning face up; the left palm moves down past the right side of the chest

图 39



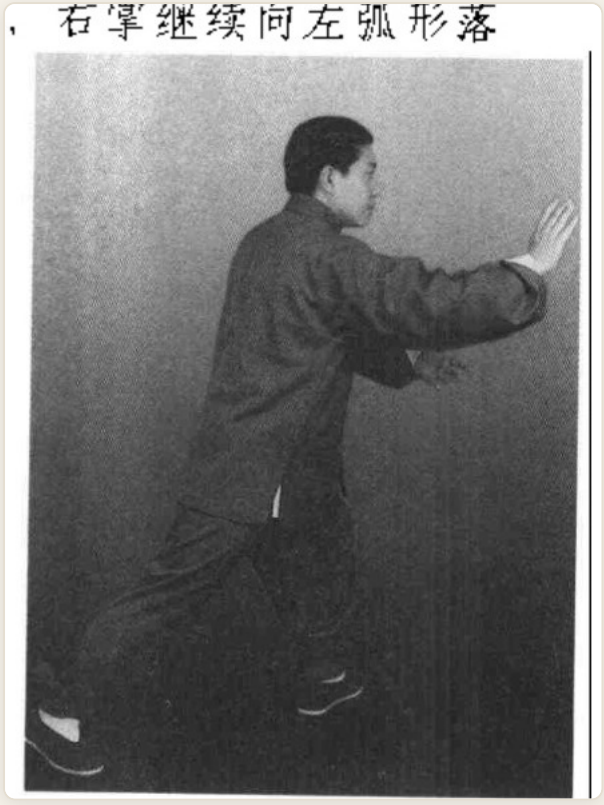
Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the left palm moving down along an arc, the right palm beside the right hip

图 40



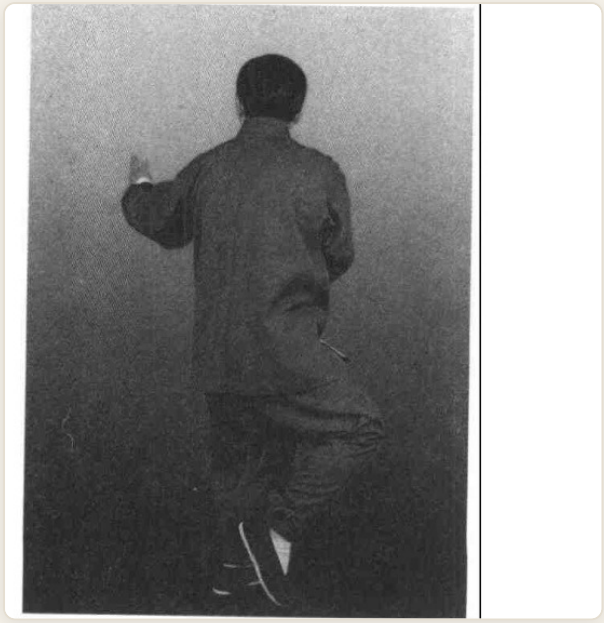
Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the transitional movement before the settled posture, the left leg lifted and the weight on the right leg

图 41



Right Brush Knee Twist Step: the left toes turned out about 45°, the left palm moving along an arc to the left and back, the right palm moving inward and down to the left

图 42

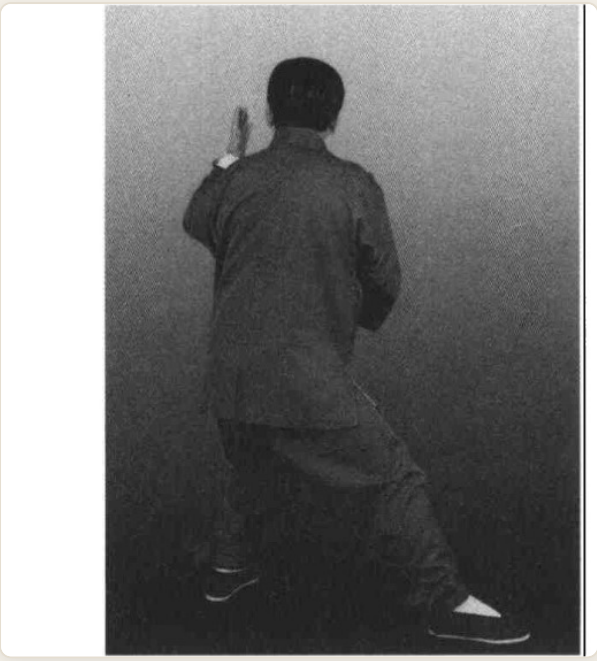


Right Brush Knee Twist Step: the weight on the left leg, the right foot lifted forward, both palms moving up to the left diagonal at the same time

in front of the abdomen; the gaze attends briefly to the left palm and then shifts to the right palm (see the figure on p. 60). (iii) The right foot lands forward, heel first; as the weight gradually shifts onto the right leg until the whole foot is set down, the body gradually turns right at the same time, bowing the right leg and pushing back with the left, forming a right bow stance. At the same time the right palm follows the turning body downward, brushing past the front of the right knee in a horseshoe shape to beside the right hip; the left palm also continues upward along an arc as the weight moves forward and the body turns right, pushing forward past the side of the left ear. The moment the eyes see the right palm brush past the knee they look level ahead, the gaze attending to the forward strike of the left palm (see figures 43 and 44).

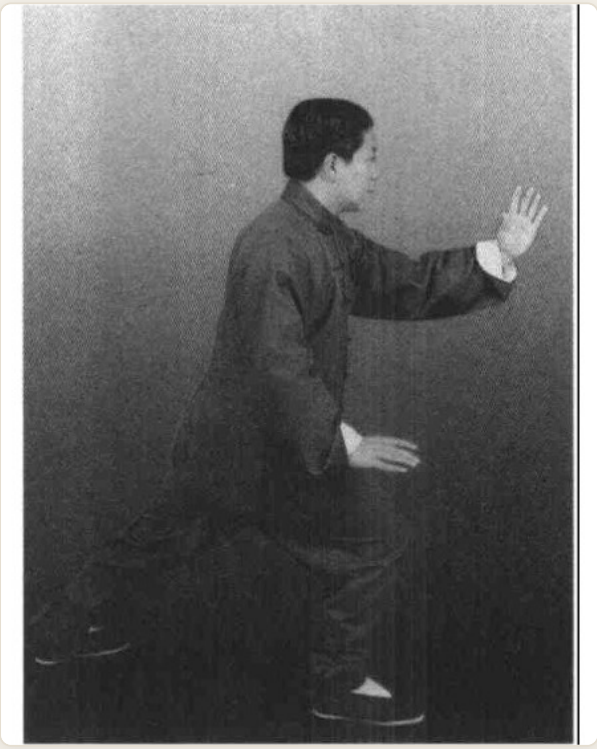
3. Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the movement is the same as the Right Brush Knee Twist Step, simply with left and right reversed (figures 45–48 on this page; they repeat, left-right reversed, the movements shown in figures 33, 34 and 35 of the Seventh Posture).

图 43



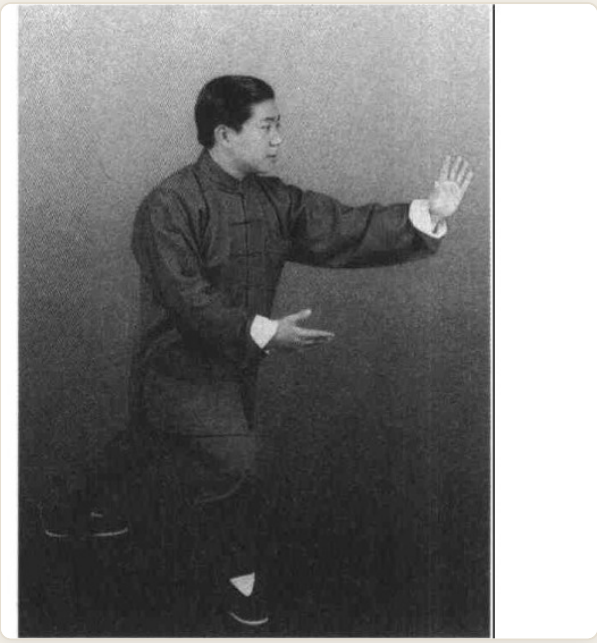
Right bow stance brush knee: the right palm brushing past the front of the right knee in a horseshoe shape to beside the right hip

图 44



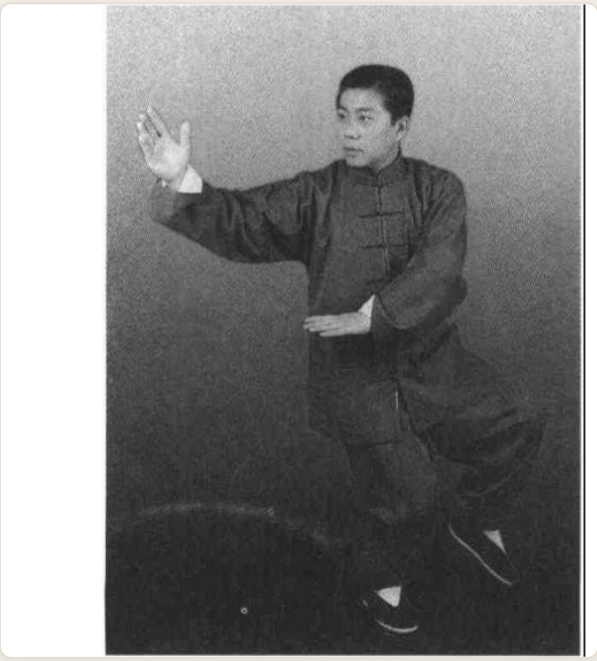
Right Brush Knee Twist Step in its settled posture: the right leg bowed and the left pushed back into a right bow stance, the left palm pushing forward past the side of the left ear

图 45



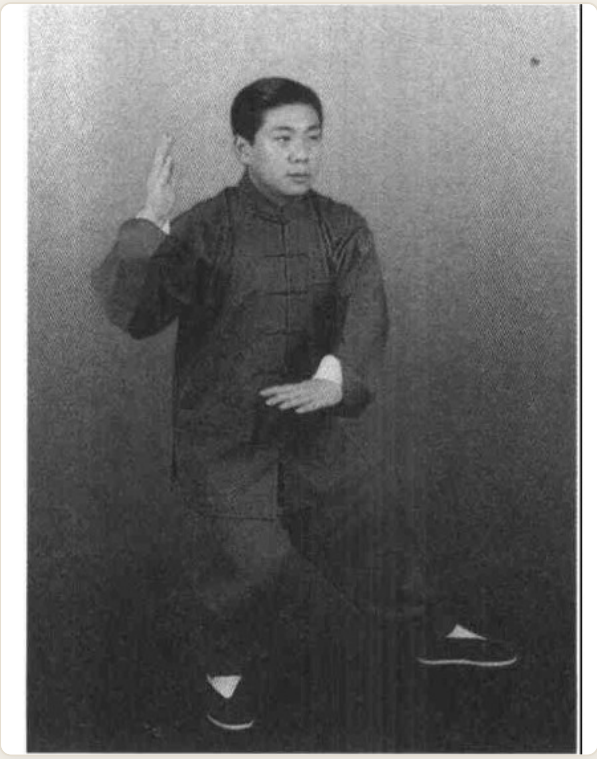
Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the movement of 图 33 (with left and right reversed)

图 46



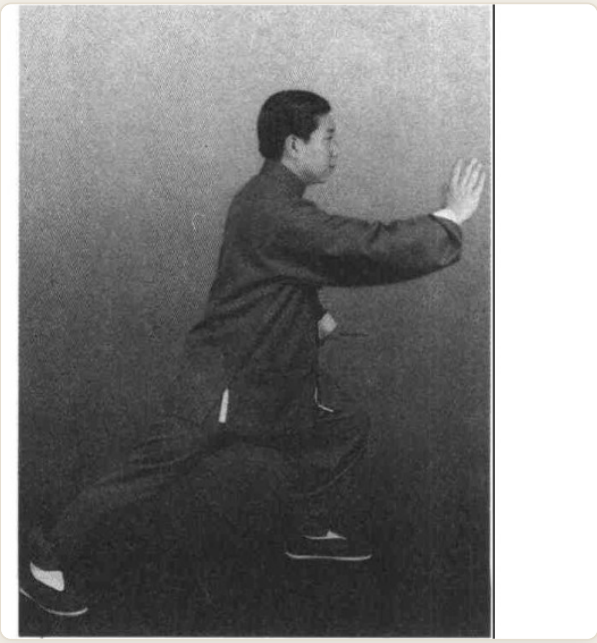
Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the movement of 图 33 (with left and right reversed)

图 47



Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the movement of 图 34 (with left and right reversed)

图 48



Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the movement of 图 35 (with left and right reversed)

III. Essentials

III. Essentials

1. The essentials are the same as those of the earlier Left Brush Knee Twist Step.

2. In practising the Yang-style form, the front and rear feet of the bow stance must not stand on a single line, because this easily produces instability of the centre of gravity and an awkward feeling; the rear foot and the front foot must both be separated laterally (by about the width of the shoulders). Hence, whenever one steps forward or steps back (as in Step Back to Repulse the Monkey), one should take care that the landing position is somewhat opened out, so that it appears steady — "only so can one, advancing or retreating, gain the opportunity and the position."

3. In changing from left bow stance to right bow stance, the footwork requires: in advancing and retreating, in changing, substantial and insubstantial must be clearly distinguished; when the left is insubstantial the right is substantial, when the left is substantial the right is insubstantial; in advancing and retreating the body and waist must change along with it. The knee of the substantial leg must be made more stable, yet without losing its nimbleness; the standing posture must be extremely stable, the step light and nimble, striving to "step as a cat steps", never double-weighted and sluggish; the foot must land light, nimble and steady, never swaying.

4. The turning of the waist must lead the hands. When the two hands are about to finish moving to the left (or right) diagonal rear, one should turn the waist to lead one hand in brushing and the other in striking forward, embodying "the ruler is in the waist" and "power issues from the spine".

5. In going from the Left Brush Knee to the Right Brush Knee, as the right hand moves the left hand must turn at the same time, achieving "when one part moves, every part moves".

6. In brushing, the waist leads the elbow, the elbow leads the wrist, and the wrist must seat downward.

7. The front foot faces squarely in the direction of advance (east); the rear foot is at a slant. In taking up the next brush knee, first turn the waist and turn the toes outward; then the position of the leg is in order.

IV. Requirements

1. The change of the bow stance requires substantial and insubstantial to be clearly distinguished. Taking the change from Left Brush Knee Twist Step to Right Brush Knee Twist Step as the example: the right foot lifts lightly, moves forward, and extends slowly forward; before the right heel lands, the left leg must bear the whole weight of the body — only thus can the substantial and insubstantial of the legs be distinguished.

2. The palm that strikes forward must rotate: that is, in the course from back to front the wrist must turn, advancing in a spiral.

3. In the turning of the upper body the substantial and insubstantial lie in the waist, and secondarily in the chest; the alternation of drawing in the left and right waist creases is used to distinguish substantial and insubstantial. If the turn is insufficient, the two arms that of the movement is restricted; if the turn is too much, "scattering" results.

4. In the linking of "left–right–left" brush knee, there must be no pause: the moment one settled posture is reached, one blends fluidly into the next brush knee; yet one must not go into the next brush knee before the hand has arrived and the knee has bowed fully.

BOOK PAGE 63

V. Errors That Are Easy to Make, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Errors That Are Easy to Make, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Error: turning the body too much. The main cause is that shoulder and hip do not form a vertical line; in turning left and right, shoulder and hip should stay aligned vertically above and below. If the body turns too much the shoulders turn too much, which destroys the correctness of the body and produces an awkward feeling. Correction: the direction in which the line joining the two shoulders points is also required to be the direction of the two hips.

2. Error: in going from Left Brush Knee into Right Brush Knee Twist Step, the left hand has not turned over but merely moves as an upturned palm slanting back and up. The main cause is that in initiating movement one does not lead the elbow with the hand and the shoulder with the elbow. Correction: "the upper arm follows the wrist, the wrist follows the palm", forming a circle at every point. Therefore, when the right hand moves the left hand should turn palm upward, moving along an arc up to the left diagonal.

3. Error: in going from Left Brush Knee into Right Brush Knee, the right hand moves while the left hand halts and does not move. The main cause is a shallow feel for "when one part moves, every part moves". Correction: as the waist turns and the right hand moves inward, along an arc down to the left, the left arm must rotate outward so that the palm turns face up and moves to the left and back.

4. Error: one leg has not yet sat solid when the other leg steps out, and the weight moves forward too quickly, producing double-weighting, and the movement is also not even. The main cause is weakness in the supporting leg, and the hip root on the supporting side not drawing in slightly, so that the leg has not sat steady. Correction: only after the supporting leg has sat

steady may the forward-stepping leg extend slowly, and before it lands the weight must not shift forward.

5. Error: the three brush-knee twist steps have no settled posture that is "as if stopped yet not stopped"; instead the two arms go on drawing arcs forward without pause. The main cause is a shallow understanding of continuity and roundness-and-liveliness. Every posture has a beginning, a continuation, a turn and a close; once a posture is complete, it must close at every point. Correction: every settled posture must have a moment of "as if stopped yet not stopped", so that the spirit gathers and concentrates; only thus can the conditions for the next posture be created. Therefore, in link- ing, both falling short of and overshooting in roundness-and-liveliness are incorrect.

6. Error: the two eyes always stare fixedly straight ahead. The main cause is a shallow understanding of "the eyes follow the hands as they turn, and the light glances in all four directions". That is to say, hand arrives and eye arrives, and to look ahead is right; but one must not stare blankly ahead. Correction: the eyes must turn with the principal hand or foot, achieving "eye arrives where hand arrives".

BOOK PAGE 64

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explain (laying stress on the lateral distance between the feet and on "when one part moves, every part moves") and demonstrate.

2. At each settled posture, stop and check the lateral distance between the feet. Have groups of 2–3 check and correct one another; one may also practise as a group and stop to check oneself.

3. Paired application drills: in pairs. A — strikes B's middle and lower body from the front with fist or foot; B — sinks the body down, sits solid on one leg, steps the other leg one step forward, one hand parries A's hand or foot aside and the other presses toward his chest. Left-right-left, three times in succession.

4. Progressive method — from Left Brush Knee Twist Step into Right Brush Knee Twist Step: (i) repeatedly turn the left toes outward. (ii) While the left toes turn outward the left palm turns up, the right hand draws back along an arc to the left, the weight moves forward and the right leg lifts. (iii) As above, the two hands continue moving, the right leg extends slowly forward and the heel lands lightly, while the left hand moves diagonally back and up and the right hand moves down. (iv) As above, bow the right knee into a right bow stance, while the right hand brushes the knee and the left hand pushes and presses forward.

Improve one section, add one section, like going up a staircase — one more step up from where you already are, until the whole movement is learned and mastered.

5. Supplementary practice: with the two hands hanging naturally, do the bow stance forward step repeatedly, to improve the ability to command substantial and insubstantial, strengthen the legs, and thereby improve health.

6. In practice one should repeatedly perform the linking of left and right brush-knee twist steps.

VII. Technical Analysis

1. The three brush-knee twist steps cover both left and right directions, which benefits the balanced development of the body and its all-round activity.

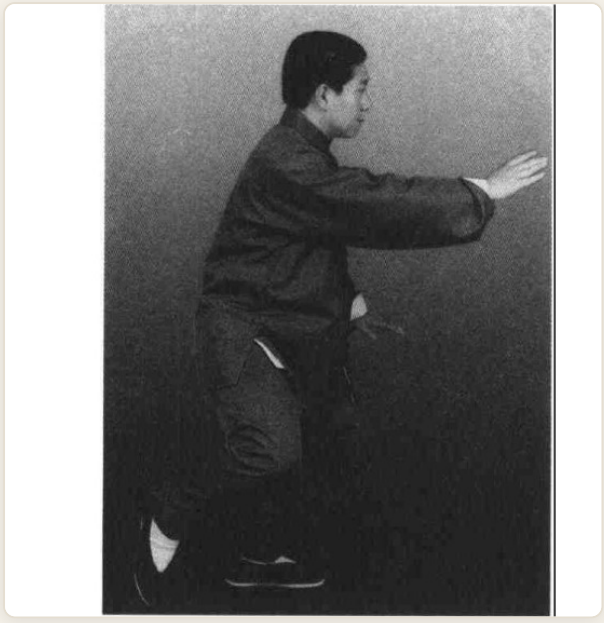
2. Beginners, faced with movements that are identical but reversed in direction, very easily get muddled, so the right brush-knee twist step should be practised more.

3. The three brush-knee twist steps should embody what the *Treatise on Tai Chi Chuan* says: "The long form is like the great Yangtze and the ocean, ever flowing without cease." Each must follow on from the last, round, lively and continuous, with no pause (and so it should be with every movement in the whole set).

4. In the three steps forward, the rear leg goes from lifting to extending forward to landing lightly, all carried out evenly and slowly; this not only exercises the muscles of the straight supporting leg but, through the bending and extending of the forward-stepping leg, also exercises the muscles of thigh and calf and the muscles of waist and hip.

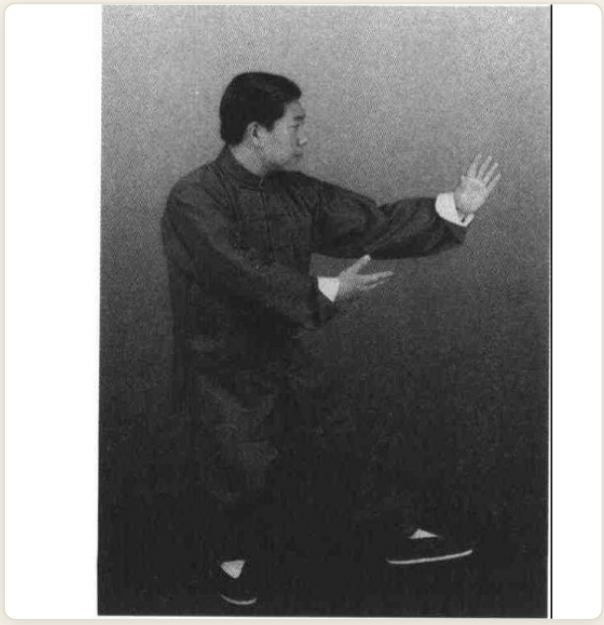
Tenth Posture: Hand Strums the Lute The explanation of the movement is the same as for the Eighth Posture; see figures 49 and 50 in the left-hand column (the same as figures 36 and 37 of the Eighth Posture).

图 49



Hand Strums the Lute: the right hand withdrawn and the left hand extended forward in the lute-cradling posture (the movement is the same as 图 36)

图 50



Hand Strums the Lute in its settled posture (the movement is the same as 图 37)

图 51

Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the right hand pushing forward past the side of the ear, the left hand brushing past the left knee

图 52

Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the settled posture, the left palm pushing forward and the right palm beside the right hip

图 53

Left Brush Knee Twist Step: the movement of 图 33–图 35

(This page also carries an unnumbered close-up photograph of the hand: the palm rotated outward, the four fingers spread, the thumb drawn in — the seated-wrist palm shape. It bears no printed figure number, so it receives no figure note.)

Eleventh Posture: Left Brush Knee Twist Step The explanation of the movement is the same as for the Seventh Posture; see figures 51–53 at the head of this page (the same as figures 33–35 of the Seventh Posture).

Twelfth Posture: Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch

BOOK PAGE 66

I. Application

I. Application

Continuing from the previous posture. If the opponent strikes with his right hand, I immediately opens the left foot slightly to the left side and the waist accordingly turns left; the left hand then turns over backward to beside the left chest, the palm slanting downward. The right hand, wrist

turned down, follows the turning body to the front of the left ribs and closes into a fist; turning the wrist, the waist turns right and the right fist follows the rotation to below the right ribs — this is called the "ban" (deflecting). At the same time the right foot lifts and is set down solidly to the right side; the waist and hips relax and sink, and my left hand brushes the opponent's right arm across to my left, whereupon the left hand strikes forward flat and straight with the side of the palm — this is called the "lan" (parrying). The left foot at the same time lifts and steps out one pace into a left bow stance, and the right fist, in unison with the action of waist and legs, punches forward — this is called the "chui" (the punch). The whole subtlety of this punch lies in neutralizing the opponent's right punch: first using my right wrist to stick to his right wrist and deflect it from above the left ribs to below the right ribs. At this point, fearing that the opponent may withdraw his arm and change step, I immediately send my left hand straight forward, following the step, containing an opening strength. When parrying his right hand, I at once drive my right fist at the opponent's chest, so that he has no time to evade and must be struck by me. Hence the whole subtlety of this punch lies in the correct method of the "deflect" and the "parry".

The slanting variation: if the opponent's right palm strikes with especially great force, I take advantage of his momentum and, listening to his strength (high, low, left, right), follow it at random — my right arm deflects to the right, my left hand parries his right forearm to the left, and I then strike him hard with my right fist.

BOOK PAGE 67

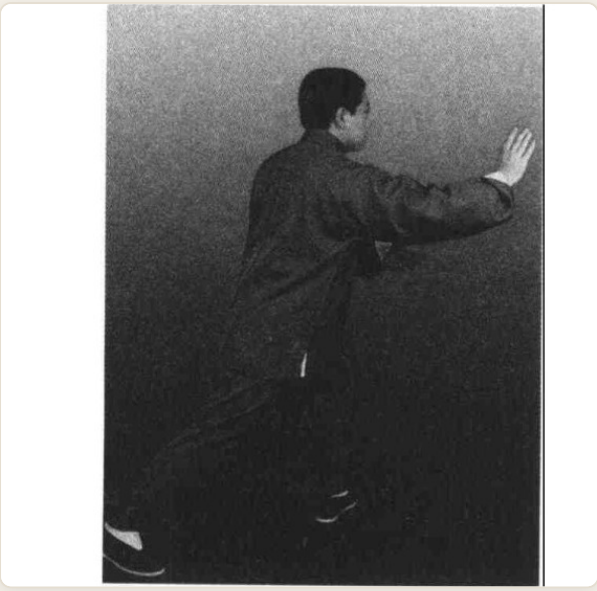
II. Course of the Movement

II. Course of the Movement

1. The body gradually turns left, the left toes turn out 45°; the weight then gradually moves forward onto the left leg, the right heel leaves the ground and the step begins. As the waist turns, the right palm moves naturally along an arc down to the left, as low as the ribs, changing into a fist as it moves, and the right arm rotates inward so that the fist faces down; the left palm also moves slightly back as the waist turns. The gaze attends to the right hand moving down, but one must not bow the head (see the first figure in the left-hand column).

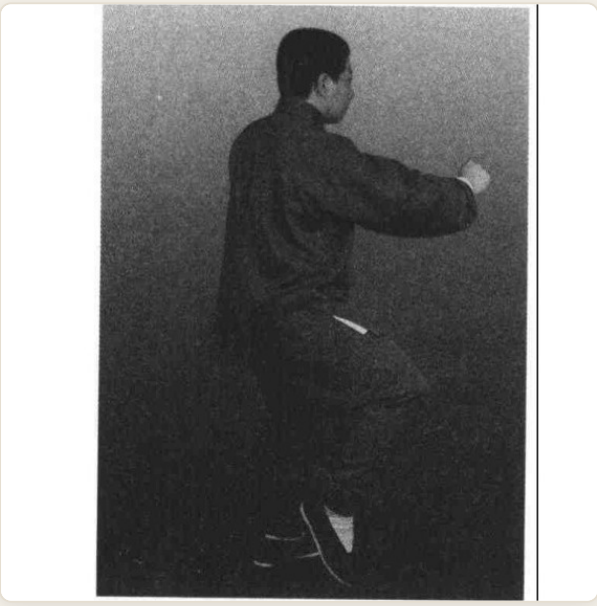
2. The whole weight gradually shifts onto the left leg, the right leg lifts and moves forward; at the same time the right fist goes along an arc to the left past the front of the left ribs and up to the front, and the left palm draws an arc upward (no higher than the chest), the arm rotating slightly inward into an upright palm as it arcs, so that the palm slants to the right. The gaze attends briefly to the right fist, then turns level ahead (see the second figure in the left-hand column).

图 54



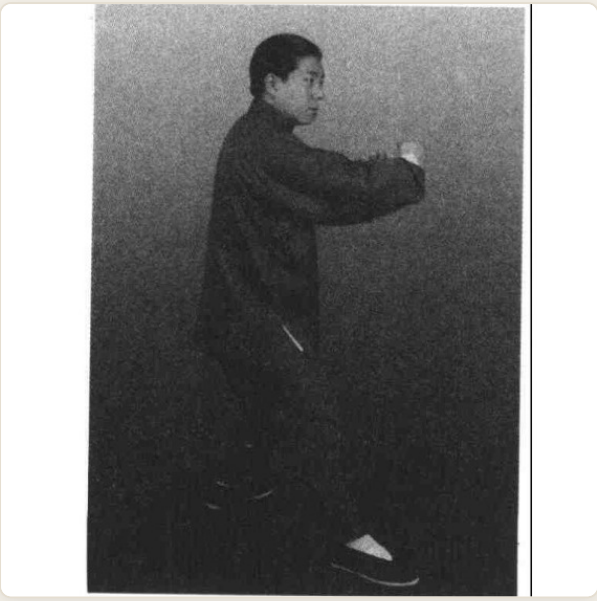
Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the body turning left, the right palm moving along an arc down to the left at rib height and changing into a fist as it moves

图 55



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the right fist arcing up to the left and forward past the front of the left ribs, the left palm arcing upward into an upright palm

图 56A

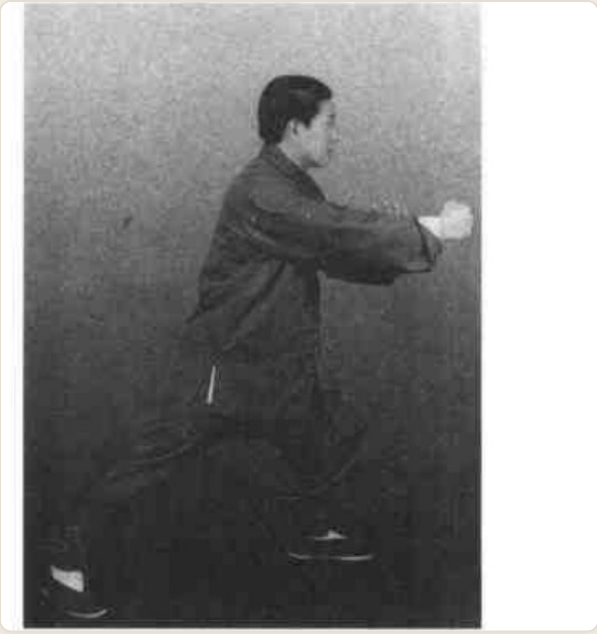


Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the right foot stepping out one pace to the right front, heel touching down first with the toes turned out

图 56B

Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the right fist deflecting out forward and to the right past the chest, the arm rotating outward as it deflects so that the fist eye faces up

图 57



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the right hand closing toward the left, the heel of the left palm against the inner side of the right wrist; as it deflects out the two hands are about level with the shoulders

图 58

Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the weight on the right leg, the left leg lifted; the right fist withdrawing along an arc to the right, the fist centre gradually turning up, and the left palm parrying forward past the right inner side

图 59

Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the left bow stance, the right fist punching forward with the fist eye facing up and the left palm drawn back close to the wrist on the inner side of the right forearm

3. The body gradually turns right (to face east); the right foot steps out one pace to the right front (slightly toward the southeast), heel touching down first with the toes turned out, At the same time the right fist deflects out forward and to the right past the chest, the arm rotating outward as it deflects so that the fist centre gradually turns over and the fist eye faces up. The left palm closes in toward the right hand, its heel resting against the inner side of the right wrist; as it deflects out the two hands are about level with the shoulders. Immediately the ball of the right foot is set down solidly, the whole weight gradually shifts onto the right leg, the left leg lifts and moves forward, and the waist gradually turns right at the same time. As the waist turns the right fist gradually draws back along an arc to the right, the right arm rotating outward so that the fist centre gradually turns up; the left palm likewise follows the turning waist and parries forward past the right inner side (see the first and second figures in the left-hand column).

4. The left foot steps one pace forward, heel touching down first; at the same time the body continues to turn right, and as it turns the left palm continues to strike forward flat and straight (with the side (This page also carries an unnumbered wide photograph: Fu Zhongwen in a light practice suit demonstrating the deflect-and-parry posture from the front, with the left hand pressing the right wrist. It bears no printed figure number, so it receives no figure note.)

of the palm upright), the right fist drawing back along an arc to beside the waist with the fist centre facing up (the two hands drawing apart, one forward and one back) (see the first figure on this page).

5. The weight then gradually shifts onto the left leg until the whole foot is set down; the left leg bows and the right leg pushes back, forming a left bow stance. At the same time the body gradually turns left, and as the waist turns the right fist punches forward, the fist eye gradually turning to face up; the left palm draws back slightly toward the chest, seating the wrist, the fingertips slanting upward and the palm facing right, moving to a point on the middle of the right forearm nearer the wrist, as if touching yet not touching (see the second figure on this page).

BOOK PAGE 69

III. Essentials

III. Essentials

1. In the successive steps forward, one must "step as a cat steps", and the speed must be even, matching above and below. The body must be straight and correct, never slanted, never leaning forward or back.

2. The right foot steps to the right front; this step is required to be rather wider than an ordinary step, but one must avoid the upper body tipping to the right as the right foot steps.

3. The movements of the four limbs must turn with the waist. The right palm arcing to the left and down is precisely the turning of the body to the left. The right fist arcing and deflecting forward is precisely the turning of the upper body to the right; the right fist punching forward is precisely the moment when the upper body turns left and the left leg bows while the right leg pushes back.

4. When the right fist deflects out it must not be too far from the body, and care must be taken not to raise the elbow.

5. In punching out one must "let the fist issue from the heart" — that is, not extend it at random but strike with deliberation, so that inner and outer are as one.

6. In parrying, hand and foot must arrive together, matching above and below.

7. The fist must be closed naturally and firmly, not clenched with force (and so with the whole set), but it must not be a hollow fist either.

IV. Requirements

1. At the point where the punch lands (the settled posture) the back of the fist must form a straight line with the forearm; it must not be bent inward or turned outward, otherwise the wrist is

easily injured when a resisting force strikes it.

2. Substantial and insubstantial must be clearly distinguished. The left foot must turn out and sit solid before the right leg is gradually lifted and brought forward; at the moment the right heel lands the weight is still on the left foot, and the weight must then be moved forward slowly — in this way the step will not drag weight with it.

3. The head must be straight and upright and must have the lifting strength — that is, the spirit runs through to the crown; but the head and neck are not exerted strongly, it is not a hard pushing upward, and forcing the neck makes blood and breath not flow freely; hence one must naturally "let the nape lift the crown".

4. In the parry the left hand is in front and the right fist behind, in opposite directions but answering each other; one must achieve "drawing apart and lengthening, seeking the straight within the curved".

5. The deflect is a circling movement along an arc — "one marvellous hand makes one tai chi". Within this circle there must be both yielding and firm, both insubstantial and substantial, firmness and yielding aiding each other, substantial and insubstantial interpenetrating — it is not a circle suddenly drawn in the middle.

BOOK PAGE 70

V. Errors That Are Easy to Make, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Errors That Are Easy to Make, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Error: when deflecting, the right fist circles down in too big a loop. The main cause is an insufficient grasp of the martial requirement of the "deflect". Correction: the action should use my right wrist to deflect the opponent's right wrist from the left ribs across to the right ribs; so the right elbow should be the pivot and the fist should go down to the left, passing from between the left ribs, turning the wrist as the waist turns right, over to below the right ribs.

2. Error: the fist and the waist fall out of step — in the "deflect" only the hand moves and the waist does not, and in punching out the waist is not used to drive it either. The main cause is insufficient attention to "at every moment keep the mind at the waist". Correction: one must carefully experience "palm, wrist, elbow and shoulder, back, waist, hip, knee and leg — nine joints above and below, and every joint issues from the waist". Hence raising a hand or stepping a leg must all be driven by the waist; the movement of the hand alone cannot neutralize an incoming punch.

3. Error: in the "deflect" the right fist goes from the lower left forward, and before the movement is finished the right arm is drawn back. The main cause is an insufficient understanding of the

application. With the opponent's right fist striking straight forward, if my deflecting movement goes from the lower left forward, then the opponent's right fist is still in front of my body and I am still under attack. If I then deflect to the right, the opponent's right fist is beside my body, and because the straight-striking fist has been carried left and then right by me, its strength is neutralized by me, creating the conditions for my own forward attack. Correction: the deflecting movement should go from between the left ribs to below the right ribs.

4. Error: the deflecting movement is too low. The main cause is a failure to understand the application. Because the opponent's punch comes at the chest and ribs, if I circle in front of the abdomen I do not accord with the actual situation of the neutralization. Correction: the right fist and left hand should be about level with the chest.

5. Error: hand and leg fall out of step — in the "deflect", the "parry" and the "punch" there is no support from the legs. The main cause is inattention to the actions of the lower body here. Correction: within advancing there must be a supporting-back. The feet must be as if rooted in the ground, the base steady; only then is the fist powerful and can the lower body gain the opportunity and the position.

6. Error: the fist or palm is carried too far from the body when striking. The main cause is insufficient attention to storing the momentum. Correction: if fist or palm passes too far beyond the knee, the stability of the centre of gravity is easily lost and the strength becomes rigid and interrupted. Therefore one must note that "strength is stored in the bent so that there is a surplus"; in punching or pushing out the palm one must not straighten the arm and extend it far.

7. Error: the centre of gravity rises and falls too much. The main cause is poor command of the substantial and insubstantial of the two legs. Correction: stepping a leg out or drawing a leg back must both be done while one leg is sitting solid; in this way substantial and insubstantial become clear and the rise and fall small.

BOOK PAGE 71

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explain, and demonstrate. After demonstrating the movement as a whole, break it down into deflect, parry and punch so that the concept of the whole movement is clear.

2. Mnemonic for the movement: turn out the foot and close the fist, raise the right foot; turn the body and join the hands in an arcing deflect; sit solid on the right leg and draw apart in the parry; left leg bows and right fist punches, arriving together.

3. Practise the whole movement as a group.

4. Take the three actions — deflect, parry and punch — separately, and learn them one by one.

5. Progressive method: (i) turn the left toes outward, the left hand goes back and the right hand down to the left. (ii) As above, lift the right foot and sit solid on the left leg. (iii) As above, bring the right leg forward, the right fist arcing forward and up and deflecting to the right, the left hand moving up to the right to near the right wrist, the right leg stepping out forward with the right heel landing. (iv) As above, continue turning the body right, the left hand parries out, the right fist draws back to the waist, the left leg steps out and the heel lands. (v) As above, bow the left leg, the body turns slightly left, the left hand draws back slightly, the right fist punches forward, and the left hand rests at the right elbow and wrist.

Once a part of the preceding movement has been basically mastered, then add the following part — practise the two parts together, and so on; finally, practise the movement in its entirety.

6. Paired application drills: (i) A — stands upright and strikes forward with his right fist; B — from the position of Left Brush Knee, steps out with the right foot and uses the deflecting method to carry A's right fist from the left across to the right. (ii) A — steps back; B — steps out with the left foot and strikes straight forward with the left palm. (iii) A — steps back; B — bows the left leg and punches straight out with the right fist. This makes the actions of deflect, parry and punch vivid and concrete.

7. Observe from different angles to find and correct errors: (i) from the front, watch the turning out of the foot and the closing of the fist. (ii) From the left side, watch the height and distance of the deflect and the position of the left hand. (iii) From the front, watch the lateral distance of the right foot. (iv) From the right side, watch the height of the drawing-apart palms in the parry, and that the right fist withdraws without exposing the elbow. (v) From the side, watch that bowing the leg and punching out arrive together.

8. Students help one another.

9. Practise more: sitting solid on the left leg, slowly lifting the right leg and stepping out to the right front (east, slightly toward the south), a little wider than an ordinary step.

BOOK PAGE 72

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. This movement requires two steps forward, while the hands are in unceasing motion; hence it makes high demands on clearly distinguishing substantial and insubstantial and on a stable lower body. For this reason one must take care that one leg sits solid while the other moves lightly and nimbly.

2. The actions of deflect, parry and punch must be closely coordinated with the turning of waist and hips; use intention, not force — but the intention must be brought to bear.

3. The movement must be continuous. Let there be no defect, no hollow or protruding place, no interruption: the three actions are finished in a single breath.

Thirteenth Posture: Apparent Close-Up (Ru Feng Si Bi)

I. Application

图 60

Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the left leg bowed and the right fist punching straight out (demonstration for the technical analysis)

图 61A

Apparent Close-Up: the left hand raised and passed beneath the right elbow, the palm stuck to the elbow to guard the arm and parrying away toward the opponent's left wrist

图 61B

Apparent Close-Up: the right fist opened and drawn and folded inward to the breast, the two palms crossing at a slant face inward to form a slanted cross sealing bar

Continuing from the previous posture. If the opponent grasps my right fist with his left hand, I immediately raise my left hand and pass it under my right elbow, sticking the palm to the elbow to guard the arm, and parry away toward the opponent's left wrist. If the opponent changes hands to press in, I then open out my right fist, drawing and folding it inward toward my breast until the two palms face inward and cross at a slant, forming a slanted cross like a sealing bar, so that the opponent cannot enter — as though closing a door. This is called "as if sealing" (ru feng). At the same time, hollowing the chest and sitting the hips, the two hands then separate, changing so that the two palms are about to press and hold his elbow and wrist, so that he can neither escape nor neutralize, as though his door were shut and could not be opened — this is called "as if closing" (si bi). Then, swiftly using a long strength, pressing outward with the press posture, the eyes looking ahead, the strength of the waist also joining in the attack, The left leg bends and sits solid, the right leg straightens with the hip; they combine into a single strength and strike at the opponent — this too is a closing method. Variation: if my right fist is grasped, the right hand sinks down and I then step in with a shoulder-lean.

II. Course of the Movement

II. Course of the Movement

1. The right leg bends and the weight gradually shifts back onto the right leg; at the same time the left palm extends forward past the right elbow, along under the forearm, the arm rotating outward as it extends so that the palm faces up, then rotating inward so that the palm turns inward. The right fist becomes a palm, the elbow sinking, and draws back inward; as it draws back the arm rotates outward so that the palm also turns inward. The two arms cross, the right arm inside, the fingertips slanting up, the two palms and fingers level with the shoulders, forming a slanted cross shape. The gaze attends to both palms (see the figures 60 and 61 at the top of the right-hand column).

2. The weight continues to shift back; sit solid on the right leg (the left leg must not straighten completely). The two palms separate to left and right, a little wider than the shoulders, and as they separate the two arms rotate inward, gradually turning the two palms over until they face each other (see the first figure in the left-hand column).

3. The weight gradually moves forward; the left leg bows and the right pushes back, forming a left bow stance. At the same time the two palms press out forward, and as they press the two arms continue rotating inward so that the palms turn to face obliquely forward, the wrists slightly below shoulder height. The gaze must attend to the forward press of the two palms (see the second figure in the left-hand column).

III. Essentials

1. The two arms should draw back and close as the body sits back. When the two arms cross, one must avoid the shoulders hunching or lifting; the shoulders must sink and the elbows hang, and room must be kept under the armpit, about enough to hold a fist. But the elbows must not protrude or lift outward, nor may they be withdrawn behind the body, so that one does not trap oneself.

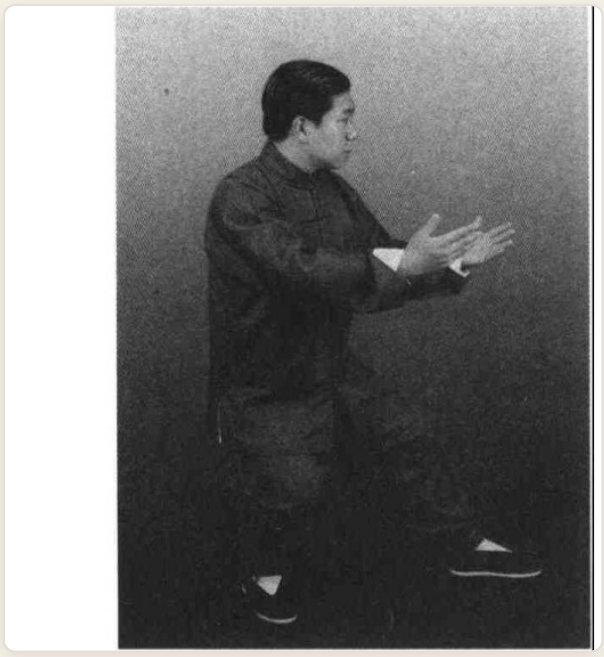
2. In sitting the weight back, relax waist and hips and sit solid on the right leg; one must not fail to shift the weight back while merely drawing the arms in and tilting the body back, nor bend forward while pressing out. Whether sitting back or bowing forward, the upper body must stay straight and correct with the tailbone centred and upright. When the weight moves forward and back, note that chest and abdomen advance and retreat together, neither first nor last; then the body method stays centred and upright and the upper body will not tip forward or lean back.

3. The drawing back and the pressing out of the two hands are essentially horizontal, backward and forward; the elbow has a sinking action, but the hand does not sink down.

IV. Requirements

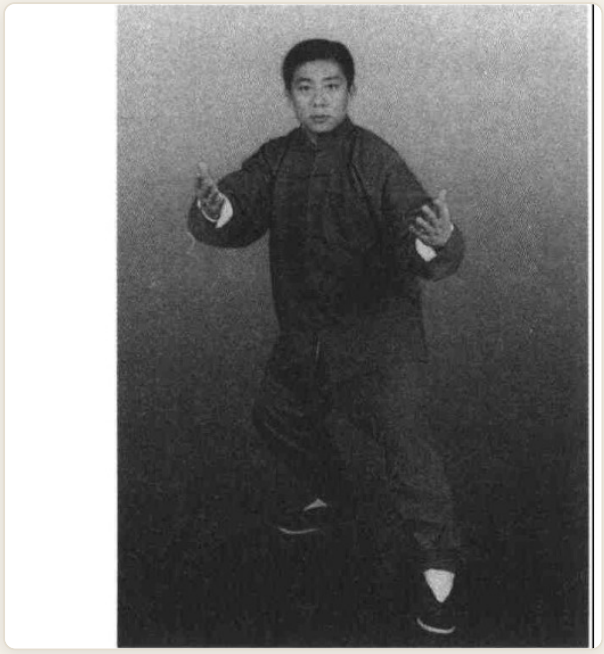
1. One must be able to keep the arms relaxed, soft and rounded while extending, contracting and turning the circle.

图 62A



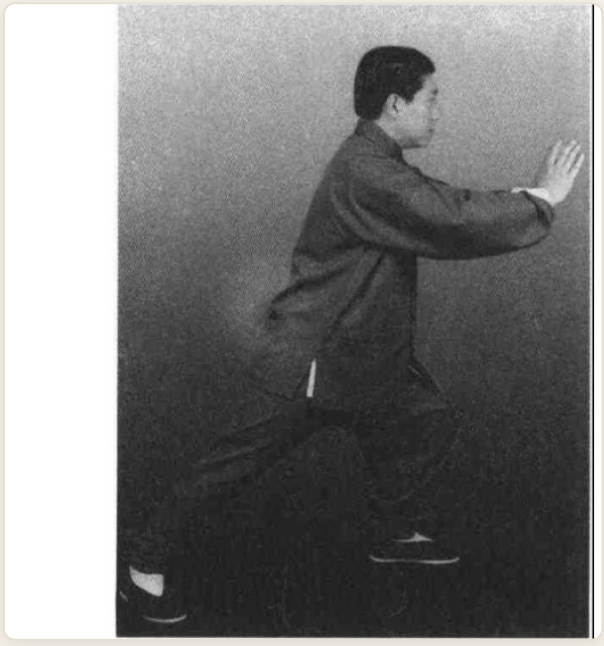
Apparent Close-Up: the two palms separating to left and right a little wider than the shoulders, the two arms rotating inward so that the palms gradually face each other

图 62B



Apparent Close-Up: the two palms separated, the palms gradually facing each other

图 63



Apparent Close-Up: in the left bow stance the two palms press out forward, the palms facing obliquely forward and the wrists slightly below shoulder height

The key lies in whether the shoulder joint can be loosened; hence the requirement "sink the shoulders and hang the elbows" must be approached from the notion of "relaxation".

2. Sink the shoulders and hang the elbows, but also note that "the elbow does not stick to the ribs", so that the arm has room to turn; note that one must "relax and open so that my strength is not bent".

3. In advancing and retreating, shoulder and hip must stay aligned above and below, advancing and retreating together; then one will not behave like a rowing boat, with the seat unmoving while only the body tips forward and leans back.

4. The movement must be completed: do not separate the two hands before the slanted cross has formed.

5. As the hands move, the feet must at the same time sit slowly back. When the hand presses home, the foot is also required to bow home.

BOOK PAGE 74

V. Errors That Are Easy to Make, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Errors That Are Easy to Make, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Error: the legs move while the hands do not, or the hands move while the legs do not. For example, at the start, as the left hand passes to below the right ribs and the right fist becomes a palm, the foot does not move at all. The main cause is insufficient attention to "when one part moves, every part moves". Correction: the moment the two hands above begin to move, the weight below must shift.

2. Error: the two hands cross for too long, held close against the chest, producing "inviting in and letting it land". The main cause is a shallow understanding of the application. The cross was originally formed to prevent the opponent's hand from entering, holding the intention of sealing; but if I myself bring the two hands close against my chest, then of course his pressing hand also lands on my body. Correction: the two hands must keep a certain distance from the chest, so that even when the opponent presses in I still have room to turn.

3. Error: when the two hands draw back the chest is hollowed and the shoulders tense and draw in. The main cause is failing to distinguish a hollowed chest from a contained chest. Containing the chest means the chest feels broad and at ease, which aids breathing, and the two shoulders close slightly forward. Hollowing the chest is a tense drawing in, which is bad for the neutralizing strength of the two hands. Correction: the shoulder joints must relax, the two shoulders close slightly forward, the chest broad — but one must not puff out the chest either.

4. Error: in moving the two hands forward and back, the rise and fall is great. The main cause is pursuing an outward "roundness and liveliness" while neglecting the requirements of the application. Correction: the two hands should move essentially level and straight. Because of the

step type changes, the two hands seem to move up and down; only thus is it favourable for sealing the opponent's elbow and wrist so that he cannot escape or neutralize, and favourable for my own pressing out.

5. Error: on the forward press the fingers become stiff, or else collapse limply. The main cause is insufficient attention to the requirements of an upright wrist and relaxed, extended fingers. Correction: both pushing out and drawing back the palm should be chiefly natural and extended; one must not clench the fingers tight or spread them with force. The wrist joint must be round and lively, and on the forward push the heel of the palm should apply a slight force.

6. Error: in the forward bow the left knee goes beyond the toes — this is called "overshooting the strength". The main cause is a subjective belief that this makes the movement fuller, whereas in fact it makes the change-over sluggish. Correction: the knee joint may go slightly forward of the vertical line of the lower leg, but it must not pass beyond the toes.

7. Error: the left leg bows first while the two palms are still slowly pressing forward, so that hand and foot do not arrive together. The main cause is a shallow understanding of the application. "Issuing strength requires above and below to match, and then one goes forward invincibly." If the foot arrives but the hand does not, above and below do not match; such a press has only the strength of the hand and cannot make the strength rise from the heel. Correction: hand must arrive with foot; the pressing hand requires the coordination of a forward bow and a backward push. Hence, within advancing, there must be a supporting-back.

BOOK PAGE 75

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explain, and demonstrate.

2. Practise together as a group, following the leader.

3. From the front, check the distance between the separated hands; from the left side, look at the point where the left hand passes the right elbow; from the right side, look at the amount the two hands rise and fall as they move forward and back.

4. Mnemonics for the movement: (i) thread through, cross, turn over, press; (ii) parry, seal, close, press.

5. The successive positions of the two hands as they move should be practised section by section, so that the student has a clear understanding of the requirements of the movement.

6. Paired application drills: A — takes up the settled posture of Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch; B — stands upright and grasps A's right hand with his left. A — parries forward with his

left hand from below the right elbow; B — steps up with the left foot and, changing hands, presses forward with both palms. A — the two hands cross at a slant, then separate, holding down B's elbow and wrist and pressing out with a long strength.

BOOK PAGE 76

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. Although this movement has no stepping, sitting back and bowing forward make high demands on the beginner's tailbone being centred and upright. Therefore one must earnestly practise shoulders and hips advancing and retreating together.

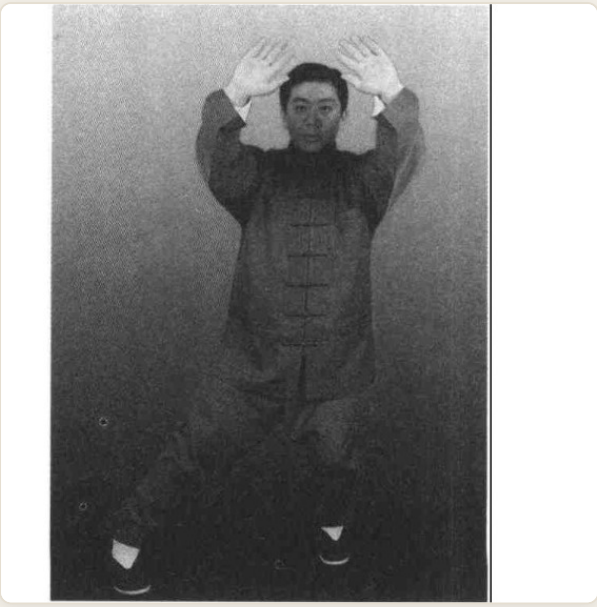
2. The sealing and closing movement travels a short distance and changes fast; a moment's inattention and the movement is easily performed perfunctorily. Hence the requirements on relaxing the shoulders, containing the chest and holding the wrist upright are high.

3. Practising tai chi chuan requires quiet: one must set aside distracting thoughts and be calm and even in temper. At first one thinks only of the method of the movement, the direction, the angle and so on, and easily loses one thing while attending to another; after long practice the movements become skilful and the mind gradually quiets of itself. This exerts a very good regulating effect on the cerebral cortex and is of good use in preventing and treating various chronic diseases and strengthening the constitution.

Fourteenth Posture: Cross Hands (Shi Zi Shou)

I. Application

图 64



Cross Hands: the two hands separating from above and joining from below, forming the cross shape in front of the forehead

Continuing from the previous posture. If the opponent comes at me from my right side, from above downwards, I immediately open out my right arm upward and wide to the right, and the body turns right at the same time, while the left foot turns in to the right. The two hands separate from above and then join from below, forming a cross shape. The whole body sits on the left leg; the right foot is immediately lifted and drawn back half a step to the left, the two feet planted flat as in the Opening Posture. This is an opening energy and a closing energy. When I use opening energy to separate the opponent's hands, I guard against the opponent seizing the opening to strike at my chest, and so I at once make the two hands into a closing energy. At this moment the palms face inward, pinning the opponent's arm. If the opponent presses in with both hands, I use both hands to separate his arms from the inside out to left and right, palms up or palms down, either will do. But when the cross hands are formed, the knees and waist must at the same time relax somewhat and sink down a little, and then the force coming from the opponent is of itself scattered and broken.

II. Course of the Movement

II. Course of the Movement

1. The body turns right, and at the same time the left toes turn in (facing south), sitting firmly on the left leg. As the waist turns and the elbows bend, the two hands move to the right (south) until they reach in front of the forehead (see the first figure on this page). They stop about two of the practitioner's fists from the forehead. As they move the two arms rotate slightly inward so that the palms face forward and the arms form a ring. Following the turning of the waist, the gaze passes between the two palms and looks level ahead.

2. The centre of gravity gradually shifts entirely to the left leg; the right heel leaves the ground first and the whole foot lifts, drawing in to the left, touching down toes-first toward the south (shoulder-width), then the whole foot gradually presses flat; at once the centre of gravity shifts right, the two legs gradually straighten, and at the same time the left toes lift slightly and the two knees bend slightly, forming a feet-apart stance. At the same time the two palms separate, each descending from left and right, passing in front of the abdomen; the right palm on the outside joins and crosses and arcs upward to in front of the collarbone, the left wrist about three fists' distance from the chest. As the two palms move down to below shoulder height, the two arms rotate outward as they move so that the palms gradually turn to face inward. The eyes first follow the arcing of the two palms, and when the two arms are about to cross they look level ahead (see the second and third figures on this page).

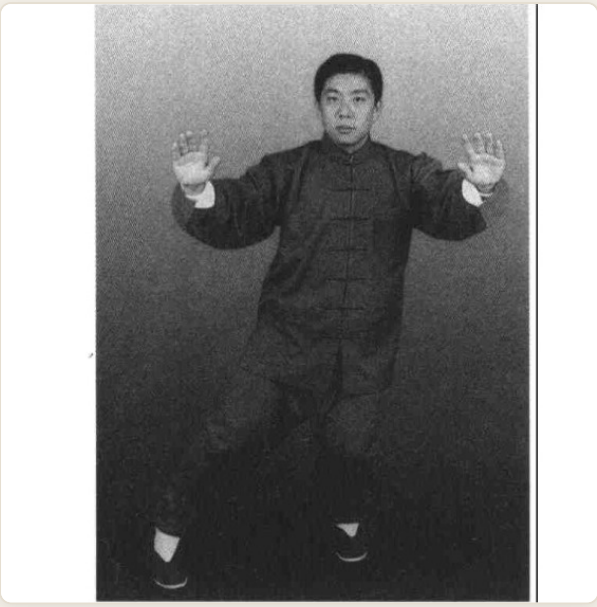
III. Key Points

1. As the left toes turn in and gradually press flat, the two hands move with the turning of the body (toward the south), arcing upward as they move.

2. The right foot gradually lifts off the ground and steps down; the centre of gravity gradually shifts to the right leg. It should be like a see-saw, one end rising as the other falls; the two feet must not share the body's weight equally (double weighting).

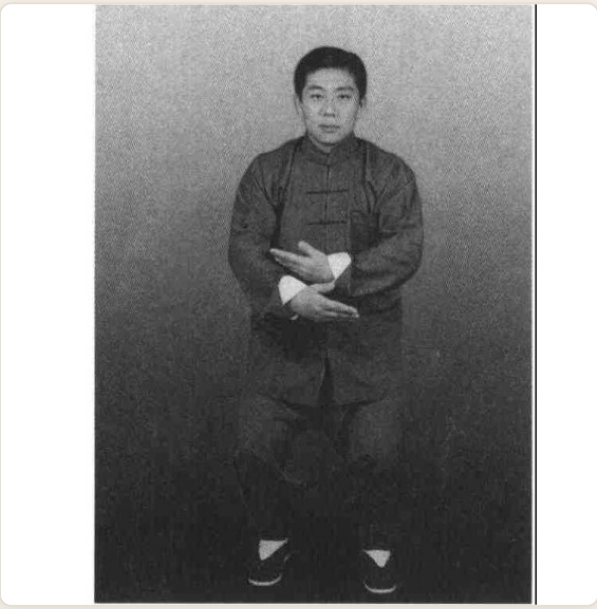
3. As the two hands move up, the mind must attend to the point of energy — the ulnar side of the two wrists.

图 65



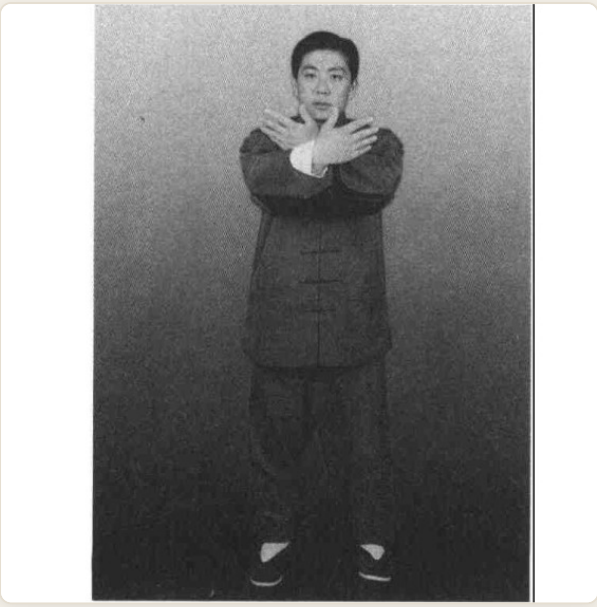
Cross Hands: the body turns right, the two hands move in front of the forehead, the two arms forming a ring

图 66



Cross Hands: the right foot draws in to the left and presses flat, the two palms descending from left and right past the front of the abdomen

图 67



Cross Hands: the two palms cross and arc upward to enfold in front of the collarbone, the gaze level ahead

4. As the two hands move down, the left leg must sink, and at the same time "send down" the right leg.

5. When the two hands cross in front of the chest they must go slightly upward and outward, until the heels of the two palms are level with the shoulders, so that the movement is rounded and possesses ward-off energy.

6. The whole Cross Hands movement must have upper and lower accompanying each other: the hands' and feet's movements should begin at the same time and end at the same time, and must be coordinated.

7. When the two legs rise, the body must be upright and every part must relax.

BOOK PAGE 78

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. When the left toes turn in and you sit solidly on the left leg, the waist and the crotch must be relaxed and mobile and the hip joints loosened; then waist and legs can follow each other.

2. Sit solidly on the left leg, draw the hip root slightly inward, rotate and sink; the right leg slowly lifts. When the right leg approaches the left leg, relax the left waist and knee somewhat and let

the body sink down a little; the left leg must not sit so solidly as to be completely rigid.

3. As the two hands move up, the fingers are about level with the head.

4. As the two hands move down, the two elbows must not hang from above but form a full arc; the heels of the two palms must not drop below the waist.

5. When the cross hands are formed, the two arms must make a ring; relax the shoulders and sink the elbows; do not shrug the shoulders or lift the elbows.

V. Errors Easily Committed, Their Causes, and Their Correction

1. **Error:** the two palms rise too high. The main cause is an unclear grasp of the application of "separating". When I use opening energy to separate the opponent's hands, if the two hands are too high my own chest is left empty. **Correction:** the height of the two hands should not exceed the head by much.

2. **Error:** the right foot steps down, but not by bending the left leg to "send" it down. The main cause is tension in the hip root. **Correction:** after the right leg lifts, loosen the left hip root. First squat down on the left leg, while the right leg slowly descends. This is a strenuous way of practising; long practice can develop the muscles of waist and legs and make the step light and quick.

3. **Error:** hand and foot fall out of step — only the hands move while the feet do not, and the movement is broken. The main cause is failure to meet the requirement that upper and lower accompany each other. **Correction:** hands up, right foot lifts; hands down, right foot steps down; the two feet rise and the two hands go up.

4. **Error:** double weighting of the two feet at the settled Cross Hands. The cause The main cause is that most people take the section as finished — this is a resting movement. **Correction:** like a see-saw, when the right foot is solid the left foot must become empty; one foot does the work, not two feet sharing the weight — only then is there no double weighting. Otherwise the two feet stand dead, which is unfavourable for flexibly taking up the next movement.

BOOK PAGE 79

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

1. Explain (with emphasis on double weighting) and demonstrate.

2. The group practises along, with emphasis on the coordination of hand and foot movements.

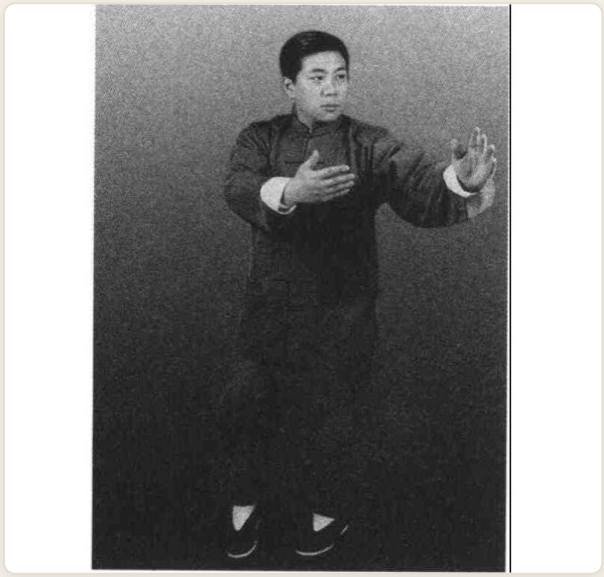
3. Students observe and correct one another, e.g. the height of the hands and the "sending" down of the right leg.

4. Each person senses the solidity and emptiness of the two feet, and compares and experiences double weighting.

5. Paired practice using the application: A — takes up the settled posture of Sealing and Closing; B — strikes down from above on A's right side. A — at once turns the left toes in and arcs the two hands upward to separate; B — presses with the right hand on A's chest from the front. A — moves the two hands down to join and form the cross and move it up, pinning the opponent's arm. The two then exchange roles.

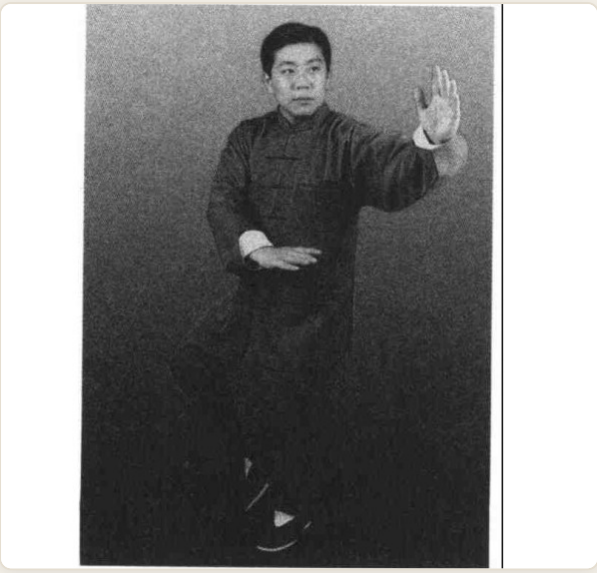
6. Practise the linkages: ① as the press of Sealing and Closing is ending, in the moment between seeming to stop and not stopping, at once connect the right turn of the body, the turning in of the left toes and the moving of the two arms to the right. ② as Cross Hands ends, in the moment when the two hands seem to stop and yet do not, at once connect the turning in of the left toes, without allowing a pause, so that the link is round and lively.

图 68



Cross Hands linking into Embrace the Tiger and Return to the Mountain: the two hands arc upward and separate, the left toes turn in, the body turns right

图 69



Cross Hands linking into Embrace the Tiger and Return to the Mountain: the two hands come down, join and form the cross and move upward

Fifteenth Posture: Embrace the Tiger and Return to the Mountain (Bao Hu Gui Shan)

I. Application

Continuing from the previous posture. If the opponent closes in and strikes at my right side or from behind me, and there is no time to tell whether he is using hand or foot, I hastily turn my waist to the right, separate the two hands, step out with the right foot, bend the knee and sit solidly, the left leg straightening; the right hand, following the turning of the waist, intercepts toward the opponent's waist and then embraces back, while the left hand hastily follows forward to press. So the right hand first intercepts with the waist and then withdraws as an upward-facing palm, as in making the Embrace-the-Tiger posture. If the opponent's hand and foot are very fast and I fail to embrace him, but only deflect or press him out, and he then changes to strike with the left hand, I ward him back with the "unfold" energy; hence the unfold, squeeze and press movements of Grasp the Bird's Tail are appended below.

II. Course of the Movement

(1) Embracing the Tiger

1. The left toes turn in about 90° and press flat; the left leg gradually bends at the knee and squats down, and as the centre of gravity shifts onto the left leg the right foot gradually lifts (heel leaving the ground first); at the same time the body turns right about 135°. As the waist turns, the left palm withdraws downward from in front of the chest, the arm rotating inward to arc to the

left, and is raised level with the left shoulder with the palm facing south-west; the right elbow sinks and naturally carries the right palm down, rotating inward as it moves so that the palm turns to face down. The eyes first attend to the raising of the left palm to the left, then turn right to look level ahead (see the first two figures on this page).

2. The right foot steps out diagonally to the right front (north-west), touching down heel first; as the centre of gravity gradually shifts onto the right leg the whole foot comes flat, the right leg bows and the left leg pushes, forming a right bow stance; the body continues to turn right. As the waist turns, the right palm continues downward, passes in front of the waist and gathers to the right side of the body, while the left palm goes from left upward past the left ear and strikes forward with the turning of the waist. The eyes attend slightly to the right palm embracing to the right, then look level ahead, and then attend to the left palm's forward strike (see the third, fourth and fifth figures on this page).

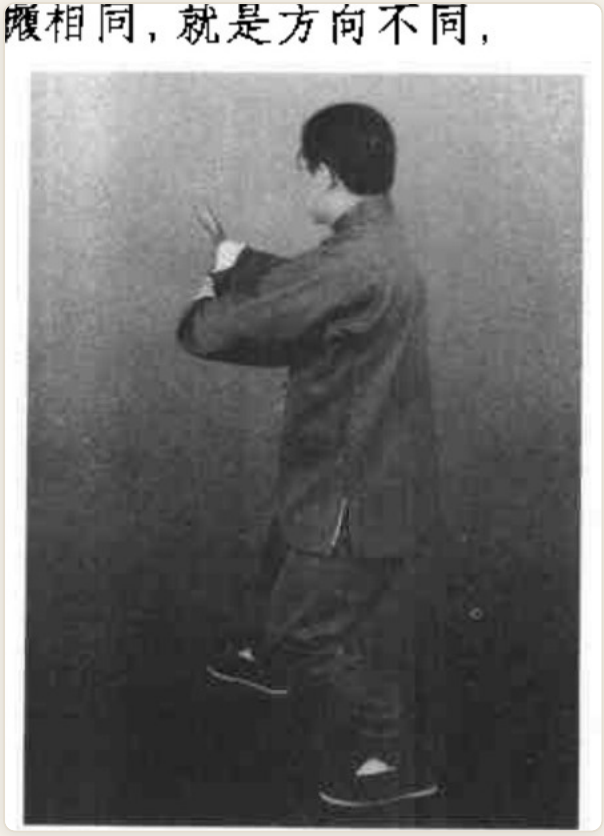
图 70

Embrace the Tiger and Return to the Mountain: the right foot steps out diagonally to the right front, the right hand gathering in past the front of the waist

图 71A

Embrace the Tiger and Return to the Mountain: the right leg bowing and the left leg pushing to form a right bow stance, the left palm striking forward

图 71B



Embrace the Tiger and Return to the Mountain: the settled posture with the left palm striking forward

(2) The Unfold Movement

1. The centre of gravity gradually shifts to the left leg and the waist gradually turns left; at the same time the left elbow sinks and the left arm rotates outward so that the palm faces inward and slantingly upward; the right palm arcs forward from the right side of the body and, passing inside the left hand, is raised in front of the left palm, the palm slanting downward.

2. The movement is the same as the unfold of Grasp the Bird's Tail, only the direction differs, This movement goes from the north-west diagonal toward the south-east, whereas the earlier Grasp the Bird's Tail unfolds from west toward east (see the first two figures on this page).

3. The squeeze movement (see the third and fourth figures on this page).

4. The press movement (see the fifth and sixth figures on this page).

III. Key Points

III. Key Points

1. The Embrace-the-Tiger movement turns from the Cross Hands, which face south, to face north-west behind and to the right; therefore the left toes must turn in fully, the waist turn and the stepping out of the right leg must be complete, and it must reach the true diagonal.

2. The right leg travels a direction of about 135°; therefore the left leg must sit solid and the waist and hips must be fully loosened so that the right leg moves fully with the turning of the waist.

3. The right hand embraces to the right rear, so its height is higher than in Brush the Knee — about level with the waist.

4. In linking Cross Hands into Embrace the Tiger and Return to the Mountain the two feet must not double-weight. The right heel steps down, the left toes lift slightly and turn in first, and at the same time the sole of the left foot presses flat and the right heel at once lifts.

5. After the right leg has stepped out and pressed flat, if you feel the turn is insufficient or awkward, you may let the sole of the left foot stay on the ground and rotate the heel outward.

IV. Requirements

1. As the left toes turn in, this must be coordinated with the squatting, the turning of the waist and the movement of the two arms; upper and lower move together, otherwise it does not accord with the principle "one part moves, no part is still".

2. After the waist turns right, the diagonal position in which the right leg steps out must be accurate, so that the left palm's strike goes in the north-west direction.

3. The toes must turn in properly. For the outward splaying and inward turning of the toes bear on the accuracy of the whole movement. In Embrace the Tiger and Return to the Mountain, if the left toes turn in insufficiently the strike direction comes out too far west, or if the right foot is forced to step out too far north, the hips are opened too wide and the two feet end up in an awkward, unstable stance. So the movement of the toes and the movement of the whole body are mutually related and mutually constraining; a moment's inattention makes the whole movement incorrect.

4. Solid and empty must be clear. After the waist turns right, the right leg must, in stepping out, be required to touch down slowly and lightly.

5. In the unfold of Embrace the Tiger, the right hand's forward extension and the left hand's withdrawal of the welcoming palm must happen at the same time as the centre of gravity slowly

shifts back; otherwise the foot moves while the hand does not, or the hand moves while the foot does not — not "one part moves, no part is still".

BOOK PAGE 82

V. Errors Easily Committed, Their Causes, and Their Correction

V. Errors Easily Committed, Their Causes, and Their Correction

1. **Error:** double weighting at the very start of the movement, as the left toes turn in and the body turns. The main cause is an unclear conception of the movement. **Correction:** when the left toes turn in, most of the centre of gravity must be on the left foot; the left toes turn in and press flat, and the right heel lifts off the ground at once. In this way it is both light and free of double weighting.

2. **Error:** the turning of the waist and the movement of the two hands fall out of step — a commonly committed — the error of moving the hands without turning the waist. The main cause is a shallow grasp of the principle "the lord is in the waist, expressed in the fingers ... it must always be one complete breath of energy". **Correction:** one must understand that the waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower body, and therefore moving the hands requires turning the waist — that is, the waist must lead the hands. So in Embrace the Tiger the body does not first turn to face north-west and only then move the hands; rather the hands move as the waist turns, and the hands must arrive where the waist arrives.

3. **Error:** the direction in which the right foot lands when stepping out to the right rear is wrong; usually the angle of travel is insufficient. Then the direction of the hands' press comes out too far west. The main causes are that the left toes do not turn in enough and the hips do not open enough. **Correction:** the left toes must turn in as fully as possible. But often, because the two feet are placed too close together in Cross Hands, the left foot cannot turn in fully. Therefore correct the two feet of Cross Hands: the lateral distance should be about shoulder-width.

4. **Error:** during the unfold, hand and foot are poorly coordinated. One way is that the foot does not move and only the hands move — the right hand forward, the left hand back, the two hands moving while the feet do not. The other is that the centre of gravity shifts back quickly and sits entirely on the left leg, so that in the unfold there is only hand movement and no foot movement. The main cause is a shallow understanding of the application of the unfold. **Correction:** as the right hand goes forward and the left hand withdraws, the two legs must move slightly together and the centre of gravity gradually shift back.

BOOK PAGE 83

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

1. Explain the course of the movement, its key points and its application.

2. Demonstrate: ① the movement as a whole. ② broken down, with emphasis on Embrace the Tiger and the preparation for the unfold.

3. Use contrast: compare the differing heights of the hands in Embrace the Tiger and in Brush the Knee and Twist the Step.

4. Study the passage from Embrace the Tiger into the unfold as a focus: first demonstrate and compare the movement of hands-without-feet and of feet-without-hands, let the students observe the results of the two errors, and then demonstrate and study the correct movement.

5. After the Embrace-the-Tiger posture the right hand extends forward, and this varies from person to person; the teacher should break it down for practice — in extending the right hand forward one must "hold the palm upright", that is, slightly — has a slanting palm spiralling forward.

Sixteenth Posture: Fist Beneath the Elbow (Zhou Di Kan Chui)

I. Application

I. Application

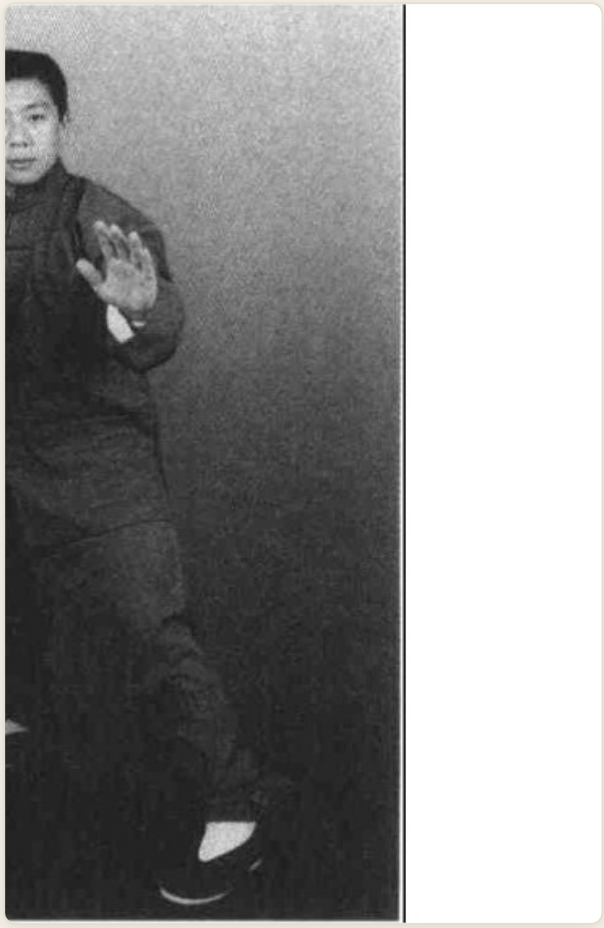
Continuing from the previous posture. On discovering the opponent striking from behind, the movement is like the Single Whip body-turn studied earlier and may be applied by reference. As the body is about to turn back to the front, the left foot plants flat straight to the front (east); the right foot then steps out half a step diagonally to the right front. When the right foot sits solid, the left foot lifts and lands on the heel with the toes raised. The two hands are level with the shoulders, and the body turns left along with them; at this moment I use my left wrist to meet the opponent's right wrist flat on the outside and push it aside to the left. When he loses his centred balance I drop the fingers of the left hand, approach his wrist and wind a small circle inward; the right hand at the same time goes left to meet his left hand and stick and join from above, so that both his hands are in an unfavourable position and he has lost the direction in which he wants to exert force. I then take my left wrist and press down his right wrist, and the right hand hastily forms a fist and turns to beneath the left elbow, tiger's mouth upward, storing strength in order to issue it wherever an opportunity offers.

A side variation: if, at my fist-beneath-the-elbow, the opponent uses his right hand to press slantingly on my left hand from my right, I take the opportunity to loose the right step and use the right hand to pluck the opponent's right wrist.

II. Course of the Movement

1. The waist turns left; at the same time the right toes turn in as far as possible and press flat, the left foot is empty, the two elbows sink slightly and bend a little, the two palms dip slightly, level with the shoulders, and with the turning of the waist wipe round half a flat ellipse to the left (the body turning from north toward south-west), the gaze following the turn of the body and looking level ahead, reaching the left slightly before the left palm arrives there, but the gaze must also attend to the right hand (see the first figure on this page).

图 78

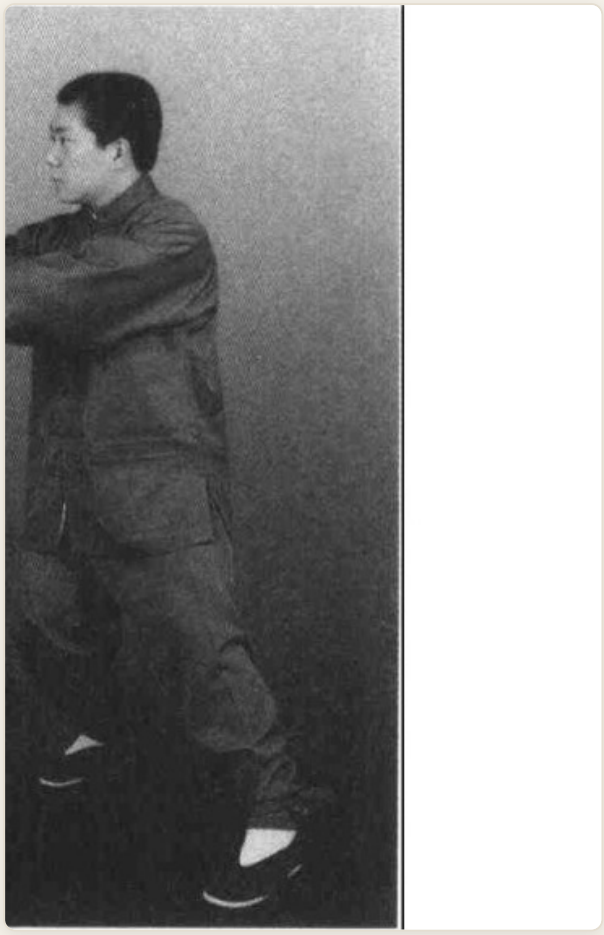


Fist Beneath the Elbow: the right toes turning in and pressing flat, the two palms wiping round half a flat ellipse to the left with the turning of the waist

2. The body slowly turns right and the two palms, slightly outward, wipe round with the turning of the body inward past the front of the chest, arcing right through another half flat ellipse (body

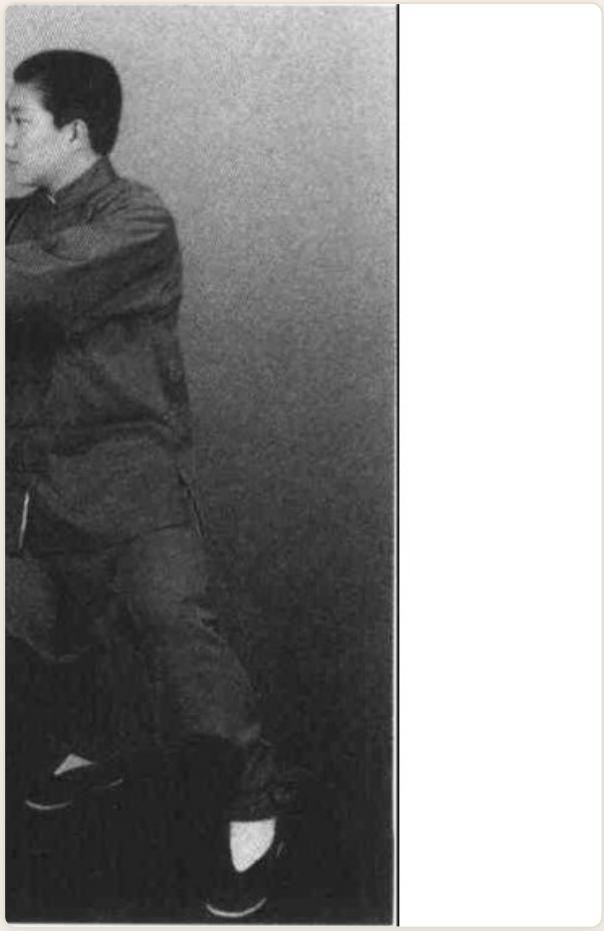
and arms turning from south-east toward south-west), the gaze shifting level with the turn of the body and also attending to the two palms (see the second figure on this page).

图 79



Fist Beneath the Elbow: the two palms wiping inward past the front of the chest, arcing right through another half flat ellipse

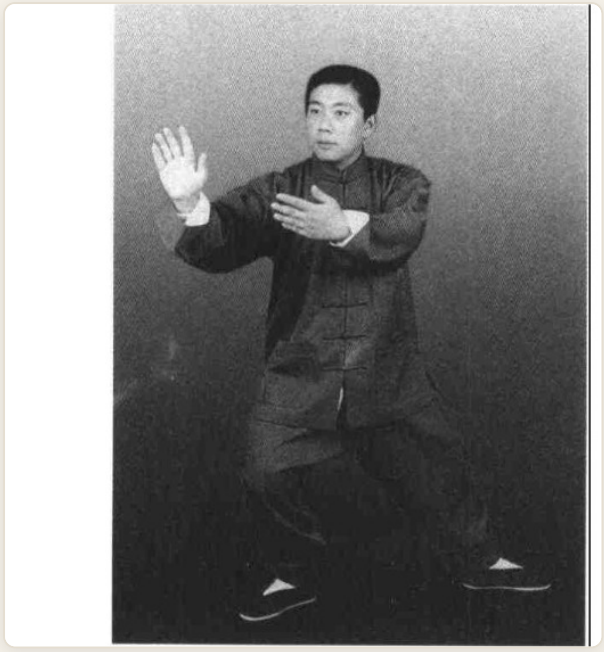
图 80



Elbow-Under-Fist: the left arm rotates outward and translates left along an arc, the right hand forms an upright palm with the palm turning to face left; both elbows sink slightly and bend a little, the two hands facing each other across a distance. (This figure is re-printed on the following page, before figure 81.)

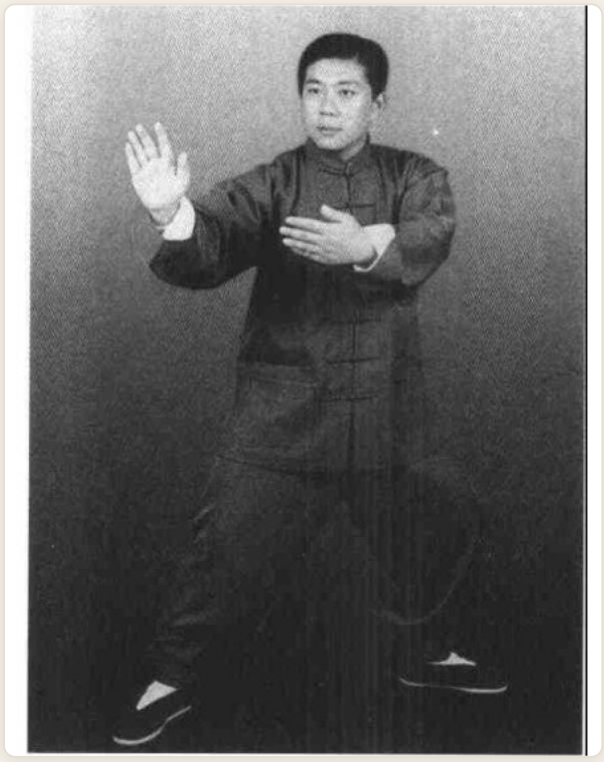
3. The centre of gravity is still entirely on the right leg; the body slowly turns left and the left leg lifts and steps out toward the left rear (due east). With the turning of the body the left arm rotating outward so that the palm turns to face inward, translates in an arc to the left, and the right palm follows closely, also translating in an arc to the left, so that the right hand holds its palm upright and the palm turns to face left. The two elbows sink slightly and bend a little so that the two hands face each other at a distance. The gaze attends to the left palm moving left (see the first two figures on this page).

图 81



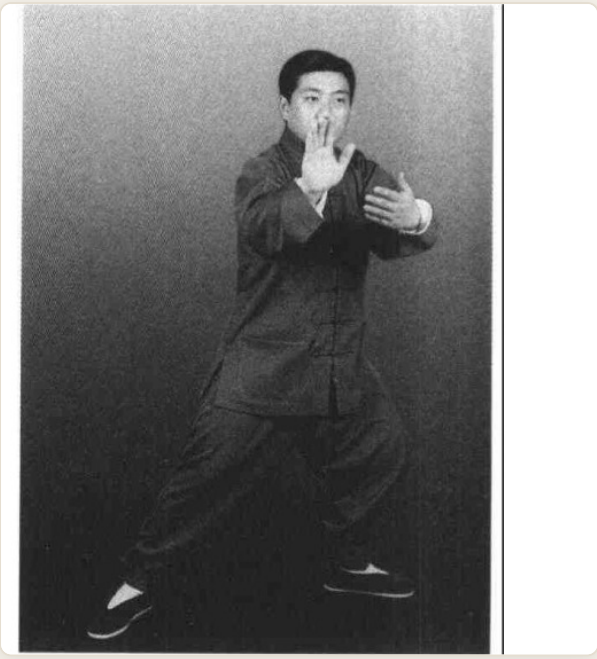
Fist Beneath the Elbow: the two hands facing each other at a distance, the gaze attending to the left palm moving left

图 82



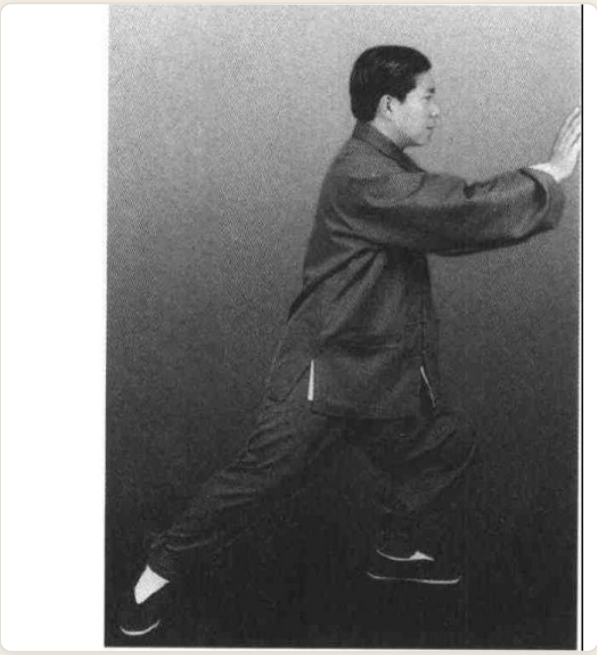
Fist Beneath the Elbow: the left foot coming down to the left (east), touching down heel first and pressing flat

图 83



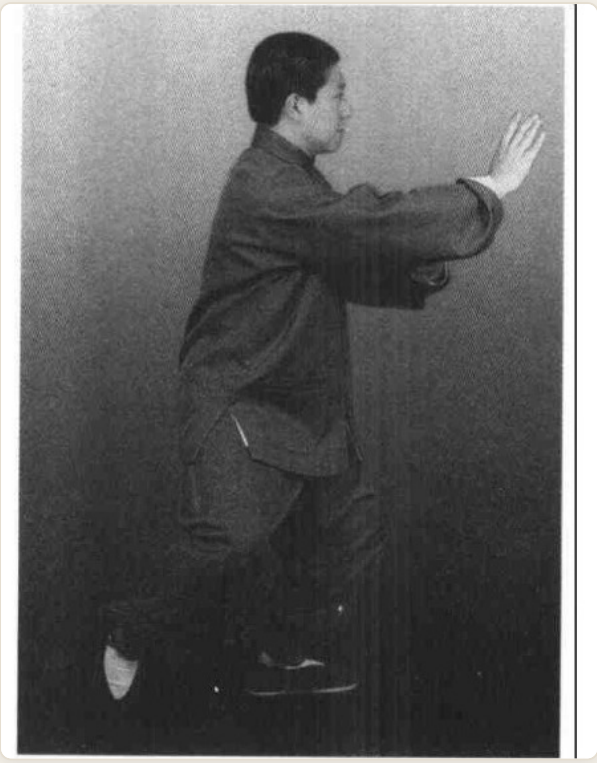
Fist Beneath the Elbow: the two palms translating in an arc to the left, the palms turning to face down

图 84



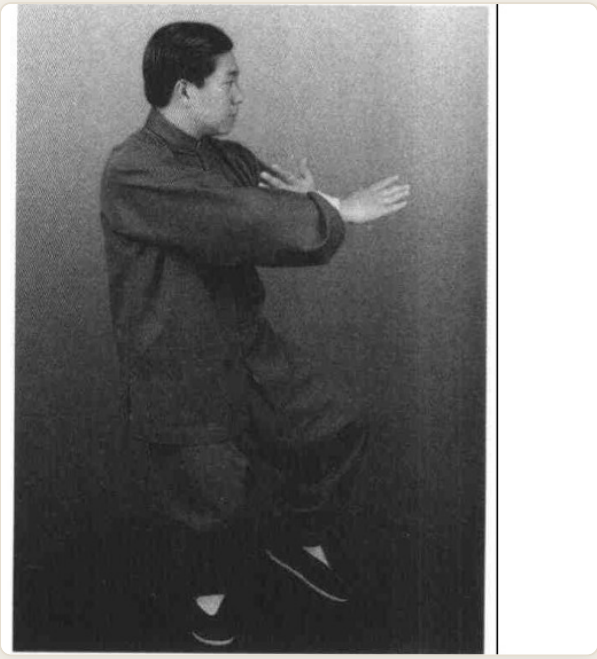
Fist Beneath the Elbow: the right leg lifting, shifting slightly forward and coming down, the centre of gravity moving onto the right leg

图 85



Fist Beneath the Elbow: with the turning of the body the left palm moves to slightly left of the front of the body and arcs down to the left

图 86



Fist Beneath the Elbow: the settled posture with the left palm moved by the turning of the body to slightly left of the front of the body

4. The left foot comes down to the left (east), touching down heel first, and the centre of gravity gradually shifts entirely onto the left leg. With the turning of the body the two palms translate in an arc to the left, and the left arm rotates inward as it moves so that the two palms turn to face down. The right leg lifts, shifts slightly forward and comes down, and the centre of gravity at once moves onto the right leg. When, with the turning of the body, the left palm has moved to slightly left of the front of the body it arcs down to the left. The gaze first attends to the left palm moving left, and when the right palm is about to arrive in front of the chest, to the right palm (see the third, fourth, fifth, sixth and seventh figures on this page).

图 87

Fist Beneath the Elbow: the left palm going from the left downward and inward, passing inside the right forearm and piercing forward and up, the right palm covering and grasping outside the left palm to form a fist placed beneath the left elbow

5. The centre of gravity shifts entirely to the right leg; the left foot lifts a little, moves slightly forward and comes down, touching down on the heel with the toes slightly raised; the body continues to turn slightly left. The left palm goes from the left downward and inward, passes inside the right forearm, and turns and pierces forward and up, palm facing right, the index finger level with the eyebrows and aligned with the tip of the nose; the right palm passes to the left outside the left palm, covering and grasping to form a fist, which is placed beneath the left elbow, the eye of the fist upward, and the upper body turns slightly right. The eyes attend a little to the left palm circling down to the left; when the left palm is about to pierce out past the inside of the right arm they look level ahead, but the gaze must still attend to the piercing out of the left palm (see the eighth figure on this page).

III. Key Points

III. Key Points

1. Solid and empty must be clear. The right toes turn in fully and the right leg bears the whole body's weight; only then can the left leg lift light and nimble.

2. The arms turn with the waist. It is through rotating the waist and turning the spine that movement is transmitted from the turning of the wrist and the turning of the upper arm to the tips of the hands. Therefore the movement of the arms must be as the boxing theory says, "the lord is in the waist" — one must not move only the arms without moving the waist.

3. It must proceed according to "when one part moves, no part is still; when one part is still, no part moves" and to the requirement of unbroken continuity — without corners, without pauses, rounded and coordinated. In the two movements of lifting the right foot and slightly lifting and setting down the left foot, the hands move as the feet move. Just as the settled posture of the hidden fist beneath the elbow is completed, the opportunity for the left-right opposing brace arises at this moment of seeming to stop and not stopping, and not as something joined and again broken; for the old force is spent and the new force not yet born, and this is the moment when one is most easily taken by an opponent seizing the opening.

4. The two feet must not double-weight; they must rise and fall in turn like a see-saw. When lifting the right foot or lifting the left foot, one leg must bear the body's weight.

5. When the two palms translate to the left, the right palm must not lie flat or swing down but must sit the wrist and stand upright; and the left hand must go forward while the right hand follows, at an equal distance.

6. In the settled posture the left knee must naturally bend slightly and the two shoulders must not shrug. The two arms form an arc and must not be held straight. The waist and hips must be relaxed, and the chest must not face the front squarely but turn slightly toward the right-front diagonal, while the two arms still face straight to the front (east), and the left palm must sit the wrist.

7. When the two hands translate eastward, the back of the left hand faces outward and the right palm faces left and outward; when the body turns to face the front (east) the left hand goes down first and the right hand goes forward afterwards — not both downward at the same time, because at this moment I use my left wrist to meet the opponent's right wrist flat on the outside and push it aside to the left, while the right hand goes to the left hand to meet his left hand; each has its own purpose.

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. Particular attention must be paid to the stepping: advance and retreat, and the transitions of solid and empty must be distinct. When the two arms begin to translate to the left, the right leg is solid and the left leg must be empty. When the body turns to the front, the left leg is solid and the right leg lifts easily; when the centre of gravity moves onto the right leg the left leg is empty and the landing step must be steady — the change of solid and empty is gradual, not sudden.

2. One must "let the hands follow the movement of the feet, and the feet follow the movement of the hands", with "upper and lower accompanying each other".

3. One must take the waist as the axis; the strength of the waist must be used appropriately, and only then does it aid the body's balance. The waist must not sway away from centre; therefore the body must not lean forward or backward.

4. When the right toes turn in, the right is solid and the left is empty; the centre of gravity should not shift left.

5. The movements of the hands must be clear. When the two hands swing level the distance between them is about 20 centimetres; too large or too small is incorrect.

6. The fingers should be slightly curved but must not be stiff. If the fingers are too curved, it is hard to carry the intent through to the fingertips; if they are too straight, that is stiffness. The intent must reach the fingertips, with the pads of the fingers exerting a very slight force; with long practice this makes the qi and blood flourish in the fingers.

V. Common Errors, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Common Errors, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. **Error:** the right foot is not turned in sufficiently, so the waist and hip cannot turn to the left fully. **Main cause:** the hip-root is not adducted enough and the knee is twisted too much, with too little foot-turning. **Correction:** lift the ball of the right foot slightly; the foot follows the knee and the knee follows the waist, so that the right sole turns in no less than 90°.

2. **Error:** when turning the foot in and turning the waist, the centre of gravity shifts left, producing double-weighting. **Main cause:** there is no right-fullness, and so no left-emptiness. The movement then cannot rotate freely, cannot gain power, and cannot keep a stable centre. **Correction:** the body's weight must settle fully on the right leg; during the turn the centre of gravity does not move — turn on the full right leg. The waist must be straight and the central axis

must not sway, so that the upper body does not lean to one side. The waist-gap governs the two legs: on the solid side of the waist-gap, the leg below is also solid. Hence the left waist-gap must be empty.

3. **Error:** as the waist turns left and the left foot lifts and steps back to the left, the centre of gravity shifts left too quickly, destroying the principle of "uniform tempo in every movement." **Main cause:** the right foot is not fully turned in and the hip-root is not opened; added to that, at the moment the right foot turns in the centre of gravity is wrongly shifted left, so the right leg cannot exert its normal supporting power. The left leg is therefore forced to land quickly to gain support. **Correction:** turn the right foot in fully; the right knee stays under the centre of gravity without shifting; open the hip-root, and let the left leg step slowly.

4. **Error:** the two hands move left too high or too low. **Main cause:** insufficient attention to the application. The left hand meets the opponent's left hand flat, and the right hand connects with his left hand; if my hand is too high or too low it does not meet the requirement of "connecting." **Correction:** the proper height is with both hands level with the shoulders.

5. **Error:** after the body turns square (to the east), both hands press down at the same time. **Main cause:** insufficient attention to the application. The left hand should first push out to the left and then circle down in a small arc; the right hand then goes left-and-back, forming a fist that is carried lightly beneath the left elbow. **Correction:** the left hand goes down first while the right hand is still moving forward; the two hands must not press down simultaneously.

6. **Error:** moving the hands without moving the waist, so that upper and lower are disconnected. **Main cause:** there is no whole-body consideration governed by the waist — it is a tree without roots. **Correction:** when the hands go forward they must have a sinking, root-driven quality; the soles of the feet take the force, and as the waist and legs move forward the two hands move in the same direction.

7. **Error:** at the set position the upper body faces squarely to the front. **Main cause:** a shallow understanding of storing power. **Correction:** the body should be turned to the side. If the body faces squarely forward, the right fist that has turned in beneath the left elbow loses the stored impulse to strike at the ready, and the chest is also compressed, which obstructs the free flow of qi and blood.

BOOK PAGE 89

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explanation (with emphasis on turning the foot in and on the movement of the two hands).

2. Demonstration of the whole movement.

3. Progressive-addition method:

- ① Begin from the set position of Grasp the Sparrow's Tail / Embrace the Tiger and Return to Mountain, making a good link; immediately turn in the right foot while the two arms shift level to the left and to the right, arriving at the forward-right diagonal.
- ② As above, then continue: the back of the left hand turns outward, the right hand forms a vertical palm; the left leg lifts, the upper body turns left, and the left leg steps forward with the heel landing first; the two arms follow the waist and transfer to the front of the body. Once ② is grasped at a basic level, join it to ①.
- ③ Shift the centre of gravity forward; the two hands move forward with the waist; the centre of gravity gradually moves onto the left foot; the right leg lifts slightly; the left hand turns to a downward palm. Once grasped at a basic level, join ①②.
- ④ Shift the centre of gravity back; the right foot shifts slightly to the right and comes down, seating the right leg; the left hand circles in a small arc inside the right arm and threads out; the right hand forms a fist and is placed beneath the left elbow; the left foot lifts and comes down slightly forward-left, heel landing first. Once grasped at a basic level, join ①②③.
- ⑤ The complete movement. Note: in the progressive-addition practice, take particular care that the movement is unbroken and continuous, with no place where it halts.

4. Paired practice combining the application:

- ① A — takes the set position of Embrace the Tiger and Return to Mountain (facing northwest); B — comes out from behind A (the east); A — turns the body left, seats the right leg, and shifts the two hands level to the left and right; turning the body left, A steps the left foot out to the front (east), meets B's right wrist level with his own left wrist, pushes out toward B's right, then drops and, clinging to B's wrist, circles inward in a small arc; the right hand meets B's left hand and adheres to it from above. ② A's left wrist rolls B's right wrist, while A's right hand turns

...the fist turns to beneath the left elbow, waiting there at the ready, or immediately strikes forward.

5. Mnemonic: turning left, turn in the right foot; both hands shift level as the body turns; left hand horizontal, right hand vertical palm; turning left, step out the left foot; the rear foot is reset; the front foot lifts and comes down again; the left arm circles in a small arc; the right fist hides beneath the elbow.

6. The student should first concentrate on training emptiness and fullness: the right foot turned in fully, the right leg seated solidly, the centre of gravity not shifting left. Lift the left foot toward the rear-left (east); the right leg must be steady, the hip must be open; as the body turns square, the right knee must follow the direction of the toes and must not twist inward. The body turns about 45° + 180°; so if the right foot is not turned in fully and the lower body is not stable, turning the body square is difficult. Hence emptiness and fullness must be practised repeatedly.

7. Turning the waist, shifting the centre of gravity, and the movement of the hands — these three are "upper and lower following one another," and may be practised separately (practising only the waist turn, only the weight shift, only the hand movement). This lets the beginner learn the movement rather quickly; but take care: separating is for the sake of joining, and in the end the upper and lower must follow one another. Fortunately, in the later stage of this movement the body turns slightly right, the left foot lifts slightly and comes down again, and at the same time the left palm threads out and the right palm becomes a fist — so that upper and lower do follow one another, rather than each going its own way.

BOOK PAGE 90

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. In this movement one must first be clear about the change of direction. From the set position of Embrace the Tiger and Return to Mountain, where the body faces northwest, the two arms shift level first toward the southeast and then toward the southwest, and finally move to the east — and to this are added the changes of step of the two feet and the differing actions of the two hands... The movement is thus fairly complex. One must therefore concentrate on the progressive-addition method of learning: be clear about the direction, be clear about the movement, and climb as if going up stairs, one step at a time — firmly fix each part as you learn it, and only then add the next.

2. In this movement the body's weight is alternately supported on one leg. It looks like an alternation; but because the movement is slow, with one leg supporting and the other lifted clear for a long time, the actual time under static load is considerable. The demands this makes on the strength of the muscles of the waist, hips and legs are high. And precisely because of this, the muscles concerned are very well trained.

3. After the right foot is turned in and the right leg seated solidly, the left leg is empty and the left hip is relaxed. The leftward turn of the waist carries the two arms in a level shift to the left; at this moment the two shoulder-joints are required to line up level with the two shoulders, striving to achieve "shoulder and hip joined together." Therefore ...the demands on the opening and relaxing of the hip-joint are very high; otherwise, with so large an angle of rotation, how could the movement be completed smoothly?

4. The burden carried by the full right leg is very great. It is like the movement of the trunk and branches of a great tree: because the root and limbs are as firm as a great root and a deep root, it stands steady and unmoving — and so this is a very demanding form of training.

Seventeenth Posture: Step Back and Repulse the Monkey, Left and Right (Zuo You Dao Nian Hou)

BOOK PAGE 91

I. Application

I. Application

Continuing from the preceding posture: if the opponent uses his right hand to grip my left wrist or forearm tightly, and with his left hand supports the fist beneath my elbow, then I am first constrained by him and cannot execute my movement. At this moment I turn my left fist over upward, and with a sinking energy relax the waist and hip, withdrawing it back-left, while the left foot also steps back one pace, bending the knee and seating it solidly, and the right foot becomes empty. The opponent's grip is then lost at once. At the same time, the right hand separates to the rear, and at the instant he loses his grip I press forward swiftly. Although this posture takes one step backward, it can still repulse the opponent's energy — hence it is called "Repulse the Monkey." In this movement, take care to relax the shoulders and sink the elbows.

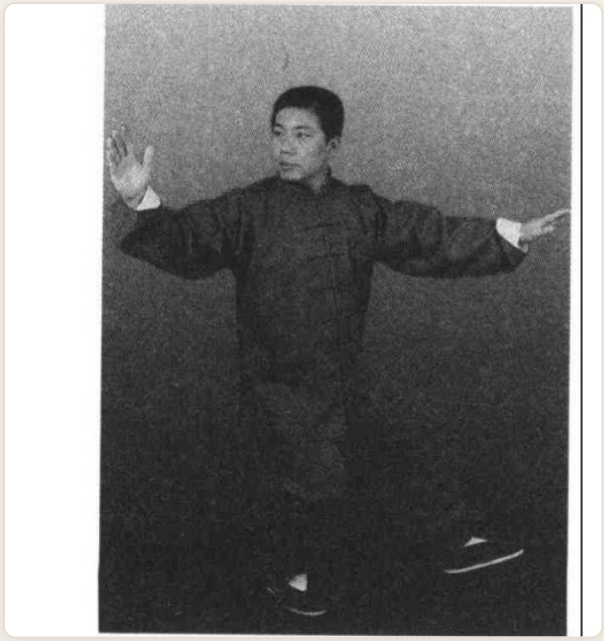
II. Movement Sequence

(A) Left Repulse the Monkey

1. The right hip-root draws in slightly; sit firmly on the right leg; the left leg lifts slightly with the toes hanging naturally; the body turns slightly right. At the same time the left palm drops slightly and extends slightly forward; the right fist becomes a palm, drawing from beneath the left elbow past the front of the abdomen, curving down-and-across to the side of the right hip; as it draws, the right arm rotates outward so that the palm gradually turns upward. The gaze follows the forward extension of the left palm (see the figures on this page).

2. The centre of gravity gradually shifts entirely onto the right leg, and the body continues to turn slightly right; the left foot slowly lifts and draws in past the inside of the right ankle. At the same time the right palm continues to arc up to the rear and slightly right until it is level with the shoulder, the palm facing slanting upward. The left arm gradually rotates outward so that its palm faces slanting downward. The gaze follows the rearward lift of the right palm (see the figure on this page).

图 86



Right Repulse the Monkey set position: left palm extending forward, right palm lifted to the rear, the two arms drawing against each other front and back

3. The body gradually turns left; the left foot steps back one pace, touching down first with the toes; as the centre of gravity gradually shifts onto the left leg the foot comes down flat (the foot set at a slant, toes pointing northeast). The right toes then turn to the front (east). At the same time, as the body turns, the right palm arcs slightly upward, drawing in past the side of the right ear and pushing out forward; the left palm turns palm-up and arcs back to draw in beside the left hip. The upper body turns about 90°, to the northeast, while the face still looks forward (east). The gaze follows the turn and looks level before it; the gaze must also take in the forward push of the right palm (see the figures on this page).

(B) Right Repulse the Monkey

The movement is the same, with the directions reversed (see the figures on this page).

(C) Left Repulse the Monkey

The movement is the same: the corresponding figures are as for the left-hand instance already described above.

III. Key Points

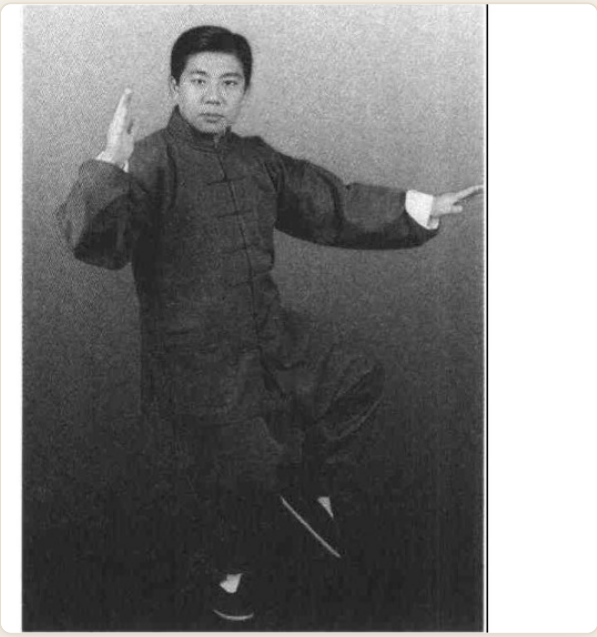
III. Key Points

1. A characteristic of this movement is the step backward. To keep the body balanced the lower body must be stable, and so when stepping back there must be a certain lateral distance; the two feet must therefore not be placed on a single line.

2. When one leg lifts and prepares to step back, the other leg must support; it must not rise or straighten up, and must still preserve the same height of the body's centre of gravity as in the original empty stance — that is to say, in the course of practising the form the centre of gravity must not rise and fall too much.

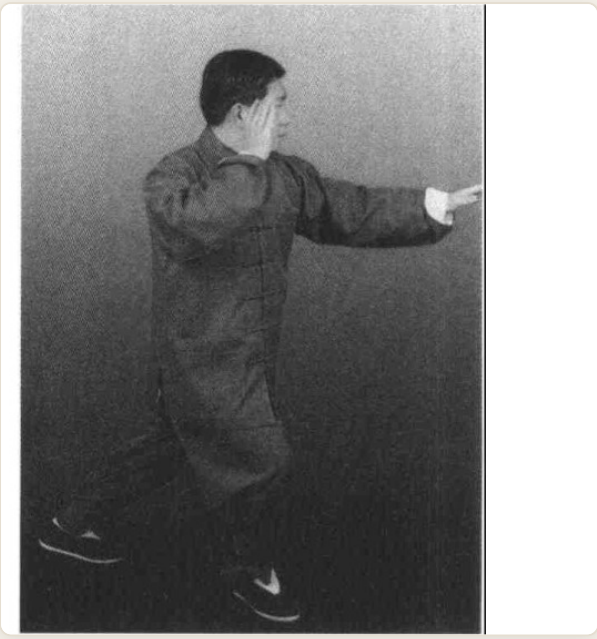
3. The chest must be contained and the back raised, the sacrum centred and upright; there must be no leaning forward or backward. When stepping back, in order to land slowly one easily tends to lift the upper...

图 89



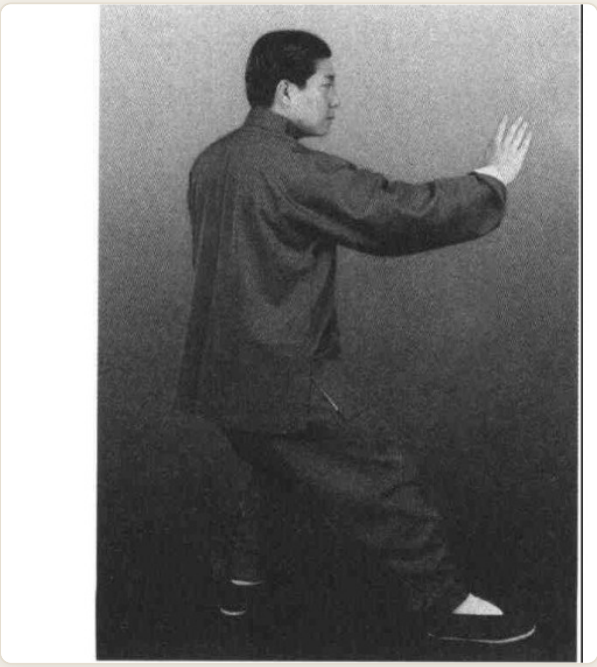
Left Repulse the Monkey: the left foot steps back, the right palm arcs up to the rear-right until level with the shoulder

图 90



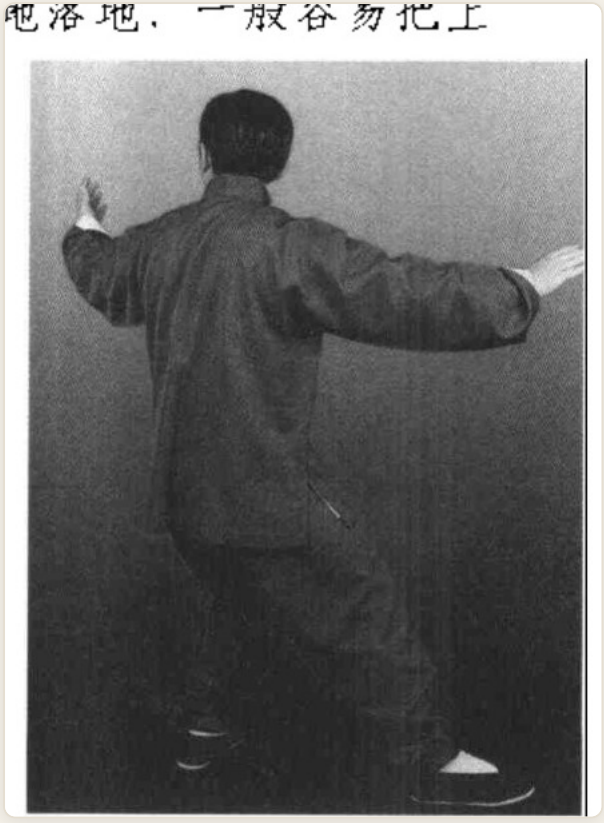
Repulse the Monkey: the right palm draws in past the side of the right ear and pushes forward, the left palm draws back beside the left hip

图 91



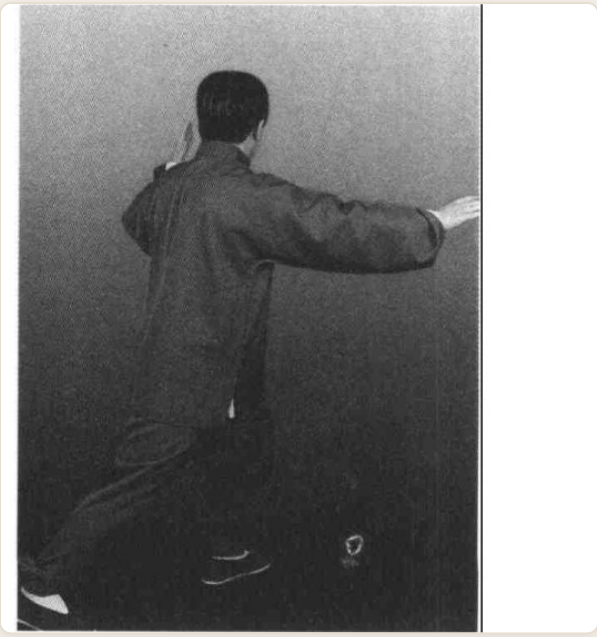
Repulse the Monkey: the two arms draw against each other front and back, the left foot planted firmly to the rear, the right toes turning square

图 92



Right Repulse the Monkey: left hand extending forward, right hand lifted to the rear, stepping back the right foot

图 93



Right Repulse the Monkey: right hand pushing forward, left hand drawing back, the gaze taking in the forward palm

...leaning the body forward to obtain balance. After the centre of gravity has settled back, when the two hands exchange front-and-rear before the body, it is easy to let the body pitch forward. One must therefore attend to the body method: the two shoulders and the two hips must advance and retreat together, neither leading nor lagging, so that from the crown of the head through the trunk down to the perineum point there is always a straight line. The *Boxing Treatise* says: "Baihui and Zhongji are threaded through by a single qi."

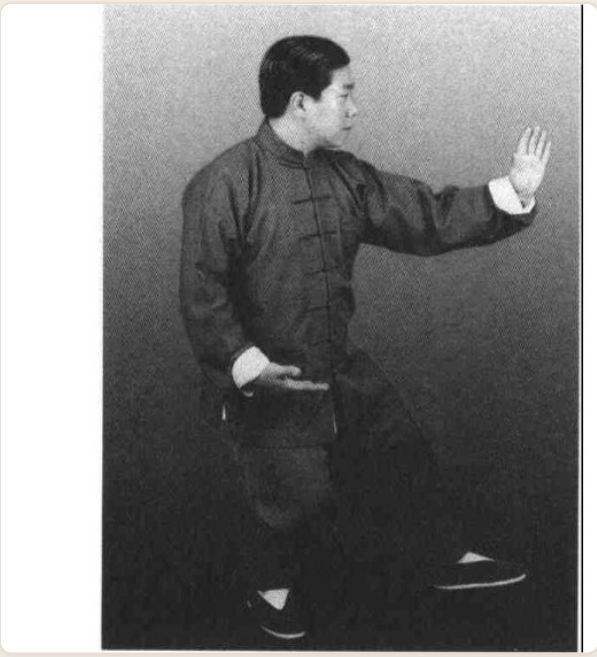
4. The two hands must exchange before the body, one going back and the other forward, moving without pause; neither hand may halt at the side of the body. Beginners, attending too much to the hand that extends rearward and to other actions, let the hand at the front very easily halt motionless. Both hands must therefore move evenly and unbrokenly; when one thing moves, nothing is unmoving.

5. When a palm draws back it must pass by the side of the hip; beginners often carry the hand too high and should alter this so that it passes by the side of the ribs. Otherwise the arm and elbow become an angle smaller than a right angle and no longer form an arc — it looks awkward rather than broad and comfortable, and the shoulder is also lifted.

6. For the front foot to step back, one must first lift the thigh, storing power in the knee, raising the heel with the toes hanging naturally; then slowly extend back, touching down lightly with the toes and the ball of the foot first, and then letting the heel come down firmly. Only thus is the requirement "stepping as a cat walks" embodied. Moreover, because the time supported on one

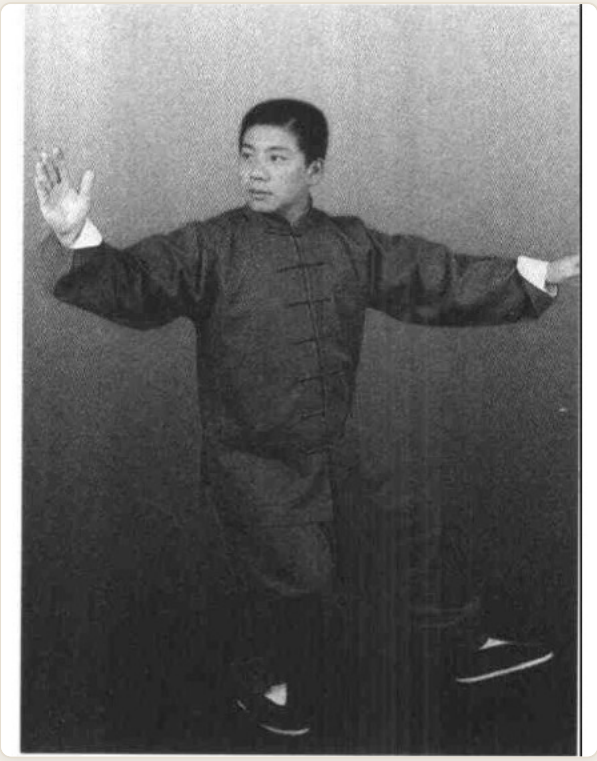
leg is lengthened, the burden on the supporting leg is increased, which better trains the strength of the legs.

图 94



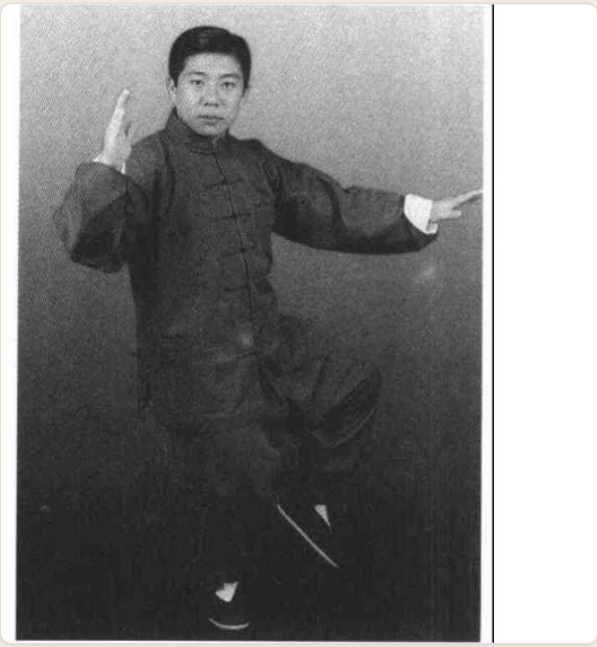
Right Repulse the Monkey: right palm pushing forward, left palm drawing back, the two arms drawing against each other front and back

图 95



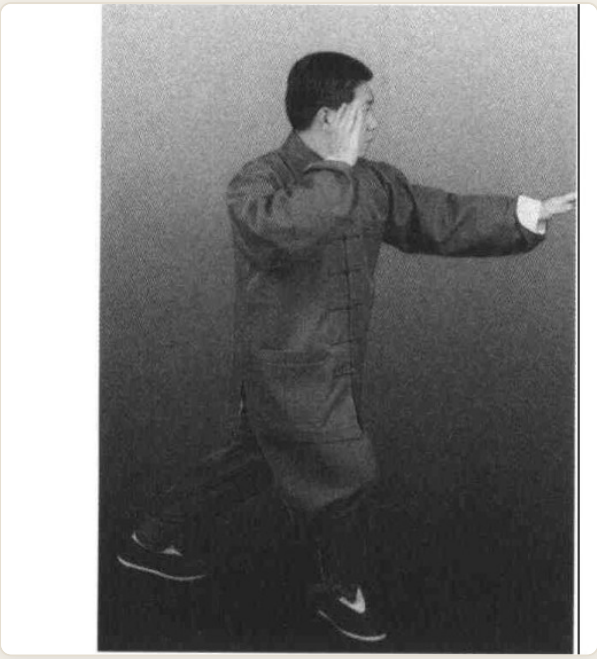
Left Repulse the Monkey: the left foot planted firmly to the rear, the right arm lifted to the rear level with the shoulder

图 96



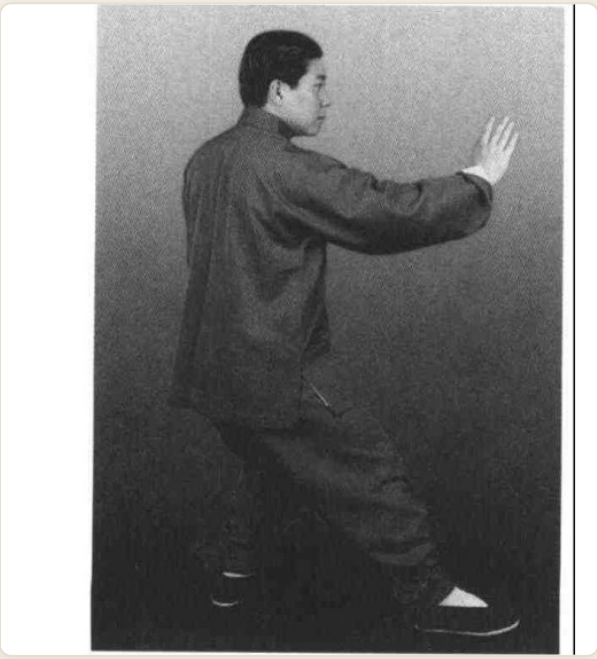
Repulse the Monkey: the step back is light and nimble, the body centred and upright without swaying

图 97



Right Repulse the Monkey: on the backward step the heel lands first, the sole then settling firmly

图 98



Left Repulse the Monkey set position: chest contained and back raised, shoulders relaxed and elbows sunk

7. Step Back and Repulse the Monkey, left and right, may be done three times each (in a single set of the form ...the Repulse the Monkey occurs twice), or it may be done five or seven times each, but the number must be odd (five is generally appropriate). In addition, Cloud Hands should correspondingly be done three, five or seven times; otherwise, at the closing posture one cannot return to the starting place.

8. The gaze alternates its attention to the movement of the hands.

BOOK PAGE 94

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. The shoulders must sink and the elbows hang. In Taijiquan, on the premise of relaxing the shoulders, "sinking the shoulders" is required; only with sunk shoulders can there be lightness and nimbleness. If the shoulders can relax, the whole arm's extending, contracting and coiling can be natural, lively and utterly un-sluggish, and after long practice one reaches the mutual tempering of firmness and suppleness.

2. The two shoulders must be level; the shoulder of a gathered arm must not be low while the shoulder of a forward-pressing arm is high, nor the reverse, for this destroys the uprightness of the body method.

3. When stepping back, with one leg supporting, the body must be stable and must not sway; it must be as firm as a great tree that cannot be shaken.

4. The waist rotation must be neither too large nor too small; turning to the two diagonals is the proper measure. For the body to face squarely forward and move only the arms without turning the waist is certainly wrong; but when the arms extend to the rear diagonal and the body has turned through some 90°, with the two arms almost straight front and back at some 180°, that is too much and does not meet the requirement of the application.

5. There must be "uniform tempo in every posture" and "unbroken continuity." The rearward-travelling foot must not land too fast, nor may the front leg lift too fast; it must be even, rising and falling slowly, using intent and not force, unbroken from beginning to end, returning again to the start, cycling without end.

6. Beginners at the front hand often turn it over too fast, producing the phenomenon of one hand halting while the other is still moving. Since the requirement is that when one thing moves nothing is unmoving, both hands should be in motion.

V. Common Errors, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. **Error:** the body sways when stepping back. **Main cause:** the knee of the full foot is not stable, and the movement of the rearward-extending leg drags at the full leg, causing sway. **Correction:** the waist and hip must relax and sink, the buttocks drawn in slightly, the leg muscles steadying by force so that the knee-joint is stronger and the sole presses the ground more evenly and firmly; the lower body is then stable. Alternatively, if the shoulders are not relaxed, the movement of the arms drags at the upper body and disturbs its central uprightness, which also causes sway. 2. **Error:** when stepping back the two feet land on a single line. **Main cause:** a failure to understand the application. With the two feet on one line the base of support is small, and the slightest movement makes the already awkwardly placed legs unable to steady the centre of gravity — how then could one possibly neutralize and attack well? **Correction:** when stepping back the lateral distance between the two feet should be about the width of the shoulders.

3. **Error:** the two arms open out too widely, forming one arm forward (east) and one arm back (west), with the angle between the arms reaching 180°, which looks scattered. **Main cause:** an insufficient understanding of the circular movement of Taijiquan. If the arms open out too widely the movement becomes straight back-and-forth, and there is no longer "a marvellous hand whose every move is a taiji." Opening the arms too widely also drives the waist-axis to rotate too far; in combat this gives the opponent a gap — that is, it offers him an opening to attack.

4. **Error:** the front hand halts while the rear hand moves. **Main cause:** insufficient attention to "when one thing moves, nothing is unmoving." **Correction:** (taking Right Repulse the Monkey as the example) the left palm extends slightly forward and slowly rotates the arm outward so that the palm faces slanting down; then it slowly draws back... Meanwhile the right palm arcs up to the rear-right diagonal beside the right ear, and the left arm rotates almost "in place," with little visible change of shape. In fact, at this moment the shoulder, elbow and wrist joints and other parts of the body are all in motion; and as the right arm moves from below up and back, the two hands have precisely completed the preparatory action of the left hand drawing back and the right hand pressing forward — so that it is not one arm moving and one arm halting.

(The photograph at the foot of this page shows Fu Zhongwen demonstrating push-hands; it carries no figure number.)

...It is the same with the action of the foot: here too, when one thing moves nothing is unmoving. As the waist moves and the hands move, the foot below should at the same time slowly lift; as the right hand presses and the left hand draws in, at the same moment the left leg settles solidly and the right foot turns in exactly into place (facing squarely forward).

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explanation and demonstration (with emphasis on emptiness and fullness).

2. Breakdown method (taking Right Repulse the Monkey as the example):

- ① First do the backward step. The right leg supports steadily and the left leg slowly lifts; the waist and hip must relax and sink, so that as the left leg travels from front to back the movement is even and does not drag the body into swaying. The teacher should lead the student to keep the waist "straight" and lifted. The teacher checks, and students check one another, on the lightness of the left leg's lift and backward step and on the lateral distance.
- ② On the exchange position of the two hands front and rear — left hand forward, right hand beside the ear — as the body settles back the left hand draws in and the right hand presses forward; and while the hands move, the right toes slowly turn in to square. The teacher checks, and students check one another, on the coordination of hand and foot.
- ③ The set position. The left leg is full (the knee not past the toes), the right leg is empty (the right knee slightly bent), the body turns slightly left, the left hand palm-up beside the hip, the right hand pressing forward in an arc (vertical palm), shoulders relaxed and elbows sunk, chest contained and back raised, sacrum centred and upright. Although the set position is a brief moment, that moment must certainly be present and must not be slurred over; one may pause in it for inspection.

3. Auxiliary practice: the right leg is full; slowly lift the left leg — extend it back; the ball of the front foot lands lightly — the heel comes down lightly until the whole foot is firmly planted. This may be repeated, and the legs may be alternated. The number of repetitions and the speed may be set according to each person's strength; after finishing, do relaxing exercises.

4. Movement mnemonic: turning left and raising right, lift the left foot; the body turns, the hands move, the leg moves slightly; the left leg must land to the rear light and nimble; left draws in, right presses, then settle back steady; hand and foot must be full and round and easy; the centre of gravity must not rise and fall;

5. Students should value the training of the legs and equally value the training of the hands, observing in one another the sinking of the shoulders and the hanging of the elbows during the movement of the hands.

VII. Technical Analysis

1. This movement is a backward step, so it trains muscles different from those used in stepping forward, and is all the more effective for training the body.

2. In stepping back it is comparatively difficult to "step as a cat walks." With one leg extending rearward, before the foot lands one must keep the other, supporting leg steady and the body unswaying, and land lightly and slowly — the demands this makes on every part of the body are very high. And the more one requires the rearward-extending leg to be slow and nimble, the higher the demand; the lower the stance and the longer the step, the harder it is to lift the front leg; and the farther the rearward leg extends, the longer the movement takes, so that the muscular burden on both the supporting leg and the extending leg is greater. Hence long practice in a fairly low stance is very effective for increasing the strength of the waist and legs and for health.

Eighteenth Posture: Diagonal Flying (Xie Fei Shi)

BOOK PAGE 97

I. Application

I. Application

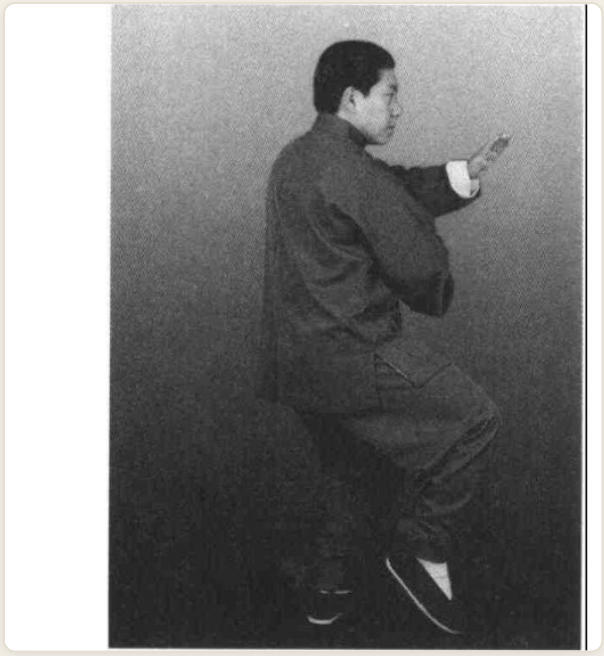
Continuing from the preceding posture: if the opponent strikes at my upper body from my right side, or presses with force between my right arm and wrist, I take the opportunity to sink and close downward, storing energy; at the same time I step out with the right foot, bend the knee and seat it solidly, and split the right hand out toward the upper-right corner, striking diagonally with an opening energy, as if flying out diagonally. The intent of the palm's delivery should also accord with the requirement of this movement.

Slanting variation: if the opponent presses my right upper arm, I contain the chest and relax the hip, first neutralizing his pressing energy; the left foot lifts and steps quickly down, the right foot lifts and is then put down, and the two hands first ward off and then press.

II. Movement Sequence

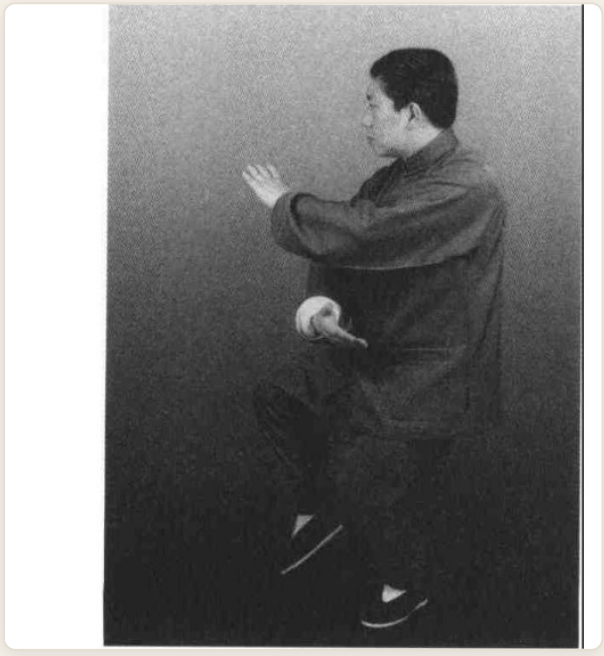
1. The centre of gravity gradually shifts entirely onto the left leg; the right leg lifts, and at the same time the waist turns slightly right. The left arm slowly rotates inward; the left palm-up hand, as it arcs up and to the right, turns over into a downward palm, the arm bent and placed before the left chest, the hand about level with the shoulder, the arm forming an arc, the elbow slightly sunk. The right palm, from the front, goes down and across the front of the abdomen, arcing down-left; as the right arm shifts, it rotates outward so that the palm faces upward, joining with the left palm above and below. The gaze takes in the left palm's arc (see the figures on this page).

图 99A



Diagonal Flying: the right palm splits out toward the upper-right corner, striking diagonally with an opening energy, the left palm at the left chest

图 99B



Diagonal Flying: bow the right leg and push back with the left, the right palm warding out toward the upper rear-right, the palm facing slanting upward

2. The body continues to turn right; the left leg seats solidly and the hip opens; at the same time the right foot steps out toward the rear-right (south). The heel lands first; as the centre of gravity gradually shifts onto the right leg the whole foot settles firmly. Bow the right leg and push back with the left, forming a right bow stance. As the body turns, the right palm, using the ward-off side, wards out toward the upper rear-right, the palm facing slanting upward, at about the height of the forehead; the left palm arcs down-left ...plucks down, at about the height of the hip, the palm facing down. The left foot pivots on the heel as the body turns, the sole turning inward. The gaze follows the turn of the body, looking level as it turns; the gaze must also take in the right palm's outward plucking (see the figures on this page).

BOOK PAGE 98

III. Key Points

III. Key Points

1. The right leg slowly lifts and turns right with the waist, the body centred and upright, laying the foundation for the step to the rear-right.

2. In stepping the right foot to the rear-right, the body's balance is comparatively hard to control. Beginners tend to pitch the body forward, to lean crookedly, and to land heavily (the boxing proverb says: head bowed and back hunched — the boxing art is not high). The waist must both turn nimbly and stay "straight"; only with the central axis unbent can one support all eight directions. Hence one must sit solidly on the left leg, relax the waist and hip, and let the right leg, as the waist turns, gradually step out to the rear-right — only then will it look light and nimble.

3. When the right palm plucks out to the upper rear-right, the energy must arise in the foot, issue from the leg, be governed by the waist, and pass through the spine and back, from shoulder to elbow and elbow to hand, taking form in the fingers. Struck out with every joint threaded through, body, hand and step coordinated, arriving all as one — neither first nor last; the hand and the rest of the body must not be disconnected. One must attain "upper and lower following one another" and the requirement of the energy path; at the same time the right arm must not be fully straightened.

4. Because for beginners the supporting leg is not easily made stable, the body is not easily kept "straight," and the waist and hip are not easily relaxed, the movement is not easily controlled and the waist and leg actions tend to halt or go too fast. Hence the movement must change gradually and not abruptly, and the knee-joint of the supporting leg must be kept steady.

5. Because the stepping method is always best when advance and retreat are convenient, the stance is steady, and the hip-root is opened, when the waist turns and the right hand strikes out to the upper right, the left foot must plant and its front sole turn inward.

IV. Requirements

1. The movement must be done in one continuous breath, not broken up.

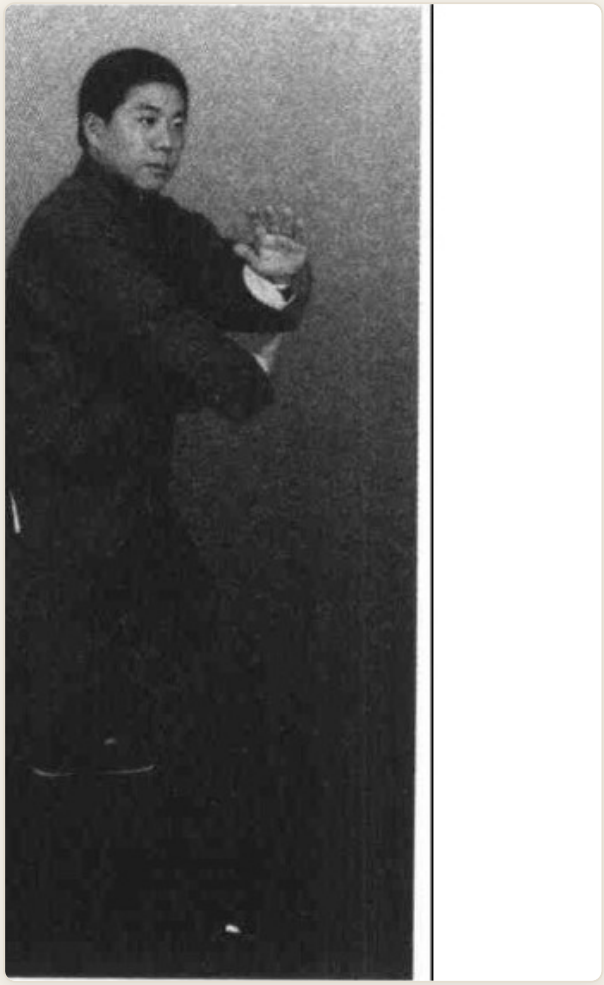
2. The waist must relax, sink and stand upright; no pitching forward, no tilting, no swaying.

3. The landing position of the right foot must be correct; it must not be too small, for if too small the waist becomes awkward.

4. The right leg must land lightly and nimbly.

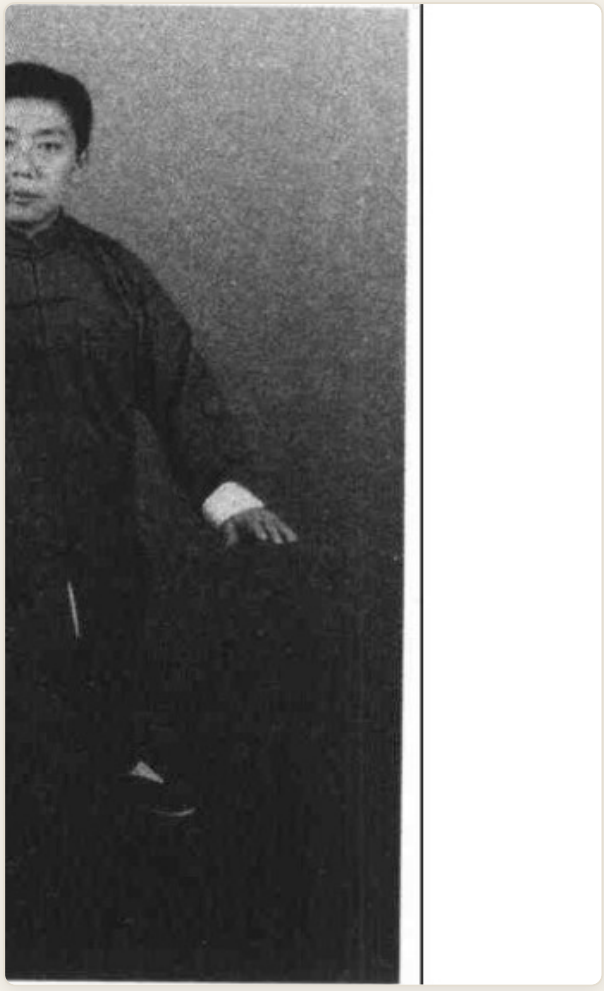
5. The hand that plucks out to the upper right must turn with the waist.

图 100



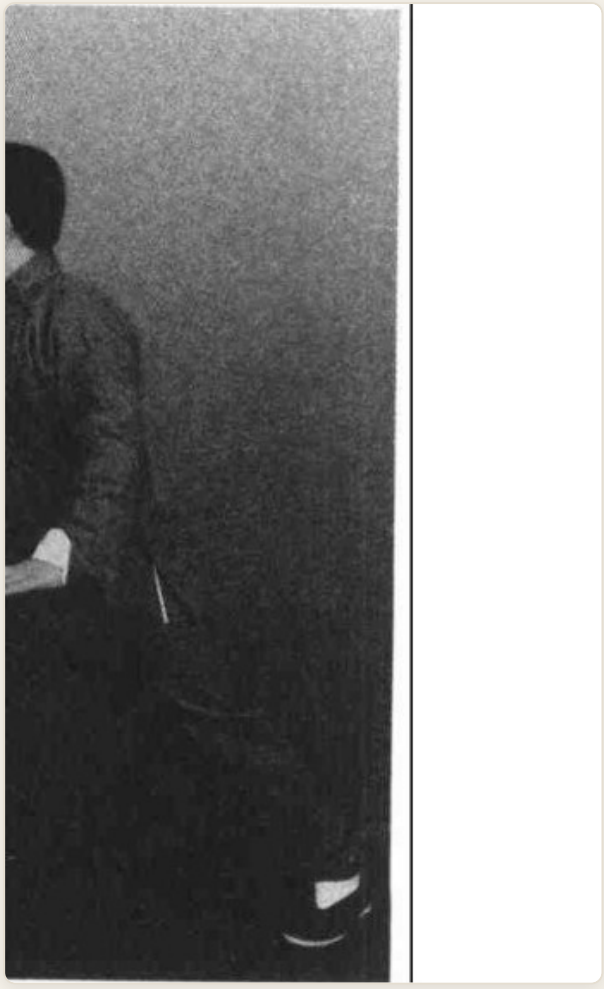
Diagonal Flying: the right palm plucks out to the upper rear-right, the palm facing slanting upward, at about the height of the forehead

图 101A



Diagonal Flying: the right leg lifts and, as the waist turns, steps out to the rear-right, the body centred and upright

图 101B



Diagonal Flying: right bow-stance set position, the right hand plucking out, the left palm beside the left hip

BOOK PAGE 99

V. Common Errors, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Common Errors, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. **Error:** after the right leg lifts, in the course of stepping out to the rear-right the leg does not travel by way of an arc. **Main cause:** an insufficient understanding of the requirement of spiral, arcing movement. **Correction:** in Taijiquan every movement's rise and fall, rotation, opening and closing, emptiness and fullness is constituted by arcs. Above, it is the turning of the wrists and the turning of the upper arms, taking form in the fingers; below, it is the turning of the ankles and the turning of the legs, reaching to the tips of the toes. The hip must urge the knee and the knee urge the foot. The right leg lifts and steps forward as the body turns — it must not first be

brought stiffly in beside the inside of the left ankle and only then stepped out; rather it must arc out to the front-right as the body turns. Of course, withdrawing the leg straight sideways is also not good.

2. **Error:** after the right leg lifts it simply stops moving, and only after the body has turned does it step out to the rear-right. **Main cause:** an insufficient understanding of the requirement "when one thing moves, nothing is unmoving." **Correction:** at the same moment the right leg lifts, the waist and hip should gradually turn right; as they turn, the right leg, lifting, arcs out to the rear-right. The waist is turning, the hands are moving, and the right leg too is ceaselessly changing — attaining the gradual transition from opening to closing and closing to opening, from full to empty and empty to full.

(The photograph at the foot of this page shows Fu Zhongwen demonstrating push-hands; it carries no figure number.)

3. **Error:** when stepping out the right leg the upper body pitches forward and topples sideways. **Main cause:** in order to lighten the load when stepping out the right leg, because the left leg's support is weak, one borrows a forward pitch and sideways topple to keep balance. **Correction:** first of all the waist must be kept straight — that is, the central axis must not bend — so that all the weight above the waist is borne by the waist and legs. In addition, the leg strength must be increased so that the supporting leg is steady.

4. **Error:** the right hand plucks out to the upper right by moving the hand alone, without coordinating with the turning of the waist and hip and the extending and pressing of the left leg, so that upper and lower are disconnected. **Main cause:** a shallow understanding of "upper and lower following one another." **Correction:** as body, hands and legs go forward, the crotch energy must sink, the soles of the feet take the force, and the inner energy turns up from within the crotch, penetrating the spine and back and shooting straight out to the palm and fingers. Within going forward there must be a bracing behind; only thus will the right hand not be grasping at empty air.

5. **Error:** the left leg sits dead and unmoving. **Main cause:** the movement is not full and rounded, but wooden. **Correction:** when the waist turns, the left leg should carry a sinking intent and the waist and hip must be relaxed.

BOOK PAGE 100

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explanation, demonstration, building the concept.

2. Teach by highlighting the difficult point. The difficulty of Diagonal Flying is the action when the right leg lifts and, as the body turns, steps out to the rear-right: either the body is not upright, or the landing is very heavy. This should therefore be taken as the key point and this barrier broken through:

- ① Explain clearly the requirements of the correct movement and demonstrate it repeatedly.
- ② Break through by stages.

A — The right leg lifts and draws back slightly; as the body turns, the left hand moves to the upper right and the right hand to the lower left; while the two hands join above and below, the right leg extends slightly to the rear-right. At this moment hold the correct requirements — the upper body upright, and so on — laying the foundation for the movement to follow; this part can generally still be managed. B — The body continues to turn right and the right leg continues to extend to the rear-right. As the suspended right leg goes on extending, the weight thus carried away from the support point continually increases, and so too do the demands on the muscles of the waist, back, hip and knee. Hence the beginner, wishing to keep the movement slow and nimble but lacking the strength, is forced to bring the right heel down quickly and heavily. Thus the requirement "stepping as a cat walks" is not attained. To overcome this difficulty the only way is ...to strengthen the training of the muscles of the waist and legs; in time, as the muscles grow strong, the step becomes nimble. Hence, in practising the form one should repeatedly perform the lifting and stepping of the leg as the body turns.

3. The teacher inspects, and learners, in groups of two or three, inspect one another on: ① whether the body pitches forward, leans back or topples sideways; ② whether the turning of the waist and hip is full; ③ whether the right leg, when stepping out to the rear-right and landing, is heavy or light.

4. On the basis of having practised the earlier requirements well, then progressively resolve the details.

5. Paired practice combining the application: A — takes the set position of Repulse the Monkey. B — stands at A's right side and strikes down from above with the right hand, or presses between A's right arm and wrist. A — takes the opportunity to sink; the two hands join above and below; sit solidly on the left leg and step the right leg out to the rear-right; at the same time the right hand splits out and plucks toward the upper-right corner. The two then exchange roles.

6. Attention must be paid to stability of the lower body: one must practise the left leg's solid seating well, and repeatedly practise the left leg's steadiness during the waist-and-hip turn, the leg lift, and the step.

7. When the right foot lands, begin the two-way even division. One must practise well the energy arising from the foot and reaching the elbows and hands through the waist and back. Repeatedly experience this, so as to attain "upper and lower following one another."

8. The teacher should observe the changes in each part of the learner's body at every stage.

BOOK PAGE 101

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. The body moves from a northeast-facing position to the south, a shift of about 135°. Since the left foot is fixed, the left knee tends somewhat to the northeast, while the right leg steps toward the west-southwest; hence as the two legs open out, the actual angle approaches 180°. Thus not only are the demands on the left leg's support extremely high, but the lifting and moving of the right leg also makes it extremely hard to train the upright centring of the upper body's sacrum. It requires that the left hip be adducted and seated solidly, the lower body steady, the waist relaxed and sunk; the central axis must on no account bend — only then can the inner energy support all eight directions, and only then will there be no left-right crookedness nor forward-and-backward pitching.

2. In outward form Diagonal Flying is the right palm plucking out to the upper rear-right; at a glance it seems to be only the action of a hand. But unless the energy arises in the foot, issues from the leg, is governed by the waist, passes through the spine and back, and goes from shoulder to elbow and elbow to hand, threaded through joint by joint, one cannot attain the requirement of the application nor the better ...requirement of training the body. Therefore, after the right foot lands, one must begin the release of energy from the foot, reaching gradually upward to the wrist and fingers.

Nineteenth Posture: Raise Hands and Step Up (Ti Shou Shang Shi)

BOOK PAGE 102

I. Application

I. Application

The same as the Fifth Posture, Raise Hands and Step Up, above.

II. Movement Sequence

The waist and hip sink slightly; the centre of gravity shifts forward and is placed entirely on the right leg; the left foot lifts slightly and comes down a little forward (essentially in place); the centre of gravity then gradually shifts back until it rests entirely on the left leg. The body turns slightly left; the right foot lifts slightly and comes down essentially in place, landing on the heel,

the toes slightly raised and pointing forward, the knee slightly bowed, forming a right empty stance. At the same time the right arm rotates inward; as the elbow sinks and draws inward, the right palm gradually turns downward and slants down; the left palm arcs forward and upward; the two palms close toward the chest. The right palm is in front, the fingers at about the height of the midpoint between the eyebrows, palm facing left, a vertical palm; the left palm's fingers are at about the height of the chest, palm facing right (slightly downward), squarely facing the right elbow-joint. The waist turns slightly left. The gaze passes over the right palm and looks level forward. See the figures on this page (the last of which is the same posture as shown in the earlier Fifth Posture).

III. Key Points

1. The centre of gravity moves forward and back, but the body must not rise and fall greatly; it must be steady.

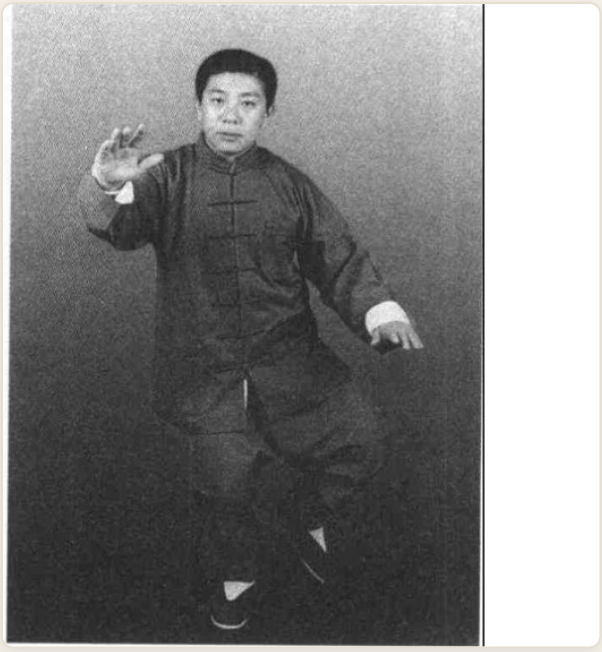
2. From the beginning to the end of the whole movement, the waist and hip and the upper and lower limbs must all begin at the same moment and finish at the same moment.

IV. Teaching Method and Practice Method

The learner must understand that although the Nineteenth Posture and the Fifth Posture are both Raise Hands and Step Up, the linkage is different. In teaching and learning, the linking process must be made clear.

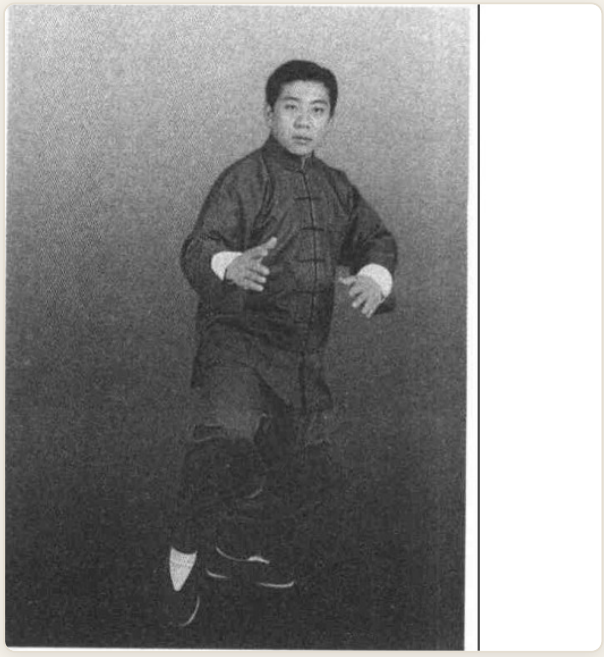
All other points are the same as for the Fifth Posture.

图 102



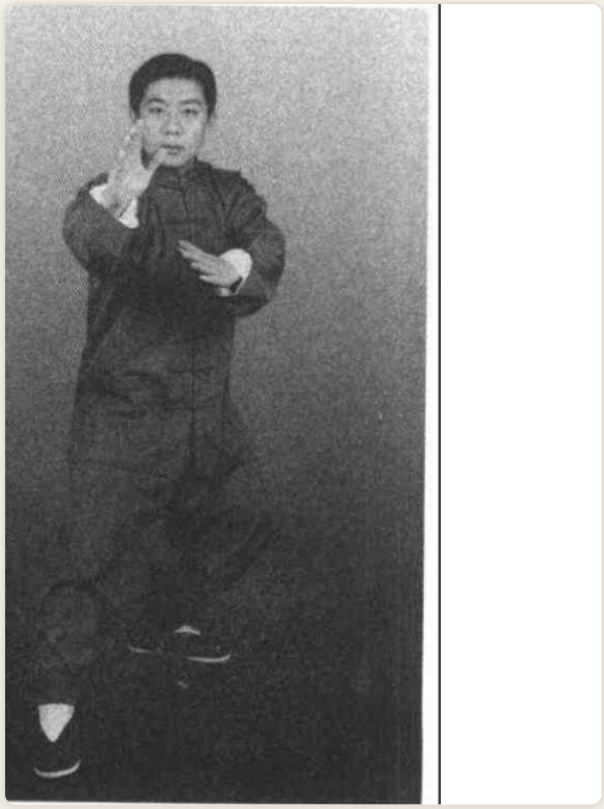
Raise Hands and Step Up: the right palm stands vertical in front, the fingers at the height of the midpoint between the eyebrows; the left palm, slightly downward, squarely faces the right elbow-joint

图 103



Raise Hands and Step Up: right empty stance, landing on the heel, the toes slightly raised and forward, the knee slightly bowed

图 104

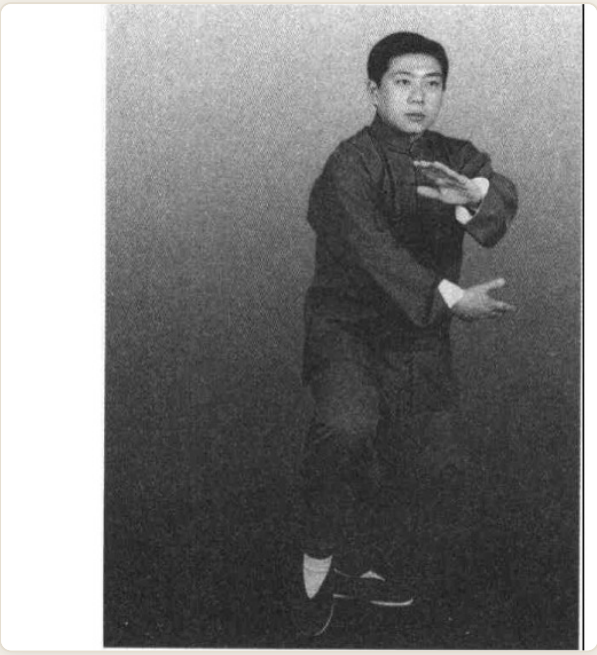


Raise Hands and Step Up: the gaze passes over the right palm and looks level forward, the two palms closing toward the chest

Twentieth Posture: White Crane Spreads Its Wings (Bai He Liang Chi)

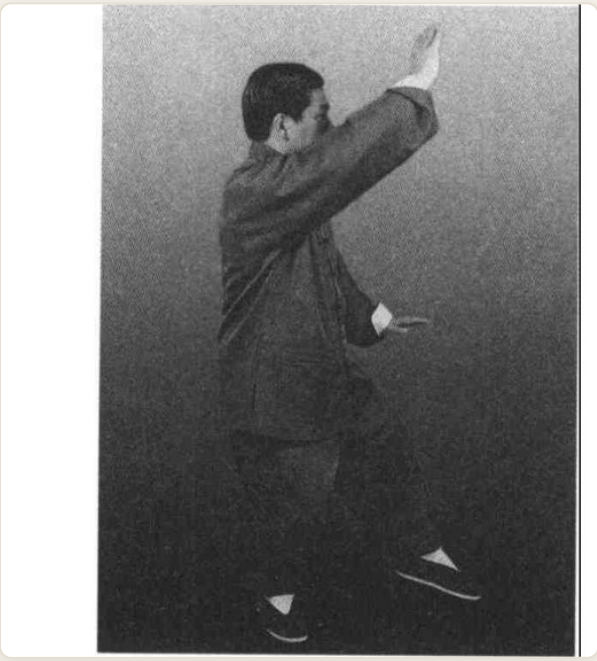
The application, the movement sequence, the key points and all other aspects are the same as for the Sixth Posture, White Crane Spreads Its Wings. See the figures on this page (which correspond to those of the Sixth Posture).

图 105



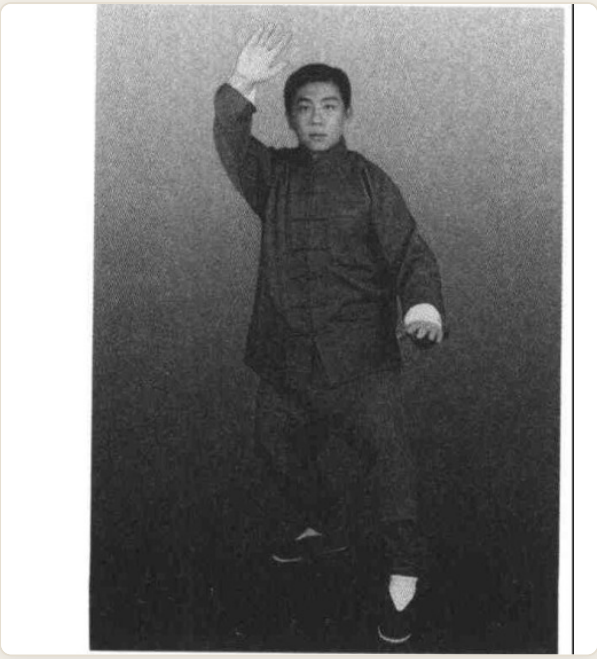
White Crane Spreads Its Wings: the right arm lifts, the left hand plucks down, forming a right empty stance

图 106



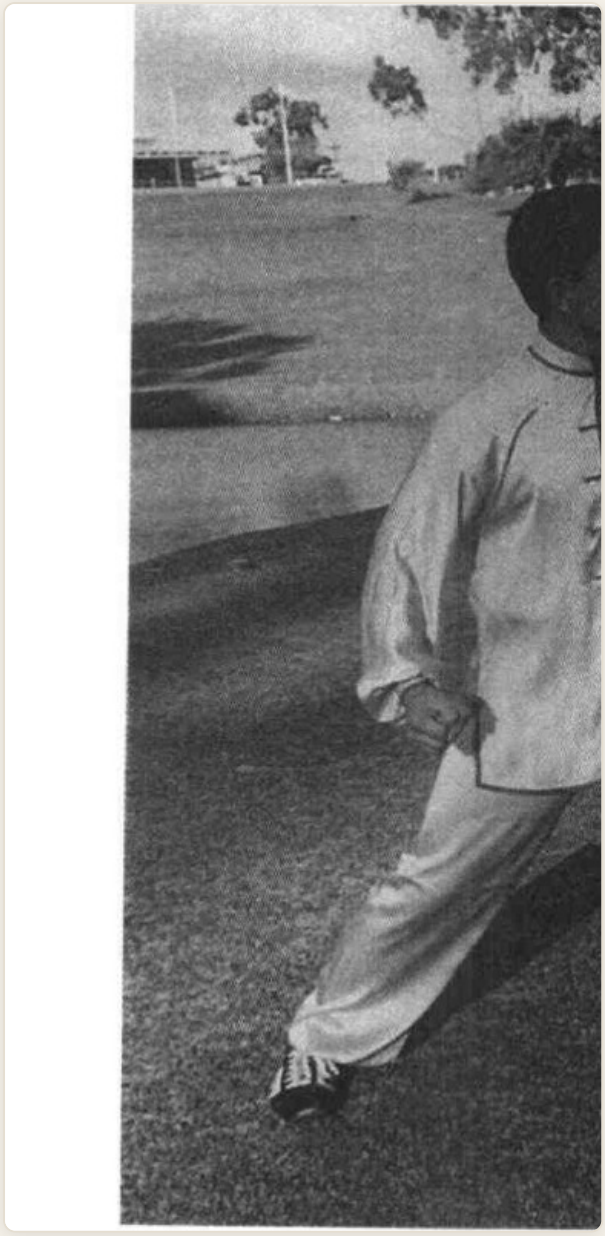
White Crane Spreads Its Wings: the right hand raises above and in front of the forehead, palm facing left

图 107



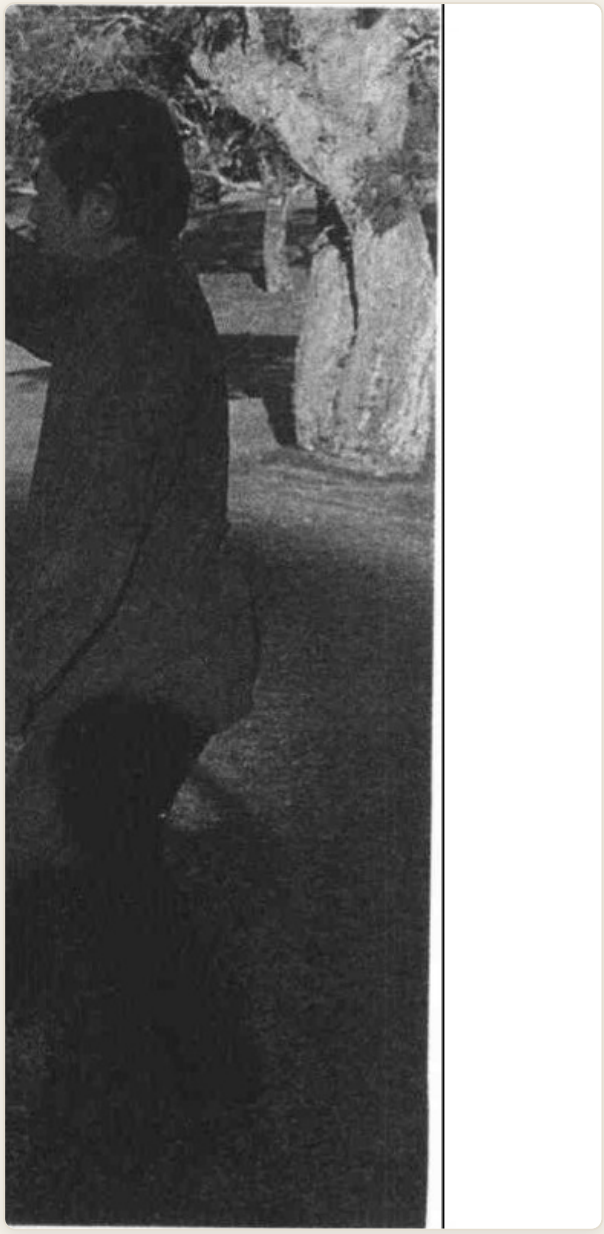
White Crane Spreads Its Wings: the left hand presses down beside the left hip, the right hand lifts to before the forehead

图 108A



White Crane Spreads Its Wings: frontal view, the two arms opening up and down, the gaze level before it

图 108B

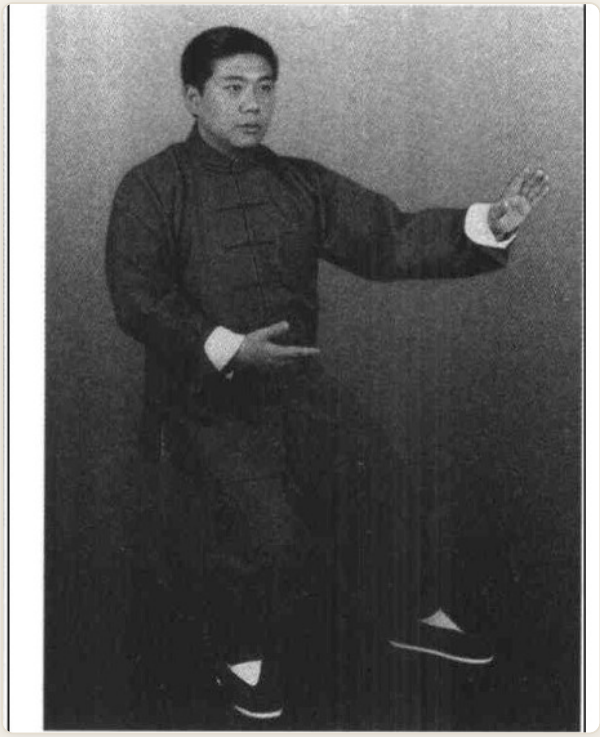


White Crane Spreads Its Wings: side view, chest contained and back raised, standing steady on the right empty stance

Twenty-First Posture: Brush the Knee and Twist Step, Left (Zuo Lou Xi Ao Bu)

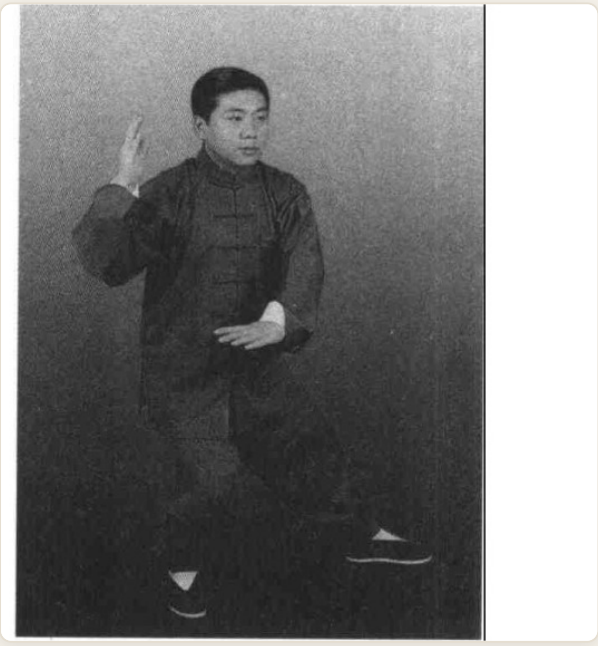
The application, the movement sequence, the key points and all other aspects are the same as for the Seventh Posture, Brush the Knee and Twist Step, Left. See the figures on this page (which correspond to those of the Seventh Posture).

图 109



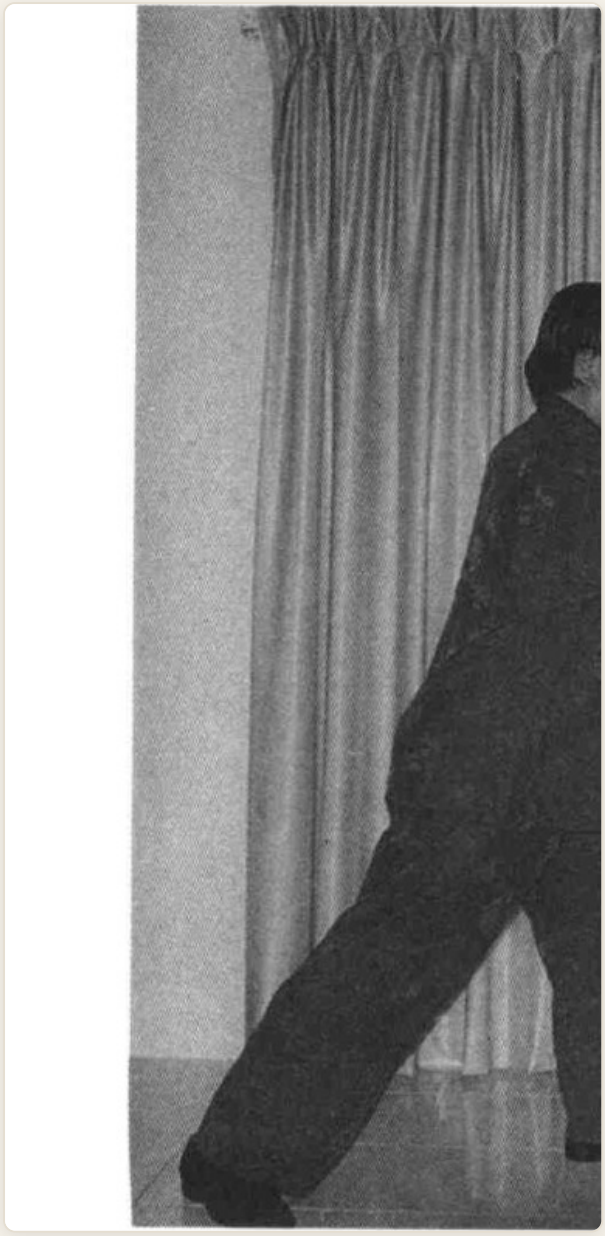
Brush the Knee and Twist Step, Left: the left hand brushes past the left knee, the right hand pushes forward

图 110



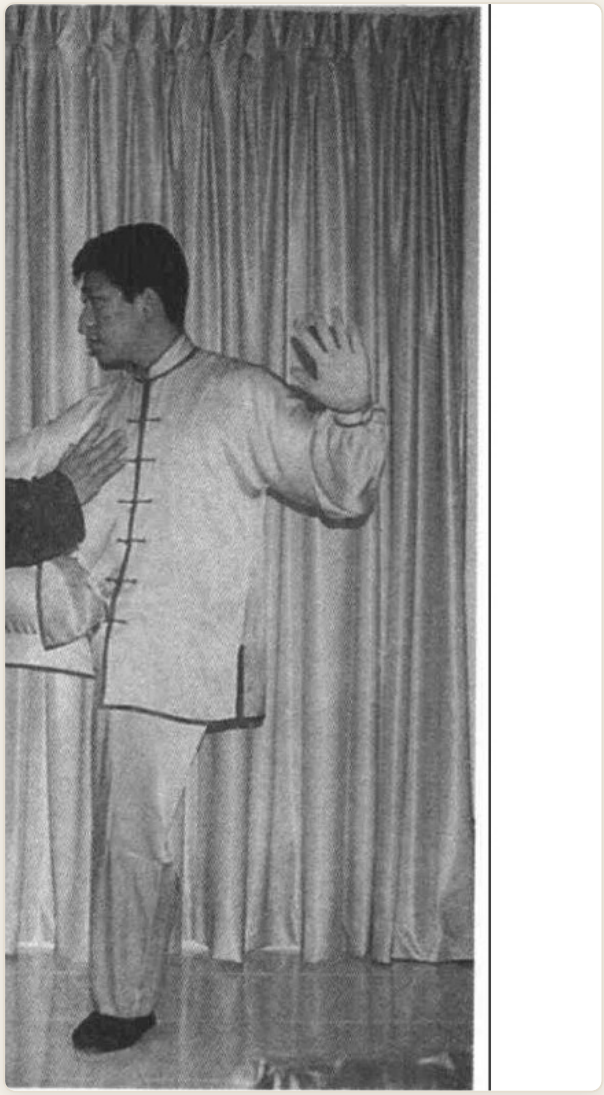
Brush the Knee and Twist Step, Left: the right hand pushes forward as a vertical palm, the left hand pressing beside the left hip

图 111



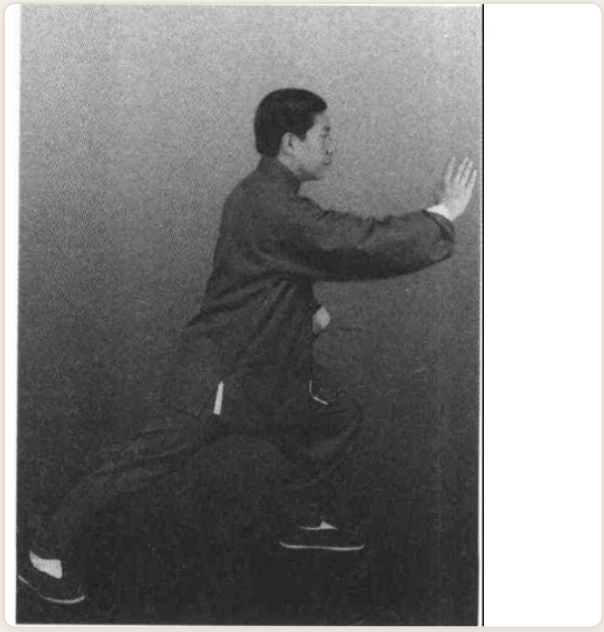
Brush the Knee and Twist Step, Left: bow the left leg and push back with the right, forming a left bow stance

图 112



Brush the Knee and Twist Step, Left: the knee-brushing hand method, the left hand brushing open from before the knee

图 113A



Brush the Knee and Twist Step, Left: the set position, the left hand pressing after brushing the knee, the right hand pushing out forward

Twenty-Second Posture: Needle at the Bottom of the Sea (Hai Di Zhen)

BOOK PAGE 105

I. Application

I. Application

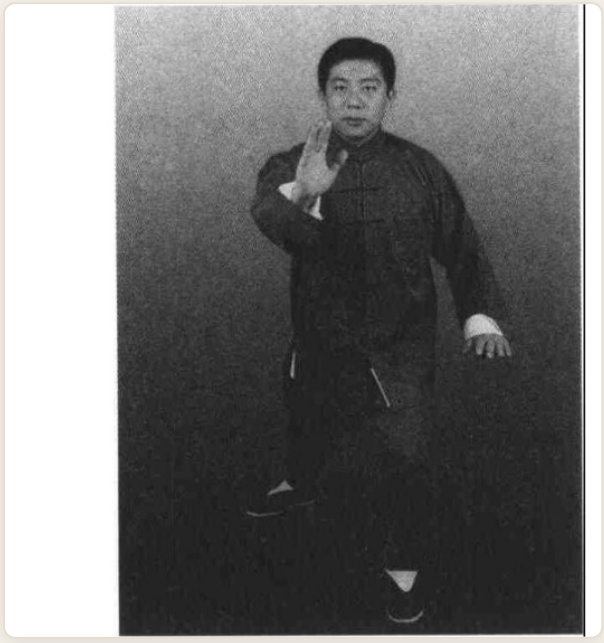
Continuing from the preceding posture: if the opponent uses his right hand to pull my right wrist, I bend my right elbow, sit on my right leg and turn my waist, drawing my right hand back. At the same time the left hand goes left and the left foot is drawn back with it, touching the ground with the toes. If the opponent still has not let go, and instead wishes to press his advantage further and attack me, I let my right wrist go slack in the direction of the movement, fold at the waist and sink down, the gaze looking forward, the fingertips hanging down, as if searching for a needle at the bottom of the sea. At this moment, though the opponent means to pluck or to attack me, his incoming force is a single straight force; he does not expect that, checked by my one fold, his root-force snaps by itself — and I take the opening to strike him.

II. Movement Sequence

If the opponent uses his right hand to pull my right wrist, I immediately sit on the right leg, bend the right elbow and turn the waist to the right, drawing the right hand back; the left foot is at once drawn back, touching the ground with the toes. The purpose is to break free of the gripped right hand: taking the seated right leg as the base, using the turn to change the direction in which he pulls me, using the outward rotation of the right arm and the leftward turning of the palm to alter the opponent's grip, and using the drawing back of the left leg to increase the distance of withdrawal and to make attack and defence easier.

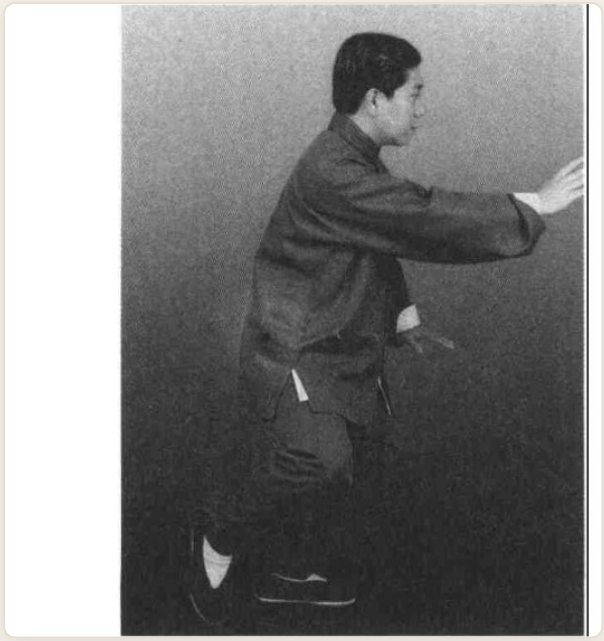
1. The centre of gravity gradually shifts entirely onto the left leg; the right foot lifts and comes down a little forward (about a foot or a little more). At the same time the right arm rotates outward so that the palm faces left, and turns from a vertical palm with a seated wrist into a flattened one; the right hand sinks slightly and the left hand shifts slightly forward and sinks (see the figures on this page).

图 113B



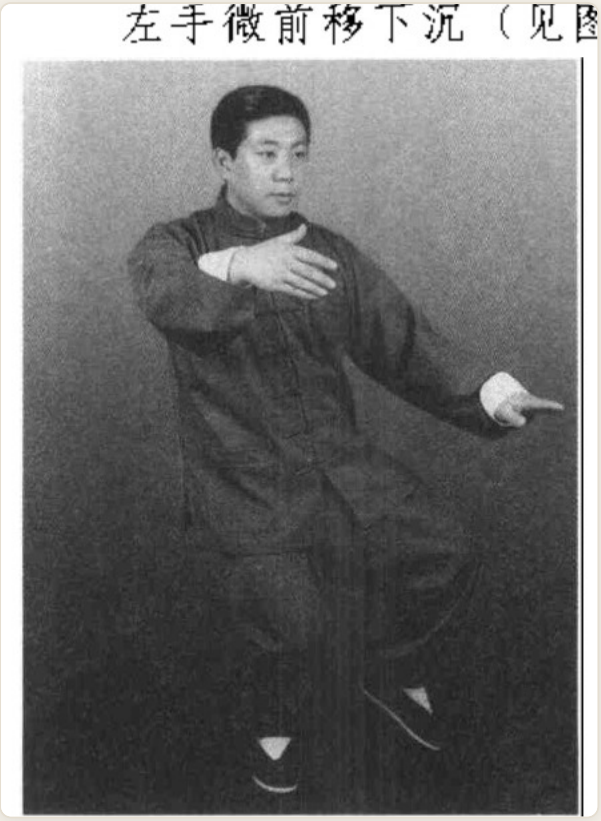
Needle at the Bottom of the Sea: after joining hands, the right hand bends at the elbow and draws back, the left hand extending forward to guard the inside of the right elbow

图 114



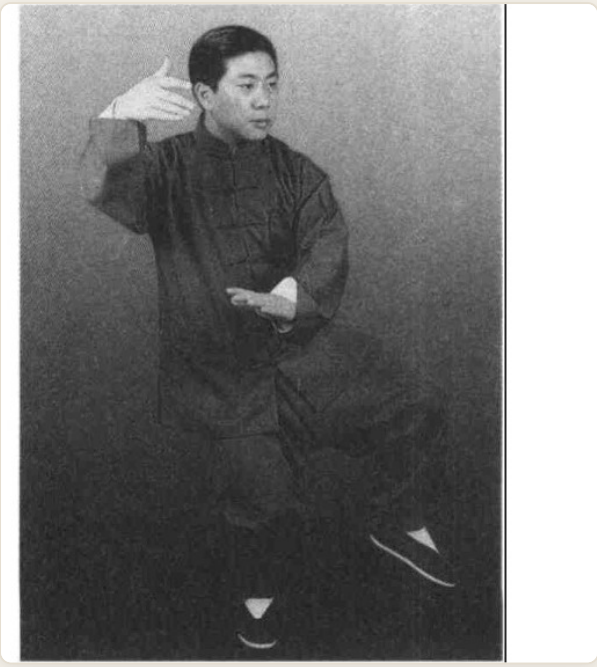
Needle at the Bottom of the Sea: the centre of gravity shifts onto the left leg, the right arm rotates outward, the palm turning left

图 115



Needle at the Bottom of the Sea: the right hand turns from a vertical palm with seated wrist to a flattened one, the left hand shifting slightly forward and sinking

图 116



Needle at the Bottom of the Sea: the two hands rise slightly with the shifting centre of gravity, the gaze taking in the drawing back of the right wrist

2. As the centre of gravity gradually shifts back until it rests entirely on the right leg, the left foot lifts, the waist turns slightly right, the right elbow bends and the right wrist draws in and back; the two hands rise slightly with the shifting of the centre of gravity. The gaze takes in the drawing back of the right wrist (see the figures on this page).

3. If at this moment the opponent still has not let go, and instead wishes to press forward and attack me in the same direction, I fold at the waist and sink down, changing the direction of his force. Therefore the left foot draws in slightly and comes down, touching the ground with the toes, forming a left empty stance; the waist turns slightly left, the right leg sits solidly, the left hip-root adducts, and the waist folds and sinks. At the same time the right palm, with the turning and folding of the waist, drives forward-and-down; the left palm arcs down to rest beside the left hip. The eyes look forward; the gaze must take in the right palm's downward drive (see the figures on this page).

III. Key Points

III. Key Points

1. As the centre of gravity moves forward and back, the two hands sink slightly and rise slightly; but the upper body still maintains "the sacrum centred and upright."

2. When the left foot lifts and comes down after drawing in slightly, and the upper body folds at the waist and sinks, the right leg must gradually squat, the left toes merely touching the ground in emptiness, and the centre of gravity must be borne entirely by the right leg.

3. When the right wrist draws inward and back, one must guard against shrugging the shoulder and lifting the elbow.

4. When the right palm, having drawn back, drives up, forward and down, its arc must accompany the squatting of the right leg and the folding of the waist, and the shoulder must urge the elbow and the elbow the hand, driving down with every joint threaded through.

5. In folding the waist, the neck and the waist-and-back must be kept in a single straight line; one must not bow the head or hunch the back. One must attend to the uplifting energy and the sinking of qi, threading one qi through above and below.

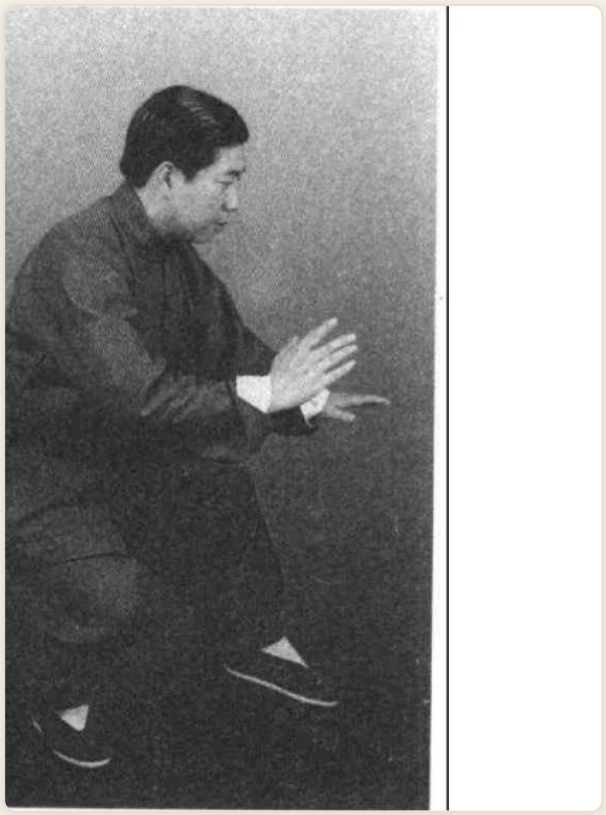
6. While driving down, the eyes look before the right palm, but the head must not be raised.

7. One must practise well "when one thing moves, nothing is unmoving." If the right palm has a drawing-back action, the left palm must likewise move forward and back with the centre of gravity and act together with the turning of the waist; one must not move only the right hand and not the left. The two arms must not be fully straight; they must be slightly bent.

8. When the right arm draws back the waist turns slightly right; when the waist folds and drives down it must turn slightly left. One must not move the hand alone without moving the waist; one must meet the requirement "the waist is the governing authority."

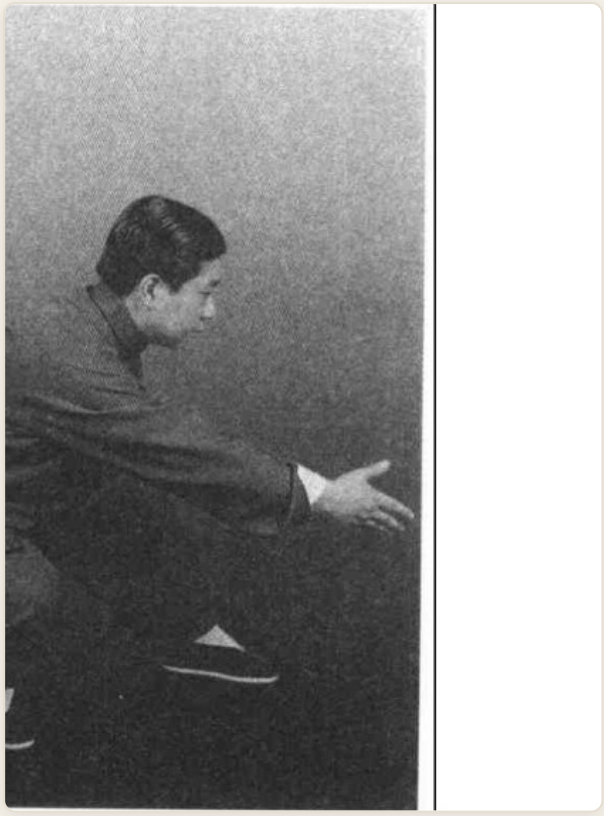
IV. Requirements

图 117A



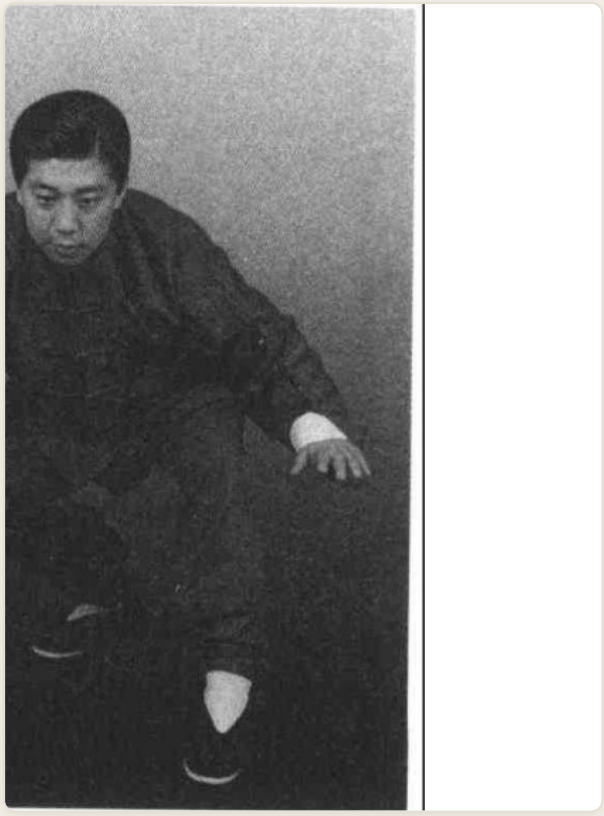
Needle at the Bottom of the Sea: the right palm draws back, the right elbow bent, the right wrist turning inward, the two hands rising slightly

图 117B



Needle at the Bottom of the Sea: the waist folds and sinks, the right palm drives forward-and-down, the left palm arcs down beside the left hip

图 117C



Needle at the Bottom of the Sea: left empty stance, toes touching the ground, sitting solidly on the right leg, the gaze taking in the right palm's downward drive

1. When folding at the waist and sinking, the neck and the waist-and-back must keep a single straight line; the buttocks must not protrude — protruding buttocks easily twist the arms and impair "the sacrum centred and upright."

2. After the sole of the right foot lifts, it must be set down with the palm of the foot at a slant; thus the lower body is easily made stable.

3. When folding at the waist and sinking, the right must be full and the left empty; otherwise one's own stance is unsteady and one is easily dragged about by the opponent.

4. The right hand's downward drive must seat the wrist; it must not be slack and powerless.

5. When folding at the waist the head must follow naturally, neither raised nor lowered; otherwise the qi and blood are made to flow poorly.

V. Common Errors, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Common Errors, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. **Error:** the right hand does not bend at the arm when drawing back. **Main causes:** ① attending to the foot and neglecting the hand; ② insufficient understanding of the application. In the action of bending the arm there are sinking and turning actions, and the distance the held point must travel is increased, which readily snaps the opponent's root-force. **Correction:** when the right hand draws back, one must at the same time shift the centre of gravity back, turn the waist right, and bend the arm.

2. **Error:** when the left foot comes down, it is not "sent down" by the squatting of the right leg; instead the right foot sits motionless and the left foot comes down by itself. **Main cause:** insufficient understanding of the application. If the right leg does not squat, then to sink and break free of the opponent's wrist-grip one can only rely on the strength of the hand, or at most of the waist and abdomen, and cannot bring the strength of the whole body into play.

(The photograph at the foot of this page shows Fu Zhongwen and Fu Shengyuan demonstrating push-hands; it carries no figure number.)

Correction: the right leg sinks to "send" the left foot down, and at the same time the right leg bears the whole body's weight as it squats.

3. **Error:** lowering the head and rounding the back. The main causes are: ① the right leg lacking the strength to squat. ② a shallow understanding of "the tailbone centred and upright". ③ a shallow understanding of the application. With the head lowered and the back rounded one cannot see the opponent's movement and cannot know him; how then can one attack and defend? Only by practising with the tailbone centred and upright can one be calm and comfortable. A rounded back and hollowed chest is a sickly posture and is unfavourable to breathing. **Correction:** the crown of the head, the trunk and the perineum must form one straight line.

4. **Error:** when turning the waist right to draw the right hand back, the turn is too wide — approaching 90° to the right. The main cause is a subjective pursuit of expansiveness, which results in scattering. **Correction:** the turn should be slight.

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

1. Explain and demonstrate (with a student as assistant, demonstrating the backward raise and the sinking).

2. Mnemonic: shift forward and sink slightly, then raise; turn the waist and bring the arm back, sinking down; the right leg solid and the left leg empty; fold at the waist, draw in the buttocks, and look ahead.

3. Group practice: ① while the centre of gravity shifts forward and back, observe the alternation of solid and empty in the two feet; one may support on one leg and lift the other, holding it off the ground for the moment and then slowly setting it down, to deepen the experience of solid and empty. ② in the left empty stance, squat slightly on the right leg while the left leg lifts empty and does not touch down, to strengthen the right — the solid leg — and deepen the experience of solid and empty.

4. Those of weak constitution should not squat deeply on the right leg; the stance may be higher, to reduce the amount of exertion.

5. The focus of teaching may be placed on folding at the waist and sinking, on improving the solidity and emptiness of the legs, on drawing in the buttocks, and on correcting such faults as lowering the head, rounding the back and crooking the spine.

6. In the course of practising the form the student must be brought to understand the application. The Needle at the Bottom of the Sea is not only the application of the right arm thrusting down; before it there is also the movement of drawing the right arm back, and in this way one gains an understanding of the whole process.

7. Whole-form practice, improving the movement of the two hands. The centre of gravity shifts forward, the body rises slightly, and the two hands rise slightly with it, forming the left empty stance. The right leg squats, the right hand thrusts down, and the left hand presses down. Practise repeatedly, experiencing the requirement of "when one part moves, no part is still".

8. Paired practice using the application: A — performs Brush the Knee and Twist the Step, and offers the right wrist to be gripped by the partner, B. A — shifts the centre of gravity back, turns the body slightly right, and draws the right arm back, feeling the strength of the backward draw, then thrusts the right arm down and lowers the centre of gravity, and so on, to experience the application of Needle at the Bottom of the Sea and to feel how one snaps B's root strength. Practise repeatedly and exchange roles.

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. The first difficulty of Needle at the Bottom of the Sea lies in the squat of the left empty stance. For it makes high demands not only on the quadriceps and other muscles of the front of the thigh, but also — because the upper body folds forward, the left leg hangs empty and the body's centre of gravity shifts forward — on the muscles of the waist and back and the gluteals. Hence a good many muscles are brought into play, which raises the training effect. At the same time, because the upper body bends forward, it squeezes and massages the internal organs of the chest and abdomen, which is a great help in strengthening the constitution.

2. The characteristic of Needle at the Bottom of the Sea is that it folds the body forward, and in the whole of the Yang-style form this is rather conspicuous. Bending forward, lowering the head, bending the waist and crooking the back — this loses the upward energy of the empty collar and loses the containing of the chest. But in a correct fold-and-sink, although the bend at the waist is large, one still maintains "the crown point, the central pole, one breath running through"; for although this is a deviation within centredness, the inner energy is still centred and undeviating. Therefore the head must follow naturally — one must not lower the head, must not protrude the buttocks, and must draw the buttocks in.

Twenty-third Posture: Fan Through the Back (Shan Tong Bei)

I. Application

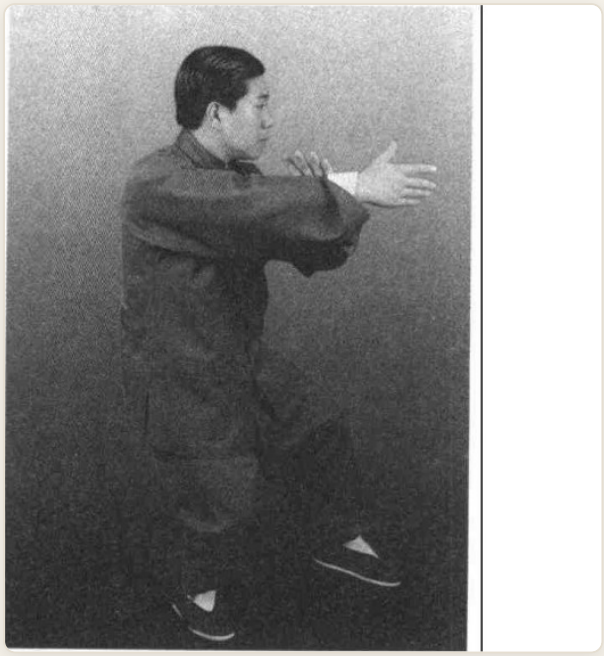
Continuing from the previous posture. If the opponent again strikes with his right hand, I hastily raise my right hand from in front upward until it is beside my right temple, and at once turn the palm outward, using it to support the strength of the opponent's right hand; the left hand at the same time comes up in front of the chest, bursts open with the palm, and drives straight at the opponent's ribs, sinking the shoulders, dropping the elbows, sitting the wrist and relaxing the waist. At the same time the left foot steps forward, the knee bends and sits solid, the toes pointing forward. The gaze follows the left hand forward, and the right leg's hip and waist extend and send the strength out. Its energy issues from the back; the two arms open out, so that the fan opens through the back.

II. Course of the Movement

1. Sitting solidly on the right leg, the waist straightens as it turns right, and the left foot lifts and moves back; at the same time the right palm is raised from in front of the body, rotating inward as it rises so that the palm faces right and the fingers slant downward; the left palm is raised from beside the left hip up to in front of the chest, its palm also facing right, the fingers slanting

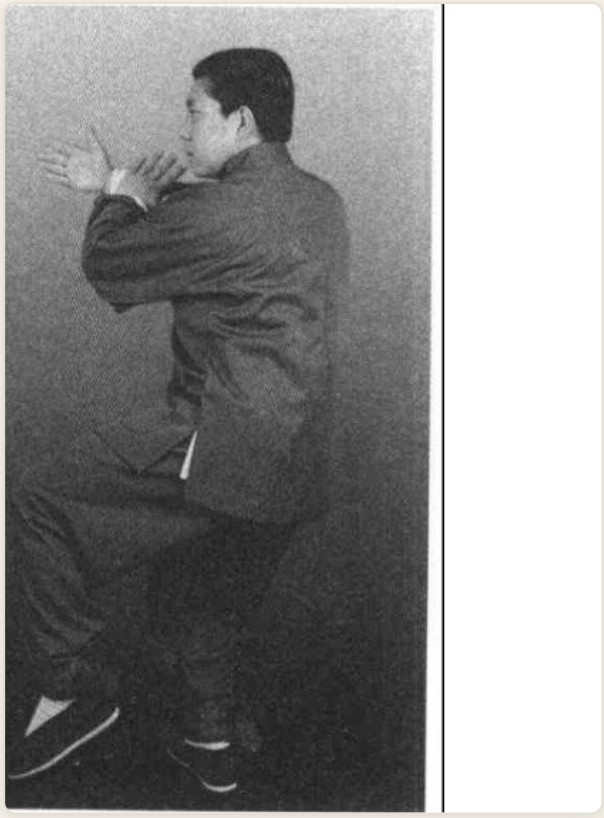
upward. When the right arm has been raised to the height of the chest, the gaze must attend to the right palm's rising (see the first two figures at the right-hand side of this page).

图 118A



Fan Through the Back: sitting solidly on the right leg, the waist straightening as it turns right, the right palm raised from in front of the body

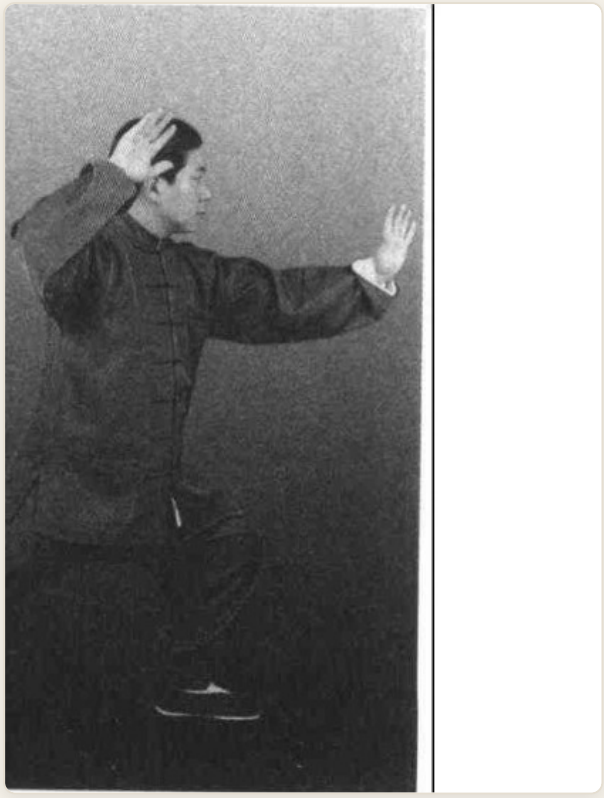
图 118B



Fan Through the Back: the right palm raised to the height of the chest, palm facing right, the gaze attending to the right palm's rising

2. The left leg lifts and steps forward a pace, touching down heel first, the toes pointing forward; as the centre of gravity gradually shifts onto the left leg the whole sole presses flat, the left leg bows and the right leg pushes, forming a left bow stance; at the same time the right arm continues to rotate slightly inward and bend at the elbow, and the right palm arcs outward to support, the left palm moving right to come close to the right forearm; the right hand is drawn back to the right side of the forehead, no higher than the crown, and the left hand strikes forward, the fingers no higher than the eyebrows. The eyes look level ahead, and the gaze attends to the left palm's forward push (see the third figure at the right-hand side of this page).

图 119A



Fan Through the Back: the left leg stepping forward into a left bow stance, the left palm striking forward, the right hand drawn back to the right side of the forehead

BOOK PAGE 110

III. Key Points

III. Key Points

1. The linking of the movements is very important. Once the right arm of Needle at the Bottom of the Sea has thrust down into place, the upper body must rise, the left leg draw back and the two arms be raised; there must be no pause anywhere. Inside and outside, above and below, left and right, front and back must be coordinated; upper and lower accompanying each other, done in one breath — only then does one gain the opportunity and the advantage.

2. The difficulty of Fan Through the Back lies in doing the slow forward step of the left leg well while supported on the right leg alone, and in requiring an even speed and a clear distinction of solid and empty. The right hip root must draw in, the right abdomen be full, and one must sit steadily on the right leg; then the left leg slowly advances a pace. Hence beginners find this movement hard to do well: they usually fail to control the centre of gravity, so that the left leg lands quickly, or the right leg straightens; this fails to meet the requirement of unbroken

continuity and of stepping like a cat, and also produces the error of the centre of gravity rising and falling violently. Therefore attending to the stability of the right leg is of great importance.

3. In changing from the right empty stance into the left bow stance, the left leg bowing forward, the right leg pushing back, the left palm pushing forward and the right palm supporting upward — these four movements must be as one. In this way, while the upper frame is set, the left palm drives straight at the opponent and one achieves the effect of attacking where he is empty.

4. The right palm's upward support must sink the shoulder and drop the elbow; do not shrug the shoulder or lift the elbow, for lifting the elbow exposes the ribs. The left palm's push must sit the wrist, and the palm must not face squarely forward.

5. In the course of the movement the arms are often easily held straight, which does not accord with the requirement "strength is stored in the bends and has surplus" — the movement should leave room for extension, and one should be storing power everywhere and able to release power everywhere. Therefore, throughout the whole set of tai chi chuan movements, neither the two arms nor the two legs may be straightened or held rigid.

6. In the movement one must not throw the chest out; throwing the chest out does not accord with the requirement of "containing the chest and raising the back". For the right hand's support and the left arm's level push both require the strength to issue from the spine. The function of containing the chest is to favour the dissolving of energy, and the function of raising the back is to favour the rolling and releasing of energy; in combat they are related as storing and issuing, each transforming into the other.

7. One must "keep the tailbone centred and upright, and support the eight directions": never allow any part of the body to slacken and lose its centre, and however the limbs may turn and change, from the crown of the head to the perineum there is always one line. When the left leg steps, the body must not lean forward or backward, nor tilt to left or right; one must both have upper and lower accompanying each other and keep upper and lower essentially one line.

BOOK PAGE 111

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. As the body straightens and the left foot is drawn back, one must sit solidly on the right leg, not lower the head or stoop, and not sway the body from side to side.

2. At the same time as the upper body straightens, the left foot, left hand and right hand — together with a slight turn of the waist to the right — must all move together.

3. The right palm must turn as it rises; by the time it has risen to shoulder height the elbow joint should already be hanging down. The left palm, raised to beside the right forearm, should be no

higher than the shoulder; otherwise the left palm will not be driving straight forward.

4. The left foot steps forward, touching down heel first, and is required to be light and slow.

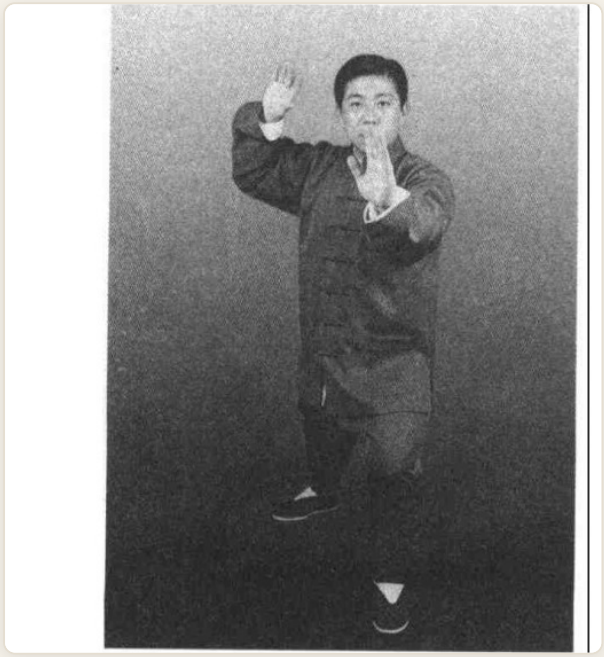
5. In stepping the upper body must not fall forward or lean back; the tailbone must be centred and upright.

6. The waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower limbs. In issuing the left palm, the waist turns slightly right, the leg bows, the leg pushes, the waist wrings, and finally the palm is issued. If the strength of the waist is used appropriately it reinforces the issuing of power and concentrates the whole body's force at one point.

7. The left leg steps forward and only after the heel has landed does the left hand push forward.

V. Errors Easily Committed, Their Causes, and Their Correction

图 119B



Fan Through the Back: the upper body straightening, the left foot drawn back, the right palm turning as it rises, the left palm pushing forward

1. **Error:** the left leg steps forward and lands fast and heavily. The main cause is that the upper body has not been raised and the body — the body's centre of gravity has moved far from the support point of the right foot; the moment the left foot is lifted empty, the body rushes forward, so the left foot has no choice but to land heavily and in haste. **Correction:** the upper body must be raised and kept upright, "containing the chest and raising the back", and the body's weight placed entirely on the right leg, so that the lower body is first made stable. Then the left leg is slowly stepped out, and in this way one can be light and nimble.

2. **Error:** when the movement begins, only the hands and feet move and the waist does not turn. The main cause is that the practitioner has not deeply grasped that "the waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower limbs", nor deeply experienced the change of the whole body's movement and the transmission of energy to every part of the limbs. **Correction:** from the very start of the movement the waist must lead the hands and feet. Hence "in the change of solid and empty one must be attentive".

3. **Error:** the left leg has bowed into place but the two hands are still moving. The main cause is an insufficient understanding of the application. "Within going forward there must be a bracing behind." When body, hands and leg go forward, the crotch energy sinks, the sole takes the weight, and the force passes through the spine and reaches the palm and fingers to shoot straight. Hence where there is forward there must be backward; this is what must be done well to reinforce the reactive force. **Correction:** the hands must arrive, the feet must arrive and the eyes must arrive.

4. **Error:** the right elbow lifts as the right hand rises. Some lift the elbow above the shoulder; some let the elbow stick out far from the body. The main cause is a shallow understanding of the requirement to "sink the shoulders and drop the elbows". A lifted elbow point is a lifting energy; it both hinders the sinking of the shoulder and affects the sinking of the breath, and exposes the ribs too much. **Correction:** the elbow must always be slightly bent and carry a downward-sinking energy, and the right elbow must be lower than the right palm.

BOOK PAGE 112

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

1. In group practice, bring out the common errors and faults.

2. Mnemonic: sit solid on the right leg, its root unmoving; the two hands gradually rise as the body straightens; lightly step the left leg out, the eyes looking forward; the left drives while the right supports — a fan through the back.

3. Paired practice using the application: A — takes up the posture of Needle at the Bottom of the Sea. B — strikes straight at A with the right hand from the front. A — at once straightens the upper body and, as the left foot steps forward, raises the right hand to support B's hand beside the right temple, and at once drives the left hand from the chest to strike B's left ribs. The two exchange roles.

4. The emphasis of this movement must be placed on the supporting leg — the right leg. Sitting solidly on the right leg, the body straightens as it turns right, and the left foot lifts and moves back. At this moment the right leg must not straighten: that is, one must keep the right leg bent while doing the movement, so that the right leg is close to an isometric exercise. Gradually

master the method of threading energy into the lower limb — the sacrum must sink powerfully, the girdle vessel be fully filled, the strength of the buttocks be threaded through to the heel, and the energy of the right foot be as if wound into the ground. In this way, only when the right is solid can the left be empty, and only then can the left leg step light and nimble; the body will naturally not sway.

Twenty-fourth Posture: Turn the Body and Swing the Fist (Zhuan Shen Pie Shen Chui)

BOOK PAGE 113

I. Application

I. Application

Continuing from the previous posture. If the opponent strikes with his hand at my back or at my ribs from behind, I immediately shift the left foot slightly and sit solidly, the right foot becomes empty, and I turn the waist so that the body turns to face the front (from east toward south); at the same time the right hand forms a fist and is held for the moment at the left ribs, with the left palm slanting upward, joining to protect the left corner of the forehead. The body continues to turn right (toward west), and at the same time the right fist circles upward and swings out, meeting the opponent's hand, and with a sinking energy sits firmly at the side of the right ribs, while the left hand, from the left side, darts at the opponent's face. In this way the opponent loses the measures of attack and defence he ought to have.

II. Course of the Movement

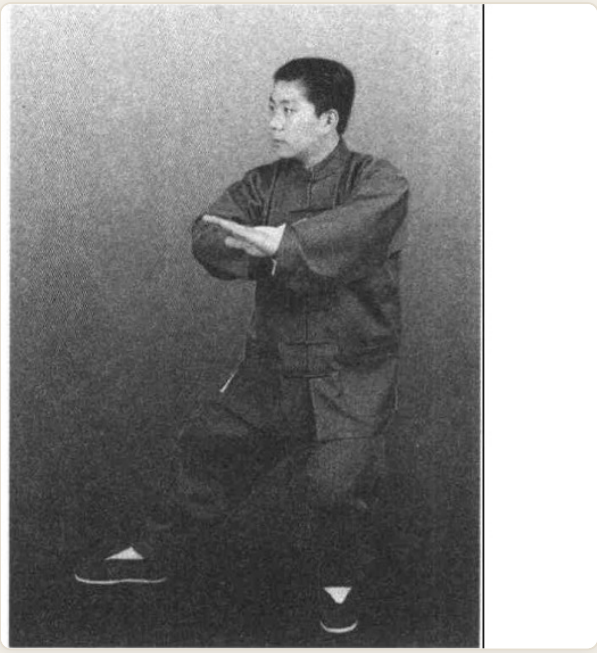
1. The body slowly turns right (toward south), and at the same time the left toes turn in, the left leg sits solid, and the right foot becomes empty. With the turning of the body the right palm arcs down. It forms a fist and is held for the moment in front of the left ribs, the elbow bent and the arm across, the fist's centre facing down, while the left palm is drawn back, arcs up and is placed above and in front of the left corner of the forehead. The gaze attends slightly to the right hand's arc, then looks level ahead (see the figure at the left-hand side of this page).

图 120

Turn the Body and Swing the Fist: the body turning right, the left toes turning in, the right hand forming a fist and held for the moment in front of the left ribs, the left palm arcing up to be placed above and in front of the left corner of the forehead

2. The body continues to turn right (toward west), the centre of gravity shifts entirely onto the left leg, and the right foot lifts; the left palm, with the turning of the body, at the same time arcs from the right downward, passes outside the right forearm and comes down level with the right elbow, while the right fist circles upward (slightly higher than the left elbow). The eyes follow the turning of the body, looking level ahead and attending to the movement of the two hands (see the first figure at the right-hand side of this page).

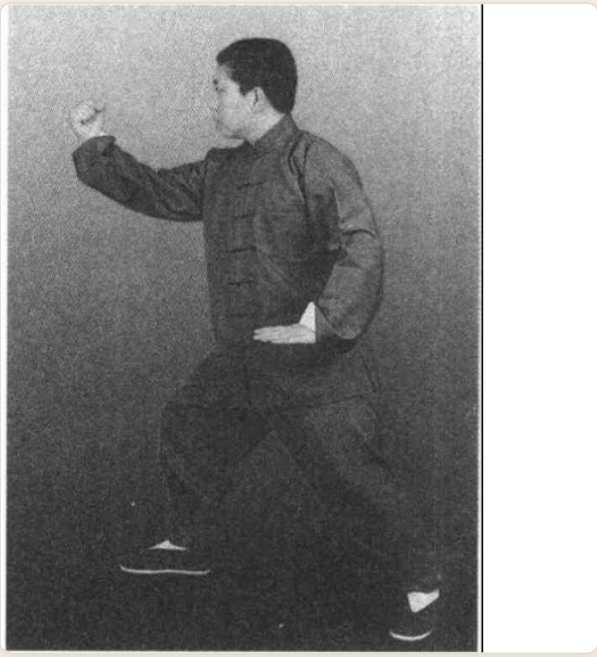
图 121



Turn the Body and Swing the Fist: the body continuing to turn right, the right fist circling upward, the left palm coming down outside the right forearm level with the right elbow

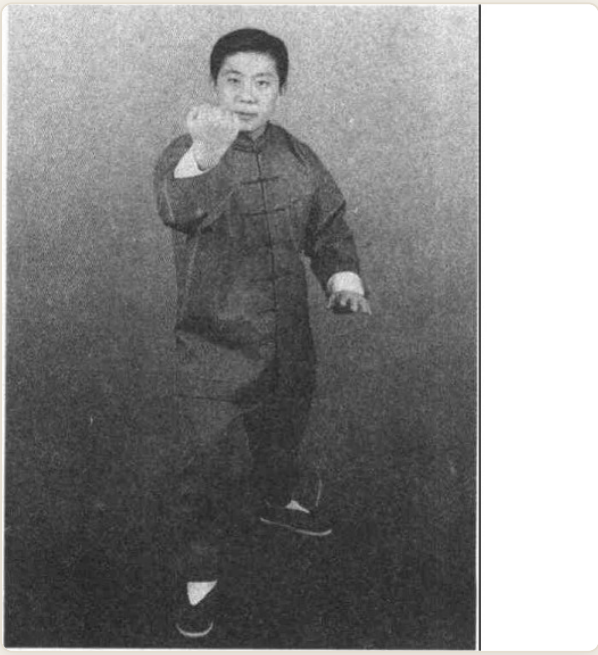
3. The right foot comes down forward (slightly to the right), toes pointing forward, touching down heel first, and at the same time the right fist swings out forward. As the centre of gravity shifts onto the right leg and gradually comes entirely flat, the right leg bows and the left leg pushes, the left heel pivoting on the ground, forming a right bow stance. At the same time the body continues to turn right and the right fist, with the turning of the body, continues to arc down and swing out, then is drawn back to the side of the waist, the fist's centre facing up; the left palm continues to circle past the left side of the chest and pushes forward above the inside of the right forearm. The eyes look level ahead, and the gaze must first attend to the right fist's swing out and then to the left palm's forward push (see the second and third figures at the right-hand side of this page).

图 122A



Turn the Body and Swing the Fist: the right foot coming down forward, the right fist swinging out forward

图 122B



Turn the Body and Swing the Fist: the right leg bowing and the left leg pushing to form a right bow stance, the left palm pushing forward above the inside of the right forearm

III. Key Points

III. Key Points

1. "The thousand changes and ten thousand transformations are moved by me; the two feet of the lower body fix the foundation." If the foundation is not stable, one cannot keep one's balance. Therefore the right leg, in stepping out, must be placed slightly to the right; the two feet must on no account stand on one line, which would make the body sway. Hence one must make the lower body firm in order to gain freedom in the upper body.

2. The right toes must point straight ahead; they must not splay outward or turn in, for the direction the toes point bears on how far the hip roots are opened and on the amount of exertion. If the right toes turn in, then the opening of the hip roots is affected, the two hip roots form a pinched inverted V, and the body too will be off to the left instead of facing squarely forward.

3. As the waist and hips turn, the left foot must be turned in with the turning; that is, turn the foot as you turn the body. The boxing theory says "the lord is in the waist" and also "the waist is the axle of the cart, the breath like the wheel". The waist, then, is the key to the turning of the upper and lower body; if the central axis does not bend, the body will not sway.

4. When turning the waist the buttocks must not protrude but be drawn in — this is "drawing in the buttocks". If the waist is not drawn in and not upright, the buttocks easily protrude, and this adversely affects both "the spirit threading through the crown" and "strength issuing from the spine".

5. The movements of the two hands must be "clear". The right hand uses a fist, the left hand uses a palm, and the right hand's stay at the front of the left ribs is temporary (held for a moment). It swings out in the instant of seeming to stop and not stopping; after swinging out there is still a sinking energy — this is the plucking energy used in secret. The left hand closes and guards in front of the left forehead, then arcs downward and strikes out from in front of the left chest. When the two hands circle, the left hand is outside and the right fist inside. All these movements must be clearly understood from the application and must not be left vague.

6. The right leg is lifted and steps straight forward; do not draw it back close to the left ankle and then step across.

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. When the left foot turns in and the body turns, the body must be straight, the posture steady, the left leg solid and the right leg empty; otherwise one is unstable and cannot make the attacking and defending movements.

2. The movements must be linked without a break. Each movement is at the point of seeming to stop and not stopping; the breath moves gradually and the inner energy is then poured in fully. The opportunity for the next posture arises of itself. Therefore, although the direction the body faces is changing, the movements of hands and feet must be unbroken.

3. The left foot must turn in fully (past 90°); otherwise, when the right leg steps forward (toward west), the crotch opens too wide, which makes the left leg's support unstable and the direction in which the right leg lands hard to control — not only awkward, but losing the bracing strength behind.

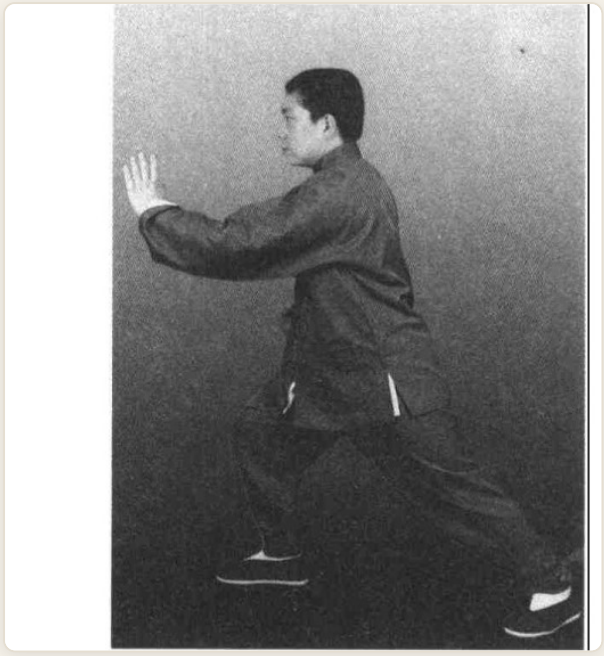
4. During the turn one must not tense and exert force; it should be "use intent, not force". Tai chi chuan must be practised from looseness into softness; attend to relaxing the waist — do not press down hard on it, lest it hinder the freedom of the waist's rotation.

5. The fist that swings out must not swing too wide or too narrow. Too wide easily raises the shoulder and makes the movement slack; too narrow does not meet the requirement of the application.

V. Errors Easily Committed, Their Causes, and Their Correction

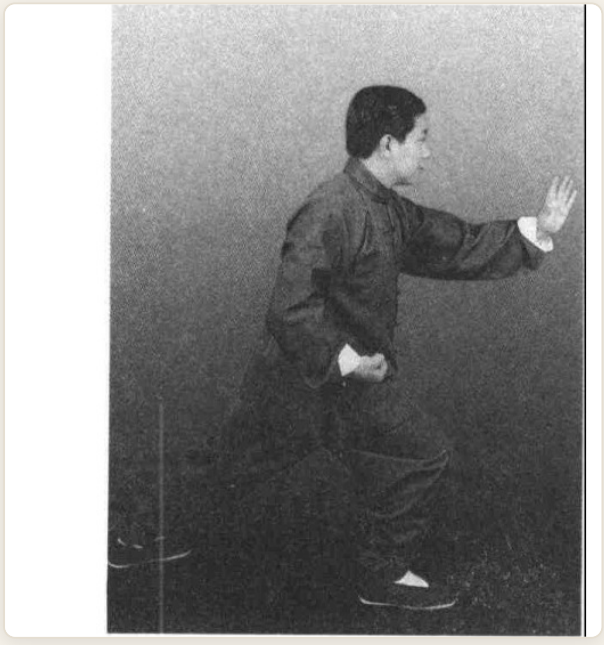
1. **Error:** the movement pauses after turning right. The main causes are: ① the left foot is turned in without the waist leading it, so the turning is awkward and the attention is on the leg, which causes the upper body's movement to pause. ② the right fist's temporary stay at the left ribs is not deeply understood — that in the midst of seeming to stop and not stopping, the right fist immediately circles up and swings out. Often, after the two hands have arrived in position, all movement stops and only the right leg's drawing back remains. ③ a shallow understanding of the pattern of continuous liveliness and symmetrical coordination. **Correction:** as the body turns and the left foot turns in, with the left hand guarding above and the right hand staying temporarily at the left ribs, the body turns right without pause and the two hands circle — at the same time the right foot lifts. Do it unbrokenly.

图 123A



Turn the Body and Swing the Fist: the left foot turning in and the body turning, the right fist staying temporarily at the left ribs, the left hand guarding above in front of the forehead

图 123B



Turn the Body and Swing the Fist: the body turning right without pause, the right foot lifting as the two hands circle

2. **Error:** the two hands lift the elbows. The main cause is that the left shoulder uses force and the right elbow leaves the ribs. **Correction:** the elbows must always be slightly bent and carry a sinking energy. When the left hand is raised to the front of the left corner of the forehead the elbow ends up higher than the shoulder, but the inner energy of the elbow is still falling and sinking. If the elbow point is raised, that is a lifting energy, and it does not accord with tai chi chuan's "sink the shoulders and drop the elbows". If the right elbow lifts, the ribs are exposed and are easily attacked. Lifting the elbows inevitably hinders the sinking of the shoulders and also affects the sinking of the breath.

3. **Error:** after the turn, the right leg is drawn back and then steps out too far. The main cause is a shallow experience of the application. **Correction:** it should be lifted slightly and at once step forward, so that when the right fist swings out and meets the opponent's arm, and sinking energy is used, there is firm support.

4. **Error:** when the left hand strikes forward it is not hand-arrives-with-foot-arrives; usually the right leg has already formed the bow stance while the left palm is still extending forward. The main cause is a shallow understanding of "when one part moves, no part is still; when one part is still, no part moves" and "within going forward there must be a bracing behind". **Correction:** when the hand and fist are striking forward and applying force, there must be firm support from the left leg. When the left palm arrives, that is precisely when the bow stance is completed — hand arrives, foot arrives — and this meets the requirement of combat. When body, hands and leg go forward, the inner energy turns up from the crotch, passes through the spine and back and shoots straight out through the palm and fingers, and the waist and the spine's gate of life must brace behind; the palm presses forward with far-reaching intent and long energy, while the back of the hand still has the intent of drawing in and bracing behind. If the foot has arrived while the hand is still moving, this does not accord with the principle of upper and lower accompanying each other; hence the hand must arrive when the foot arrives.

5. **Error:** protruding the buttocks while turning the body and the foot in. The main cause is failure to attend to drawing the buttocks in, the waist not being relaxed, sunk and upright. **Correction:** one must "draw in the buttocks" — that is, not stick the buttocks out but draw them in naturally. This stabilises the lower end of the spine, helps increase the spine's flexibility and the elasticity of the back muscles, and prevents the back from being bent and crooked.

BOOK PAGE 116

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

VI. Teaching and Practice Methods

1. Focused broken-down practice: ① after turning the body (toward south), check the degree of the foot's turning in, whether the buttocks are protruded, and the position of the two hands. ② after continuing to turn the body (toward west), the place where the right foot lands and the

circling movement of the two hands. ③ the coordination of the left palm's forward strike with the bow stance.

2. The demonstration should also include a front-facing mirror demonstration, for with the back to — the learner cannot see the teacher's arm movements, especially the right arm; when the two arms circle, one should also demonstrate one arm at a time separately, and finally the two hands circling together. This makes it easier for the learner to understand.

3. Mnemonic: turn the foot in after first loosening the hips; the right fist and left palm come together; face south, then turn west; the right swings out, the left palm issues.

4. First practise the direction and the positions of the hands' and feet's movements, and only then learn "looseness" and "evenness", so that the movement has neither fast nor slow, nor pauses.

5. Paired practice using the application: A — takes up the settled posture of Fan Through the Back. B — strikes straight from behind A. A — turns the body and turns the foot in, lifts the right foot and steps forward (toward west), the right fist swings out and meets B's hand, sits firmly at the side of the right ribs with sinking energy, and drives the left palm quickly at B's face. The two exchange roles, experiencing the swing, the sink and the strike.

6. Practise repeatedly the turning of the body and the turning in of the foot, to raise the quality of the straight body and the "drawing in of the buttocks".

7. Practise repeatedly the support on the left leg, with the right leg lifting lightly and stepping out slowly, to raise the left leg's capacity to bear the body's weight and thereby strengthen the constitution.

8. Practise the arm movements repeatedly. When the right fist swings out, attend to using the elbow as the axis, not the shoulder. Using the shoulder as the axis draws too large an arc and produces "scattering". When the two arms circle, be clear that the left hand is outside and the right fist inside.

BOOK PAGE 118

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. The swinging-body fist is an attack-and-defence method against a strike from behind: turning the body and swinging the fist dissolves and defends, and the issuing of the palm is used to attack.

2. The left foot turns as the solid leg, which makes high demands on relaxing the waist and hips. If one cannot let the waist lead the movements of hands and feet, one will stick the buttocks out

and lower the head and bend the waist. Hence the demands on the turning of the solid left leg are very high.

3. Under the guidance of intent, the movement is required to be light and unhurried, neither slow nor rushed, and throughout the course of the movement to keep the posture correct everywhere, so that the movement is correct: above, the two arms are linked, and below, the two legs accompany each other. Only then does the turning avoid stiffness and slackness.

4. After turning the body to the rear, the right fist is placed at the left ribs and the left hand closes and guards the left corner of the forehead; there must be a closing energy and a sense of guarding. In the previous posture, Fan Through the Back, the right ribs are exposed — if the opponent attacks from behind he will strike either the ribs or the head. So in turning the body hurriedly without knowing his intent, one hand guarding the forehead and one hand's fist staying at the ribs (in fact the right elbow guarding the ribs) meets the requirements of combat and also the requirements of opening and closing and of storing the posture. Therefore the two hands must on no account be dropped at random. Once moved, one must concentrate wholly and continually use intent to guide the correctness, continuity and roundness of every movement. Throughout the movement, the opening and closing, the solid and empty, and the turning and changing of the inner and the outer must seek upper and lower accompanying each other, inner and outer as one, intent arriving and energy arriving, and every movement in accord with method.

5. When the right fist swings out, what position should the right foot be in for it to be reasonable? There are generally two: one is that the right foot has been lifted but not yet stepped out and the right fist has already swung out — this is a mere form and is empty, because on one leg's support neither the swing nor the sink has any power. The second is that the right knee has already bowed out while the right fist has not finished swinging — by then one is already too close to the opponent, which is unfavourable to sinking, one cannot use the whole body's strength, and the left palm's strike is powerless. Therefore the correct way is: when the right fist swings out the right foot has already stepped out, and when the left palm issues the right knee has just bowed into place — hand arrives, foot arrives — in accord with the requirement of the application.

6. "Looseness". If the movement is practised badly, especially at the moment of turning the body, turning the foot in, lifting the leg and stepping, one tenses very easily. In practising tai chi chuan the whole body must loosen, without a hair's-breadth of clumsy force to stagnate in the sinews, bones and blood in between, binding oneself; only then can one change lightly and nimbly and turn freely and smoothly, with breath and blood flowing, poured through day after day and circulating the whole body — which is of the greatest benefit to improving health.

Twenty-fifth Posture: Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch (Jin Bu Ban Lan Chui)

I. Application

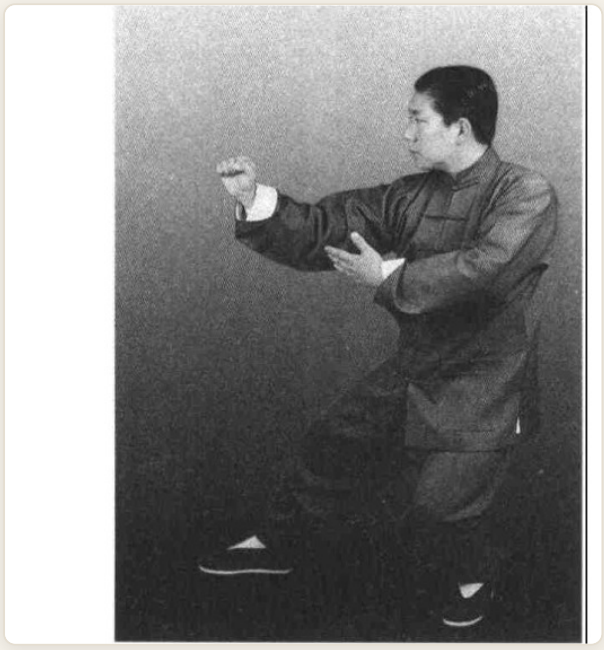
I. Application

The same as the twelfth posture, "Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch".

II. Course of the Movement

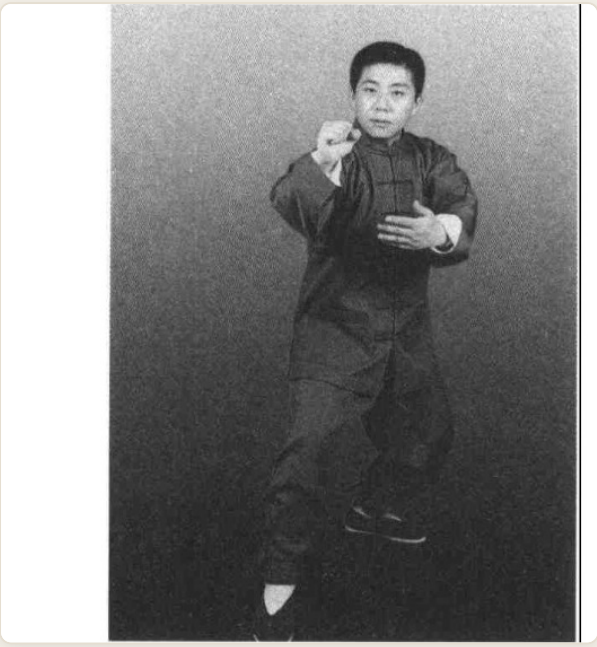
1. The centre of gravity gradually shifts back onto the left leg, and at the same time the body turns slightly left (from east toward south-east); the left elbow sinks with the turning of the body, and the left arm, as it sinks, rotates outward so that the palm gradually turns to face up; the right arm gradually rotates inward and the right fist extends forward and up past the upper side of the left palm, the fist's centre facing down. The gaze attends to the right fist's forward extension (see the first two figures at the left-hand side of this page).

图 124A



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the centre of gravity shifting back onto the left leg, the left elbow sinking with the turning of the body and the left arm rotating outward with the palm turning to face up

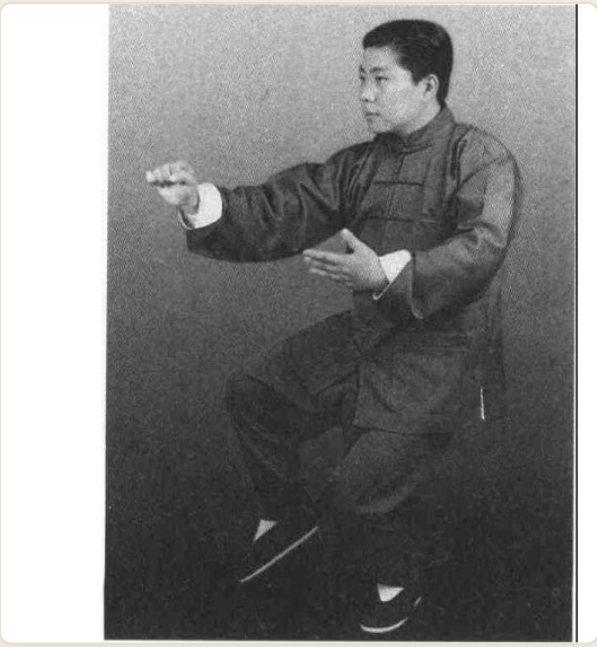
图 124B



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the right arm rotating inward, the right fist extending forward and up past the upper side of the left palm, the fist's centre facing down

2. The centre of gravity continues to shift back, sitting solidly on the left leg, and at the same time the body continues to turn left; the two hands ward to the left with the turning of the body, the right hand arcing slightly down and the left hand arcing slightly up (see the third figure at the left-hand side of this page).

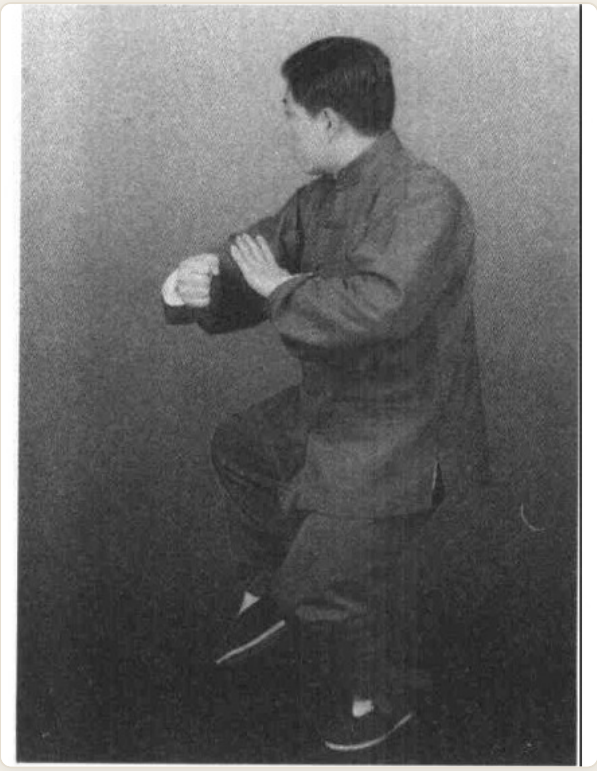
图 125



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the two hands warding left with the turning of the body, the right hand arcing slightly down and the left hand arcing slightly up

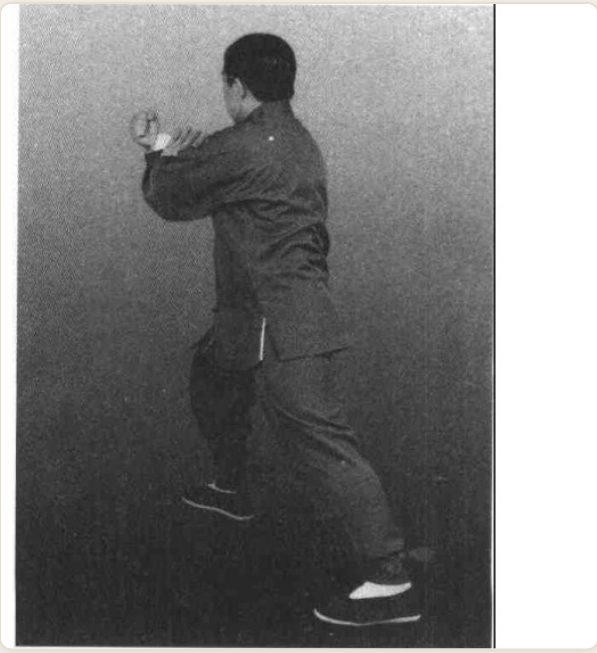
3. The right leg is drawn back, and at the same time the body turns right; the right fist arcs down from the right front, passes in front of the abdomen and circles to the left, the fist's centre turning to face down; the left hand arcs from the left upward (no higher than the shoulder), rotating inward as it arcs so that the palm turns to face slantingly down-right. The eyes attend slightly to the two hands' arcing circle, then look level ahead (see the fourth and fifth figures at the foot of this page).

图 126



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the right leg drawn back, the right fist arcing down past the front of the abdomen and circling to the left

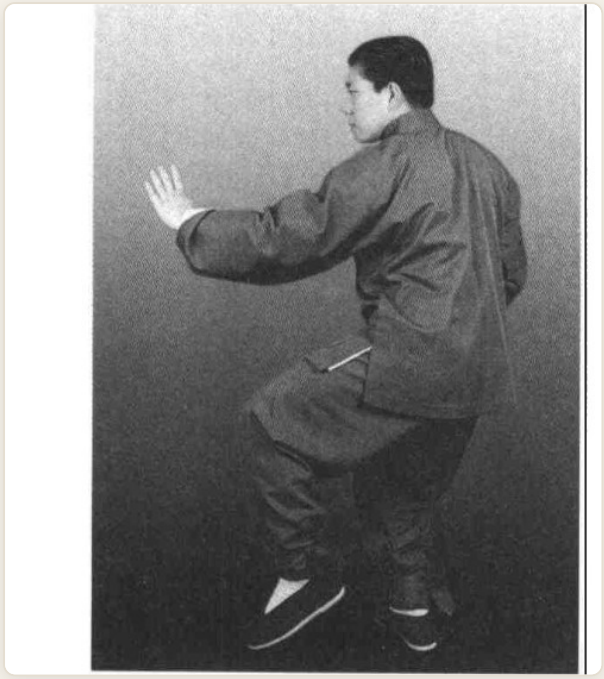
图 127



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the left hand arcing from the left upward, the palm turning to face slantingly down-right

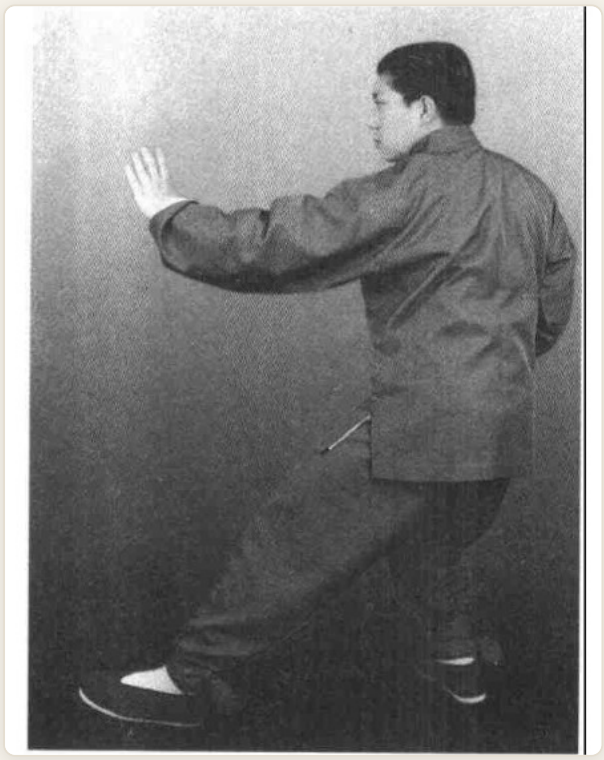
4. The following movements are the same as the twelfth posture, "Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch", only the direction is reversed: the former goes east, this one goes west (see the first three figures at the foot of this page).

图 128



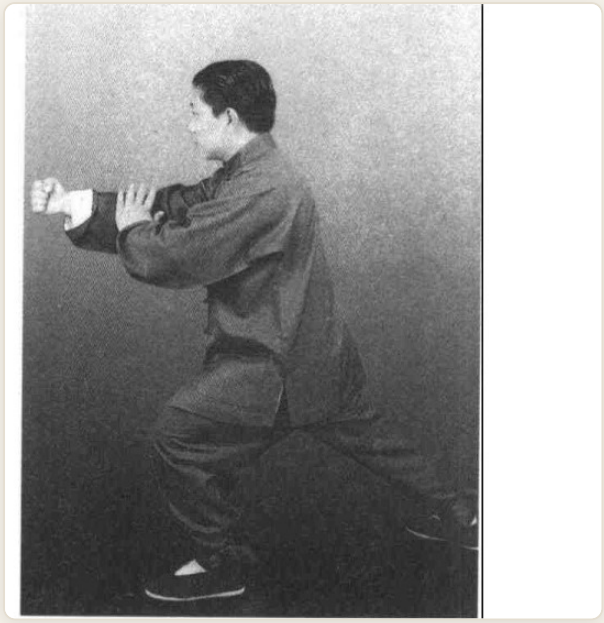
Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the deflect (direction reversed; this posture goes west)

图 129



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the parry

图 130



Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch: the punch (the right fist striking forward)

BOOK PAGE 120

III. Key Points

III. Key Points

The same as the twelfth posture, "Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch".

Twenty-sixth Posture: Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail (Shang Bu Lan Que Wei)

I. Application

The same as the third posture, Grasp the Bird's Tail.

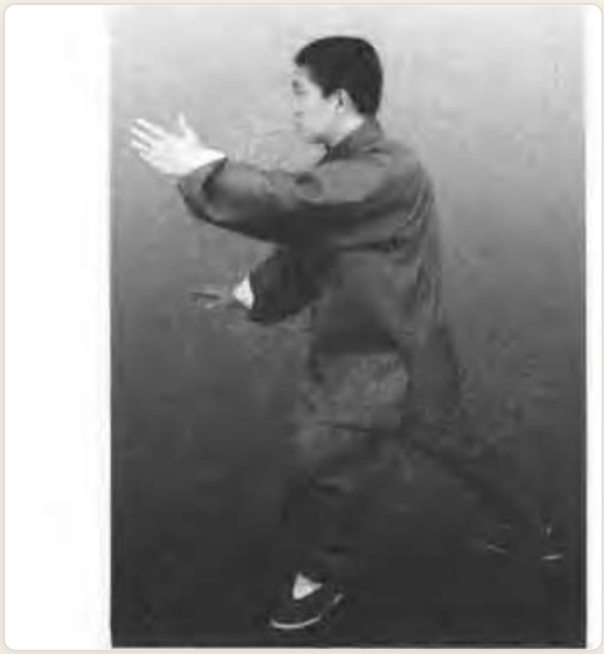
II. Course of the Movement

The body gradually turns left, the left toes splay outward and press flat, and the centre of gravity gradually shifts entirely onto the left leg, while the right leg is lifted and brought forward; at the same time the left elbow sinks as it draws back to the left, naturally carrying the left palm in an arc to in front of the left side of the chest; the right fist changes to a palm, goes from the front downward, and scoops in an arc to the left to in front of the abdomen, rotating outward as it scoops so that the palm turns to face slantingly up-left and joins with the left hand, both arms forming arcs. The eyes attend slightly to the left forearm, then turn to look level ahead in front of

the right arm (see the figures on this and the following two pages — the same as the plates of the third posture).

The remaining movements are the same as the third posture, Grasp the Bird's Tail (except the left ward-off). (This page is a full-page plate sheet with no running text. The nine photographs below are the continuous illustration of the movements of Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail.)

图 131



Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the body turning left, the left toes splaying outward and pressing flat, the right leg lifted and brought forward

图 132

Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the left elbow drawing back to the left and sinking, the left palm arcing to in front of the left side of the chest

图 133

Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the right fist changing to a palm and going from the front downward, scooping in an arc to the left to in front of the abdomen

图 134A

Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the right palm joining with the left hand, both arms forming arcs

图 134B

Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the front view of the two hands joining

图 135

Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the right arm rotating outward so that the palm turns to face slantingly up-left

图 136

Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the transitional position as the right leg steps forward

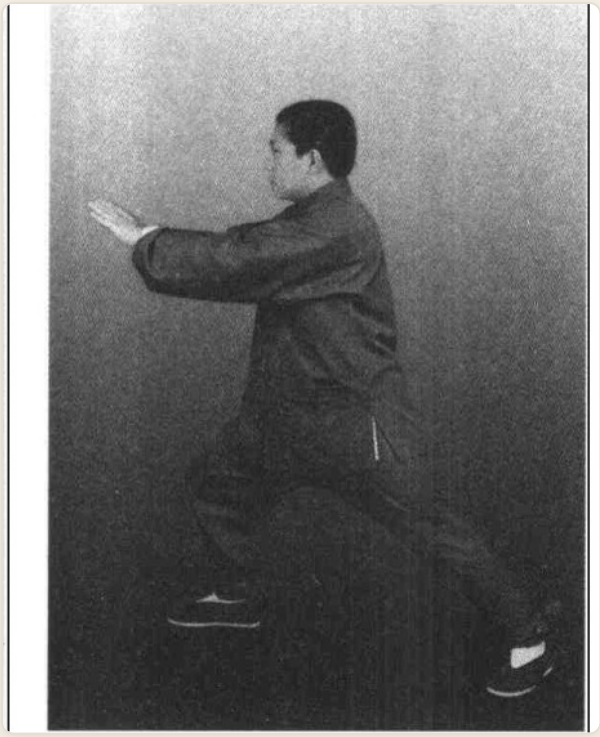
图 137

Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the centre of gravity shifting onto the right leg, the two arms warding out with the turning of the body

图 138

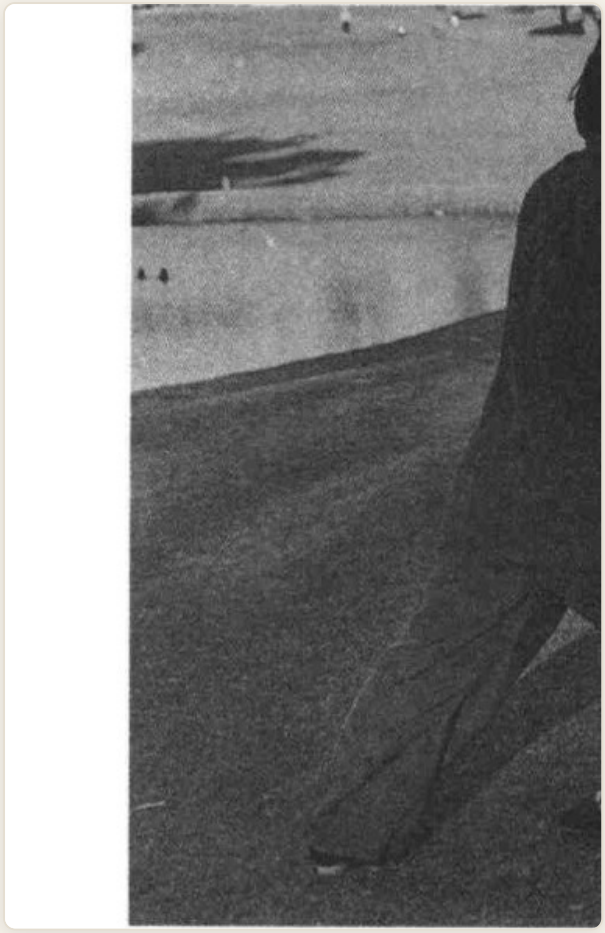
Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the completed posture of the ward-off

图 139



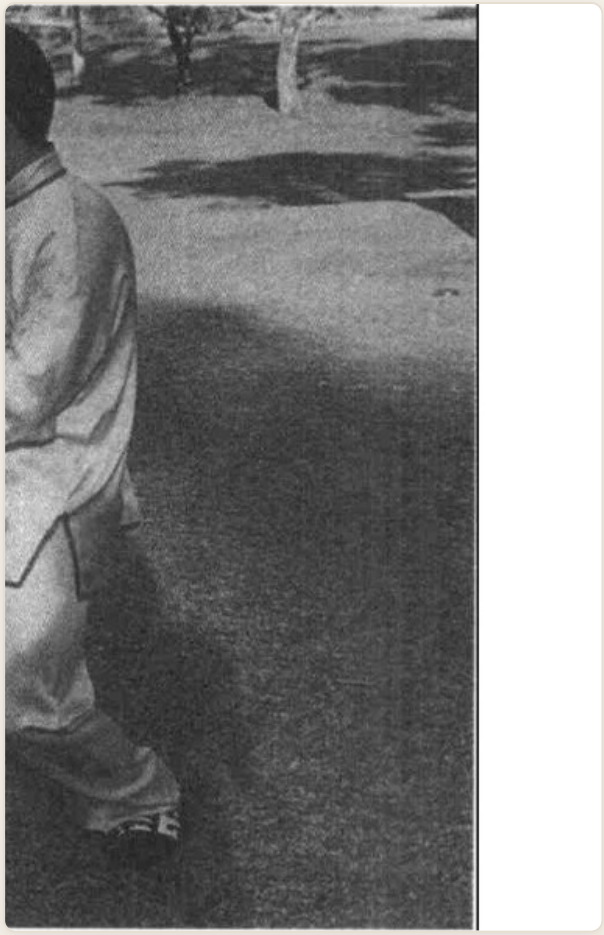
Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the right leg stepping forward, the centre of gravity gradually shifting onto the right leg

图 140



Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the right leg bowing and the left leg pushing to form a right bow stance, the two arms warding out

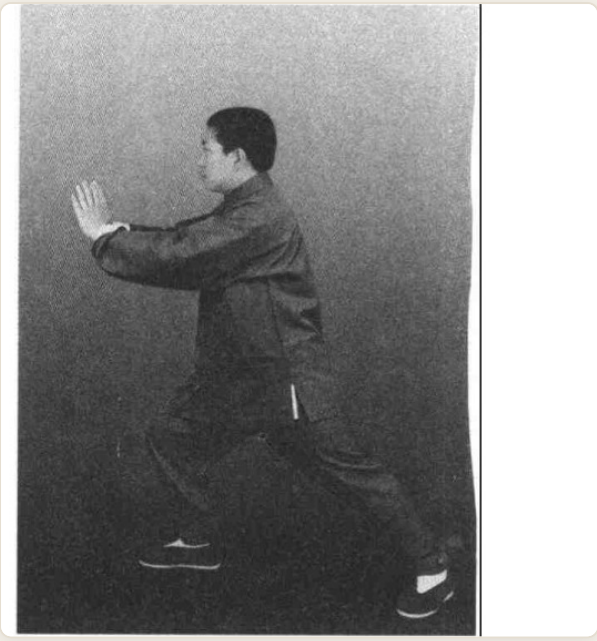
图 141



Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the transitional position of the two arms warding out to the right front with the turning of the body

(There is also on this page a photograph of the push-hands application, which carries no figure number.)

图 142

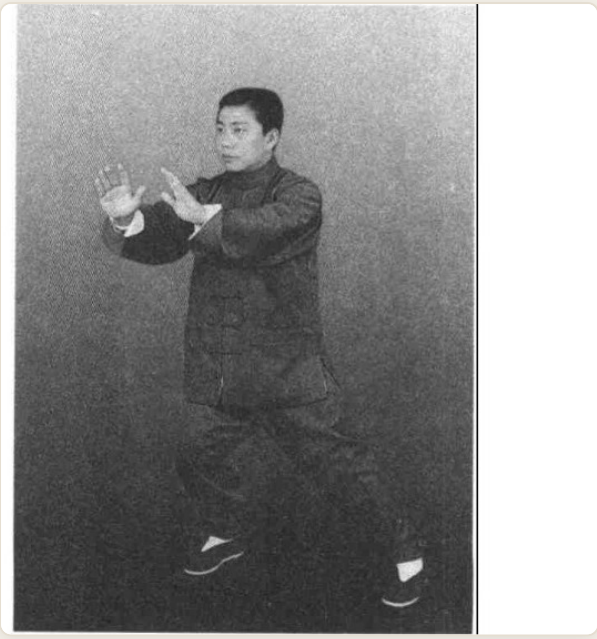


Step Up and Grasp the Bird's Tail: the completed posture of Grasp the Bird's Tail in the right bow stance

Twenty-seventh Posture: Single Whip (Dan Bian)

The same as the fourth posture, Single Whip. See the figures on this and the following pages (the same as the plates of the fourth posture).

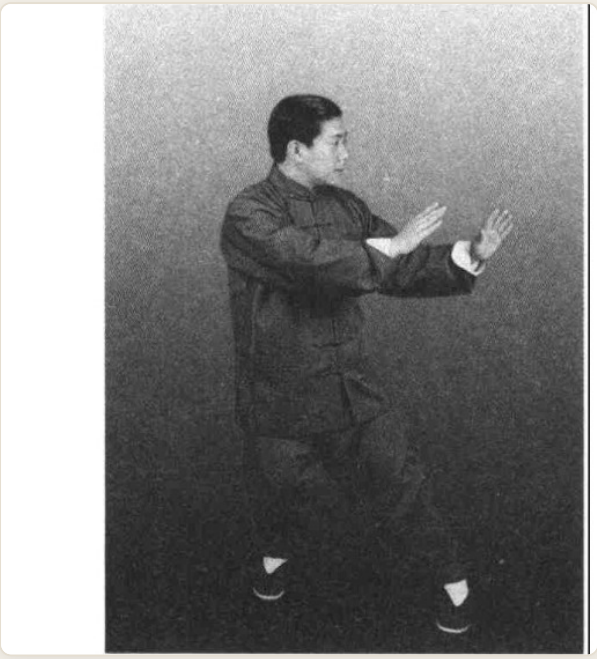
图 143



Single Whip: the two palms separating to left and right, the opening position of the right bow stance

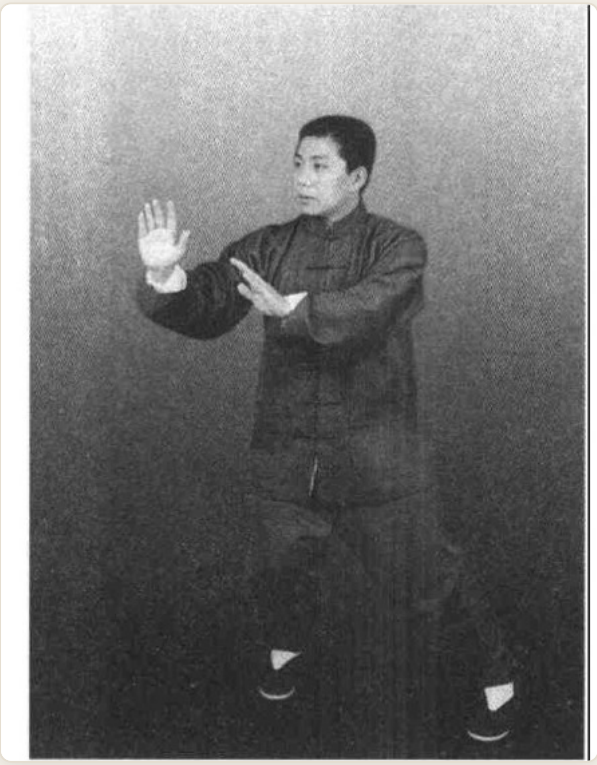
(The body text of this page follows on from the twenty-seventh posture, Single Whip; the upper half holds six further plates of Single Whip — three in the upper row, and three in the lower row, all continuing the Single Whip sequence.)

图 144



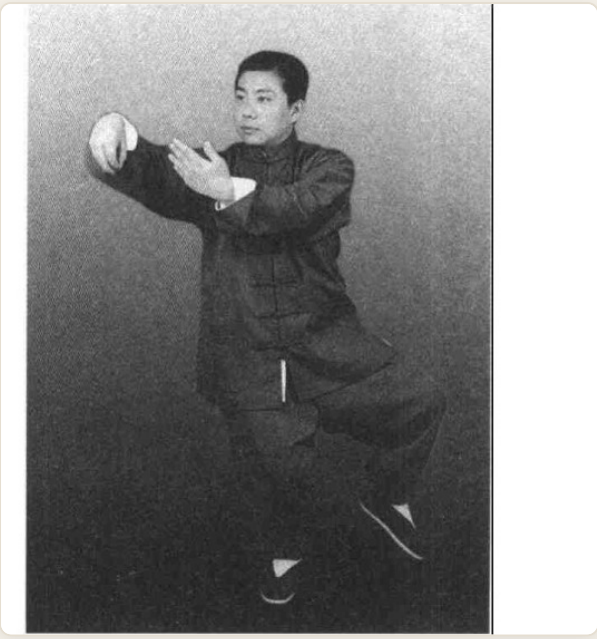
Single Whip: the two palms separating left and right, the transitional position of the right bow stance

图 145



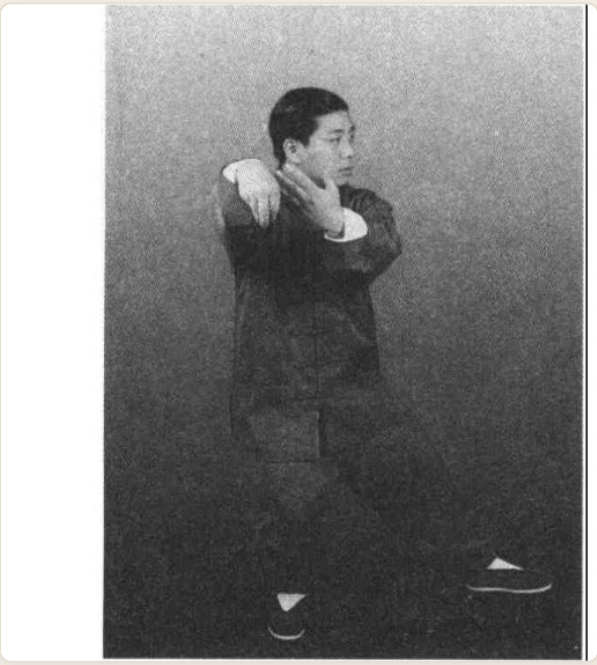
Single Whip: the left palm pushing out forward, the right hand forming the hook hand

图 146



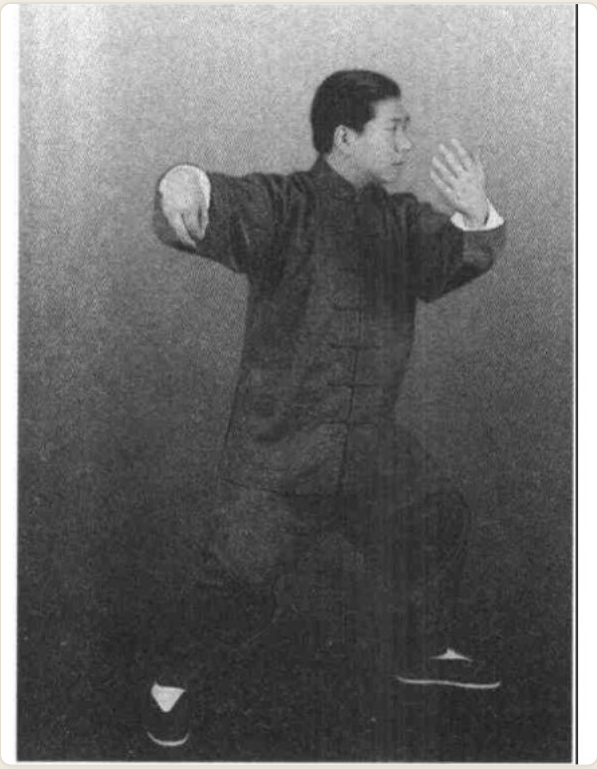
Single Whip: the two palms separating above and below, the left palm pushing forward and the right hook hand to the right rear

图 147A



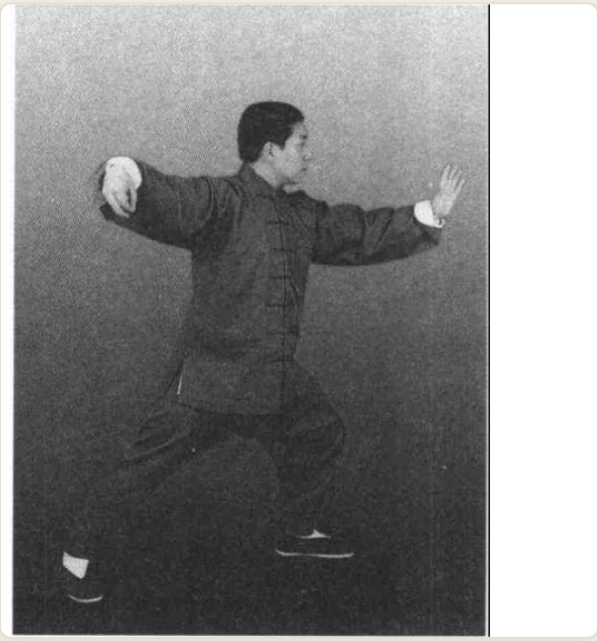
Single Whip: the right foot lifting and drawing in towards the left foot, the two palms withdrawing to cross and enfold

图 147B



Single Whip: the two palms pressing out to the left front, the transitional position of the left bow stance

图 148



Single Whip: the left palm pushing forward and the right hook hand to the right rear, the completed posture of Single Whip

Twenty-eighth Posture: Wave Hands Like Clouds (Yun Shou)

BOOK PAGE 123

I. Application

I. Application

Continuing from the previous posture. If the opponent attacks my chest or ribs with his right hand from the right of my front, I immediately lower my right hand with the palm facing inward, and join the upper side of my wrist (the radial side) to the lower side of the opponent's wrist (the ulnar side), warding from the left upward and rotating to the right; then I turn it downward and move it across to the left, drawing one great circle, like white clouds drifting in the sky, without a break. The left hand at the same time lowers, palm facing down, with the same intent as the right hand. The body also turns with the right wrist, and the gaze follows the wrist, attending as it turns.

the hand and chest turning, the gaze following the wrist as it turns, attending as it turns.

The right foot moves half a step to the left from the right rear side and settles firmly, and the left foot at once steps out one step to the left, the weight shifting left into a horse-riding stance (for an instant). At this moment the two hands have arrived exactly opposite the chest and navel, and then the right foot again becomes empty and moves half a step further in to the left, and the second movement continues. But when changing from empty to full and back in the interwoven turning, there must never be any intent of concavity, convexity, interruption or discontinuity. The subtle use of this posture lies entirely in turning the waist and hips: because the turning can draw along the opponent's root strength, one turns the hand out in response. The learner should savour and grasp this carefully.

The slanting application: when the opponent thrusts straight in with his right palm or right fist, I ward with my right hand, and at the same time immediately hollow the chest and sink onto the back leg, turning the waist and sinking downward to neutralize the force of his incoming energy; then I may use Shoulder or Elbow, or attack out with Press.

BOOK PAGE 124

II. The Course of the Movement

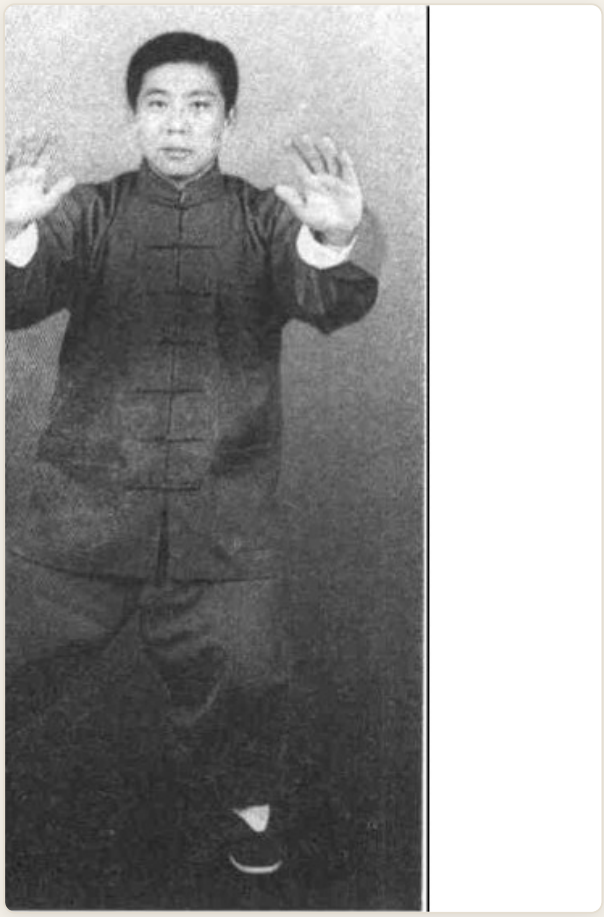
II. The Course of the Movement

1. Turn the waist slightly to the right without changing the weight; turn the left toes inward and set them down firmly, toes pointing forward. At the same time the left palm, following the turning

of the body, bends the arm slightly and sinks the elbow, palm facing down, and moves naturally and very slightly to the right. The right hook hand changes into a palm and arcs down from the right, moving across horizontally at the bottom of the arc to the front of the right abdomen. The gaze attends to the right palm as it moves down (see the first figure at the right-hand side of this page, the second figure at the right-hand side of this page).

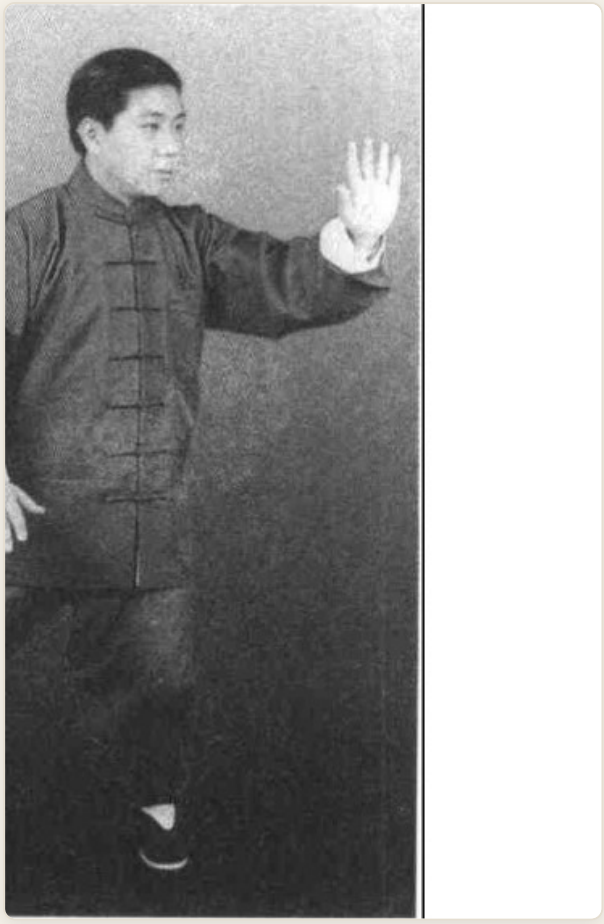
2. The weight gradually shifts entirely to the left leg; the right foot lifts and draws in towards the left (the heel leaving the ground first), the body turns slightly left, and the left palm follows the waist's turning. At the same time it transports out to the left (with a slight arc), and as the arm turns inward the wrist is held upright so that the palm slopes downward and gradually turns to face down. The right palm, following the turning of the body, travels in an arc from the lower right across the front of the abdomen to the left, and as it travels the arm turns outward so that the palm faces inward, and it gradually travels up to the left to near the left wrist. The gaze shifts as the body turns, looking level ahead, and it must attend to the right palm travelling left (see the third figure at the right-hand side of this page).

图 149



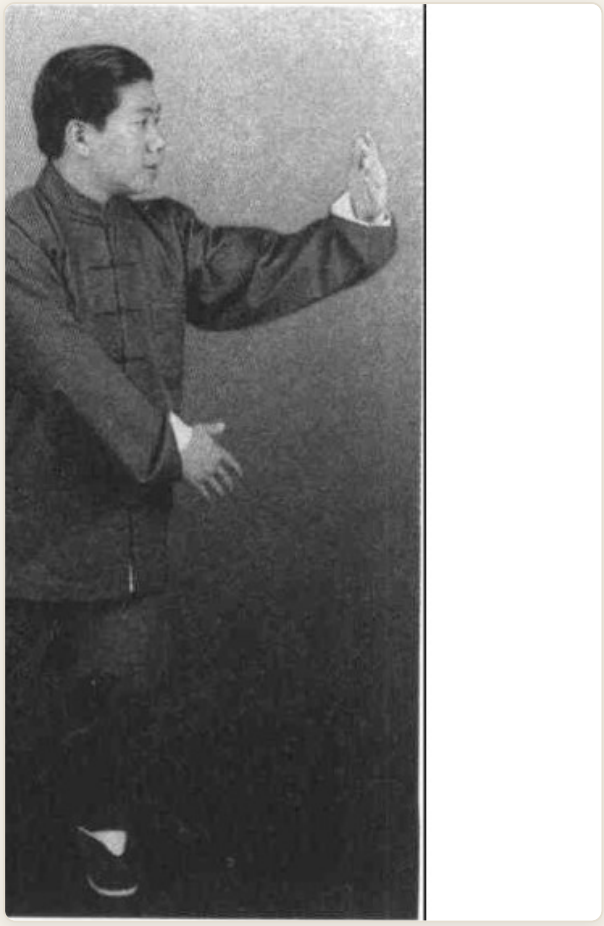
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the right hand changing from the hook hand into a palm and arcing down from the right to the front of the right abdomen

图 150



Wave Hands Like Clouds: the left palm bending the arm and sinking the elbow as the body turns, palm facing down and shifting slightly right

图 151



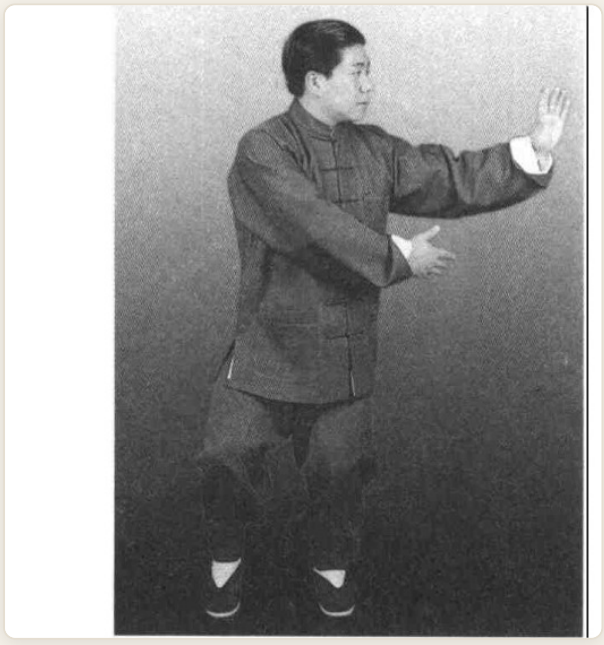
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the right palm travelling in an arc across the front of the abdomen to the left, arriving near the left wrist

3. The left leg continues to squat down and "sends" the right leg down (the right foot half a step towards the left), the toes touching the ground first, and as the weight gradually shifts right the whole foot is set down firmly; the two feet are about a shoulder's width apart, parallel and facing forward, and the left foot at once becomes empty. At the same time the body turns slightly right. The right palm, following the waist's turning, travels in an arc from the left upward and to the right (the fingers level with the shoulder), the palm still facing inward. This is joining the upper side of my right wrist to the lower side of the opponent's wrist, rotating from the left downward and then upward again, using the strength of the turning waist and hips to turn out to the right, so as to draw along the opponent's root strength. The left palm at the same time arcs down from the left and towards the right, and as it travels the arm turns slightly outward so that the palm gradually turns to face inward (slanting slightly upward). The two hands have travelled up and down to exactly opposite the chest and navel, the right hand above and the left hand below. The gaze accompanies the turning of the body, attending to the right palm travelling right (see the first figure at the left-hand side of this page).

4. The weight gradually shifts entirely to the right leg; the left foot lifts (the heel leaving the ground first) and the body continues to turn slightly right, and at the same time the right palm, following the turning of the body, arcs to the right and downward, and as it travels the arm turns inward so that the palm gradually turns to face down. The left palm, crossing the front of the abdomen, continues to travel to the upper right, drawing near to the right wrist to the right. The gaze attends to the right palm travelling right (see the second figure at the left-hand side of this page).

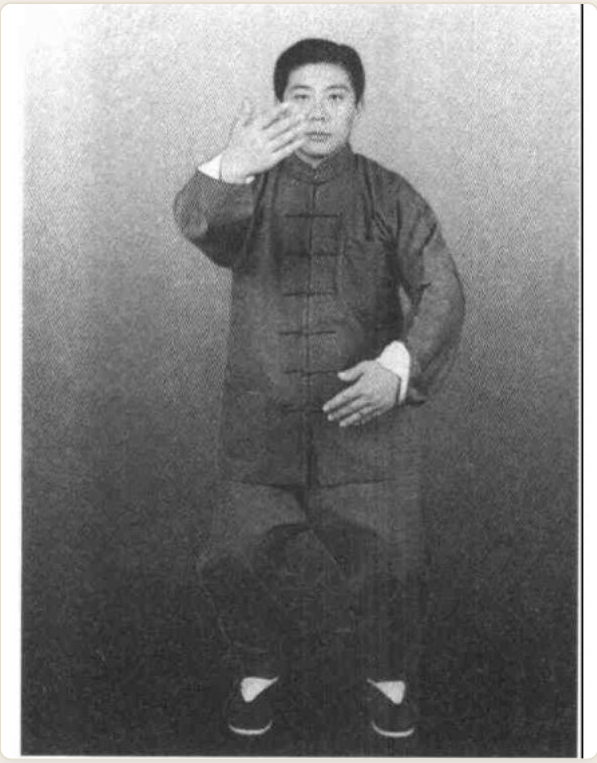
5. Repeat from the start of movement two. The left foot strides half a step across to the left, the toes touching the ground first, and as the weight gradually shifts left the whole foot is set down firmly, toes pointing forward; at the same time the body gradually turns left, and the left palm, following the turning of the body, continues from the right upward past the face (the fingers level with the eyebrows), travelling to the left. This is joining the upper side of my left wrist to the lower side of the opponent's wrist, rotating from the left downward and then upward again, using the strength of the turning waist and hips to turn out to the left, so as to draw along the opponent's root strength (the application is the same as for the right hand). The right palm continues to travel in an arc from the right downward and to the left, and as it travels the arm turns slightly outward so that the palm gradually turns to face inward (slanting slightly upward) and travels to the front of the abdomen. The two hands have travelled up and down to exactly opposite the chest and navel, the left hand above and the right hand below. The gaze shifts as the body turns, looking level, and must attend to the left palm travelling left (see the third figure at the left-hand side of this page, the fourth figure at the left-hand side of this page).

图 152



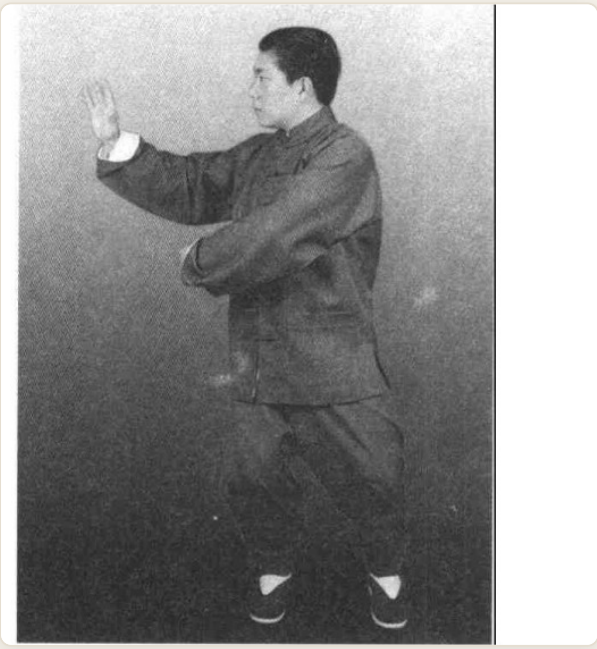
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the two hands travelling up and down to exactly opposite the chest and navel, the right hand above and the left hand below

图 153



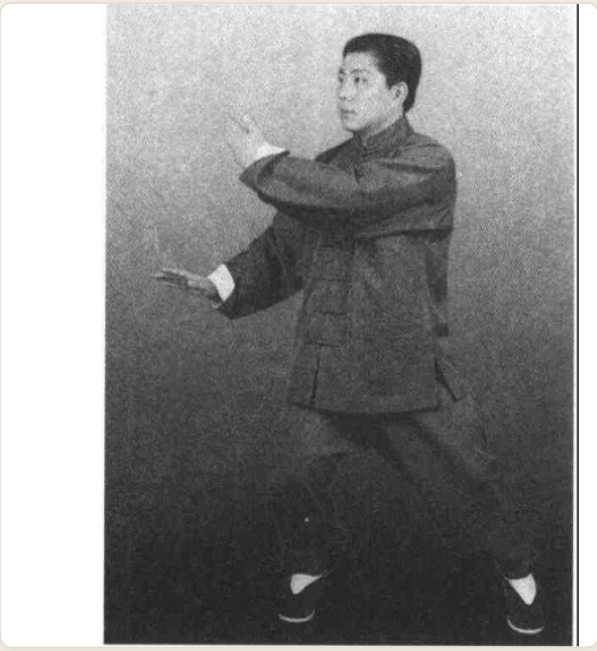
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the right palm arcing to the right and downward while the left palm travels up and right across the front of the abdomen

图 154



Wave Hands Like Clouds: the left palm travelling out to the left from the right upward past the face, the fingers level with the eyebrows

图 155



Wave Hands Like Clouds: the two hands travelling to exactly opposite the chest and navel, the left hand above and the right below

6. The weight gradually shifts entirely to the left leg; the right foot lifts to the right and towards towards the left (the heel leaving the ground first), while the body continues to turn left and the left palm continues to travel in an arc from above, downward to the left. As it travels the arm turns inward so that the palm gradually turns to face down. The right palm, following the turning of the body, continues across the front of the abdomen to the left, and travels in an arc from below upward to near the left wrist. The gaze attends to the left palm travelling left (see the first figure of the six at the foot of the next page).

7. Repeat the movement: the three plates at the foot of the next page repeat, in order, the third, first and second plates at the sides of this page.

8. Repeat movement three: the three plates at the foot of the next page repeat, in order, the third and fourth plates at the left-hand side of this page and the first plate of the previous repetition; and the three plates at the head of the following page plus the plate at its left-hand side again repeat the earlier plates in turn. In order to increase the amount of exercise, "Wave Hands Like Clouds" may also be done as three, five, or seven movements.

But the number must be odd, and "Step Back and Repulse the Monkey" must likewise be done three, five, or seven times accordingly. Otherwise, when one comes to the closing and gathering up, one will not be able to return to the original place.

III. Essential Points

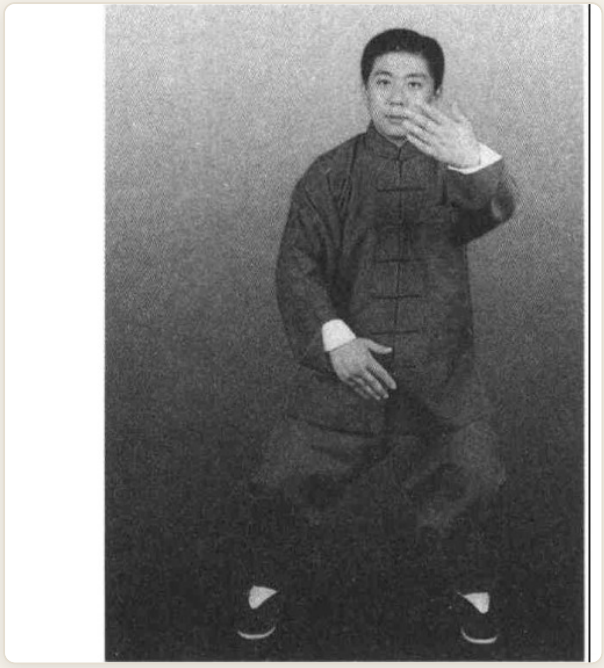
III. Essential Points

1. "Wave Hands Like Clouds" requires unbroken continuity, with intent and without force. One "Wave Hands Like Clouds" must follow another, endlessly continuous, going round and round without end. What the boxing treatises say — "like the long Yangtze and the great sea, rolling on and on without cease, threaded through as one breath" — means exactly that there must be no place of pause in the middle of the movement.

2. The two feet must not be double-weighted — that is, the two feet must not bear the body's weight on the ground at the same time. As soon as the heel of the descending foot has set down firmly, the other foot's heel must immediately leave the ground, rising and falling in turn like a see-saw, so that the two feet alternate without ever pausing.

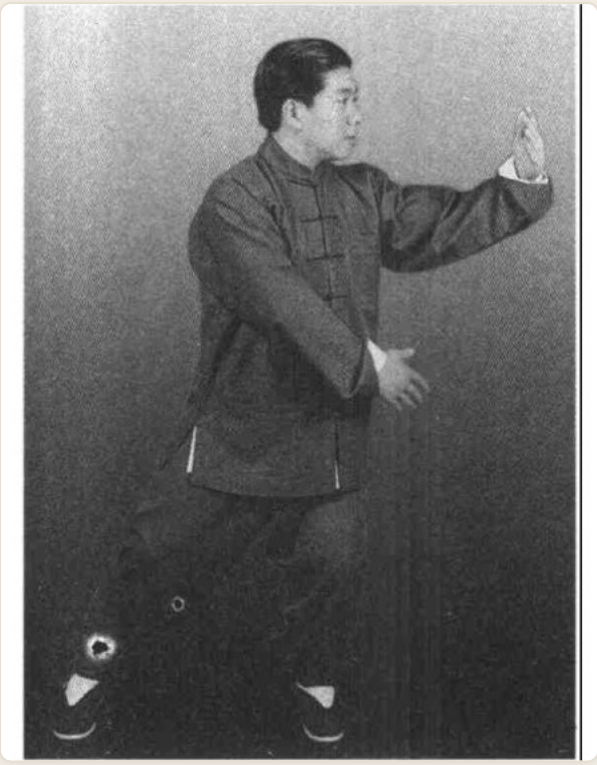
3. The circling of the hands must take the turning of the waist and hips as its foundation: the waist is like an axle, the four limbs like wheels. The waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower body, and it plays the principal role in the changes of the whole body's movement, in adjusting and steadying the centre of gravity, and in driving the jin power out to every part of the limbs. Therefore the turning must take the waist and spine as its axis and turn slowly; one must not swing about at random, the upper body must not lean or slant, must not stoop forward or lean back, and one must maintain "the tailbone centred and upright."

图 156



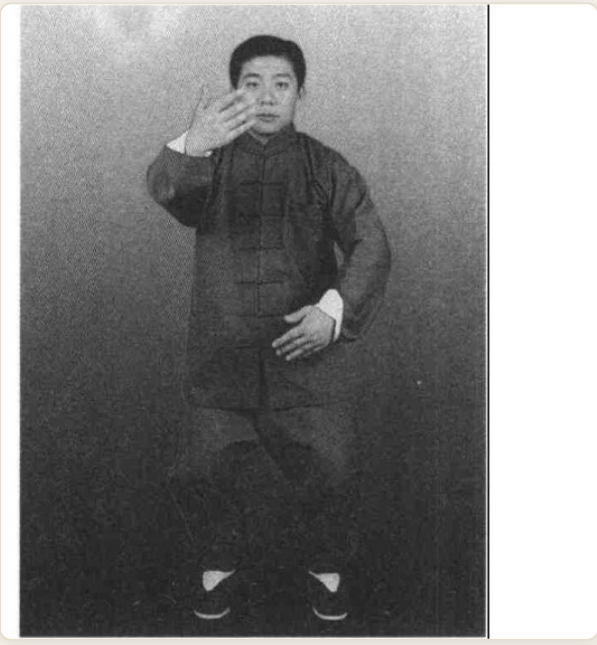
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the left palm travelling in an arc from above, downward to the left with the palm gradually turning to face down, while the right palm travels up and left across the front of the abdomen to near the left wrist

图 157



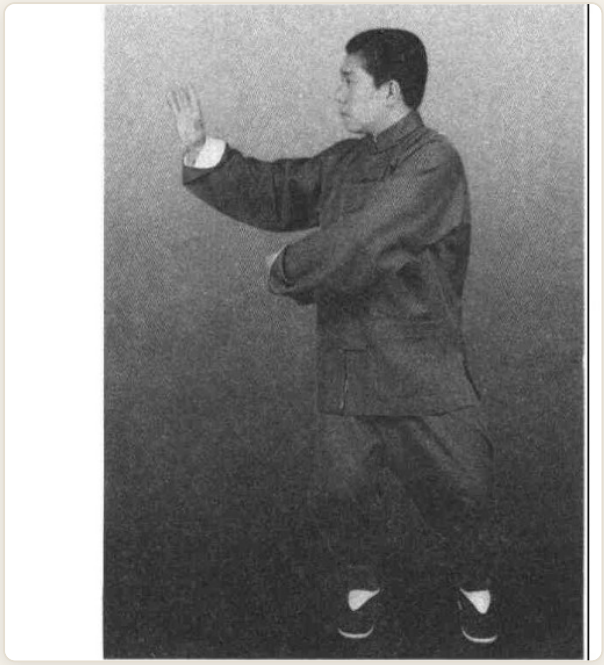
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the right palm travelling in an arc across the front of the abdomen to the left, to near the left wrist (the same as figure 151).

图 158



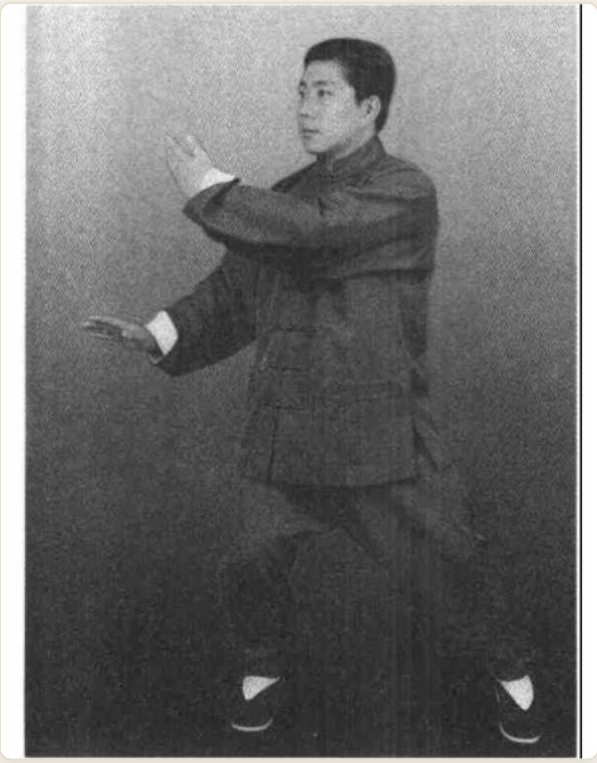
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the two hands travelling up and down until level with the chest and navel, the right hand above and the left below (the same as figure 152).

图 159



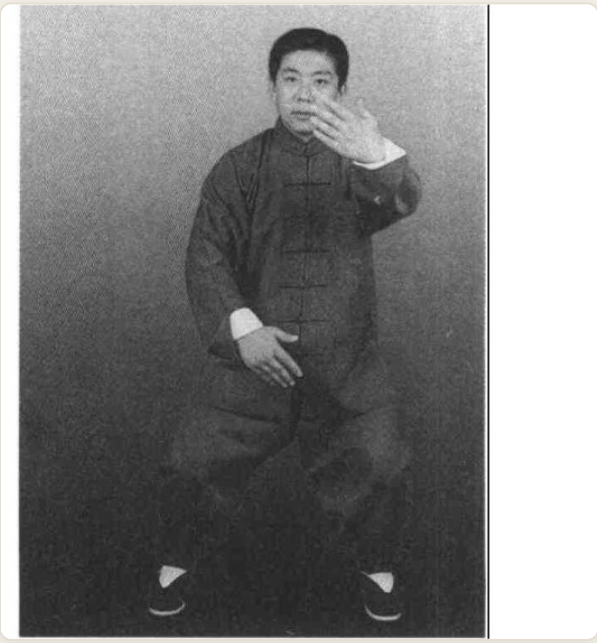
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the right palm arcing right and downward while the left palm travels up and right across the front of the abdomen (the same as figure 153).

图 160



Wave Hands Like Clouds: the left palm travelling from right to left, upward past the face, the fingers level with the eyebrows (the same as figure 154).

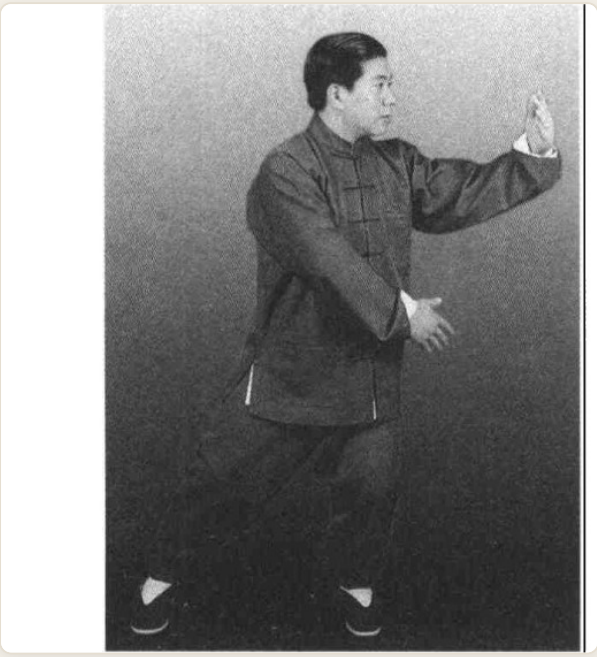
图 161



Wave Hands Like Clouds: the two hands travelling until level with the chest and navel, the left hand above and the right below (the same as figure 155).

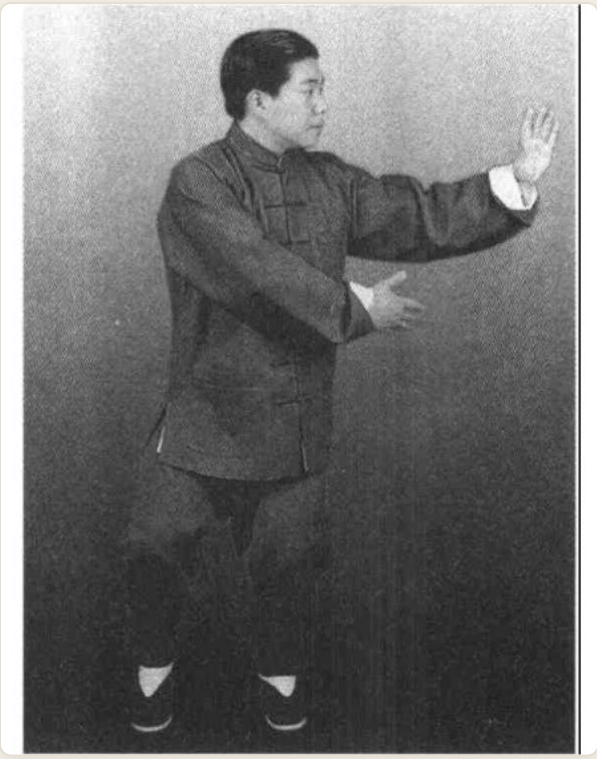
4. The two arms must travel with the waist: turning left, the left hand's upward scooping leads; turning right, the right hand's upward scooping leads. When the left hand leads, the right hand follows; when the right hand leads, the left hand follows — one up, one down, one left, one right, closely coordinated better still.

图 162



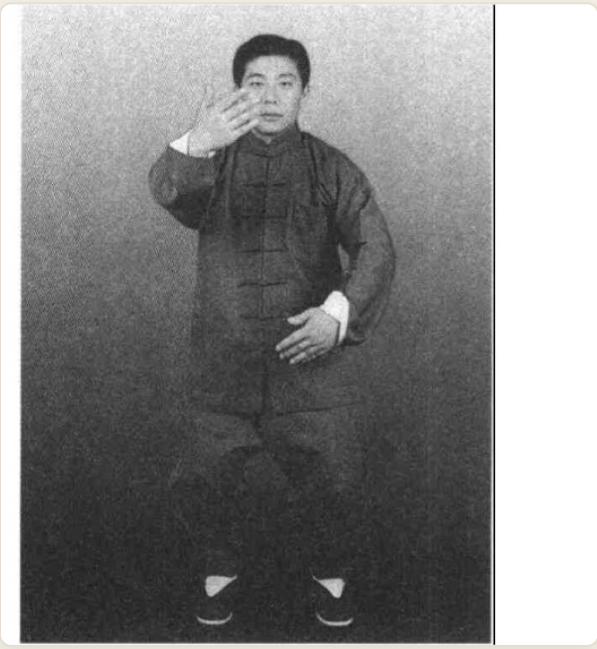
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the two hands travelling to opposite the chest and navel, the left hand above and the right below — a position of the repeated movement

图 163



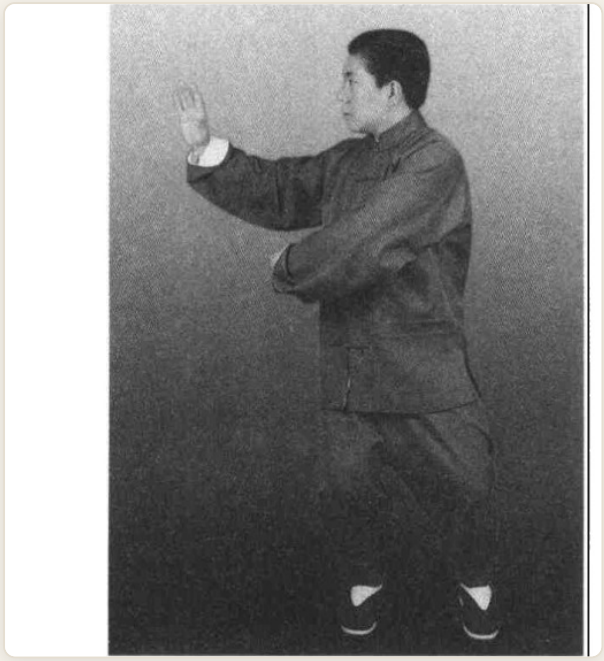
Wave Hands Like Clouds: the right palm travelling in an arc across the front of the abdomen to the left, arriving near the left wrist

图 164



Wave Hands Like Clouds: the left palm travelling out to the left from the right upward past the face, the fingers level with the eyebrows

图 165



Wave Hands Like Clouds: the right hand changing from the hook hand into a palm and arcing down from the right to the front of the right abdomen — the closing position of "Wave Hands Like Clouds"

Twenty-ninth Posture: Single Whip (Continuing from the twenty-seventh posture, Single Whip; both the application and the course of the movement are identical.) (See the figures on the following pages.)

circling without scattering or stagnating; when the turn reaches the top the elbow must not lift, and the forearm must ward loosely and keep circling. The two arms must maintain their arcs.

5. There must be "evenness from form to form". When the left leg steps out the movement must be slow and set down lightly; when the right leg lifts it must rise slowly and draw in towards the left, to a shoulder's width, and must not be sometimes fast and sometimes slow.

6. Every movement of Yang-style Taijiquan is constituted by a circle — hence the saying, "a marvellous hand is one movement, and one movement is a taiji." Within this circle are contained the two forces of yin and yang: there must be softness and there must be firmness, emptiness and fullness, firmness and softness assisting each other, emptiness and fullness interpenetrating. The carrying out of its movements always has the appearance of drawing circles and travelling along arcs; it never goes straight out and straight back — this too is a characteristic of Taijiquan. "Wave Hands Like Clouds" is a typical movement of this kind, and it plays an important part in raising the standard of the techniques of "continuous adhering and following" and "drawing in to make the opponent fall into emptiness."

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. The circling of the hands must be led by the waist, and the waist and hands must not come apart. When the opponent uses his right hand to strike my chest or ribs from the right of my front, my right wrist receives his wrist, turning up and over from below, to the left and then to the right; this must be coordinated with the turning of the waist and hips for the power to be obtained.

2. The two feet stand parallel, about a shoulder's width apart, neither too wide nor too narrow, and the two feet must not turn into the inward splay or the outward splay. The feet are the foundation of the stance forms and the stepping methods; if the foundation is unsteady, then at the least deviation the stance forms and stepping methods are certain to go awry.

(This page carries one unnumbered push-hands photograph at the foot; it has no figure number and no caption.)

3. There must be no double-weighting, for double-weighting makes one sluggish. The left foot supports while the right foot lifts and draws in towards the left; when the right foot squats down and the right heel drops, the left heel must lift at the same moment, otherwise it is double-weighting.

4. When the two arms circle they must not be straightened but must form an arc, and the distance from the body must be appropriate. If the arms are too far from the body they will be strained straight; if too close they will "deflate".

5. The two hands must have ward-off jin; they must not go slack, but neither may they use stiff force.

6. The movements must be continuous — this is the requirement of "Wave Hands Like Clouds" that stands out most. The circling of the hands must be like white clouds moving across the sky, without a break.

7. The shoulders must be relaxed, but not relaxed to excess such that they become "empty" or "loose".

8. The hand circling below must embody the action requirement of "scooping".

V. Common Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Common Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Fault: "double-weighting", that is, the two feet bearing the weight at the same time. The principal cause is an insufficient grasp of the clear division of empty and full. "When one side is heavy it follows; when double-weighted it is sluggish. One constantly sees those with several years of pure practice who cannot transform, and in every case they end up being controlled by others: the fault of double-weighting has not been understood." Therefore one foot must be on the ground bearing the whole body's weight, so that the empty foot can be light, nimble and lively. Correction: as the right heel sets down, the left heel must leave the ground at the same moment.

2. Fault: the foot moves sideways while the two hands move up and down, and the beginner's body tends to keep facing straight forward (south) without the waist and hips turning. The principal cause is that the movements of the limbs do not take the waist as their guiding principle and as their hub. If the waist is used properly it helps both to maintain the balance of the whole body and to keep the circulation of internal jin full and concentrated. Otherwise, the movement that moves the hands without moving the waist is a tree without roots, and internal jin cannot travel from the waist and spine out to the limbs — whereas the whole subtle use of "Wave Hands Like Clouds" lies in turning the waist and hips. Otherwise, when my wrist joins the opponent's wrist and turns up and over, it will appear powerless. But the waist must not turn too far either: some turn the waist and hips so much that they reach 90°, almost turning to due east or due west, and thus the body and limbs are thus overdone, which on the contrary gives the opponent a chance to attack. Correction: as the two hands and waist and hips turn the body, it is best to take an oblique angle a little to the east, or towards the south-west.

3. Fault: the two feet turning into the inward or outward splay. The principal cause of the inward splay of the two feet is that when the left foot steps out sideways the heel is pressed out too far; the outward splay comes from the left foot stepping out to the left without the heel pressing slightly outward, while the right foot, drawing in to the left, is not properly set straight. The direction the toes point governs how far the hip joints open and how great the amount of exercise is; therefore the outward turning and inward drawing of the toes, and the leftward and rightward turning of the heels, must all be clear and orderly in their empty and full, principal and subordinate. Correction: in "Wave Hands Like Clouds" the toes of both feet should point straight forward. Take special care that when the left foot steps out to the left, after the ball of the foot has landed you must let the left heel gradually press out towards the left, pressing and setting down as you go until the whole sole is firmly planted; in this way the toes will point straight forward and the requirement of the two feet being parallel will be met.

4. Fault: the movement is uneven, sometimes fast and sometimes slow, which is especially obvious when the left foot is about to land after stepping out to the left and when the right foot has just lifted. The principal cause is that when the strength of the legs and of the waist and hips

is insufficient the speed suddenly increases, and thus the whole movement becomes uneven in pace. The movement must, within its continuous and threaded arc, be complete and rounded, neither hurried nor sluggish, neither concave nor convex, with no defects and no sharp corners. The changes must be light, nimble and lively, so that emptiness and fullness can interchange and turn. Correction: practise more to strengthen the leg power step by step, and take care that when the left leg steps out the right leg is set solid, and when the right leg lifts the left leg is set solid; only when empty and full are clearly divided can the movement be light and nimble.

BOOK PAGE 130

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Explain the essential points. 2. Demonstrate the movement; demonstrate the application. 3. First practise it broken down; then immediately follow with whole-movement practice, alternating fast practice and slow practice. 4. The two hands hang loosely. The two feet stand a shoulder's width apart, in a half squat. The left foot lifts and steps out to the left, and the weight gradually shifts onto the left foot. The right leg lifts and draws in to the left, setting down at a shoulder's width; the weight gradually shifts onto the right foot, the left foot lifts and steps out to the left ... practise in this continuous way to master the leg movements well — empty and full, the two feet parallel and pointing forward, the centre of gravity not rising and falling, and so on.

5. The two feet stand a shoulder's width apart, in a slight squat, the right hand above and the left hand below. The left hand moves in an arc from below to the right, upward and to the left, while the right hand turns its palm outward and moves from the right downward, turning the palm inward and travelling across the front of the abdomen to the left (palm facing inward). Immediately afterwards the left palm turns outward, and from the left it turns downward and inward and travels across the front of the abdomen to the right, while the right hand goes upward and to the right. At this moment the two hands are again one above and one below in front of the body, returning to the starting position — that is, one movement of "Wave Hands Like Clouds" is completed. Practise continuously in this way to master the hand movements well — the path of the hands, the direction the palms face, the height of the hands, when to turn the palm, and so on.

6. Whole-movement practice must follow on closely, otherwise a split will form; one should follow the teacher's movements at a slower pace, one movement at a time, and so learn.

7. The improvement of empty and full may be undertaken once whole-movement practice is basically mastered. The left leg is set solid and the right leg lifts; when the right leg, having drawn in to the left, is about to land, the left leg must "send" the right leg down. When the left leg

steps out to the left, the right leg must be firmly set solid, and the weight must not be moved before the left heel has landed.

BOOK PAGE 131

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. "Wave Hands Like Clouds" should be performed as 3–5 continuous movements. Its distinguishing feature is "unbroken connection", threaded through movement after movement, so that at the moment of seeming to stop and not stopping, the opportunity for the next movement arises of itself. Therefore there must be no place of pause; the inside and outside, above and below, left and right, front and back must be coordinated as one, so that above and below follow each other and "one breath runs through". For this reason the movement of "Wave Hands Like Clouds" must be continuous, rounded and lively.

2. "Wave Hands Like Clouds" makes high demands on the two hands: it requires that "the whole movement depend on the two hands turning without leaving the centre line." The left hand governs the left half of the body and the right hand the right half, with the nose and navel as the centre line between them, so that even in the circular turning the movement does not leave the centre line. The arms must be relaxed, soft, rounded and lively, with firmness and softness assisting each other; they must rotate along arcs — across and straight, with and against, rising and falling, extending and withdrawing must all travel along curved lines — and they must turn with the waist and hips, and the two hands must not be allowed to go slack.

3. This movement should be done 3–5 times, and throughout those 3–5 movements the frame must not be sometimes high and sometimes low — that is, the centre of gravity must not rise and fall. The stepping out of the feet and the lifting of the right leg must both be light and nimble, and this requires that throughout the whole movement the centre of gravity stay always on one level, without rising or falling. If the centre of gravity rises and falls, it will lead to uneven pace in the movement.

attend to the gradual change when empty and full interchange.

4. The gaze in "Wave Hands Like Clouds": the beginner tends to watch the palm as it turns, which is of course wrong. But some simply look straight ahead, which is also wrong: the method of the eyes is to follow the movement of the principal hand while looking level ahead. The gaze must first look ahead in the direction one is intending to go, and then the body method, hand method and step method follow.

Twenty-ninth Posture: Single Whip

I. Application

I. Application

The same as the fourth posture, Single Whip.

II. The Course of the Movement

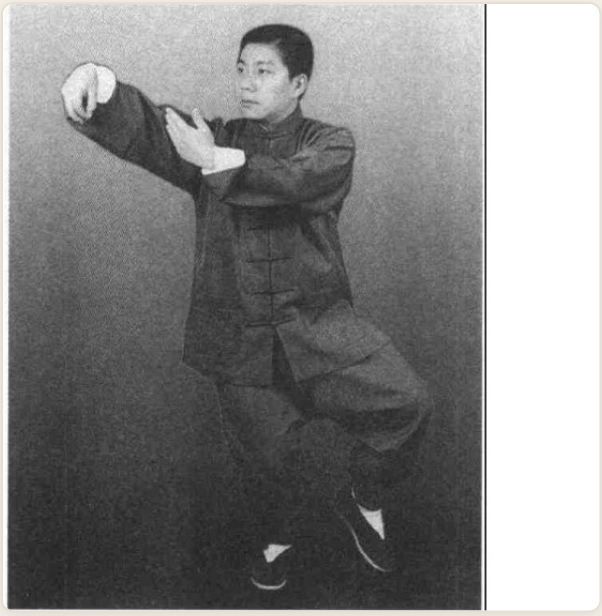
The body continues to turn slightly right, and the weight gradually shifts entirely onto the right leg; the left leg lifts. At the same time the right palm, following the turning of the body, extends slightly to the right oblique, and as it extends the arm turns inward so that the palm gradually turns to face down, and the five fingers droop and gather together to form the hook hand; the left palm continues to travel to the upper right, drawing near the right wrist. The gaze attends to the right palm travelling right, and attends to the left palm travelling left (see the figure at the right-hand side of this page).

The movements that follow are the same as movement four of the fourth posture, "Single Whip"; see the three figures in the bottom row of this page (the same as the plates of the fourth posture).

The essential points and so on are all the same as those of the fourth posture.

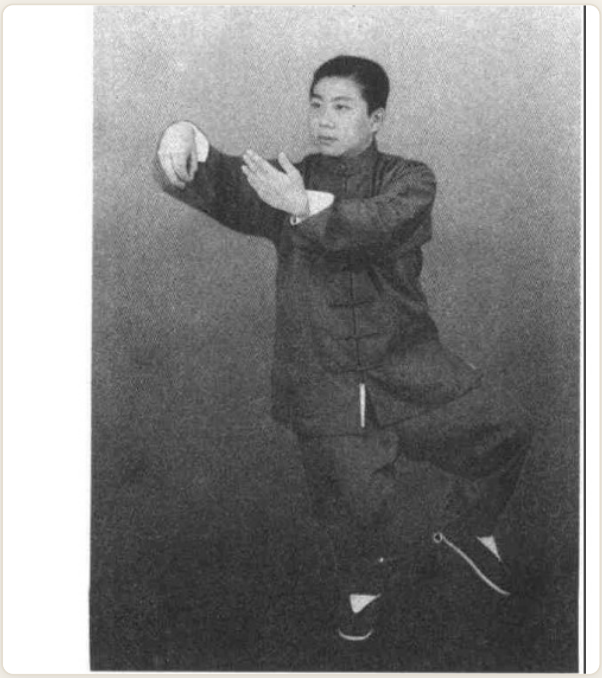
(This page carries four plates in all: one at the right-hand side of the body text, and a bottom row of three.)

图 166



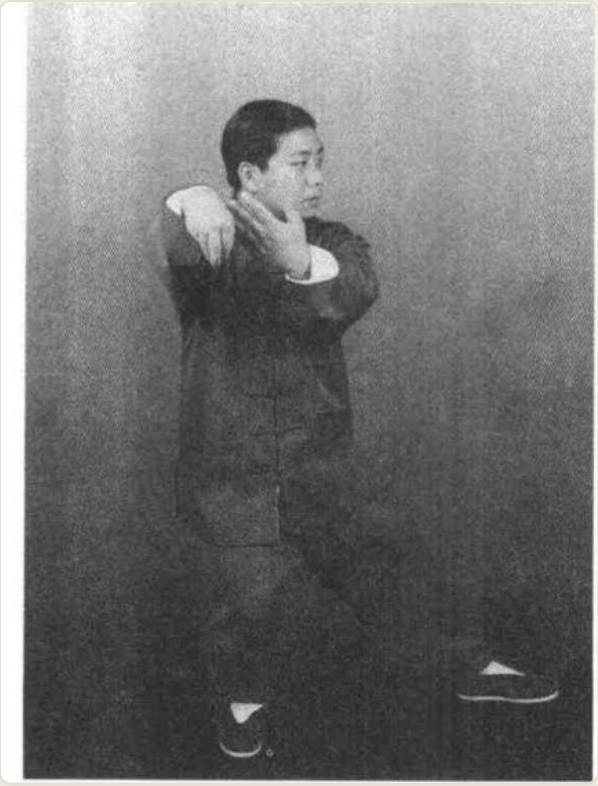
Single Whip: the right palm extending slightly to the right oblique as the body turns, the five fingers drooping and gathering to form the hook hand, the left palm travelling up and right to near the right wrist

图 167



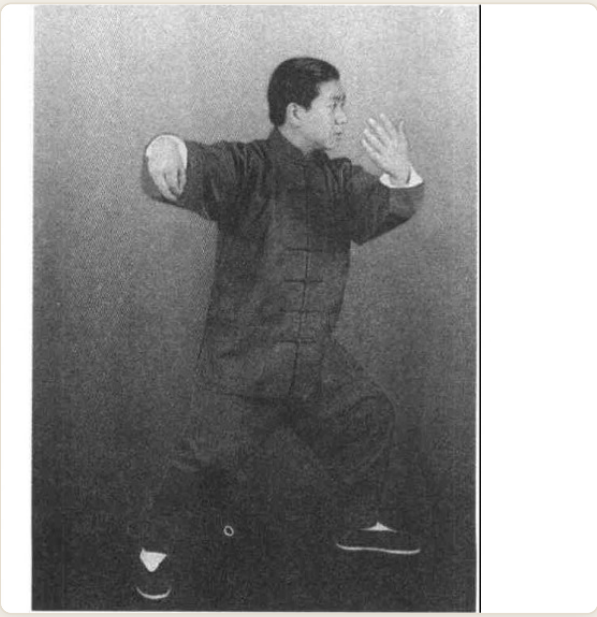
Single Whip: the left palm travelling out to the left past the face, the arm rotating inward, the palm facing forward

图 168



Single Whip: the left palm pressing out obliquely forward and to the left, forming a left bow stance with the two arms at about 135°

图 169



Single Whip: the front view of the settled posture of Single Whip

(The left-hand column of this page holds three plates, stacked top to bottom, showing the course of this posture.)

Thirtieth Posture: High Pat on Horse (Gao Tan Ma)

BOOK PAGE 133

I. Application

I. Application

Continuing from the previous posture, Single Whip. If the opponent's left hand passes over my left wrist, I at once loosen the left wrist slightly, palm facing up, and fold his wrist down and gather it back towards my breast. At the same time the left foot is drawn back, the toes touching the ground, the waist relaxed and the chest hollowed, the right knee slightly bent and set solid; then the right hand is turned round from the rear, upward and forward, and the palm probes towards the opponent's face. The eyes look forward, the spine is slightly raised, with the intent of probing and extending forward.

II. The Course of the Movement

1. The weight gradually shifts to the right leg; the left toes lift naturally as the weight moves back, the chest is hollowed and the back raised, and at the same time the right hook hand changes into a palm, the right elbow bends, and it moves in an arc to the front of the right shoulder; the left arm rotates outward so that the palm gradually turns to slant upward. The gaze attends to the turning over of the left palm (see the first figure in the left-hand column of this page).

2. The weight shifts entirely onto the right leg; the left foot is drawn back and set down half a step inward, the toes touching the ground, and the right leg at the same time gradually straightens up (the knee still slightly bent), forming a high left empty stance; the body gradually turns slightly left (facing east), and as the body turns the right palm arcs forward, passing slightly to the left over the upper side of the left wrist. The fingers point obliquely to the left front, the palm facing down, at eyebrow height; the left palm arcs down under the lower side of the right wrist and withdraws to the front of the upper left abdomen, the fingers pointing obliquely to the right front, the palm facing up. The eyes look level ahead, and the gaze must attend to the right palm probing forward (see the second and third figures in the left-hand column of this page).

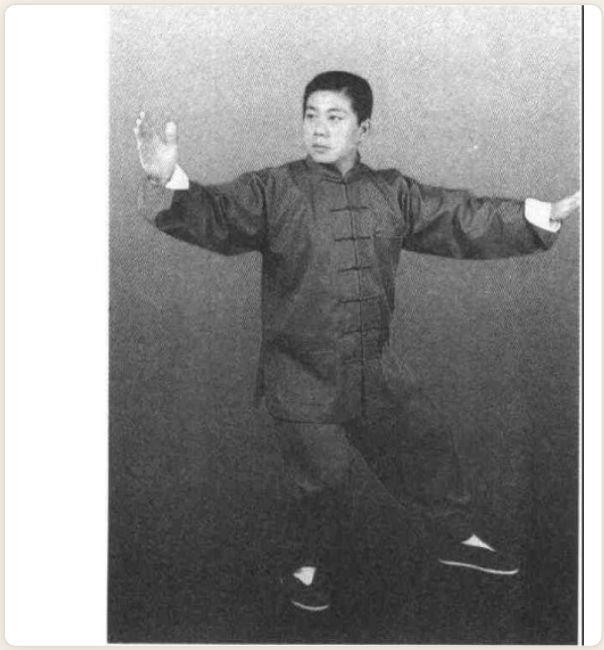
III. Essential Points

1. The weight gradually shifts to the right leg, which must be set solid, and the left hip joint gradually draws inward to lead the left leg up. At this moment the upper body must not stoop forward or lean back.

2. As soon as the left foot has left the ground and is drawn back, the right leg gradually straightens up; at this moment the spine is relaxed and sunk, upright; the breath sinks to the lower abdomen and the crotch jin sinks down; the power at the sole of the foot seems to take root in the ground; and the point at the crown of the head must naturally be lifted, with the sense of rising to the heavens. This is the practice of "empty the collar, lift the crown, sink the breath to the elixir field" and "lift the crotch and carry the crown".

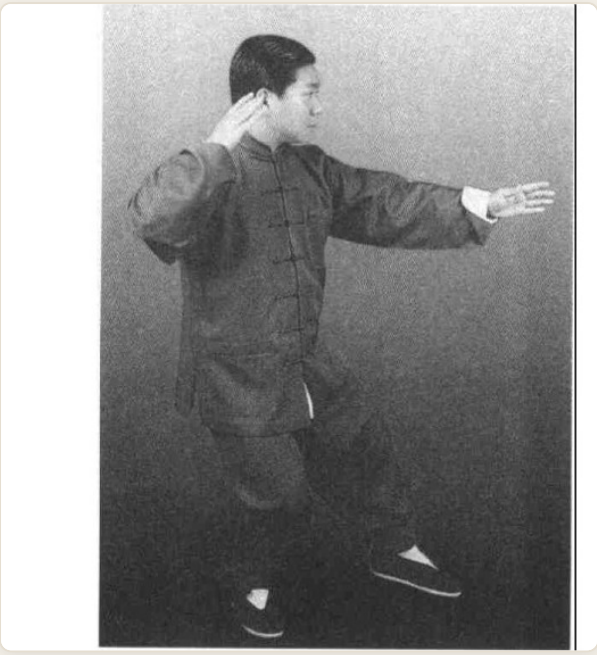
3. The knee joint of the right leg is bent and not straight; the sole of the foot is set flat and solidly on the ground, its power seeming to take root in the ground, while the power rises from the heel and the intent turns upward.

图 170



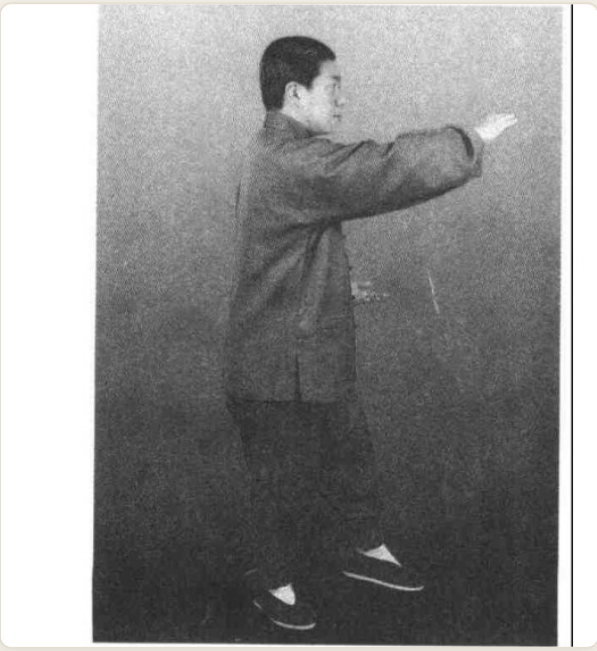
High Pat on Horse: the right hook hand changes into a palm and moves, with the elbow bent, in an arc to the front of the right shoulder, while the left arm rotates outward and the palm turns over

图 171



High Pat on Horse: the right palm arcs slightly left and probes forward over the upper side of the left wrist, while the left palm withdraws downward under the lower side of the right wrist

图 172



High Pat on Horse: the left palm withdrawn to the front of the upper left abdomen, the right palm probing forward at eyebrow height, forming a high left empty stance

4. The right arm extends forward, the intent far-reaching and the jin long, the elbow joint bent and not straight — this is used to strengthen the arm's sinking jin. The foot jin presses down and the hand jin issues forward: this has the meaning of the two hands and two feet lengthening against each other, seeking straightness within the curve.

5. When the right arm probes forward the shoulder must not be shrugged; the shoulder must be relaxed and sunk. In this way the arm's extending and withdrawing, winding and coiling can follow one's intention.

6. When the right hand probes forward the fingers must not point forward, otherwise the meaning of "seating the wrist" is lost.

7. The waist must be lifted, but not lifted stiffly upward, otherwise the flexibility of the waist's rotation will be affected; nor may the chest be thrust out or the back arched.

BOOK PAGE 134

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. When the left foot is drawn back the right leg must be set solid; the sole of the left foot must not scrape the ground as it is drawn back.

2. After the left foot has been drawn back it must not be fully straightened, nor may the right knee be fully straightened. The knee must be slightly bent and the right leg set solid.

3. When the right hand probes forward, the chest must be hollowed and the back raised, with the intent of advancing — but this is not shrugging the shoulders.

4. "The source moves in the waist and spine, the jin penetrates to the four extremities." Both the upper and lower limbs must carry jin. The left hand gathers back towards the breast and the right hand seats the wrist and probes forward, lengthening against each other; both must strive to issue from the spine and reach the fingers. The shoulders relax downward and the elbows drop; the elbow joint is bent and not straight.

V. Common Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Fault: the left foot is not drawn back but scraped and dragged back along the ground. The principal cause is that the body's weight does not shift back far enough — that is, the right leg is not set solid and the weight is between the two feet. Correction: shift the weight fully back, bend the right leg slightly and set it solid, first lift the thigh and store the jin in the knee, and then slowly draw the left leg back; in this way it will not scrape the ground.

2. Fault: the left hand is too high or too low. The principal cause is that in probing forward with the right hand to attack the opponent — which is easy for people to understand — one pays little attention to the fact that the left hand, palm facing up, is drawn back beside the upper abdomen; and so the hand's height, and its position front and back, have nothing to go by and it is placed at random. One should first know that it is gathering back towards the breast, and that "towards the breast" is neither beside the hip nor in front of the chest; then the position of the left hand will be understood without being said.

3. Fault: the movement pauses. When Single Whip is followed by High Pat on Horse, the right hook hand has already changed into a palm, the left palm already faces up, and the weight has already moved back; and here, in preparing to exert force to lift the left leg, one often pauses. The principal cause is that when the jin breaks the intent breaks too, and the strength of the waist, hips and legs is insufficient. Correction: the intention must from the first command the movement without a break; in this way there will be no pause, and "when yin reaches its extreme it gives rise to yang, and when yang reaches its extreme it gives rise to yin", and "yin and yang are each the root of the other." In addition the right leg must be set solid, and one must attend to lifting the leg rather than dragging the foot.

4. Fault: when the right hand probes forward the upper body stoops forward too much. The principal cause is that one fixes too much attention on the forward-probing action of the right hand and forgets that there is also the gathering action of the left hand: if the upper body stoops forward too far, the right hand may go out, but the gathering of the left hand has its effect reduced — and this does not accord with the application. Therefore one must "keep the tailbone centred and upright." As the boxing proverb says, how can the body form and the lifting of the crown be dispensed with? Correction: probe forward, but without stooping forward or protruding the buttocks.

5. Fault: the right palm issues slack and without power. The principal cause is an insufficient grasp of the palm methods of Taijiquan. Correction: the distinguishing feature of the palm methods of Yang-style Taijiquan is that the fingers are relaxed and extended, the thumb slightly bent and separated from the index finger, the other four fingers neither tense nor slack, each joint slightly curved, and the wrist seated. "In moving the breath and conveying the jin there must be no point however small that is not reached" — the jin must penetrate to the five fingers. But of course, using too much force and tensing the palm and fingers into stiff jin is also wrong.

BOOK PAGE 135

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. A mnemonic: sit back and lift the leg, the front foot empty; gather with the left and probe with the right, the eyes looking before them.

2. The difficulty of this movement lies in the large bow stance of Single Whip.

(This page carries one unnumbered push-hands photograph at the foot; it has no figure number and no caption.)

To make the weight shift from the left leg to the right leg, and the left foot become empty and be drawn lightly and slowly back, is very far from easy; therefore in practising this movement the emphasis must be placed on the key point of changing from the bow stance to the empty stance.

3. The height to which the right arm probes out must be taught according to the application. The right palm probes towards the opponent's face, and therefore the palm's height should be a little above the shoulder — level with the shoulder or below the shoulder would not meet the requirements of the application.

4. In teaching the body method there should be a slight raising of the spine, with the intent of probing and extending forward, but this must not be overdone: overdone, it produces a forward stooping of the upper body and loses the upright centring of the body. In teaching, one must follow the characteristics of the body method of Taijiquan and value centredness, ease and comfort, lightness, nimbleness and roundness, and calm steadiness — while of course also guarding against thrusting the chest out.

5. In teaching, one must attend to the upper and lower following each other: if the foot moves first and the hand afterwards, then the opponent's attacking left hand will either attack forward or escape backward; if the hand moves first and the foot afterwards, not only is the distance moved small, but the waist power will also be misapplied and the force hard to concentrate — and then the effect of gathering will not be produced. Therefore in teaching one must emphasise the upper and lower following each other, and make the left hand, the right hand and the drawing back of the left foot move together.

6. Compare correct and incorrect movements, so that through this vivid teaching the student can deeply grasp the application and understand the meaning of the movement.

7. Paired practice based on the application: A — takes up the settled posture of Single Whip. B — passes his left hand under A's left wrist and flicks it from the inside towards the right. A — at once loosens the left wrist slightly, palm facing up, folds the wrist down and gathers it back towards the breast, while the right knee bends slightly and is set solid, the left foot is drawn back, and the right hand probes forward. Practise repeatedly, then A and B exchange places and practise, savouring the application of the movement.

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. In this movement the distance the weight travels is comparatively large, and the left foot is far from the support of the right foot; to lift the left foot with the support of one foot (the right) requires very great strength in the muscles at the front of the foot and elsewhere. Practised repeatedly in this way, it both trains the strength of the right leg to bear the body's weight and to control and balance the centre of gravity, and trains the strength of the muscles concerned in lifting the left leg.

2. In performing the Single Whip movement that precedes High Pat on Horse, if the centre of gravity is low and the step large, then performing High Pat on Horse makes the leg power work still harder and the amount of exercise still greater, which imposes too heavy a burden on the elderly and the weak; and so some practitioners find they cannot lift the left leg and it turns into a dragging back. Therefore the elderly and the weak may take a higher frame when practising.

3. In the settled posture the right leg must not be straightened: straightened it becomes a dead stance, and a dead stance loses the opportunity.

Thirty-first Posture: Part the Wild Horse's Mane to Left and Right (Zuo You Fen Jiao)

BOOK PAGE 137

I. Application

I. Application

Continuing from the previous posture. If the opponent uses his left hand to receive my right wrist as it probes out, I at once use my right wrist to press down on the opponent's left elbow, dropping the elbow and sinking the shoulder, and at once ward the opponent's left arm back towards the left; at the same time my left hand sticks to the opponent's left wrist, palm facing down, covertly using the gathering jin. The left foot at the same time steps out half a step forward and to the left and is set solid, the waist leans obliquely to the left, and then the right foot is lifted and, with my toes and the instep of the foot, kicks straight and level at the opponent's left ribs; at the same time the two palms stand on edge and separate level with the shoulders to left and right, so as to match the action of parting the foot. The eyes follow the right hand, the chest is hollowed and the back raised, and the settling power is of itself sufficient; then the opponent's posture can no longer be directed by himself.

The left part-the-foot movement has the same application, in the opposite direction.

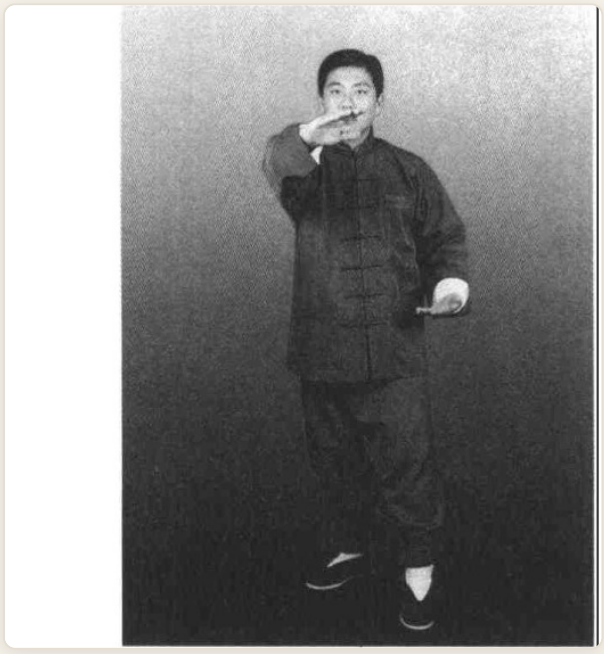
II. The Course of the Movement

(A) Part the Foot to the Right

1. The weight gradually shifts entirely onto the right leg, the right leg gradually squats down, the centre of gravity descends and the left foot lifts, and the body turns slightly left with it (facing north-east). At the same time the right palm, following the turning of the body, turns inward in an arc to the right, and the left palm wipes forward in an arc to the left; the gaze attends to the right palm wiping to the right (see the first two figures in the left-hand column of this page).

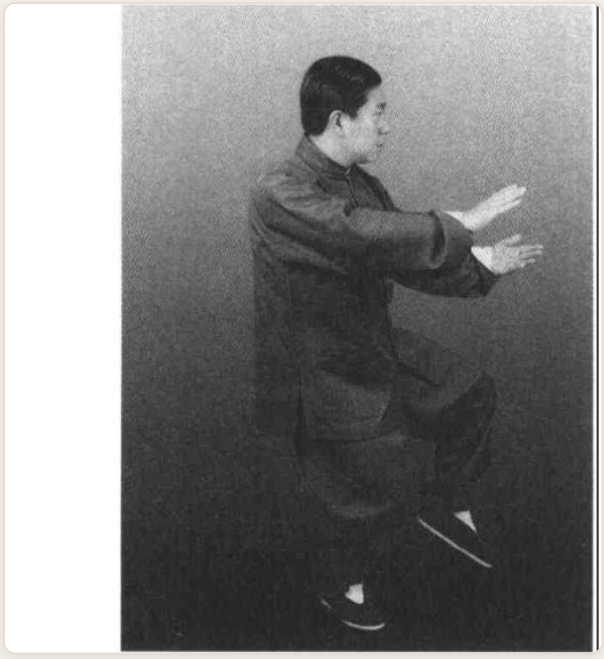
2. The left foot steps forward (to the north-east), the heel touching the ground first, and then the weight gradually shifts onto the left foot, the left leg bending and the right leg pushing straight to form a left bow stance. As the body turns right (to the south-east), the left palm wipes a circle inward from the left, forward and to the right, passing under the lower side of the right arm, and the left arm comes to a rounded, crosswise bend. The left (The left-hand column of this page holds three plates, stacked top to bottom, showing the course of this posture.)

图 173A



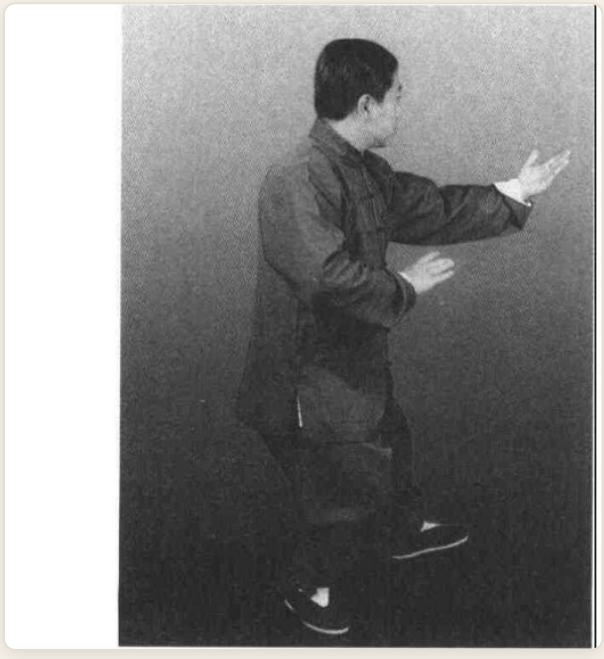
Part the Foot to Left and Right: the weight shifting onto the right leg as it squats, the right palm turning inward in an arc to the right

图 173B



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the left palm wiping forward in an arc to the left as the body turns slightly left

图 174



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the left foot stepping forward into a left bow stance, the left palm wiping a circle inward under the lower side of the right arm

The palm is held crosswise in front of the chest (beside the right elbow), the palm slanting inward and upward; the right palm wipes a flat circle from the right inward to the left over the upper side of the left arm, that is, probing out to the right front, standing the palm, the palm slanting to the left front, the fingertips slanting upward. The gaze attends to the right palm wiping, turning and probing out (see the first figure in the right-hand column of this page).

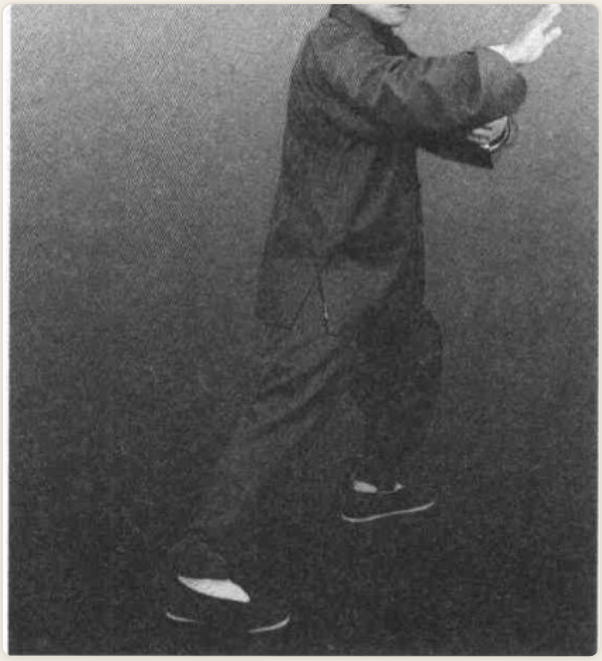
3. The weight gradually shifts entirely onto the left leg; the body turns left with it (facing north-east) and the right leg is lifted forward; at the same time the left palm moves in an arc forward and upward, palm facing inward, and the right palm scoops in an arc from the right downward to the outside of the left palm, and as it scoops the arm turns outward so that the palm turns to face inward. The two hands cross, the left palm inside. The gaze attends to the crossing of the two palms (see the second and third figures in the right-hand column of this page).

4. The left leg gradually straightens up (the knee still slightly bent); the body turns right (facing south-east) and the right foot parts out to the right oblique front (south-east), the instep naturally drawn level, at hip height; at the same time the two palms separate to the left, both palms slanting outward, the fingertips upward, the two palms at about shoulder height. The gaze attends to the right palm as it parts out, and looks level to the right past the right palm (see the first figure in the left-hand column of the next page).

(B) Part the Foot to the Left

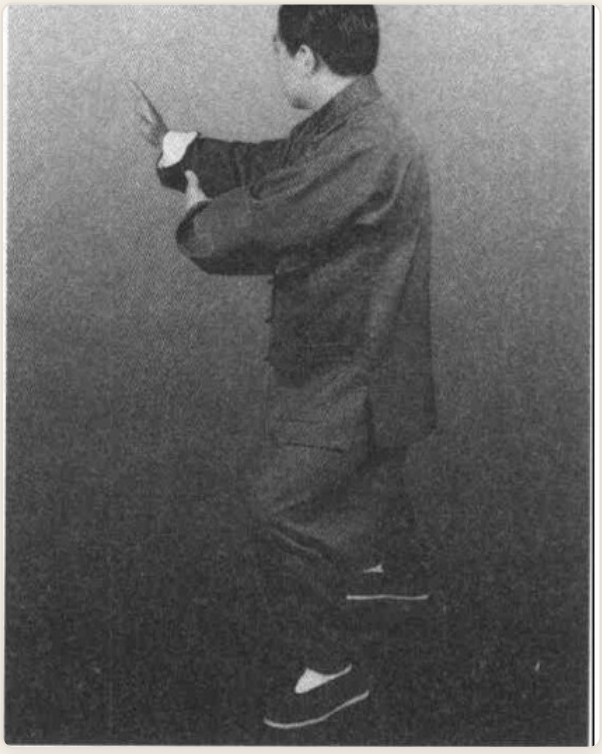
1. The left foot gradually squats down and the right foot comes down (the weight still entirely on the left foot), and the body turns slightly right; at the same time the left palm, with the elbow bent, draws near the chest and wipes from the inside towards the right, and as it wipes the arm turns inward so that the palm gradually turns to face down; the right palm wipes from the right front towards the left, and as it wipes the arm turns outward so that the palm gradually turns to face up (see the second figure in the right-hand column of the next page).

图 175A



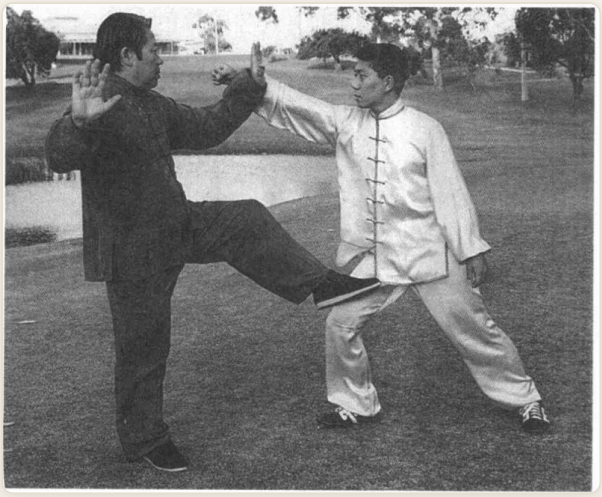
Part the Foot to Left and Right: the right leg lifted forward, the left palm moving in an arc forward and upward, palm facing inward

图 175B



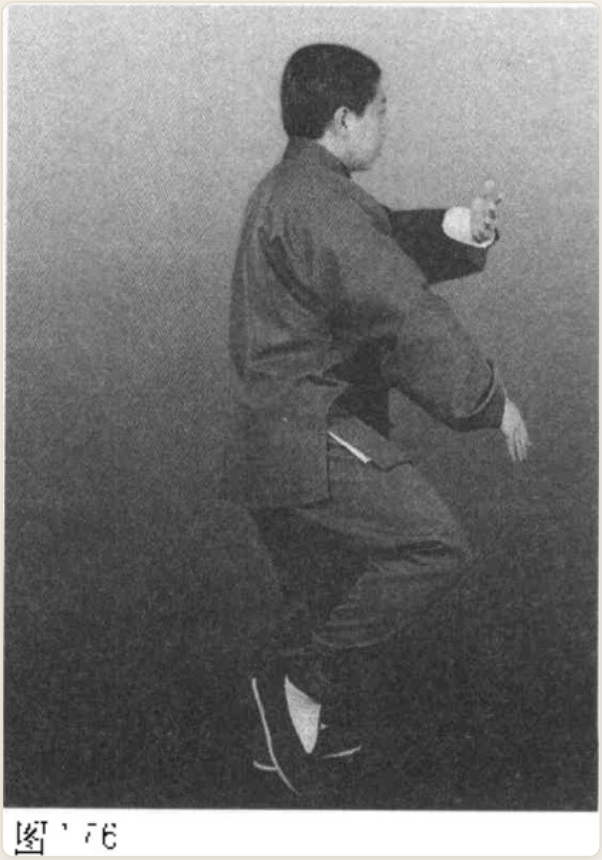
Part the Foot to Left and Right: the right palm scooping in an arc from the right downward to the outside of the left palm, the two hands crossing with the left palm inside

图 176



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the left leg straightening up, the right foot parting out to the right oblique front, the two palms separating to the left

图 177



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the settled posture of the right foot parted out, the instep level at hip height, the two palms slanting outward with the fingertips up

2. The right foot steps forward (to the south-east), the ball of the foot touching the ground first, and then the weight gradually shifts onto the right leg, the right leg bending and the left leg pushing straight to form a right bow stance. The body turns left (to the north-east); at the same time the right palm wipes and turns from the right, forward and to the left, passing under the lower side of the left arm, nearly a full circle, and the right arm comes to a rounded, crosswise bend with the right palm held crosswise in front of the left chest (beside the left elbow), the palm slanting inward and upward; the left palm wipes a flat circle from the left inward to the right over the upper side of the right arm, that is, probing out to the left front, standing the palm, the palm slanting to the left front, the fingertips slanting upward. The gaze attends to the left palm wiping, turning and probing out (see the first two figures in the left-hand column of this page).

3. The weight gradually shifts entirely onto the right leg; the body turns right with it (facing south-east) and the left leg is lifted forward; at the same time the right palm moves in an arc forward and upward, palm facing inward, and the left palm scoops in an arc from the left downward to the outside of the right palm, and as it scoops the arm turns outward so that the palm turns to face inward. The two hands cross, the right hand inside. The gaze attends to the crossing of the two palms (see the third figure in the left-hand column of this page and the first figure in the right-hand column of the next page).

4. The right leg gradually straightens up (the knee still slightly bent); the body turns left (facing north-east) and the left foot parts out to the left oblique front (north-east), the instep naturally drawn level, at hip height. At the same time the two palms separate to the left, both palms slanting outward, the fingertips upward, the two palms at about shoulder height. The gaze attends to the left palm as it parts out, and looks level to the left (see the second figure in the right-hand column of the next page).

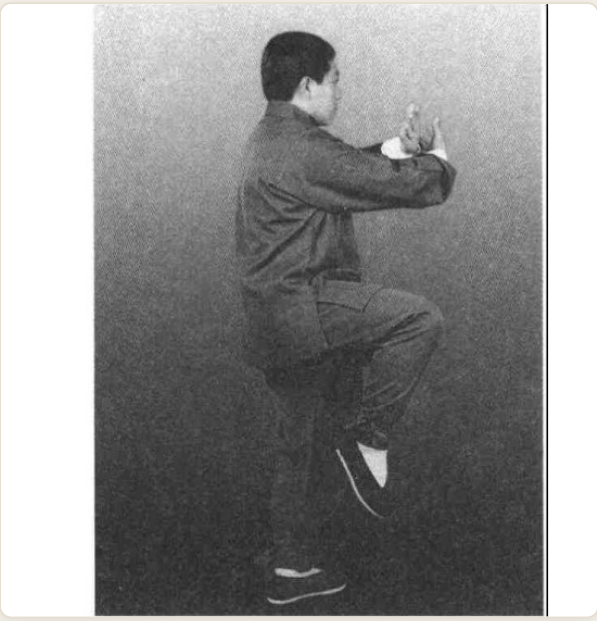
III. Essential Points

III. Essential Points

1. In the first part-the-foot the body must turn to four directions, the face must also turn to four directions, and the eyes must likewise follow the turning of the body to look in four directions.

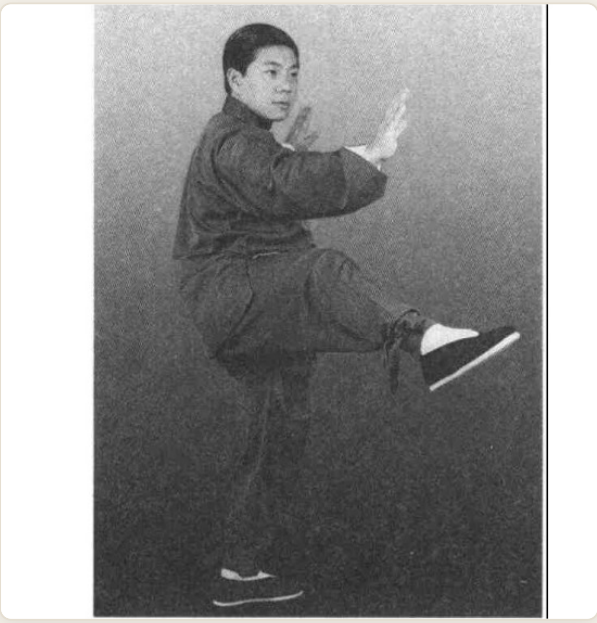
(This page carries two unnumbered photographs at the foot; they have no figure numbers and no captions.)

图 177



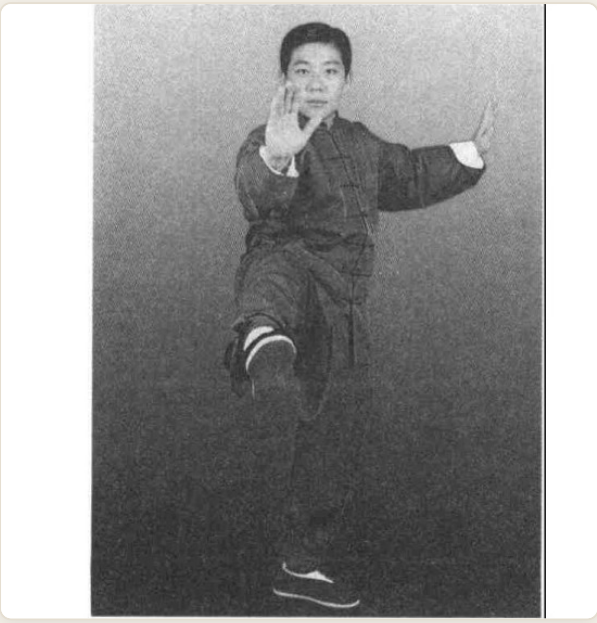
Part the Foot to Left and Right: the right leg lifted forward, the left palm moving in an arc forward and upward, palm facing inward

图 178A



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the right palm scooping in an arc from the right downward to the outside of the left palm, the two hands crossing with the left palm inside

图 178B



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the left leg straightening up, the right foot parting out to the right oblique front, the two palms separating to the left

2. In the second part-the-foot, the right foot parts to the south-east and the left foot parts to the north-east.

3. When the two hands grind and turn, the front hand must carry jin through wrist and elbow: the hand circles and the elbow circles too; the arm must form an arc, the elbow slightly sunk, and the circle must be even. When the right arm probes out after wiping and turning it too must not be straightened, and the turning of the waist must lead the hands to move.

4. The left foot steps up, facing north-east, and the waist turns to the north-east; only then does one straighten up.

5. In parting the foot one must lift the knee before extending the leg.

6. When the two hands separate the arms must form arcs, the elbows slightly sunk (the elbow lower than the wrist) and the palms higher than the shoulders (but the shoulders must not be shrugged).

7. When the two palms enfold, cross and gather, they must follow the straightening of the supporting leg and shift softly upward and outward; only then is there lightness and steadiness. If the two palms are already crossed and motionless when the left leg straightens, a sluggish quality will appear. When enfolding, the wrists of the two palms must not bend limply, and the two arms must arrive at the same moment, forming the cross, in readiness to part the foot.

8. When the two hands grind and turn, the elbows must sink and the wrists be seated (the whole form requires "seating the wrist" in every movement); the wrist strength must not be weak, nor

may the wrists collapse slackly, otherwise the internal jin will be prevented from reaching the fingers, and the use of ward-off, roll-back, press and push will be affected.

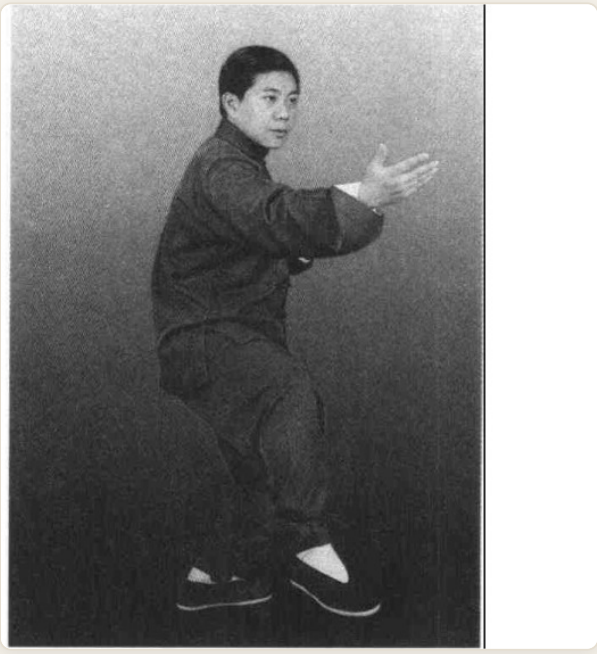
9. The right hand probing out is to press down the opponent's left elbow (taking the right part-the-foot as the example). The right hand wards from the right downward and the left hand covertly applies the gathering jin downward; this must be coordinated with the turning of the waist and hips and with sinking jin, and must not be slack.

10. When parting the foot the body must be stable, and must not stoop, lean back, tilt or lean sideways; there must be "empty the collar and lift the crown" and "sink the breath to the elixir field" — only then is it easy for the body to keep its balance.

11. In the settled posture of the right part-the-foot, the left leg (the supporting foot) must not be straightened, and must not stand utterly dead; otherwise it can neither regulate nor support the steadiness of the body's centre of gravity, nor obtain the opportunity and the position.

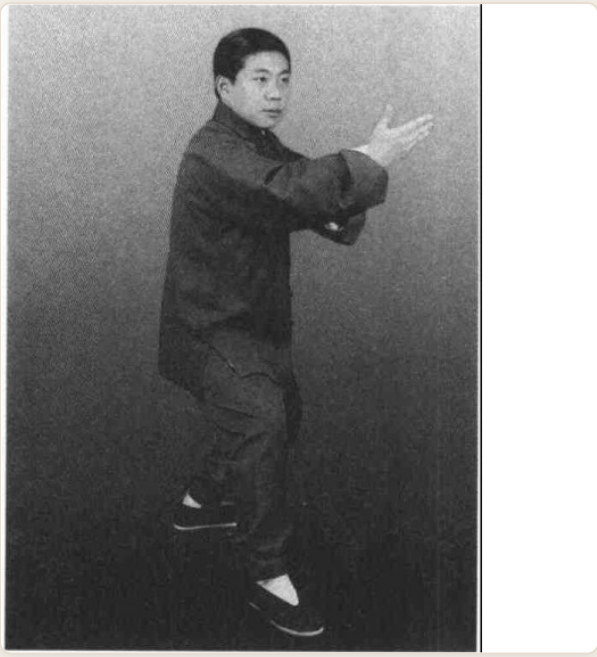
12. In going from the right part-the-foot to the left part-the-foot, first make the left leg bend and squat so that the centre of gravity descends; in the course of sitting back on the leg the right leg first comes down and then steps to the oblique direction (towards the south-east). At that moment neither the hands nor the feet may pause: one must "let the foot follow the hand's movement, turning as if divinely."

图 179



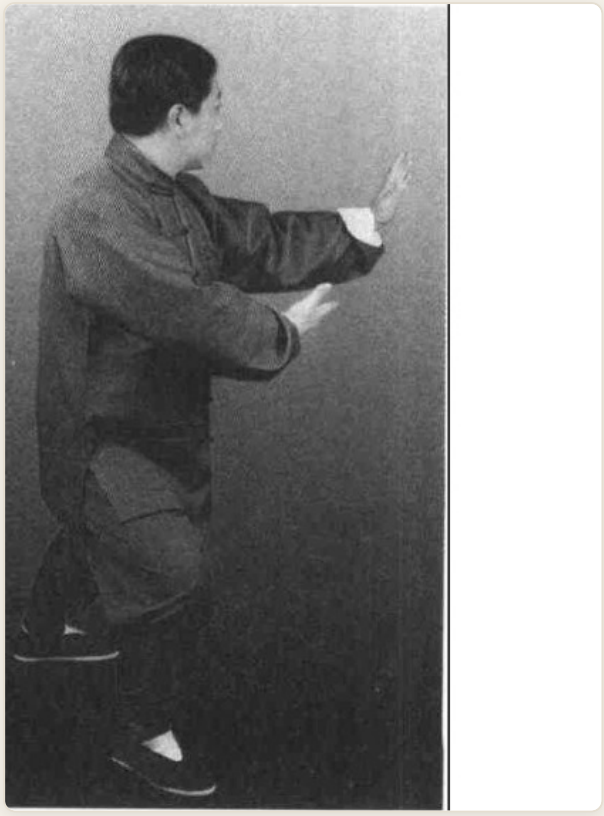
Part the Foot to Left and Right: the left palm, with the elbow bent near the chest, wiping from the inside to the right, and the right palm wiping from the right front to the left, the palms turning over

图 180



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the right foot stepping forward into a right bow stance, the right palm wiping and turning inward under the lower side of the left arm

图 181A



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the left palm wiping a flat circle forward over the upper side of the right arm and probing out to the left front, standing the palm

BOOK PAGE 141

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. The direction of the left and right parts-the-foot must be correct: the right part-the-foot towards the south-east, the left part-the-foot towards the north-east.

2. In the right part-the-foot the directions of the right foot and the right hand must agree and must arrive at the same time; the left part-the-foot has the same requirement as the right.

3. The grinding and turning of the hands must be clear and must not be vague, and the intent of the movement must be strong.

4. Going from High Pat on Horse into the right part-the-foot, one should first lower the centre of gravity, bend the right leg and set it solid, and only then step the left leg to the left oblique angle (north-east). At the end of the right part-the-foot, coming to the left part-the-foot, the stepping

must be light and nimble, and so one must first bend the left leg and lower the body's centre of gravity, and only after the left leg is set solid step the right leg to the right oblique angle (south-east), so as not to produce heaviness and sluggishness.

5. There must be "when one part moves, no part is unmoving". In the right part-the-foot, at the same moment that the right leg bends and squats and the centre of gravity descends, the right hand grinds and turns from the front to the right and inward and the left hand grinds and turns from the left outward, and the left foot lifts and becomes empty — all must move together; the hands must not move while the foot is still, nor the foot move while the hands are still.

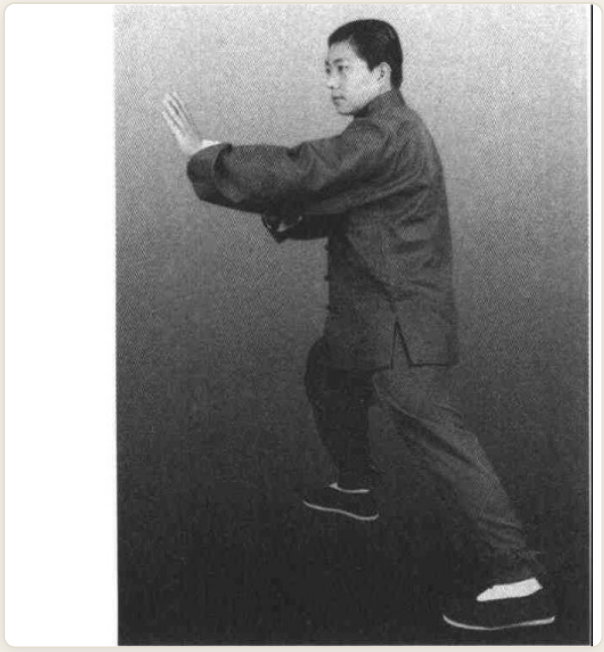
6. In going from the right part-the-foot to the left part-the-foot there must be no pause: one must "let posture follow posture, movement thread through movement", "when the jin breaks the intent does not break", and the internal jin keeps on circulating.

7. Whichever foot parts, the gaze should be fixed in that direction.

V. Common Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

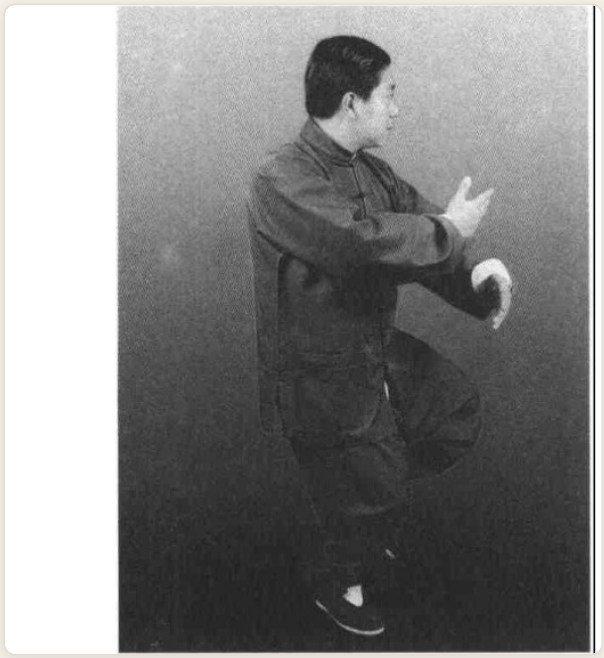
1. Fault: the direction of the movement is not correct. The principal cause lies in unfamiliarity with the application. The opponent meets my right wrist, probing out, with his left hand from the front; I ward the opponent's left arm back to the left, and at the same time step my left foot half a step forward and to the left — and at that moment the opponent is to the right front of me, so that the direction of my parted foot becomes the south-east oblique, and not some other direction. Correction: the direction of the toes of the supporting foot must be reasonable and natural, pointing to the north-east; then, on the basis of turning the waist and hips, the right part-the-foot can proceed smoothly to the south-east.

图 181B



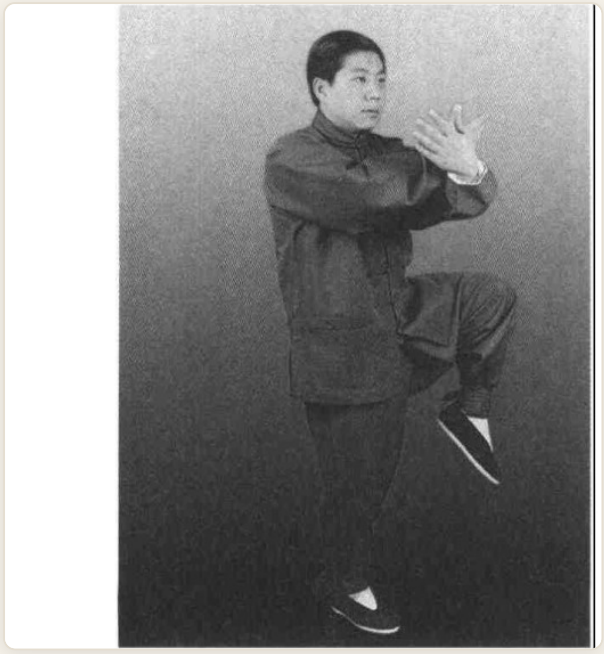
Part the Foot to Left and Right: the right palm held crosswise in front of the left chest, the left palm probing out to the left front, standing the palm

图 182



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the right hand crossed inside, the two palms enfolding, in readiness to part the foot

图 183



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the left foot parting out to the left oblique front, the two palms separating to the left, the fingertips upward

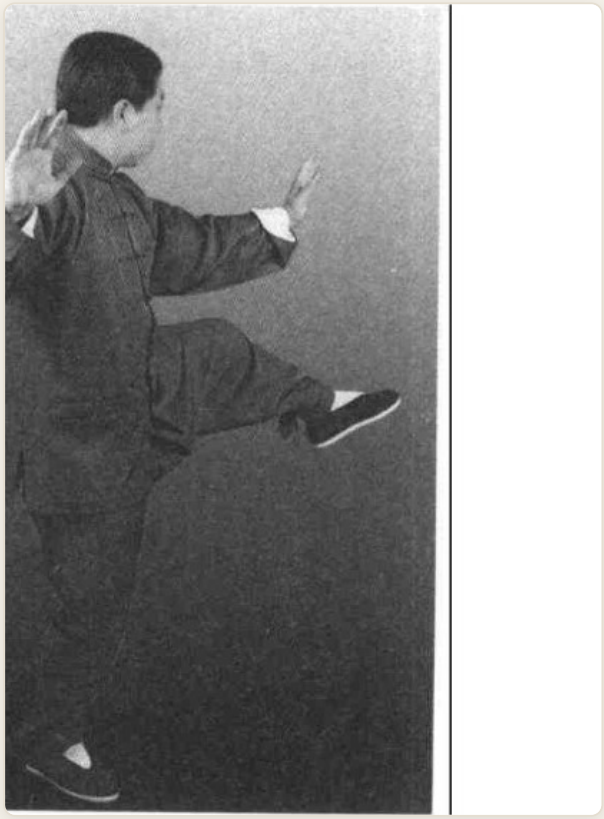
2. Fault: the parted foot is too high or too low. The principal cause is a lack of understanding of the application. I ward the opponent's left arm and at the same time my left hand gathers downward under the opponent's left wrist, so that the parts of him left open to my attack are only the middle and lower — and so a straight, level kick at the opponent's left flank is the more appropriate. Correction: since it is the flank that is being kicked, being higher than the waist or lower than the knee are both unreasonable. Of course the elderly and weak, and those who are dizzy and unsteady on their feet, may lower the requirement — lifting the foot only a little will do.

3. Fault: the gaze is fixed in one direction only and does not follow the movement. The principal cause lies in an insufficient grasp of the method of the eyes. Correction: the gaze must follow the movement of the principal hand and look level ahead, so that in practising the form the eyes arrive, the body arrives, the hands arrive and the step arrives, all together, "spirit and form united as one". Wherever the intent wants to go, the gaze must go with it; the eyes must follow the turning of the principal hand and look ahead, while of course also attending to above and below and to both sides. The neck must turn with the gaze; in this way "the mechanism lies in the eyes, and the enemy's disposition is known at once", and in martial terms one can see through the opponent's movement. The turning of the gaze, and its extension and far-seeing, are also good for restoring and strengthening the eyesight; therefore in a single part-the-foot the gaze must turn to four directions, and accumulated day after day in repeated training this is most beneficial to the health of the eyes.

4. Fault: when the two hands grind and turn they are either stiff or collapsed. The principal cause is that the intent of the pairs is unclear. The hand methods of Taijiquan abhor stiffness and sluggishness, and require firmness and softness to assist each other. Correction: in moving, lead the elbow with the hand and the shoulder with the elbow; the arm must be nimble, round and turning, the shoulder relaxed and sunk. To prevent the wrist from collapsing slackly one must attend to "seating the wrist". If the wrist is slack and powerless the hand will necessarily have no ward-off jin; therefore when grinding and turning, the front hand must carry jin through wrist and elbow, and the elbow too must circle. This keeps the ward-off jin from being lost, and one achieves neither stiffness nor collapse.

5. Fault: when parting the foot, the waist twists, producing a slanting and stooping or leaning of the upper body. The principal cause is an insufficient recognition that the waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower body. Correction: the *Treatise on Boxing* says, "the waist is the great banner" — likening the waist to the great standard of the central army, which stands upright. Therefore when performing the right part-the-foot, as the left foot steps up and one faces the north-east, the waist and hips must turn to the north-east, so that shoulder and hip are joined; and when parting the foot to the south-east the waist and hips turn with the movement — and then there will be no twisting of the waist and no slanting of the upper body.

图 184



Part the Foot to Left and Right: the settled posture of the left foot parted out, the instep level at hip height, the two palms slanting outward with the fingertips up

6. Fault: when parting the foot the leg kicks out straight. The principal cause is an insufficient understanding of the application. Correction: to kick the leg one must first lift the leg (the knee), first concentrating the force at the knee joint, and then let the motive force travel joint by penetrating through to reach the tip of the foot, so as to strengthen the issuing of power.

7. Fault: when parting the foot the two hands separate to left and right too low or too high. The principal cause is an insufficient understanding of the application. Correction: as the foot parts, the two palms stand on edge and separate in arcs to left and right level with the shoulders — this is chiefly to take advantage of the momentum of the parted foot, and is not a press-and-strike attack. The arms must be arc-shaped, the palms higher than the shoulders, and the shoulders must not be lifted, so that one's own settling power is sufficient and the opponent cannot hold himself up.

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. Mnemonics (taking the right part-the-foot as the example): (1) The hands — the right hand from outside inward, the left hand from inside outward; the two hands open and then close; the right hand presses obliquely forward; the arcs issue level with the shoulders. (2) The feet — the right leg squats and the left leg is empty; the left foot goes out obliquely forward; the heel lands first; the weight shifts to the left; the right foot rises slowly; remember the direction firmly.

2. Difficult points (taking the right part-the-foot as the example): (1) The grinding and turning of the two hands is unclear — one may use the method of breaking it down: with the feet and the direction unchanged, practise the right hand alone, circling from outside to the right and inward, then change to the left hand going left, outward and to the right, then practise the two hands together, and finally issue the right palm to the south-east after the grinding and turning. Once that is basically proficient, then add the foot movements and the change of direction. (2) The facing is unclear — stepping the left foot out one faces north-east, and issuing the right palm one faces south-east; practise repeatedly, first mastering the two hands' grinding and turning and the changing of the two directions, which is the difficult point and must be made clear. Then, having learned it, turning left to brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step one faces north-east, and when parting the foot one faces south-east — and in this way the turning and changing of directions is easily made clear.

3. Joining: in going from High Pat on Horse into the right part-the-foot, one must first squat the right leg and sink the body; and in going from the completed right part-the-foot into the left part-the-foot, one must likewise first squat the left leg and "send" the right leg down, stepping out to the south-east oblique, while coordinating the hand movements. If the joining is poor, the quality

is certain to be low; therefore in teaching one must specially bring out the practice of the joinings, and through repeated practice achieve continuity, roundness and liveliness.

4. The direction of the placed foot must be practised repeatedly and pointed out clearly. In the right part-the-foot, the left foot steps out to the left oblique, that is to the north-east; in the left part-the-foot, the right foot steps out to the right oblique, that is to the south-east. Going beyond or falling short will make the part-the-foot awkward or the stance unsteady.

BOOK PAGE 144

VII. Technical Analysis

VII. Technical Analysis

1. This movement is comparatively complex: it includes the two hands each moving in different directions, and at the same time the movement of the feet, the rising and falling of the centre of gravity, the repeated changing of direction, and support on one leg — all of these changing at the same moment. It is therefore rather hard to learn; but its very difficulty tends rather to arouse the practitioner's keen interest.

2. When parting the foot the movement of the hands is not placed at random: beyond taking advantage of the momentum of the parted foot, it also serves to confuse the opponent's line of sight and to scatter his attention. Because the right hand and the right foot strike out at the same moment and in the same direction, the opponent's gaze first meets the hand nearer his face, and so the hand's movement bemuses his attack and defence, which favours the true attack of my foot below — and this embodies the subtle use of now appearing, now hiding, and of the interchange of empty and full.

3. Once this movement is basically learned, the level of skill depends chiefly on whether the support on one leg is steady; technically one must attend to two things: (1) The supporting leg must be set down solidly and stand steady, bent and not straight, so that the lower body is stable. (2) The parting leg must not be lifted too fast — if fast, the body is easily pulled along. One should first lift the knee, and then at the same slow speed continue to part the lower leg, so as to avoid losing balance.

4. The speed at which the two hands separate must agree with the parting of the leg, and the movements must be coordinated.

5. The body must be "centred, upright, at ease and comfortable"; one must not wrongly resort to leaning back and the like to keep the body's balance.

Beyond all the above, the most crucial thing is to persevere in practising over months and years, to strengthen the power of the legs and of the whole body's muscles, and to raise one's skill unceasingly, so that the support on one leg becomes steady.

Thirty-second Posture: Turn the Body and Kick with the Heel (Zhuan Shen Deng Jiao)

I. Application

Continuing from the left part-the-foot. If the opponent strikes with his right hand from behind me, I at once turn my body to the left, hollow the chest, raise the back and relax the waist, and above all make a good "empty the collar and lift the crown"; the left leg hangs raised, and as the waist turns the toes, of themselves hang down of itself. After the turn, the right foot is set firm, and the left foot at once kicks with the heel at the opponent's abdomen, the toes drawn up. As the two hands turn with the waist they close from outside inward, and as the left foot kicks out the two palms stand on edge to left and right and separate level with the shoulders; the gaze looks away in the direction of the left fingertips, and with the root power established the opponent will certainly fall back before the leg.

BOOK PAGE 145

II. The Course of the Movement

II. The Course of the Movement

1. The left foot comes down, the left knee staying raised, and with the right heel as the axis the body at once turns to the left rear through about 180°; as it turns the two palms close inward and gather and cross in front of the chest (the left palm outside), and the eyes follow the turning of the body, looking level ahead (see the first figure in the left-hand column of this page).

2. The left leg kicks slowly out to the left (west) with the heel, the toes pointing up; at the same time the two palms separate to left and right. The right leg gradually straightens up as the left foot kicks out, but the right knee stays slightly bent. The gaze attends to the left palm as it separates, and looks level ahead past the left palm (see the second figure in the left-hand column of this page).

III. Essential Points

1. When turning, the body must always maintain "above and below essentially one line", and the body's centre of gravity must not depart from the point of support.

2. When turning to the left the whole body's movements must be coordinated: the gaze looks to the left, the right arm swings left, the left arm withdraws and swings left, the left leg withdraws and swings left, and the head turns together with the turning of the waist and hips. The waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower body, but the cooperation of other aspects must not be slighted.

3. When turning, the right leg sinks slightly downward so that the centre of gravity descends and the lower limbs are made stable. When kicking, the right leg straightens up again, but still does not straighten fully.

4. When kicking the body must be steady, and must not stoop, lean back, tilt or bend; the leg must kick out slowly, taking the heel as the point of application, without sudden change, and must not use rapid movements.

IV. Requirements

1. When turning, the upper body must not stoop forward or lean back, nor slant to left or right.

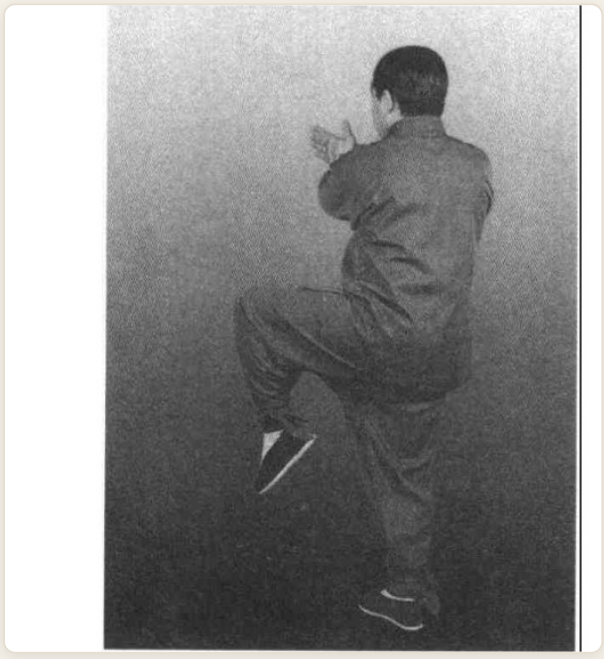
2. When turning, the left foot must not touch the ground.

3. After the turn the direction must be correct.

4. After the turn one must not kick the foot only after the movement has paused.

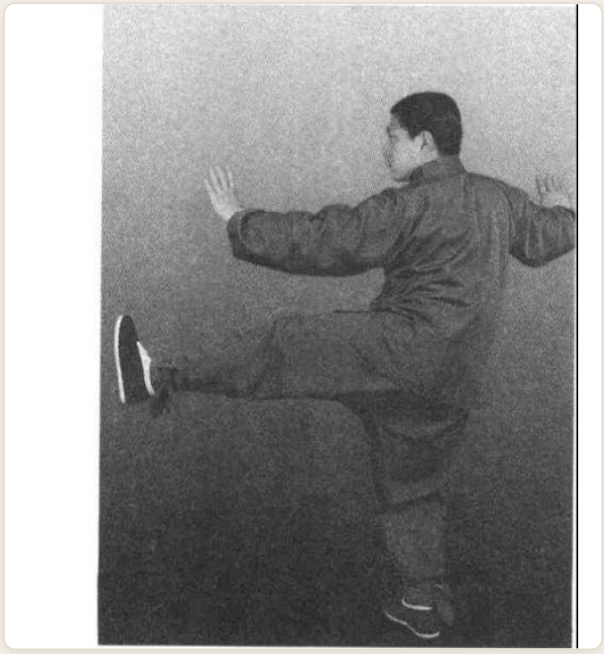
5. The movement must be even, and must not be sometimes fast and sometimes slow.

图 185



Turn the Body and Kick with the Heel: turning the body through about 180° to the left rear with the right heel as the axis, the two palms gathering inward and crossing in front of the chest

图 186



Turn the Body and Kick with the Heel: the left leg kicking out to the left with the heel, the toes pointing up, the two palms separating to left and right level with the shoulders

6. When the two hands cross they must be full and not collapsed, and the elbows must not be lifted so as to expose the ribs.

7. In the settled posture there must be the three joins (the hand joined with the foot, the elbow with the knee, the shoulder with the hip).

BOOK PAGE 146

V. Common Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Common Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Fault: on turning the body one stands unsteadily, so that the body slants or even the left foot touches the ground. The principal cause lies in not having grasped the correct position of the body's centre of gravity, and in poor control of the force of the turn. Correction: the waist and hips and the four limbs cooperate to produce a force turning to the left, and the turn must be made just right; besides applying the force properly there must also be a braking action. Therefore after the turn the right leg sinks, the left leg draws slightly inward, and the setting down of the right sole and, most fundamentally, the control of the waist and hips' turning, give one not only the ideal angle of turn (the direction needed) but also a light and nimble turn.

2. Fault: the direction of the turn is incorrect. The principal cause is paying insufficient attention to the application. When the opponent strikes with his right hand from behind me, my direction of attack and defence should be behind the position of "Part the Foot to Left and Right" (west) for it to accord with the requirement. Correction: after the left part-the-foot the movement is 45° + 90°, about 135° in all — that is, from the north-east turning to the west (the direction of the heel kick).

3. Fault: the left leg swings with the leg straight. The principal cause is wanting to use the force of the swung leg to turn the body, which loses the application's meaning as a heel kick, and in any case makes the direction of the turn hard to control. Correction: one must (This page carries one unnumbered push-hands photograph at the foot; it has no figure number and no caption.)

stand with the left leg raised and turning.

4. Fault: when kicking the leg the position of the two hands is poor. The principal cause is that the beginner concentrates too much on turning and on keeping balance. Correction: the arms separate at shoulder level — the left hand forward (west), the right hand oblique (north-east). If the two hands separate to 180° they scatter, which inevitably produces a thrust-out chest, and moreover the front of the chest is then too open and easily attacked.

BOOK PAGE 147

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. A correct turning action is the key to this movement, and so it must be practised and savoured repeatedly. On the basis of practising each detail broken down, then practise the whole repeatedly.

2. The teacher should explain the turning as the key point and demonstrate it.

3. Two directions must be made clear: first, when the two hands cross the body faces the north-west; second, the kick goes to the west.

VII. Technical Analysis

The distinguishing feature of this movement is the turn, and the technical key point and difficulty is likewise the turn. The turn is carried out while supported on one foot, and therefore the key lies in the centre of gravity. As soon as the human body makes a movement the centre of gravity changes; the direction in which the centre of gravity moves is always the same as the direction in which the body moves, and the greater the weight and distance moved (as with the left leg in this movement), the greater the distance the centre of gravity travels. After the body has turned in the left heel kick, the right foot supports alone and the left leg hangs raised on the left side, so

that the centre of gravity necessarily shifts left; and the beginner very easily becomes unsteady and sets the left foot down, or leans the upper body right to balance — which does not accord with what the boxing treatise says: "the hundred meeting-point, the central pole, one breath threading through." In sum, the technical key of the left heel kick is the turning, and to turn well is to use well the turning of the waist and hips and the appropriate coordinated movement of hands and legs.

Thirty-third Posture: Brush the Knee and Twist the Step to Left and Right (Zuo You Lou Xi Ao Bu)

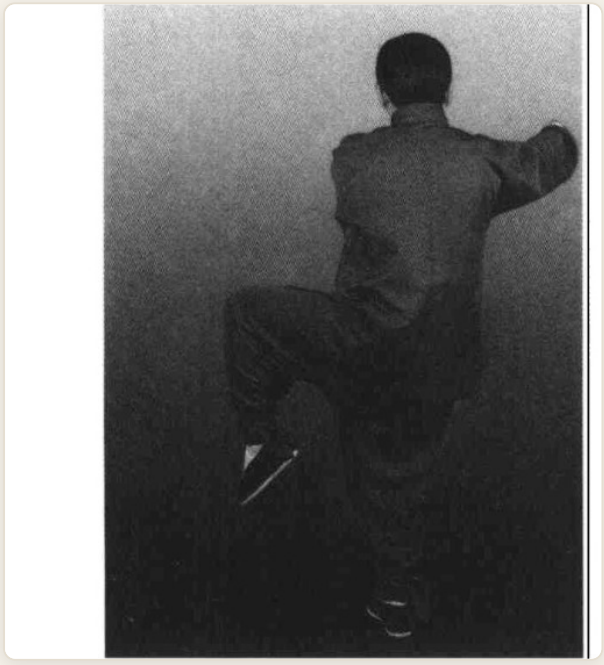
I. Application

The same as the ninth posture above, Brush the Knee and Twist the Step to Left and Right.

II. The Course of the Movement

In going from the left heel kick into the join with the left brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step, one must do well the The whole of this page is taken up by the posture photographs, arranged in three rows across the page. There is no running text on this page.

图 187A

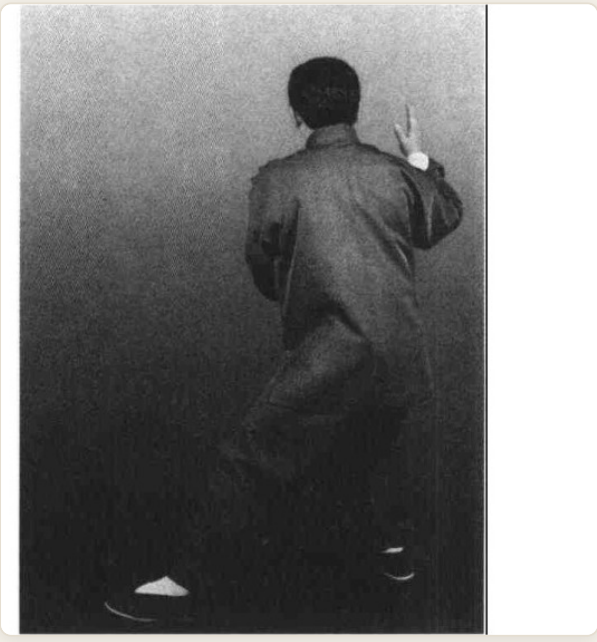


the left brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step: the body turned to the left, the left leg raised and stepping out, the left hand sweeping down past the left knee.

图 187B

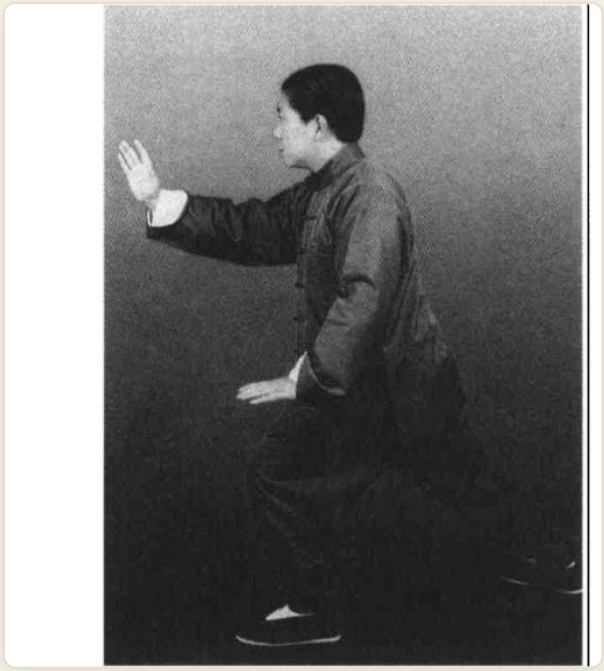
the left brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step: the left hand having brushed past the knee, the right palm pushing forward, the left bow stance formed.

图 188



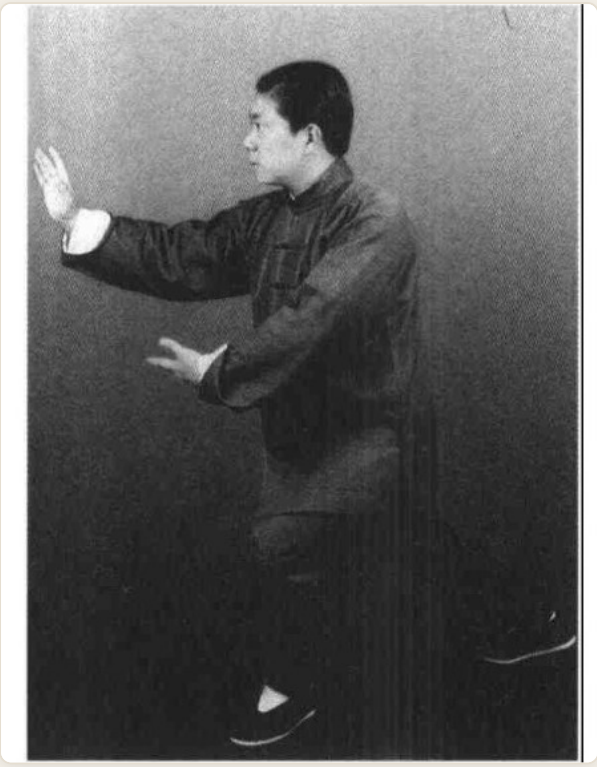
the right brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step: the body turned to the right, the right leg raised, the right hand sweeping down.

图 189



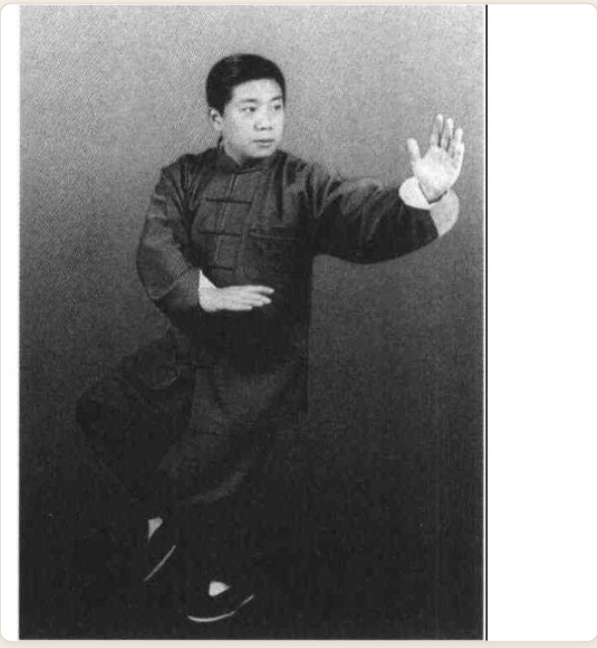
the right brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step: the right hand sweeping past the right knee, the left hand raised at the side.

图 190



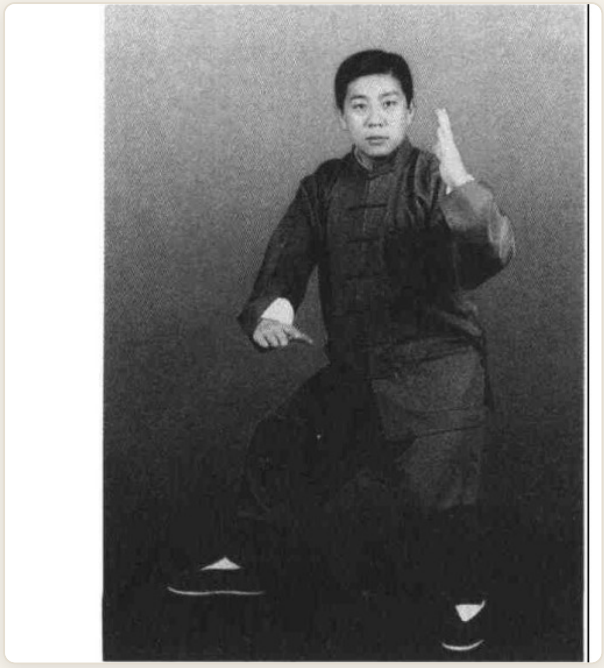
the right brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step: both hands in transition, the weight shifting, the step turning.

图 191



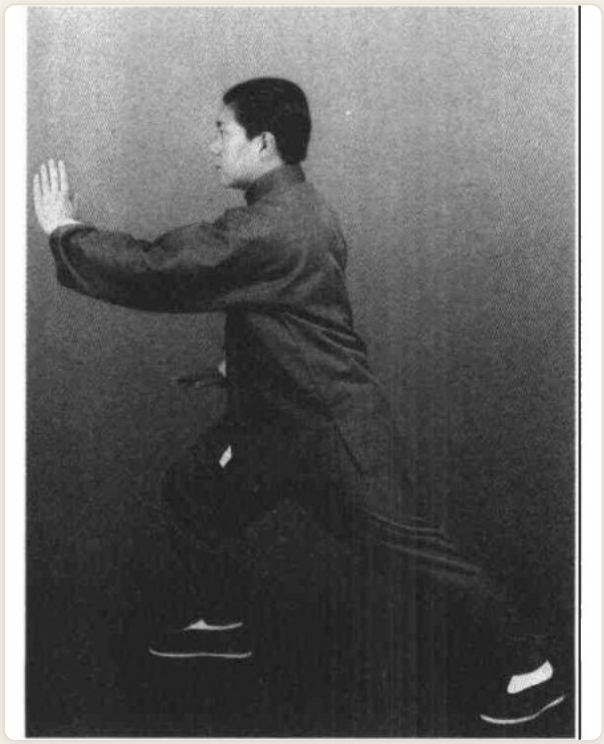
the right brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step: the right palm pushed forward, the left palm withdrawn to the waist, the right bow stance formed.

图 192



the left brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step again: the left hand sweeping down, the right hand raised before the chest, seen from the front.

图 193



the left brush-the-knee-and-twist-the-step again: the left bow stance with the right palm pushing forward, seen in profile.

The movement of the preceding figure: the right leg continues to sink, the right palm arcs to the side of the right ear, the left arm arcs back in to the front of the abdomen, then continues downward and to the left (see the second figure on this page). The other movements are the same as the ninth posture, "Brush the Knee and Twist the Step to Left and Right", only the direction is reversed (see the remaining figures on this page and on the next).

All the points — the key points and the rest — are likewise the same, only the direction is reversed.

Thirty-fourth Posture: Step Forward and Plant the Fist (Jin Bu Zai Chui)

BOOK PAGE 149

I. Application

I. Application

Joining from the preceding posture. If the opponent again kicks in with his left leg, I use my left hand to brush away from the left along the line of his leg; he is then certain to lunge to the left, and I at once take a step forward with my left foot in pursuit, bending the left knee and settling solidly, and my right hand immediately closes into a fist and strikes down at his waist or his shin — either will do. This is called "planting the fist". At that moment the right leg is straightened, the waist and hips sink down into a flat curved form, the chest is contained, the gaze is forward, and one must above all take care to guard one's own central ground.

II. The Course of the Movement

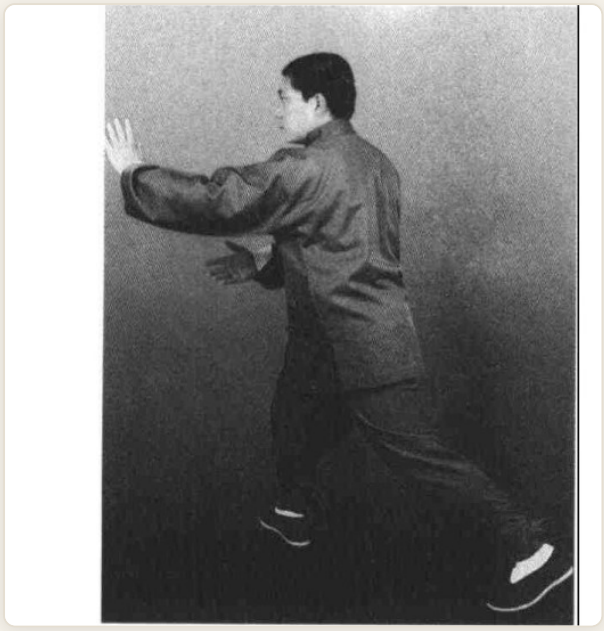
1. The body turns gradually to the right, the right toe turns out and settles flat, the centre of gravity gradually shifts onto the right leg, and the left leg is lifted forward; at the same time the right palm turns downward, parallel with the ground, moves to the side of the body, turns over to the right and rear, closes into a fist, and comes to the side of the right waist; the left palm, as the body turns, goes from the front to the right, arcs down and brushes across the front of the right chest, the gaze attending to the left palm's downward brush (see the first two figures on this page).

2. The body continues to turn slightly right, the left leg takes a step forward, the heel landing first, and as the centre of gravity gradually shifts forward the whole sole of the left foot settles flat; as the left leg bends and the right leg extends into the left bow stance, the body gradually turns left, the waist and hips sink, and as the body turns the left palm continues to arc downward, brushing past the front of the left knee up to the side of the left knee; the right fist at the same time strikes down and forward, slightly below knee height, the gaze forward, the eyes attending to the right fist as it strikes out (see the figures further on this page).

III. Key Points

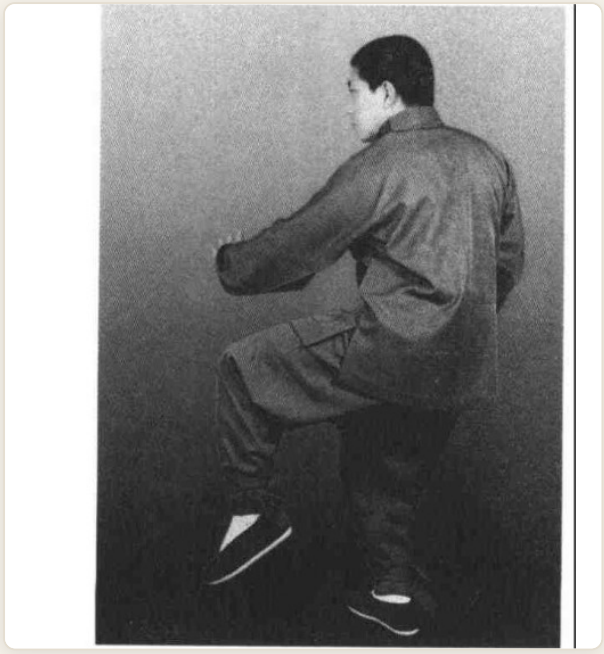
1. The brushing of the knee should be done at the moment the left heel has already landed and the weight is shifting forward and the left knee bending; it should not be done before the left foot has landed, nor after the left bow stance is already made. The bow must arrive, the brush must arrive, the fist must arrive — all three must arrive together.

图 194



the body turning right, the right palm turning over and closing into a fist at the right waist, the left palm sweeping down across the front of the right chest.

图 195A



the left foot stepping forward with the heel landing first, the weight beginning to shift forward, both arms still in transition.

2. Before the right fist strikes forward and down, take care that the body stays upright; as the right fist strikes down the upper body inclines forward with the waist folding, and the waist and hips sink — but when the waist folds, the head and neck and the waist must still be kept in one straight line (the cervical, thoracic and lumbar vertebrae essentially forming one straight line). Do not drop the head or hump the waist; maintain "the hundred meeting-point, the central pole, one breath threading through".

3. The eyes look forward past the right fist; do not raise the head, and do not lower it either.

4. The two elbows should be slightly bent, never straightened; the left palm should have the wrist seated.

BOOK PAGE 150

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. The left leg is lifted and steps forward; the movement must be even, not now fast and now slow.

2. From the moment the body begins to turn right, both left and right hands must move together; take special care that the left hand does not pause.

3. The body should not turn right too far (it should not face north).

4. Once the whole set of movements is fairly proficient, the amount of exercise should be gradually increased. One way is to lower the height of the hip-joint, bringing the knee nearly level with the hip, so that the muscular load on the waist and legs is increased.

The centre of gravity should be kept at one level, the body neither rising nor falling abruptly, and one should not cut corners by borrowing force. When the movement changes, the hip-joint draws in and lowers, and the body stays centred and upright; in this way the leg strength can be increased, and as the amount of exercise rises the constitution is further strengthened. Naturally, a practitioner whose health does not for the time being permit it must not drop too low all at once, lest he become over-tired.

5. The fist should not be gripped too tightly, nor yet left wholly slack so that it is an empty fist.

6. Do not drop the head or hump the waist.

图 195B

the left bow stance formed, the right fist planted down and forward, the left palm at the side of the left knee.

图 196

the left bow stance, seen in profile, the right fist striking down slightly below knee height.

图 197A

the left bow stance from the front, the right arm descending with the fist, the left hand pressing at the knee.

V. Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Fault: the fist comes out too high, striking down from in front of the chest and beside the shoulder. The principal cause is that one has traced an empty circle. Correction: the fist should come out from the side of the waist and strike forward and down.

2. Fault: the eyes look downward. The principal cause is that one attaches too little importance to the application, mistakenly supposing that the eye should see the point the fist strikes. Correction: the gaze should attend to the right palm, but the main thing is that the eye must observe the opponent's changes — and so it should not look down.

3. Fault: the right hand closes into a fist well before it has reached the waist. The cause is a failure to understand the application. Correction: as the boxing saying has it, "Going out the hand is open; meeting a man it becomes a fist." The right hand should therefore close into a fist only just as it arrives at position.

4. Fault: the upper body bends forward and the head drops. The principal cause is neglecting the requirement of "above and below essentially one line". Correction: the body method should be centred and true; though the bend of the waist is large, one must still keep "the hundred meeting-point, the central pole, one breath threading through" — avoid bending the waist and rounding the back.

VI. Technical Analysis

Throughout the whole of the Yang-style set there are few movements in which the upper body bends forward; Step Forward and Plant the Fist is one of them. Its distinguishing feature is the outward inclination of the upper body. How is one to understand the operation of "the tailbone centred and true" in this movement? It is a matter of understanding the difference between being centred and true without deviation, and the deviation of the centred and true. In practising the form there must be extension and contraction; sometimes the bend of the waist is very great, but so long as the principle of "the hundred meeting-point, the central pole, one breath threading through" is still maintained, it is still permitted. This is what is called "the deviation of the centred and true" — the inner strength is still centred, true and undeviating. And so one must not bend the waist and round the back, must not drop the head and stoop.

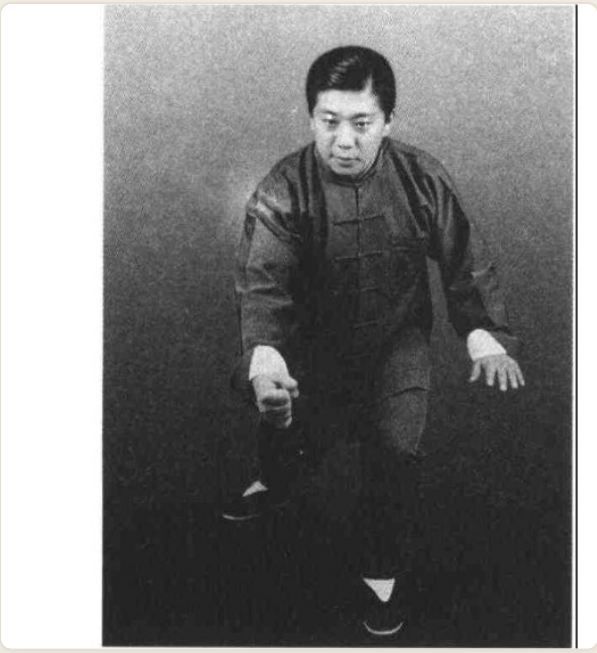
Thirty-fifth Posture: Turn the Body Over and Thrust Out the Fist (Fan Shen Pie Shen Chui)

I. Application

Joining from the preceding posture. If an opponent again strikes from behind with his fist, I turn my body over from the right towards the rear, settle solidly on the left foot, raise the right leg forward and set it down half a step, and at the same time raise the right fist and thrust it out to

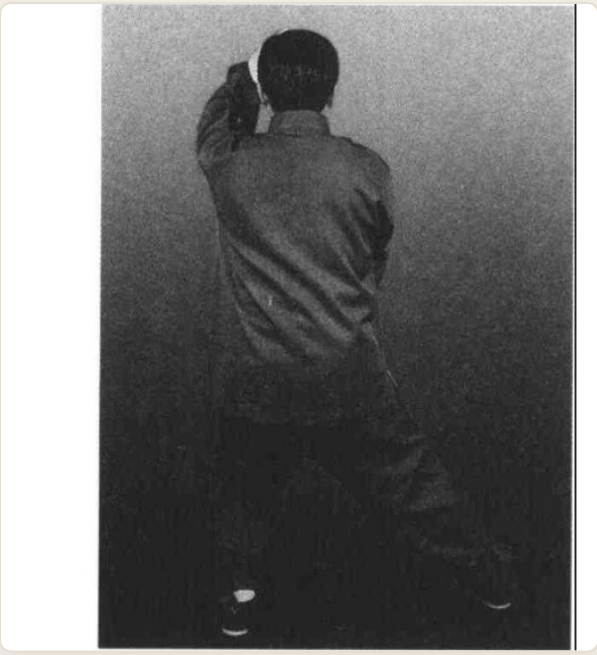
the rear and to the front, the back of the fist sinking downward — either taking control of the opponent's elbow, or secretly using the plucking energy. Either will do.

图 197B



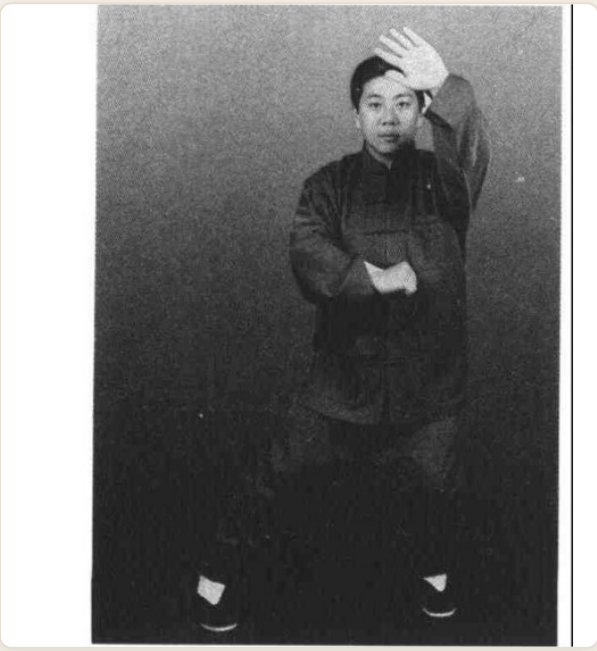
the left bow stance at the moment of the strike, seen from the front-right, the right fist planted below the knee.

图 198A



rising from the bow stance, the body beginning to turn, both hands moving as the weight comes up.

图 198B



the body turned through, the right arm raised, the left hand crossing before the chest.

At the same time, the left hand follows the right fist and strikes out with the fist at the opponent's face to assist the thrusting momentum of the right fist; the body must advance with the

movement — in this way one gains the advantage.

BOOK PAGE 152

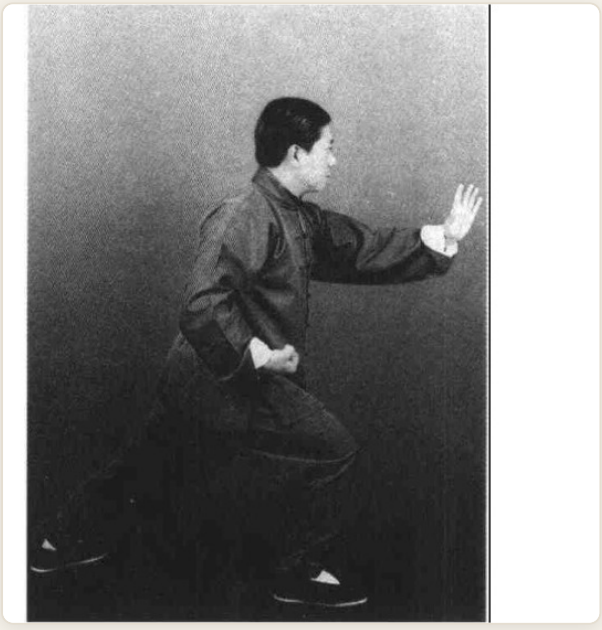
II. The Course of the Movement

II. The Course of the Movement

1. The body straightens and turns right, and at the same time the left toe turns in and settles flat; as the body turns the right fist is raised, the elbow bent and the forearm brought horizontally across to the front of the left ribs, the centre of the fist facing down; the left palm arcs up from the left to a point above and in front of the left temple, the face towards the north. The eyes follow the turning of the body and shift in level gaze, the gaze attending to the movement of the two hands (see the first figure on this page).

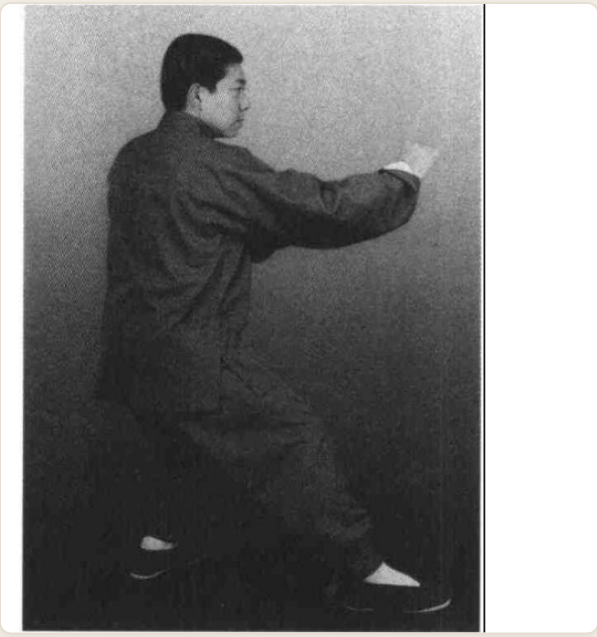
2. The subsequent movements are the same as the twenty-fourth posture, "Thrust Out the Fist", only the direction of the form's route is reversed (this movement goes towards the east) (see the later figures on this page).

图 199



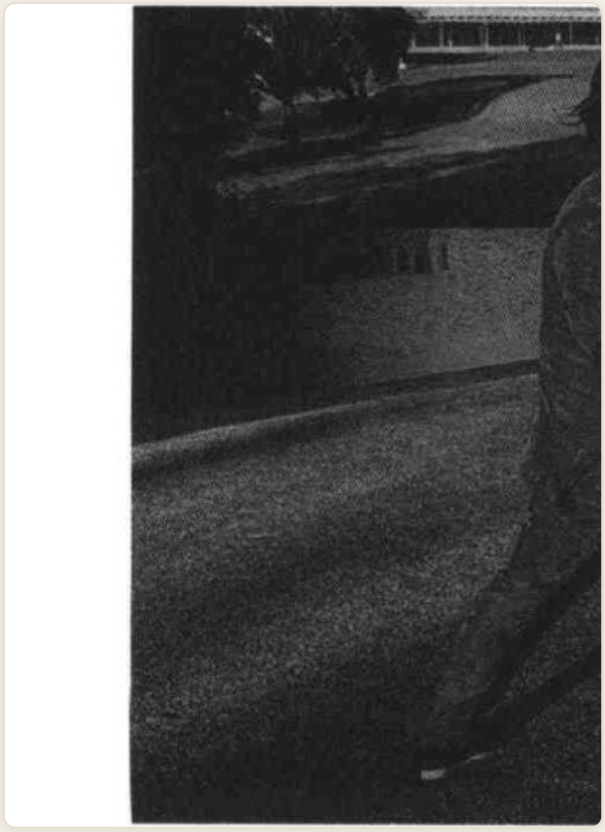
the body straightened and turning right, the right arm bent at the elbow and drawn across to the front of the left ribs, the left palm raised above the left temple.

图 200



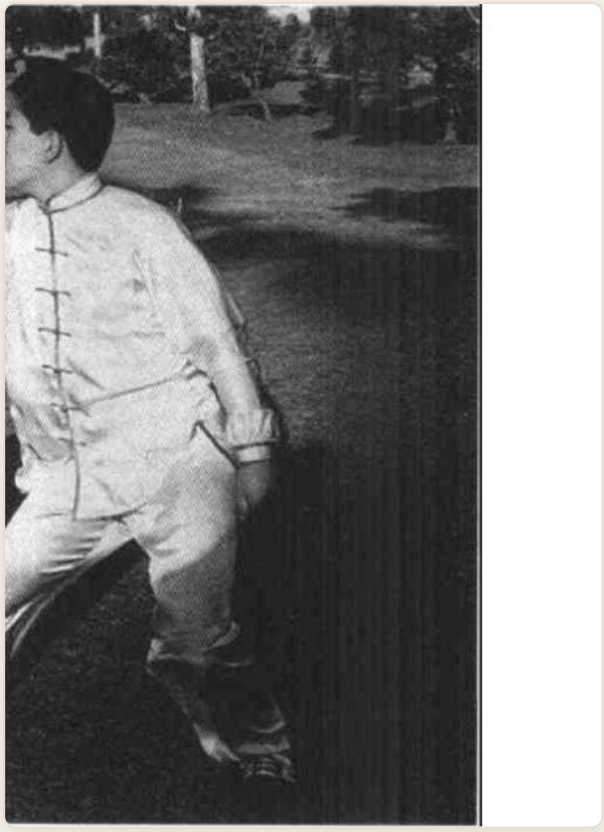
the body turned to face north, the right forearm horizontal across the chest, the left palm above the head.

图 201



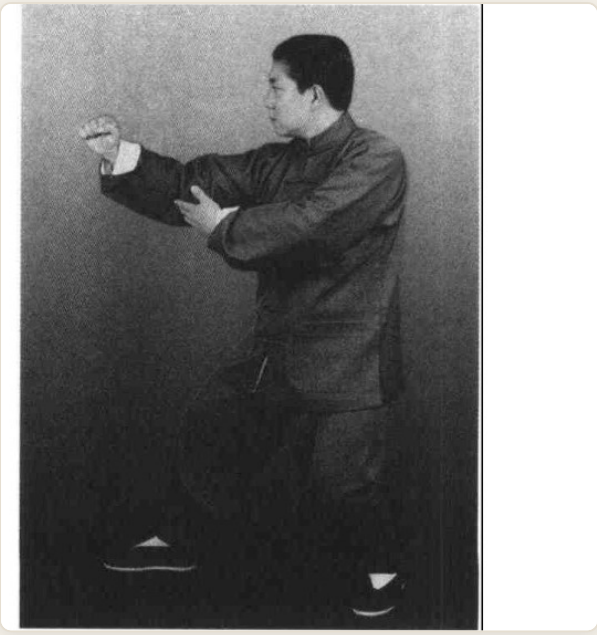
the moment of turning through, the right fist beginning to thrust out, the left hand guarding the face.

图 202A



the right fist thrust out to the front, the left hand at the side, the step set down, seen from the front.

图 202B



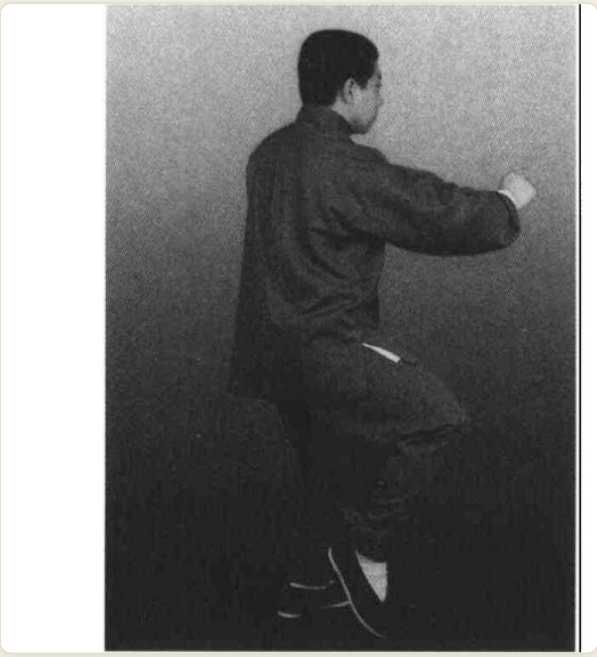
the same moment in profile, the back of the right fist facing down, the left palm withdrawn.

(There is also a push-hands photograph at the foot of the left column of this page; it is unnumbered and carries no caption.) ...the figures on the previous page).

Thirty-sixth Posture: Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch (Jin Bu Ban Lan Chui)

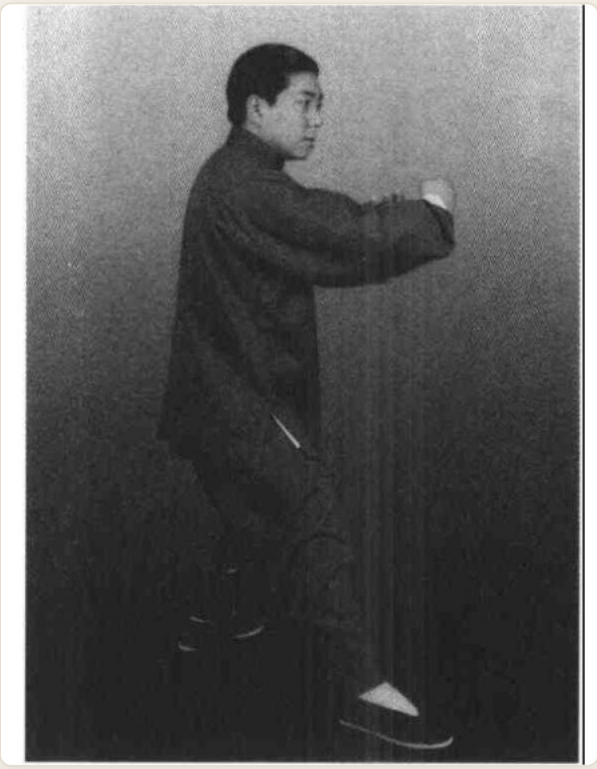
The same as the twenty-fifth posture above, "Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch", but the direction of the form's route is reversed. See the figures on this page (the same as the earlier set of five).

图 203



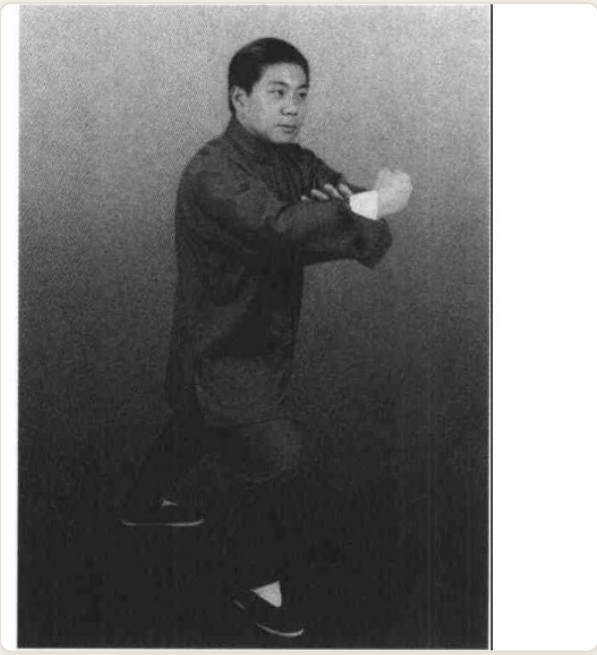
stepping forward, the right fist drawn back beside the waist, the left palm at the front of the chest.

图 204A



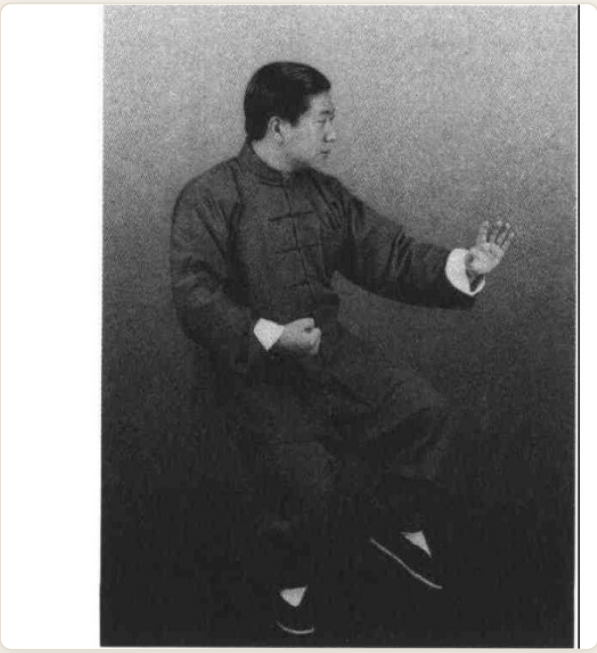
the left palm warding off to the left, the right fist at the waist, the body turning.

图 204B



the same moment seen from the front, the left forearm horizontal, the right fist closed.

图 205

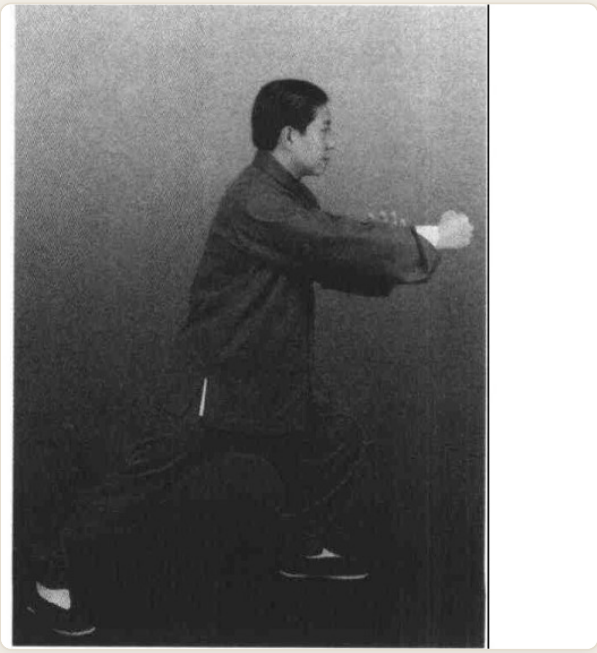


the right fist beginning to punch forward, the left palm withdrawn to the inside of the right forearm.

图 206

the right fist thrust forward, the left palm pressing at the inside of the right elbow, the left bow stance formed.

图 207



the completed right thrust, seen in profile, the left bow stance, both arms extended forward.

Thirty-seventh Posture: Right Heel Kick (You Deng Jiao)

BOOK PAGE 154

I. Application

I. Application

Joining from the preceding posture. If the opponent uses his left hand to push my right arm away to the left, I at once follow the momentum and coil my right wrist under his wrist, and use my right hand to ward him off from right to left; at the same time the left toe turns out and settles flat, the body also turns slightly left, and I kick out straight ahead (to the east) with my right foot; the body turns from the left back to facing the front, the two hands separate in proportion to the foot, and the waist and hips sink.

Another application: when the opponent's left palm has been stuck by me and he strikes straight in with his right hand, I quickly ward it off to the left with my left hand and then kick out with my right foot.

II. The Course of the Movement

1. The body gradually turns left, the left toe turns out and settles flat, the left knee bends slightly and the left leg settles solid, the centre of gravity gradually shifts entirely onto the left leg, and the right leg is lifted forward. At the same time the left palm, as the body turns, moves to the left, forward and up. As it moves, the arm rotates outward so that the centre of the palm turns inward; the right palm changes and, from the right front, goes downward and scoops in an arc to the left, and as it scoops the arm rotates outward so that the centre of the palm turns inward and it clasps with the left palm, the two crossed before the chest with the right palm outside. The eyes look level to the front toward the right, the gaze attending to the clasping of the two palms (see the first two figures on this page).

2. The right foot continues to be lifted and is slowly kicked out straight ahead with the heel (to the east), the toe pointing up; as the right foot kicks out the left leg gradually straightens, the knee still slightly bent, and at the same time the two palms separate to left and right. The gaze attends to the right palm as it separates, and looks level to the right past the right palm (see the third figure on this page).

III. Key Points

1. The right heel kick should take the heel as its point of application.

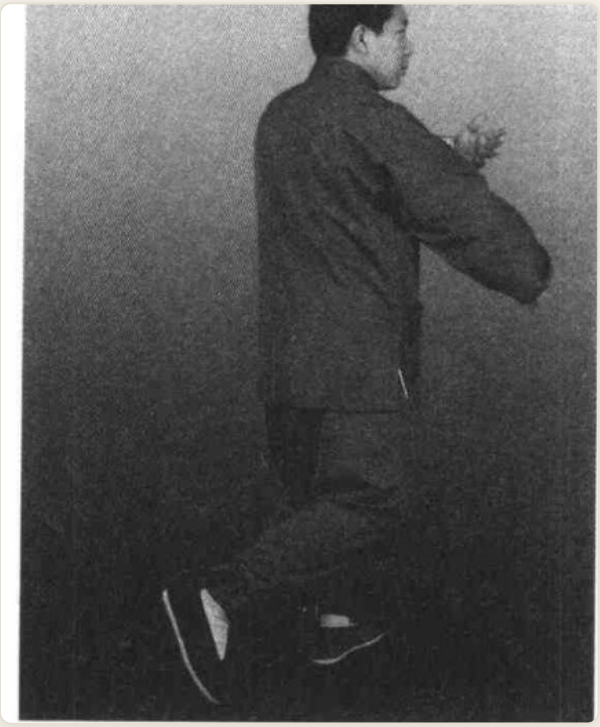
2. In the heel kick the body must be stable — no leaning forward, no leaning back, no tilting. The whole body must be relaxed, the centre of gravity steady, the movements harmonious and

coordinated, the chest broad and comfortable, the abdomen full, the centre of gravity lowered, so that the lower limbs are firm and the upper limbs agile, and the body is kept essentially in one line from top to bottom.

IV. Requirements

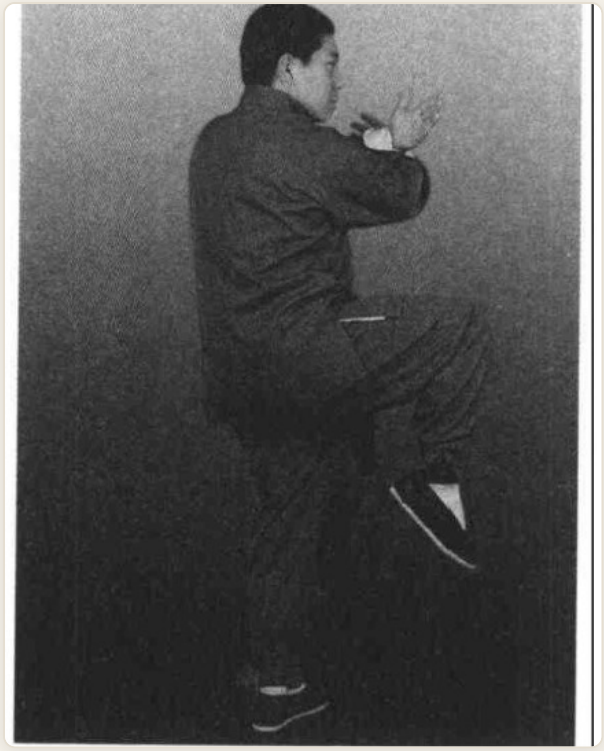
1. The turning of the waist to the left, the turning out of the left foot, the movement of the two hands and the lifting forward of the right leg must all be carried out at the same time. Because when I ward off the opponent's left hand to the left, the support of the waist's strength is necessary if the power is to reach every part of the limbs.

图 208



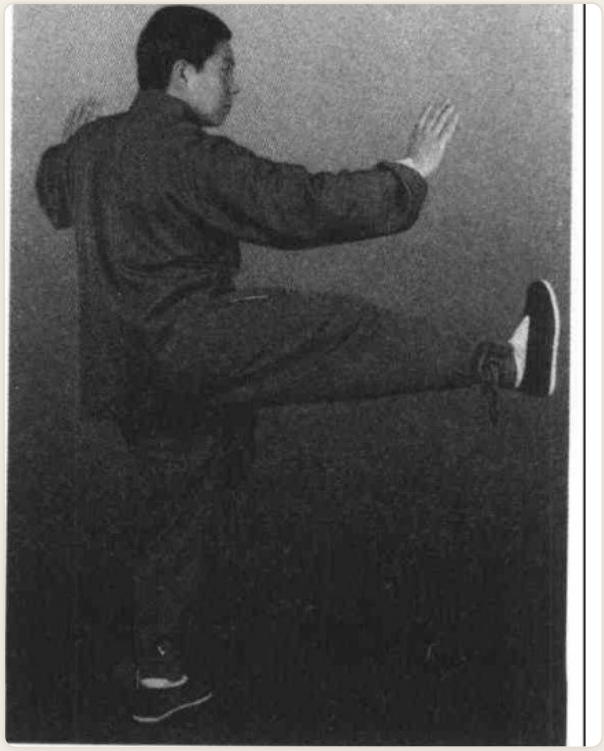
the left leg settled, the right leg lifted, the two palms crossing and clasping before the chest, the right palm outside.

图 209



the two palms clasped and crossed at the chest, the right knee raised, the gaze forward.

图 210



the right foot thrust out with the heel, the sole leading, the two palms separated to left and right at shoulder height.

2. When the right foot kicks out, the left leg that supports the whole body's weight must not be straightened completely, and the two separated arms must not be straightened completely either. "Strength is stored in the bent." And so the joints of the four limbs are required to be bent, not straight.

3. The direction of the kick must be exact: it must kick towards the right side (the east), because the opponent is at my right front.

BOOK PAGE 155

V. Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

V. Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Fault: the direction of the kick is inexact — it goes either too far left or too far right. The principal cause is that the left foot is withdrawn too far left, or not far enough. Correction: the left foot should be withdrawn to the left by about 45°; in the early stages of practice this must be checked and corrected repeatedly.

2. Fault: the separation of the two hands is out of proportion to the foot, with various errors of height, lowness, width, narrowness and speed. The principal cause is an insufficient understanding of the application in which the separation of the two hands is matched to the foot. Correction: the fingers should be raised to about eyebrow height, the right hand in the same direction as the right foot, the left hand on the left rear oblique — the foot must arrive and the hand must arrive.

3. Fault: when the two hands cross and clasp they are too close to the chest, which is called "collapsed", and in some cases the two hands are slack and without strength. The principal cause is insufficient attention to the hand method. Correction: the wrists should be seated and the palms comfortable, the two arms full — in this way breathing is smooth, and after long practice one can lead the hands with the body and lead the body with the hands, turning in circles along the momentum, which benefits both health and the martial application.

4. Fault: the direction of the body's turning is wrong — when the left foot turns out to the left, the upper body does not turn and still faces forward (east). The principal cause is a failure to understand the application. I use my right wrist, following the momentum, to ward the opponent's left wrist away to the left; if the waist's strength is used correctly, the whole body's strength can be concentrated on one point, whereas if the hand and waist are disconnected and one wards off with the strength of the hand alone, that does not meet the martial requirement. From the point of view of health, if the waist and hips are stiff and unmoving one cannot exercise the muscles of the waist and back, and there is a lack of the internal massaging effect on the internal organs. Hence the boxing treatise stresses, "At every moment keep your mind on the waist." Correction: the waist is the key to the turning of the upper and lower body; when warding off to the left the waist must turn left at the same time.

(There is also a push-hands photograph at the foot of this page; it is unnumbered and carries no caption.)

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VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

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1. The teacher must observe the movements of every part of the body from the front and from the side.

2. The emphasis must be placed on the stability of the heel kick; this must be practised over and over.

3. Paired practice following the application: A — performs Step Forward, Deflect, Parry and Punch; B — uses his left hand from the front to push A's right arm to the left; A — follows the momentum and coils his right wrist under B's wrist, uses his right hand to ward B's left wrist away to the left, kicks out straight ahead with the right foot, and the two hands separate. The two then exchange places and practise again.

4. Progressive method: (1) The left hand shifts level to the left, the right hand arcs slightly downward and to the left, and the two hands clasp (cross) before the chest, the palms facing inward. (2) The same again, adding the turning of the left foot to the left, the lifting of the right leg, the face toward the north-east. (3) The same again, adding the kicking out of the right leg straight ahead (to the east) and the separation of the two hands.

VII. Technical Analysis

1. The distinguishing feature of this movement is that one foot stands alone while the other is lifted and kicks out; the difficulty lies in how to stand firm. And so the standing foot must have the knee joint bent and not straightened, the sole flat and firmly on the ground, its strength as though wound into the earth, so that the strength rises from the heel and the intention turns upward, while the spine is relaxed, sunk and upright, the sacrum stable and strong, the breath sunk into the lower abdomen, the crotch strength sinking down, and the hundred meeting-point on the crown of the head always lightly leading upward. This is "the empty leading of the crown, the breath sunk into the cinnabar field", the practice of lifting the crotch and threading to the crown, and it has the effect of drawing and lengthening from above and below. The lower frame must be practised so as to keep steady amid change, firm as the root of a great tree that cannot be shaken. To this end one must constantly readjust the centre of gravity in much practice, and so gradually master the correct position of the centre of gravity and attain stability standing on one foot.

2. The right heel kick transforms and attacks at once; and so in one's awareness one must not slur over the movement of the hands, but must have a clear purpose in their movement, so that the movement of the hands will not be scattered and strengthless.

3. In kicking the leg one generally tends to use force and kick out fast. According to the requirement of "the ten essentials of Taijiquan", the whole set of form movements should use

intention and not force. And so in the right heel kick the leg should first be lifted with the force concentrated at the knee joint, the ligaments of the hip drawn open, and the leg kicked out gently and slowly. In practising Taijiquan the whole body must be loosened, not permitting the slightest clumsy force to lodge between the sinews, bones and blood vessels and so bind oneself; only then can one be light, nimble, changing, round and free. If instead of using force one uses intention, then wherever the intention goes the breath arrives; thus the blood and breath flow and pour in daily, circulating through the whole body without ever stagnating. Practised long and long, one obtains true inner strength.

Thirty-eighth Posture: Left Beat the Tiger (Zuo Da Hu Shi)

BOOK PAGE 157

I. Application

I. Application

Joining from the preceding posture. If an opponent strikes from my left front with his left hand, I at once set my right foot down level with the left, and both hands turn to the left side with the body; the left foot steps out obliquely to the left, the knee bends and settles solid, the right foot becomes empty, forming the left bow stance, the face towards the side square. The two hands at the same time swing as fists, and as they descend they close to the left; I use my right palm to grip the opponent's left wrist and pluck it down to the left, bringing it opposite the region of the heart, while my left fist turns over upward from the outside to the left, comes to the side of the left corner of the forehead, the centre of the fist facing outward, and strikes swiftly at the opponent's head — or I may strike his back with the right fist. This posture advances by retreating, suddenly opening and closing the embrace with a fierce intent; hence it is called Beat the Tiger.

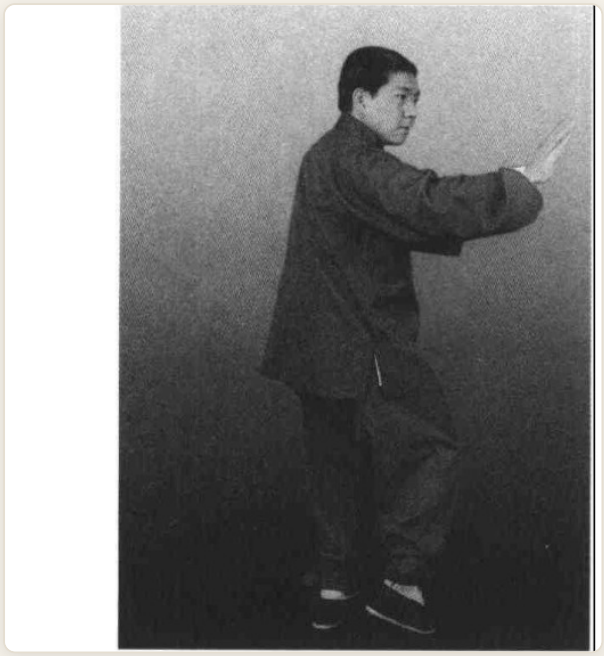
II. The Course of the Movement

1. The left leg gradually squats and the right foot descends. At the same time the left palm, from the left, passes across the front of the forehead and arcs level to the right, and as it moves the arm rotates outward so that the centre of the palm gradually turns inward; the right palm at the same time shifts slightly downward, and as it moves the arm rotates inward so that the centre of the palm gradually turns down. The gaze attends to the right palm (see the first figure on this page).

2. The left leg continues to squat, and the right foot comes down beside the left foot, the distance between the feet slightly narrower than the shoulders; the toe touches the ground first and the centre of gravity gradually shifts onto the right leg, the whole sole of the right foot settles

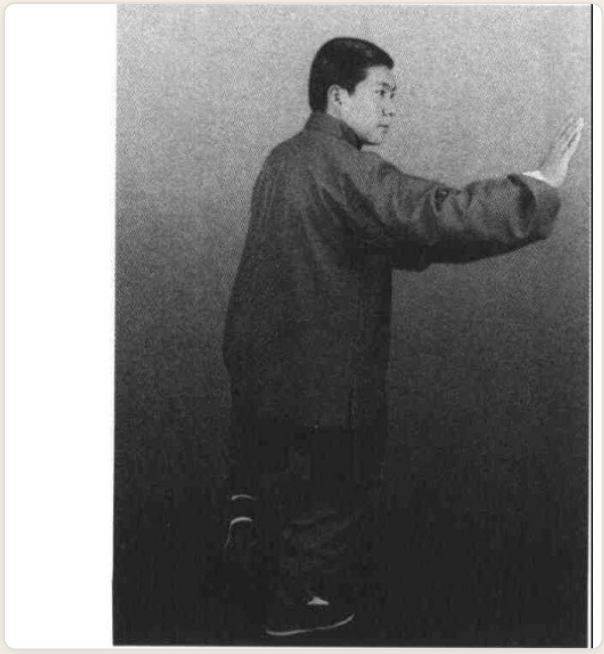
flat, and the left foot is then lifted. As the centre of gravity shifts onto the right leg the two palms continue to move to the lower right, the left palm passing the right...

图 211



the left leg sinking, the right foot descending, the left palm arcing to the right across the front of the forehead, the right palm turning gradually face-down.

图 212



the right foot set down beside the left, the weight shifting onto the right leg, both palms continuing to move to the lower right.

...beside the upper arm, and as it moves the left arm continues to rotate outward so that the centre of the palm turns up; the two hands are slightly lower than the shoulders, the eyes look level to the front, the gaze attending to the two palms (see the second figure on this page).

3. The right leg continues to squat, the body turns left (to the north-by-west), and the left foot steps out obliquely to the left rear, the heel touching the ground first; as the centre of gravity shifts onto the left leg the whole sole settles flat, the left leg bends and the right leg extends, forming the left bow stance. As the centre of gravity moves and the body turns, the left palm, from the right chest and in front of the abdomen, passes in an arc up past the front of the left knee, tracing a curve from the lower right upward (the reverse brush of the knee), and stops above and in front of the left temple (closing into a fist just as it arrives). As the left fist arcs up from the left, the left arm turns with the body and the right arm bends slightly; the right palm moves level from the right, passes across the front of the chest to the left, and the right arm is bent at the elbow and laid horizontally in front of the upper abdomen; as it moves the right arm gradually rotates slightly outward so that the centre of the palm gradually turns obliquely down; as the right palm reaches the front of the chest it changes from palm to fist, the eye of the fist facing obliquely left, the centre of the fist facing obliquely down, so that the eyes of the left and right fists are essentially opposed above and below. At the same time the upper body turns slightly right; the gaze first attends to the left hand, and when the left fist is about to arrive above

and in front of the left temple it looks level to the front (see the remaining figures on this page and on the next).

BOOK PAGE 158

III. Key Points

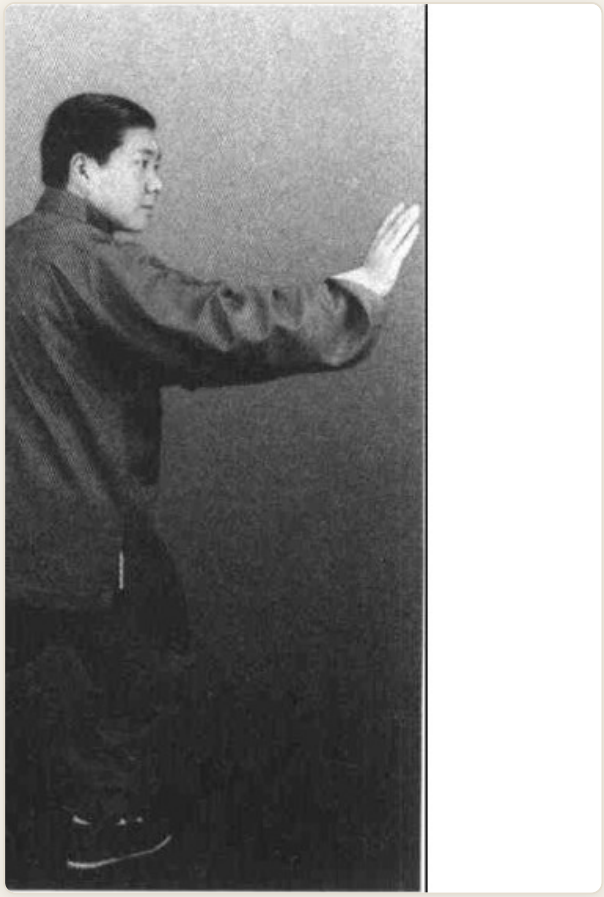
III. Key Points

1. When the right foot comes down after the right heel kick, the left leg must "send" it — that is, the left leg slowly bends its knee and squats, so as to control the right leg's landing gently and slowly; only thus does one meet the requirement of lightness and steadiness. At the same time, the lowering of the centre of gravity accords with the application in which the right hand plucks the opponent's left fist down to the left side.

2. When the left foot steps to the left rear the upper body must be upright, and the body method must be "centred, true and undeviating". In practising the form, whether advancing, retreating, turning left or turning right, and whatever the transformations of the limbs' movement, from the crown of the head through the trunk down to the perineum there must always be one straight line.

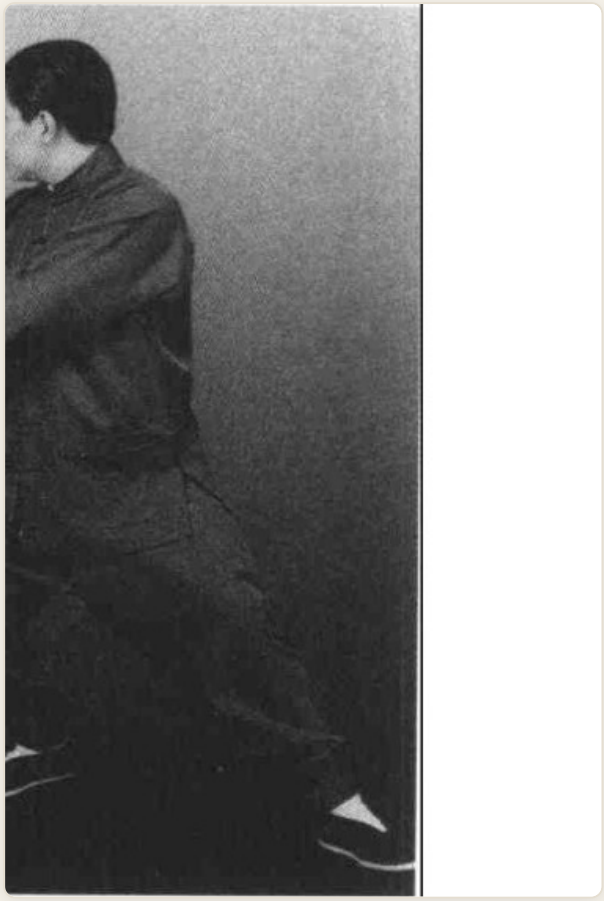
3. In stepping the left leg, pay attention to the exchange of full and empty between the two legs: the right leg must be settled solid before the left leg is slowly stepped out, so that the movement is steady, extended, centred and true, with no unsteadiness anywhere.

图 213A



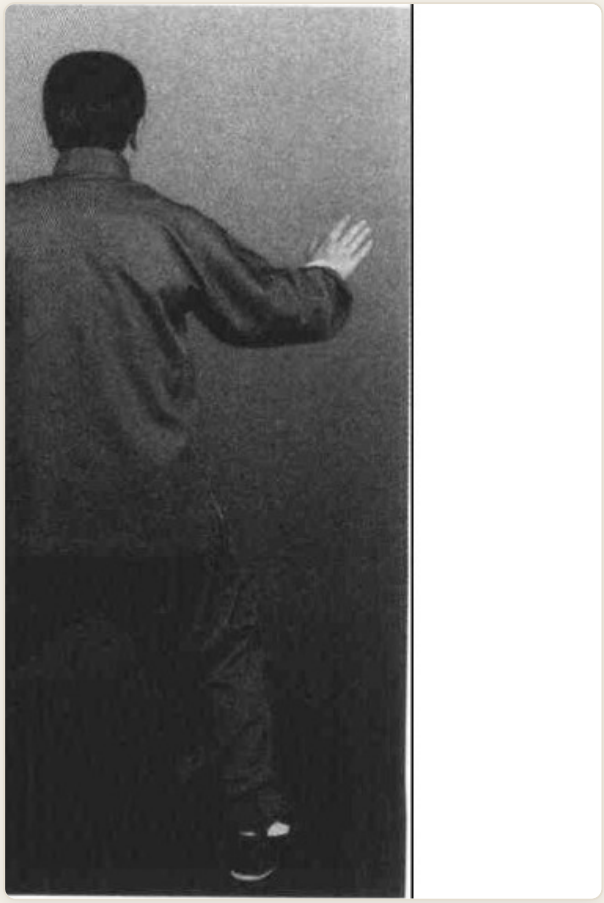
the left leg stepping out obliquely to the left rear, the left palm arcing up from the lower right to above the left temple.

图 213B



the left bow stance forming, the left fist at the left temple, the right arm bent across the upper abdomen.

图 214A



the left Beat the Tiger posture formed, seen from the front, both fists opposed above and below.

4. The movement of the two hands must follow arcs; there must be no angular corners. The arcs of Taijiquan's movements are the outward form that is necessarily present when the inner strength spirals and revolves; they are the technique of "sticking, connecting, adhering and following" and of "drawing in and dropping into emptiness", and this ...accords with the application in which the two hands swing as fists, closing as they descend to the left and plucking down to the left side.

5. In the settled pose of Beat the Tiger the two arms should be full in their arcs; in the left Beat the Tiger, for instance, the right fist should be held somewhat away from the body.

IV. Requirements

IV. Requirements

1. The two palms close into fists only as they arrive at position.

2. The left foot in the left Beat the Tiger and the right foot in the right Beat the Tiger land on two oblique angles — the former to the north-west, the latter to the south-east. The direction must be correct.

3. The knee must arrive and the fist must arrive; it is not acceptable for the knee to have arrived in the bow while the hand is still tracing its arc. Above and below must keep each other company.

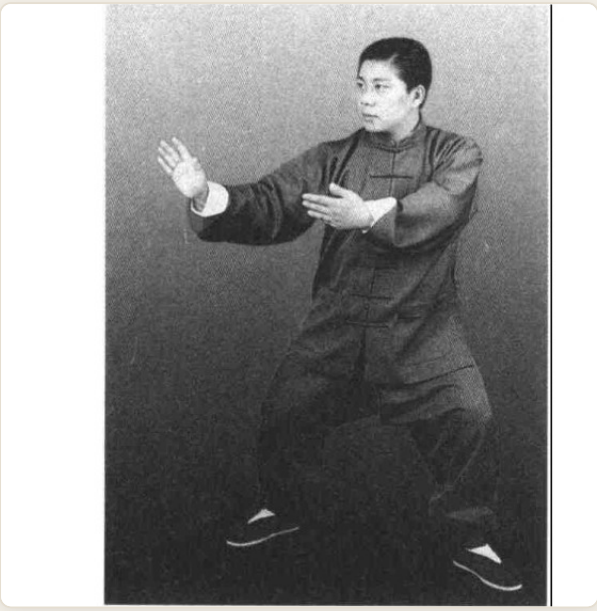
4. The level gaze shifts from the south-east to the north-west (in the right Beat the Tiger, from the north-west to the south-east).

V. Faults, Their Causes, and How to Correct Them

1. Fault: in joining from the right heel kick, the right foot comes down and treads, but the left leg does not sink. The principal cause is a shallow apprehension of the application. Correction: as the right leg comes down the left leg should bend its knee and squat, the right leg brushing the ground, and the left leg steps out to the left rear — only thus does one meet the requirement of advancing by retreating. Moreover, lifting the right leg while bending the left puts a considerable load on the muscles of the left leg; if the right leg comes down and the left leg does not sink, the training effect is very much less.

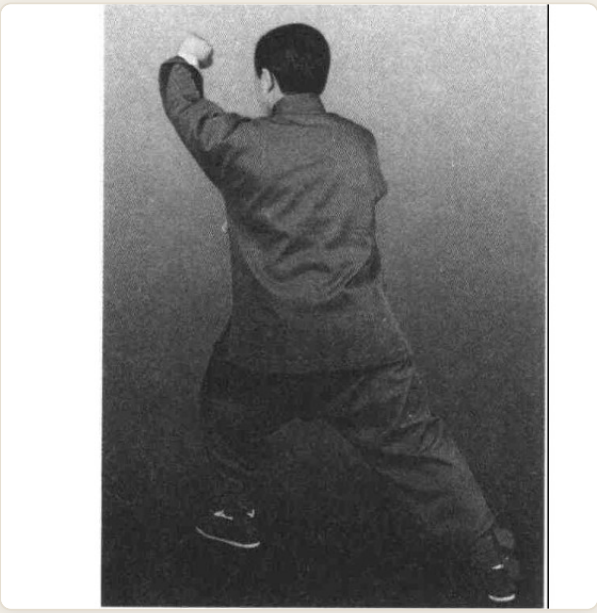
2. Fault: the hands are not led by the waist — the hands move while the waist does not. The principal cause is a shallow understanding of how the inner strength is driven through…

图 214B



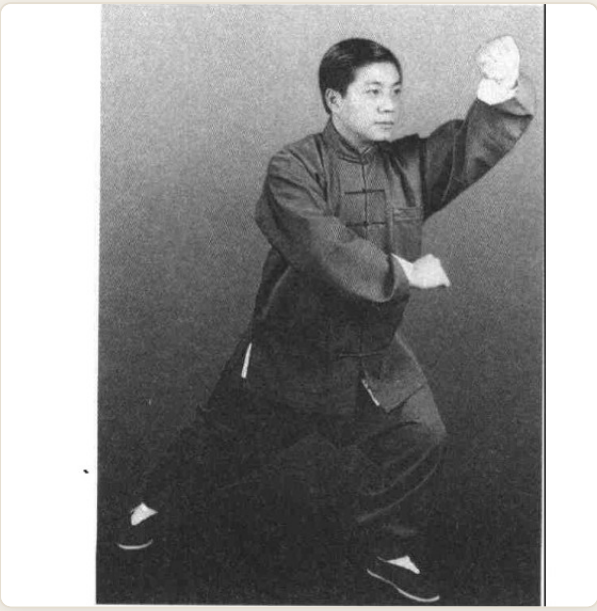
the left Beat the Tiger posture from the front-left, the left fist at the temple, the right fist in front of the upper abdomen.

图 215A



the left Beat the Tiger seen from behind, the left arm raised, the right fist at the abdomen, the weight on the left leg.

图 215B



the left Beat the Tiger in profile, the left bow stance, the left fist above the temple, the right fist guarding the abdomen.

...to the tips of the four limbs, and that the waist strength, used well, can augment the issuing of power. Correction: one must understand that the key to the turning of the upper and lower limbs is in the waist; the waist should lead the hands.

3. Fault: in the settled pose the direction of the two fists' eye is wrong, and their high and low positions are wrong. The principal cause is an insufficient understanding of the requirement for closing the fist. Correction: at the point where the fist comes out and lands, the fist and the forearm should form a straight line, so that the wrist is not easily injured when it meets resistance. And so in the left Beat the Tiger the right fist is below and slightly oblique, its eye facing obliquely inward; the left fist's eye faces obliquely right, its centre facing obliquely outward. The left fist, at the front of the left forehead, should be higher than the head; the right fist, below, should be in front of the upper abdomen.

4. Fault: the direction of the foot's movement is wrong. The principal cause is an insufficient understanding of the application. Correction: the direction in which the toe lands bears on whether the hip-joint is tight or open, and thus affects the body method. In joining from the right heel kick into the left Beat the Tiger, as the left leg sends the right leg down, the right toe is oblique (towards north-by-east), and when the left foot is lifted and steps to the left and right its toe faces obliquely north-west.

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

VI. Teaching Method and Practice Method

1. The teacher should observe the practitioner's movements from every direction — for instance from the front, to see the height and spacing of the two fists, and from an oblique angle, to see the direction of the stepping.

2. Help the practitioner quickly settle the direction of the foot and the facing of the body. One may make no demands on the two hands at first, practising the direction of the stepping repeatedly, and only then practise the stepping with the hands and feet coordinated. In the settled pose of the left Beat the Tiger the left foot is at an oblique angle towards the north-west, the body faces north-by-west, and the right foot is oblique.

(There is also a push-hands photograph at the foot of this page; it is unnumbered and carries no caption.)

...while the right foot is oblique towards the south-east and the body faces south-by-east.

3. Practise repeatedly the movement in which the left leg "sends" the right leg down, to deepen the apprehension of full and empty and to strengthen the legs.

4. Paired practice following the application: A — settles into the right heel kick. B — strikes at A with his left hand from A's left front. A — brings the right leg down and squats the left leg, changes the standing foot, steps the left foot to the left rear, uses the right leg to grip B's left wrist and plucks it down to the left side, and the left palm turns over upward from the outside, becomes a fist and strikes B's head. Apprehend the application of the two hands' movements, then exchange places and practise.

5. Progressive method: (1) The left leg squats and "sends" the right leg down. (2) The same, plus stepping the left leg. (3) The same, plus the movement of the two arms. (4) The settled pose (left Beat the Tiger). (5) The left toe turns in, the right leg is lifted, the two fists change to palms. (6) The same, plus stepping the right foot. (7) The same, plus the movement of the two arms. (8) The settled pose (right Beat the Tiger).

6. Guidance: for instance, why one must step to left and right — so that the learner understands the application of advancing by retreating.

Thirty-ninth Posture: Right Beat the Tiger (You Da Hu Shi)

I. Application

I. Application

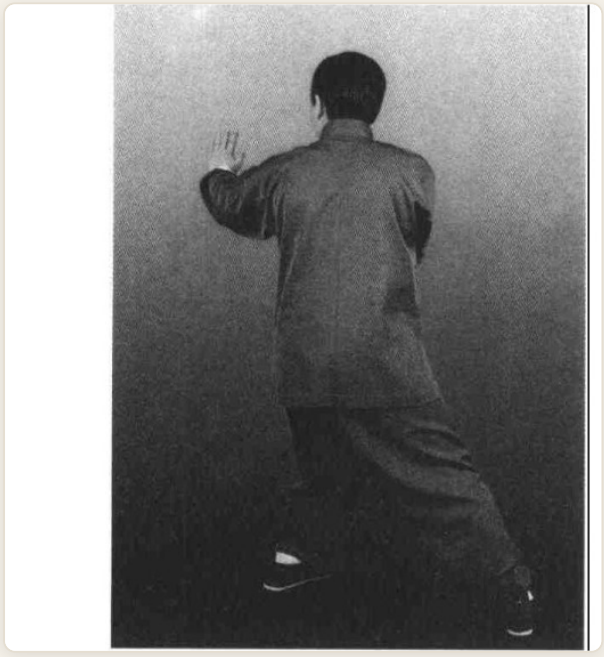
Joining from the preceding posture: if an opponent strikes from my rear right with his right hand, I at once lift my right foot and turn the waist to the right front, step the right foot out to the right side, bend the knee and settle solid, the left leg becomes empty forming the right bow stance, and the two hands at the same time turn in a circle to the right and then close into fists, forming the right Beat the Tiger. The application is the same as the left Beat the Tiger.

II. The Course of the Movement

1. The left toe turns in and the left leg settles solid, the right foot is gradually lifted with the heel leaving the ground first, and the body gradually turns right. At the same time the two fists change to palms, the left palm sinking slightly with its centre facing down; the right arm rotates outward so that the centre of the palm turns face-up and moves to the front of the left upper arm. The gaze first attends to the left palm, then follows the turning of the body in a level shift (see the first figure on this page).

2. After the right foot is lifted, the body continues to turn right, then steps forward (to the south-east), the heel touching the ground first, and as the centre of gravity gradually shifts...

图 216A



the left toe turned in, the right foot lifted, the two fists changing to palms, the right palm turning face-up before the left upper arm.